# Recipes for Rare Metal Ores: Magmas, Metasomatism, and Meteoric Mobilization via Sulfide/Goethite (U-Th)/He Geochronology and ML-Accelerated Thermodynamic Modeling

Thesis by
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# ABSTRACT

**[TODO: Write abstract.]**

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I am deeply grateful...

The fieldwork at Draaikraal would not have been possible...

Finally, I thank family/friends for their unwavering support...

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# INTRODUCTION

**[TODO: Write short dissertation introduction, longer than abstract, detail each chapter.]**

*Chapter 1*

# A SIMPLE METHOD FOR HELIUM STEP HEAT EXPERIMENTS AT HIGH WATER OR SULFUR FUGACITY

*Helium isotope studies and U-Th/He geochronology of sulfur-bearing and hydrous minerals offer direct windows into the timing and context of hydrothermal mineralization, provided the conditions governing radiogenic helium retention and loss in nature are known. However, assessing helium retentivity at elevated temperatures is currently hampered by these minerals' instability under the high-temperature, high-vacuum conditions of conventional helium step-heating experiments. This paper introduces a novel method for conducting helium step-heating experiments under hydrothermal and sulfur-saturated conditions, designed to extend our knowledge of helium diffusion kinetics in hydrous and sulfur-bearing mineral phases. In this approach, silica glass ampoules encapsulate the mineral of interest, maintaining internally sulfur- or water vapor-saturated conditions against the ultra-high vacuum of the surrounding extraction line, while the high helium permeability of fused silica permits quantification of evolved helium using standard temperature control and mass spectrometry procedures. This work presents the experimental framework and key equations necessary to deconvolve the processes of helium permeation through the silica ampoule from the thermally activated degassing of helium from the encapsulated mineral. Permeation lag is quantified with a first-order permeation model and removed by one of two routes: the* permeation step method*, which measures the ampoule's residual helium directly with low-temperature permeation steps, or, where those yields fall to blank level, the* bounding method*, which constrains that residual from above by assuming steady-state permeation during long steps. Both rest on the ampoule's permeation rate constant, which is measured during the experiment itself rather than taken from the literature. Validation experiments measuring helium permeation through empty ampoules and ampoules containing only water, sulfur,*

*or Durango apatite demonstrate that permeation lag is readily correctable in well-designed experiments and characterize the extent to which water and sulfur influence the helium permeability of fused silica. While sulfur-saturated experiments are straightforward to carry out with this method, several tractable complications are identified for experiments when significant water is present. This method expands standard experimental capabilities to encompass mineral phases that decompose under high vacuum, including sulfides and iron oxyhydroxides, opening new avenues for thermochronometric investigation of hydrothermal systems.*

## 1.1 Introduction

Noble gas geochronology and thermochronometry ($^{40}Ar/^{39}Ar$ and U-Th/He) on hydrous and sulfur-bearing mineral phases such as hornblende, clay minerals, biotite, goethite, and pyrite have already been leveraged as a powerful tool for understanding regional thermal histories as well as the timing of iron or rare metal mineralization (McInnes et al., 2005; Heim et al., 2006; P. M. Vasconcelos et al., 2013; Nomade et al., 2004; O. Yakubovich, Podolskaya, et al., 2020; O. Yakubovich, Vikentyev, et al., 2021). The interpretation of these data, however, is often complicated by the fact that helium (or argon) within hydrous or sulfur-bearing phases often degasses differently in the laboratory and in nature (Hanson et al., 1975; Lee, 1993; Lo et al., 2000; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024).

Experiments aiming to characterize the migration mechanisms and rates of noble gasses through hydrous phases yield different results when conducted under hydrothermal conditions as opposed to traditional experimental methods in vacuo. Hydrothermal step heat experiments for argon in biotite and hornblende showed higher retentivity and comparatively favored diffusive loss mechanisms relative to experiments conducted in vacuo, and these results are more likely to accurately reflect loss mechanisms in nature (Harrison, 1982; Harrison et al., 1985); however, such experiments are labor-intensive and comparatively inflexible relative to modern helium step heat methods (Farley, Reiners, et al., 1999).

Recently, some workers have taken advantage of the high helium permeability and selectivity of pure silica glass when designing novel experimental methods

for U-Th/He geochronology (O. Yakubovich, Podolskaya, et al., 2020; O. Yakubovich, Vikentyev, et al., 2021), but these ideas have only been applied in a limited way to characterize helium migration in sulfur-bearing or hydrous phases (e.g., monotonic ramped heating experiments: O. V. Yakubovich, Gedz, et al., 2019). This work aims to apply decades of research on helium permeability, solubility, and diffusion in fused silica glass (e.g., Jones, 1953; Norton, 1953; Rogers et al., 1954; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Doremus, 1966; Masaryk, 1968; Shelby, 1971; Shelby, 1972; Shelby, 1976; Shackelford et al., 1972) to adapt existing agile step-heat methods (Farley, Reiners, et al., 1999) to investigate helium loss rates and mechanisms in sulfur-bearing and hydrous mineral phases.

Encapsulating minerals in silica glass ampoules allows experimentalists to maintain hydrothermal or sulfur-saturated conditions within the ampoule without otherwise altering the experimental design. Depending on the thermodynamics of the phase of interest, this method may stabilize the phase at elevated experimental temperatures, allowing for detailed characterization of helium migration in sulfide and hydrous minerals that hitherto has remained poorly understood (Fig. **??**).

## 1.2 Experimental Methods

Five helium step heat experiments of sealed silica glass ampoules were undertaken at Caltech to demonstrate the applicability of equations derived here to real helium step heat experiments of geologic materials using a projector-lamp heating apparatus, described in detail in Farley, Reiners, et al. (1999). Four of these experiments involved introducing helium into empty, water-filled, and sulfur-filled ampoules, then measuring helium permeation to assess the applicability of theory outlined in this chapter to helium step heat experiments at Caltech, and to reproduce measurements of permeability rates from the literature (Norton, 1953; Jones, 1953; Swets et al., 1961; Altemose, 1961). The fifth experiment was a standard helium step heat experiment on encapsulated Durango apatite, a widely used standard for helium diffusion experiments and U-Th/He thermochronometry (Zeitler et al., 1987; Wolf, Farley, and Silver, 1996; Farley, 2000; Shuster and Farley, 2005; Shuster, Flowers, et al., 2006; Flowers, Shuster, et al., 2007). The aim of that experiment was to be a practical test in deconvolving the process of helium permeation through silica glass ampoules from thermal helium loss of a well-studied geologic material. Table **??**

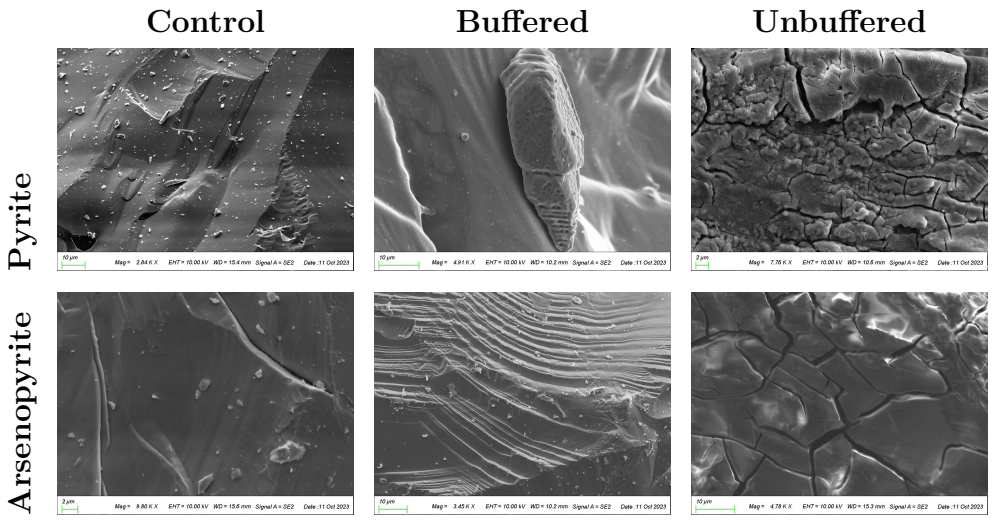



Figure 1.1: Secondary electron SEM images of pyrite (top row) and arsenopyrite (bottom row) surface textures before heat treatment (control), and after heat treatment at 400°C for at least 4 hours, both unbuffered and buffered in a silica glass ampoule with fused sulfur or mineral realgar (AsS) for pyrite and arsenopyrite respectively. The buffered samples maintain the smooth surfaces and clear cleavage faces that the controls have, showing no evidence of decomposition. The unbuffered samples show clear evidence of decomposition by devolatilization, indicated by the formation of contraction cracks and surface roughening. Using silica glass ampoules to buffer samples within controlled microenvironments can prevent phase decomposition at the elevated experimental temperatures typical of helium step heat experiments. See the supplement §**??** for details on the experimental methods and sample preparation.

summarizes the dimensions, geometric factors, and encapsulated materials of this work.

To prepare the silica glass ampoules, ~10 cm long segments of pure silica glass tubes with an outer diameter of 4 mm and an inner diameter of 3 mm were submerged and sonicated within acetone, ethanol, then MilliQ water baths in sequence, and then were dried overnight in a 100°C oven. The glass tubes were hand-pulled into thin pipettes with a jewelry welding torch and their thin ends were fused closed.

After the glass had cooled, degassed lab-grade sulfur, distilled water, or Durango apatite were added to some of the tubes. Two tubes were left empty. To seal, the top of each pipette was interfaced with a vacuum line and was pumped to a pressure of <0.1 torr. The encapsulated water tube was flash-frozen in liquid nitrogen and then pumped and sealed in a saltwater ice bath to selectively



Figure 1.2: A typical silica glass ampoule used for helium step heat experiments. The ampoule shown here contains Durango Apatite crushate sieved to 300 µm (radii ≈ 150 µm). The ampoule is roughly one cm long and one mm wide. The bars visible in the background are each separated by 1 mm.

Table 1.1: Silica Glass tubes that were the subject of helium step heat experiments in this work. Ampoules labeled "Quad" had evolved 4He quantified by isotope dilution using a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer, whereas ampoule labeled "MC" had both evolved 3He and 4He quantified using a Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer. Where 3He was measured, the ampoule was soaked in tank helium with an isotope ratio of ~0.15 Ra

| Ampoule Contents | Mass Spec. | Inner Diameter µm | Outer Diameter µm | Geometric factor $G$ cm$^{-2}$ | Volume Ratio $\left(\frac{V_{glass}}{V_{gas}}\right)$ | Content Mass | Helium Source |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Empty | Quad | 630 | 960 | 4785.3 | 1.32 | — | Atmosphere |
| Empty | MC | 747 | 1159 | 3263.9 | 1.41 | — | Tank He |
| Sulfur | MC | 529–550 | 835–872 | 5992.1 | 1.5 | ~0.2 mg | Tank He |
| Water | MC | 487–515 | 734–776 | 7789 | 1.27 | ~0.5 mg | Tank He |
| Durango Apatite | Quad | 850 | 1350 | 2393.5 | 1.52 | 3.18 mg | Radiogenic |

pump away atmospheric gasses and not water. Sublimation of sulfur and water ice during pumping was minor. The primary motivation for pumping the tube to rough vacuum was to aid the sealing process. After rough vacuum was achieved, a fine-tipped welding torch was used to seal the top of each ampoule. To determine the geometric factors for permeation of the ampoules, the inner and outer diameters of each ampoule were determined using the measurement function of the Amscope stereo microscope software, which was calibrated and tested during early development of this method.

Except for the encapsulated Durango apatite ampoule, helium gas needed to be introduced into the sealed ampoules before they were loaded into the projector lamp heating cells. About 15 nccSTP of atmospheric helium was introduced into the empty ampoule used for the quadrupole mass spectrometer experiment by heating the ampoule in a muffle furnace to >400°C in atmosphere overnight, which was sufficient to support a short permeation experiment of 4He. However, to conduct step heat permeation experiments on 3He, much larger quantities of helium were necessary. The encapsulated sulfur and water ampoules and the other empty ampoule were soaked in 2-20 torr of high purity tank helium with an isotope ratio of about ~0.15 Ra at 300°C for about 24 hours. This procedure introduced 0.6-10 pccSTP 3He and up to 52,000 nccSTP 4He into each tube, allowing for measurements of both 3He and 4He permeation simultaneously.

The sealed ampoules were placed in copper foil packets and mounted to a K-type thermocouple within an ultra-high vacuum projector lamp heating cell described in more detail by Farley, Reiners, et al. (1999). Before each experiment began, each ampoule was washed with ethanol, air-dried, loaded in the lamp cell, pumped to high vacuum, and was held at 100°C for 30 minutes under dynamic vacuum to desorb ethanol, water, and other atmospheric species on the ampoule, copper packet, and lamp cell. Less than 0.5 ‰ of the radiogenic helium in 150µm radius Durango apatite would be expected to degas in 30 minutes at 100°C, which would amount to ~0.01 nccSTP for this experiment, using the diffusion parameters of Farley (2000) and the forward equations of Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966). The atmospheric helium component within the encapsulated Durango Apatite ampoule constrained by permeation steps at the beginning of the experiment was much larger: 1.47 ± 0.18 nccSTP 4He.

We found that the fused silica ampoules were capable of maintaining surprisingly high internal pressures, but ampoules filled with water would often explode at temperatures above 315°C. It is recommended that experimentalists limit the temperature of water-filled ampoules to below 300°C. We have not observed any explosions of sulfur-filled ampoules at any temperature.

Heating steps and isotopic measurements for all samples were automated using custom LabView routines with the exception of the tank helium-soaked empty tube experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer after the 7$^{th}$ measurement. For all other ampoules, a Watlow temperature controller held the ampoule at the temperature set point for a pre-programmed

duration, after which the ampoule was allowed to cool while the evolved gas was prepared for measurement for about 25 minutes. After the first 7 measurements, the empty tube experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ was instead set to an elevated temperature manually while the evolved gas was allowed to accumulate continuously in an attempt to mitigate uncertainties related to frequently changing temperatures (supplementary Eq. (**??**); Fig. **??**) and continued permeation at room temperature during gas cleanup and measurement. The accumulated gas was measured every 40-120 minutes. For this experiment, the temperature was changed either during the 1 minute pump-out of the lamp cell after inletting gas into the mass spectrometer, or a period of helium accumulation for measurement. When the temperature was changed during an accumulation period, no permeability was calculated for that step, and the measured abundances of those steps were used only to track the helium contents of the tube.

Helium isotope measurements of evolved gasses from steps heats of one empty silica glass ampoule and glass-encapsulated sulfur and water ampoules equilibrated with 2-20 torr of high purity tank helium ($R \approx 0.15\ R_a$) were acquired at Caltech on a Thermo Fisher Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer in peak hopping mode from November 19$^{th}$, 2023 to February 15$^{th}$, 2024. Helium was purified by exposing evolved gasses to a charcoal trap held in liquid nitrogen, a titanium sponge getter, then a SAES NP10 getter before freely expanding into the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$. 3He was measured with a pulse-counting electron multiplier, while 4He was detected on a Faraday detector. The majority of the analysis time was spent measuring 3He. Every few hours, the background was mass-scanned to set the 3He and 4He measure points; each was taken to be a constant mass offset from the background $HD^+$ peak. These mass offsets are precisely measured when tuning the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ for helium isotope analysis. Months of helium measurements with the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ at Caltech have shown this approach to be reliable, reproducible, and accurate for helium isotope analysis. Additionally, an electron multiplier monitored atomic mass 3.5 to detect 4He overspray. 4He abundances were very large during these experiments, resulting in a small but measurable 4He overspray of up to 0.68 cps at mass 3.5. These overspray signals at mass 3.5 were always less than 1% of the 3He signal at mass 3, suggesting that 4He overspray did not significantly affect 3He signals. Measurements of high 3He MM gas standard were analyzed every 8 hours (totaling 116 measurements) to track instrumental

drift of 3He and 4He sensitivities and to quantify internal reproducibility. These standards show 3He was internally reproducible to within 5% ($2\sigma$), whereas 4He was internally reproducible to within 2% ($2\sigma$), where reproducibility is estimated as the standard deviation divided by the mean.

Helium-4 evolved during step heats of the empty silica glass ampoule equilibrated with atmosphere and the silica glass-encapsulated Durango apatite was quantified using isotope dilution with a high purity 3He spike on a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer from October 30$^{\text{th}}$ to November 10$^{\text{th}}$, 2023. Evolved gas from the ampoule in the lamp heating cell was allowed to mix with the 3He spike and the mixture was frozen on charcoal held at 14°K within a cryostat, then helium was selectively released to the mass spectrometer by raising the temperature to 36°K.

A standard gas with a known amount of 4He is routinely measured, at least one time per experiment, to monitor drift in the relative sensitivity of 3He and 4He on the Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer. Relative sensitivities are determined for each standard measurement and are linearly interpolated in time for sample measurements. Blanks are approximately 5 pccSTP $^4$He, which is very small compared to all interpreted $^4$He measurements.

## 1.3 Theoretical Framework of Permeation Lag

The process of helium permeation through thin walls of an ampoule is rapid but not instantaneous on experimental timescales. Helium evolved from encapsulated minerals is only available for measurement following permeation through the glass ampoule (Fig. **??**), producing a predictable "permeation lag" effect in helium measurements that commonly manifests with undermeasurement of helium during prograde heating sequences and corresponding overmeasurement of helium produced during retrograde sequences (Fig. **??**). This is not merely a theoretical concern: Fig. **??** shows the same artifact in real, uncorrected step heat data for the encapsulated Durango apatite experiment described above (§**??**); the correction developed below is applied to this dataset in full in §**??** (Fig. **??**).

This effect can be modeled (and corrected for) for a system obeying the simple equation:

$$n_t = n_0 + \omega - m \tag{1.1}$$

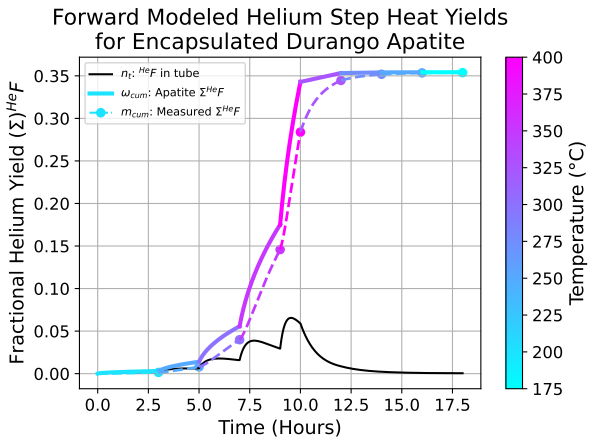



Figure 1.3: An illustrative simulation of the effects of permeation lag on step heat measurements of 150 µm radii spheres of Durango apatite encapsulated in a "standard ampoule" with an outer diameter of 1 mm and inner diameter of 0.6 mm, corresponding to a geometric factor $G$ of 4350.26 cm$^{-2}$. Some amount of helium degassed from the apatite during an experimental step remains in the tube during measurement and permeates out in later steps. The heating schedule of this model system is given in Table **??**. This simple model assumes new temperatures and their corresponding steady-state diffusive concentration profile within the glass ampoule are reached instantaneously. Effects of diffusive disequilibrium, if considered, would change the permeated amount for each step by less than 5%.

Where $n_t$ is the amount of helium within the ampoule after time $t$, $n_0$ is the initial amount of helium within the ampoule (which is inherited from previous heating steps), $\omega$ is the amount of helium evolved by the encapsulated sample during time $t$, and $m$ is the amount of measurable helium that has permeated out of the ampoule into the high-vacuum chamber during time $t$.

Heating steps are consecutive, so the helium inventory quantified between two steps applies to both the previous and the subsequent step:

$$n_t^i = n_0^{i+1}, \qquad n_0^i = n_t^{i-1} \tag{1.2}$$

Recovering $\omega$ for a step therefore requires knowledge of the ampoule's helium content immediately before and immediately after it. Sections **??** and **??** give the two routes used in this work to obtain those quantities.

Helium permeation through fused silica in diffusive steady state is a first order process that can be described with the simple differential equation:

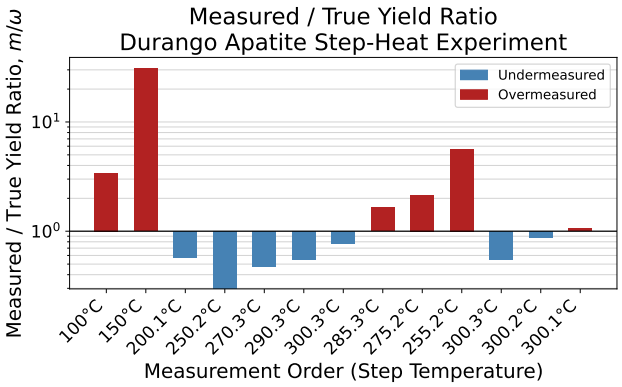



Figure 1.4: Measured-to-true yield ratio, $m/\omega$, for the first 13 experimental steps (through the isothermal 300°C triplicate) of the real encapsulated Durango apatite step heat experiment described above (§**??**) and tabulated in full in Table **??**, plotted in measurement order and labeled by nominal step temperature. Here $m$ is the raw measured helium yield for a step and $\omega$ is its permeation lag-corrected yield; bars are anchored at a ratio of 1 (no anomaly) on a logarithmic axis, so a doubling and a halving of the ratio are given equal visual weight. Steps taken while ramping to higher temperatures are generally undermeasured (blue), as some of the sample's evolved helium has not yet fully permeated out of the tube at the time of measurement, while steps taken while ramping to lower temperatures are generally overmeasured (red), as helium retained in the tube from earlier, hotter steps continues to permeate out. The first two steps (100-150°C) are strongly overmeasured despite being on the heating ramp because little helium had yet evolved from the apatite, so measured yield there is dominated by pre-existing atmospheric helium draining from the tube rather than fresh sample degassing.

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = -GKnRT \tag{1.3}$$

Where $n$ is the number of helium atoms, $t$ is the time, $G$ is the geometric parameter in units of $cm^{-2}$, which is a function only of the geometry of the glass membrane, $K$ is the permeation constant for helium in fused silica, which follows the Arrhenius law: $\left(K(T) = K_0 e^{-\frac{E_a}{RT}}\right)$ and has been repeatedly measured for fused silica (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Masaryk, 1968), $R$ is the gas constant, and $T$ is the temperature in Kelvin. Equation (**??**) is identical to the permeation equation used in early studies (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Studt, 1962; Masaryk, 1968), except that it is formulated in terms of absolute atomic abundances instead of helium gas pressure by the ideal gas law. It is easily integrated by separation of variables to yield $n_t = n_0 e^{-GKRTt}$ (see supplement, §**??**, for details). Relating that result

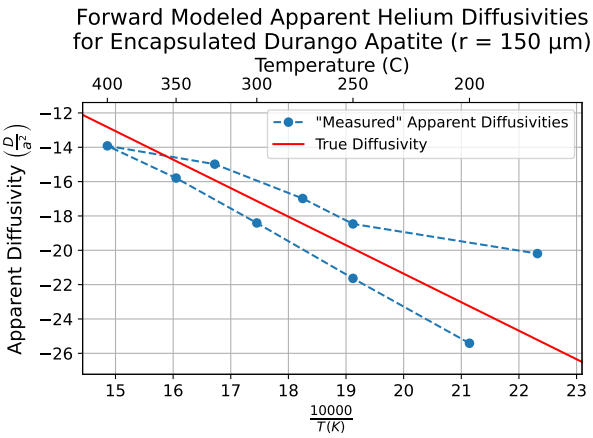



Figure 1.5: An Arrhenius plot of apparent diffusivities inverted from modeled hypothetical measurements of an encapsulated sample of Durango apatite. Permeation lag produces a characteristic effect where measurements of prograde sequences of increasing temperature produce erroneously low apparent diffusivities when inverted using the equations of Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966), whereas retrograde (decreasing) temperature sequences exhibit the opposite effect. Diffusion parameters are taken from Farley (2000).

Table 1.2: Heating schedule for numerically modeled step heat experiment of silica glass encapsulated Durango apatite.

| Temperature (°C) | Time (min) |
|---|---|
| 200 | 180 |
| 250 | 120 |
| 300 | 120 |
| 350 | 120 |
| 400 | 60 |
| 325 | 120 |
| 275 | 120 |
| 250 | 120 |
| 175 | 120 |

to the measured quantity through Eq. (**??**) in the absence of any release from the sample ($m(\omega = 0) = n_0 - n_t$) gives an expression most intuitively stated in terms of the fraction of the ampoule's initial helium reservoir that permeates during time $t$:

$$^{He}F = \frac{m}{n_0} = 1 - e^{-\lambda t}, \qquad \lambda = KGRT \tag{1.4}$$

Where $^{He}F$ is the fractional permeation yield: the fraction of the ampoule's

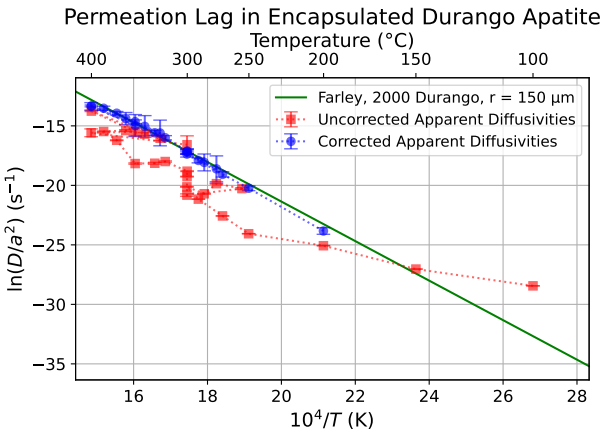



Figure 1.6: An Arrhenius plot of a helium step heat experiment of silica-glass encapsulated Durango Apatite with $2\sigma$ error bars. Without permeation lag corrections, the apparent diffusivities display highly irregular behavior that would be unrecognizable to this well-behaved sample – exactly the artifact anticipated by the simulation of Fig. **??** above. With permeation lag corrections, the sample agrees well with the reported diffusive parameters of Farley (2000) for the appropriate sieve size ($r = 150\mu m$). As the experiment proceeds beyond temperatures of 300°C, the activation energy of diffusion decreases to reveal a slight downward curl, a phenomenon well-documented for Durango apatite likely due to annealing of crystal defects and radiation damage (Wolf, Farley, and Silver, 1996; Farley, 2000). Apparent diffusivities are calculated with the equations of Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966) with and without permeation lag corrections. Four measurements of the permeation lag corrected apparent diffusivities are within error of 0 at the $2\sigma$ level and thus are excluded from the plot.

initial helium reservoir ($n_0$) that permeates as $m$ (Eq. (**??**)) during a time $t$ of steady state permeation, and $\lambda$ is the ampoule's permeation rate constant. Collecting $K$, $G$, $R$, and $T$ into $\lambda$ is useful because $\lambda$ is the quantity that can be measured directly during an experiment (§**??**), whereas $K$ and $G$ cannot be separated without independent knowledge of the ampoule geometry.

The geometric factor $G$ for a cylindrical membrane with negligible permeation through the top or bottom is determined using the effective area of permeation given by Masaryk, 1968:

$$G = \frac{2}{a^2 \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)} \tag{1.5}$$

where $a$ is the cylinder's internal radius, and $b$ is the external radius. There

is no dependence on the cylinder length when permeation through the top and bottom are negligible. This geometric constant will vary according to the experimental design and therefore must be measured by the experimentalist.

Equation (**??**) is only strictly valid with two assumptions:

1. The helium partial pressure in the "measurable" reservoir outside of the ampoule is negligible compared to the partial pressure within the ampoule. Because the ratio of typical ampoule and the diffusion cell volumes is ~1/10,000 (Farley, Reiners, et al., 1999), this assumption is essentially always reasonable.

2. The helium concentration profile within the ampoule's glass walls is in diffusive steady state between the inner and outer walls. The real steady state helium concentration profile is well-approximated by the ideal steady state profile for ampoules with a glass/gas volume ratio less than 2 (Figs. **??**, **??**). For these ampoules, (**??**) is accurate to within 1% after the establishment of a diffusive steady state. Additionally, the diffusive steady state assumption is ephemerally violated when the temperature is changed due to the temperature dependence of the glass/gas partitioning of helium. The ampoule should therefore be held at the permeation temperature for at least one diffusive timescale $\tau = L^2/D$ after every temperature change before measuring, where $L$ is the wall thickness and $D$ the diffusivity of helium in silica glass (Swets et al., 1961). In this work, low-temperature heating steps are repeated to allow for the new diffusive steady state concentration profile to become established. The ampoules of this work reach diffusive equilibrium in 30-70 minutes at 80° (Fig. **??**, supplementary figures 10 and 11). Comparisons between the abundance of helium within glass as a function of temperature limits the error introduced by thermal perturbation to less than 5% (supplementary figure 9).

## 1.4 Experimental Approaches Addressing Permeation Lag

A combination of analytical and experimental methods may be used to correct for permeation lag and properly account for all helium evolved from the sample. Some common practices for noble gas measurements may introduce error when using this method. For example, it is common practice to purify

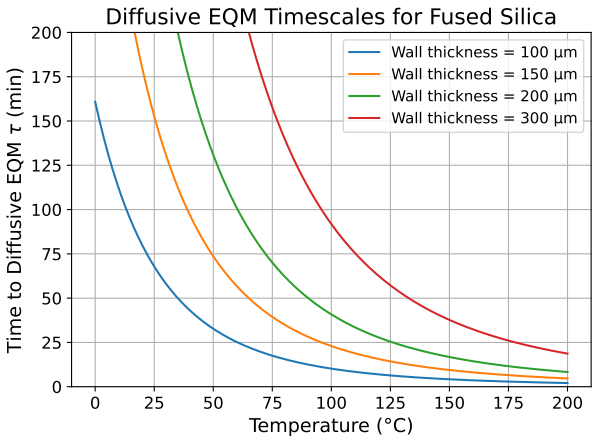



Figure 1.7: Timescales as a function of temperature to reestablish a steady state diffusive concentration profile for different glass thicknesses. These curves correspond to the timescales at which the Fourier number equals 1. 4He diffusivities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

and collect emitted helium with the diffusion cell open to the vacuum line at room temperature for extended times, often 15-30 minutes, and it is assumed that no additional helium evolution occurs. This assumption is reasonable for commonly measured geological materials, but it can be problematic when unexamined during permeation steps of silica glass encapsulated materials because helium permeation in silica glass is significant even at room temperature. In this work, permeation during these waiting times is often mathematically corrected for using Eq. (**??**), assuming permeation continues at room temperature. Alternatively, there are experimental approaches to address ongoing permeation during these waiting periods: they may be shortened to minimize their impact on the measurement, or the ampoule may be held at the warm permeation temperature during the gas purification and cryofocusing processes, so that permeation continues at the same temperature during this time without introducing complicated thermal histories.

From Eq. (**??**), it is immediately clear that when the evolved helium $\omega$ is large with respect to the amount of helium within the ampoule, $n_t$ or $n_0$, then $\omega \approx m$ and permeation lag can be neglected. Unfortunately, this is not the case for most phases commonly subjected to helium step heat experiments with routine heating schedules (e.g. hour-timescale steps at 100-400°C for apatite or zircon), but it is sometimes possible to design an experiment with long time-steps where the total evolved helium is large compared to the amount of helium in-residence

within the tube. Nonetheless, permeation lag can be quantified and corrected for in *any* experiment where the encapsulated material is effectively closed to helium loss at room temperature. Two approaches are described here to recover the helium evolved from an encapsulated sample ($\omega$) from measured amounts ($m$): the *permeation step method* (§**??**), which measures the ampoule's helium inventory directly between experimental steps, and the *bounding method* (§**??**), which constrains that inventory from above when it cannot be measured. Both require the ampoule's permeation rate constant, which should be measured during the experiment itself rather than assumed from the literature (§**??**).

**The Permeation Step Method**

In typical experimental heating steps, there are two fluxes of helium controlling the ampoule's helium abundance: an influx of helium evolved from the sample and an outflux of helium due to permeation. For lower temperature steps, for which helium release from the sample is negligible ($\omega = 0$), the helium abundance within the ampoule is controlled only by the process of helium permeation, simplifying Eq. (**??**) and allowing for Eqs. (**??**) and (**??**) to form a system of equations that can be solved for $n_t$ and $n_0$ given a measurement $m$ for an isothermal heating step of known duration.

$$n_0 = \frac{m}{{}^{He}F} \tag{1.6}$$

Where ${}^{He}F$ is the fractional permeation yield defined in Eq. (**??**). Such a low temperature heating step is hereby referred to as a *permeation step* in this work. A permeation step does double duty: through the step-to-step continuity of the ampoule's inventory, it constrains both the helium remaining after the preceding high temperature step and the helium inherited by the following one. Placing a permeation step after every high temperature *experimental step* ($\omega > 0$) therefore supplies $n_t$ and $n_0$ throughout the experiment, and Eq. (**??**) returns the helium evolved from the natural sample, $\omega$.

Equation (**??**) requires the rate constant of permeation for the ampoule in use, $\lambda = KGRT$. This may be assembled from the ampoule's measured dimensions through the geometric factor $G$ (Eq. (**??**)) together with a literature permeability coefficient $K$ for helium in fused silica, which has been measured repeatedly as a function of temperature (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Masaryk, 1968). Published values should not be relied upon, however,

especially for hydrothermal experiments: water entering the glass changes its permeability (Shelby, 1972; Tsuru et al., 2011), and water-bearing ampoules show anomalously high rate constants (§**??**). The rate constant should instead be measured on the ampoule actually in use, during the experiment itself (§**??**). That measurement is best understood as a prerequisite and extension of the permeation step method rather than as an alternative to it: the consecutive isothermal permeation steps it requires are already part of the method, so the only additional cost is the discipline of running enough of them in sequence.

**Measuring the Ampoule's Rate Constant In Situ**

The permeability coefficient $K$ of helium through nominally anhydrous silica glass is well known at relevant experimental temperatures for water-free glass (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Rogers et al., 1954; Masaryk, 1968). Literature values need not describe the ampoule actually in use. Water diffuses into glass and changes its helium permeability (Shelby, 1972; Tsuru et al., 2011), so $K$ drifts during hydrothermal experiments; and the volume occupied by a sample or buffering phase raises the effective rate constant above the value implied by the ampoule's nominal internal geometry (§**??**). Neither effect is captured by $G$ and a tabulated $K$.

Fortunately, the rate constant can be measured without knowing either quantity separately. Regardless of the values of $K$ and $G$, helium permeation through glass remains a first order process obeying Eq. (**??**), which is the recognizable decay equation written with the rate constant $\lambda = KGRT$ defined above:

$$n_t = n_0 e^{-\lambda t} \tag{1.7}$$

$\lambda$ can be experimentally determined alongside $n_0$ by using a non-linear least squares optimization to fit a consecutive series of at least three isothermal permeation step measurements to the following equation, expressed in terms of cumulative measured helium over cumulative time:

$$m_{cum} = n_0 \left(1 - e^{-\lambda t_{cum}}\right) \tag{1.8}$$

We fit individual step yields rather than cumulative yields, because cumulative fitting propagates the errors of early measurements into later measurements, unduly biasing the solver to fit the earlier measurements.

$$m_{i+1} = n_0 \left(1 - e^{-\lambda t_{i+1}}\right) - n_0 \left(1 - e^{-\lambda t_i}\right) \tag{1.9}$$

We used the Levenberg-Marquardt implementation in SciPy (Virtanen et al., 2020), weighted by each measurement's own uncertainty, with initial guesses $\lambda \approx 6 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$ and $n_0 \approx m_i / \left(1 - e^{-\lambda t_i}\right)$ evaluated at the first measurement of each series. Uncertainties come from the fit covariance matrices. The same optimization can be accomplished with the "Solver" function in Microsoft Excel.

This fit requires that enough cumulative time has passed to reveal the curvature of cumulative helium yield against time, or else the problem will be poorly conditioned. This can be assured in practice by waiting until the rate of helium permeation has slowed markedly after three or more isothermal permeation measurements before advancing to the next high-temperature experimental step. The exercise can technically be done with as few as two consecutive measurements, although the solver would then be unable to estimate uncertainties on the fit parameters.

In addition to the initial helium contents of the ampoule $n_0$, this procedure simultaneously determines the product of the permeability and geometric factor for the silica glass ampoule. Once $\lambda = KGRT$ has been satisfactorily constrained over a range of temperatures, the activation energy $E_a$ of permeation and the product of the geometric factor and permeability at infinite temperature, $K_0 G$, can be fit using linear regression. Determining these values allows for extrapolation of the permeability to the high temperatures of the experimental steps, which can be useful to an experimentalist who wishes to design a heating schedule wherein the permeation lag is negligible for some experimental steps but does not know the permeability coefficient $K$ and/or the geometric factor $G$.

The rate constant costs little to measure. A series of consecutive isothermal permeation steps is already required by the permeation step method (§**??**), so the additional expense is the discipline of running enough of them in sequence to resolve curvature rather than a single step in isolation. We therefore treat in-experiment measurement of $\lambda$ as a routine part of the permeation step method rather than as an optional refinement, and as indispensable for hydrothermal experiments, where the glass takes up water during the run and no tabulated

value can be expected to hold. Where $\lambda$ is measured repeatedly through an experiment, its drift can be tracked and interpolated; where it is measured once, it at least applies to the ampoule at hand rather than to an idealized dry one.

**The Bounding Method**

Permeation steps require a measurable signal at low temperature. When the encapsulated sample is retentive and its yields are small, the low-temperature signal can fall to blank level and Eq. (**??**) cannot be applied. An alternative is available when steps are long compared with the permeation timescale of the ampoule, which is common for retentive phases: rather than measuring the ampoule's residual helium, it can be bounded from above. Permeation lag is a significant effect for typical heating schedules operating on timescales of a few hours (e.g., Farley, 2000; Shuster, Farley, et al., 2004; Figs. **??** and **??**), but its relative significance decreases with step duration and increased temperature (Fig. **??**). Consider an arbitrarily long experimental step: after some time, a steady state $\left(\frac{dn}{dt} = 0\right)$ will be reached where the helium permeation rate out of the ampoule is balanced by the production rate of helium within the ampoule from the degassing of the natural sample. The upper bound for this steady state concentration as a function of measured helium abundance (Eq. (**??**)) is derived in the supplement, §**??** (Eq. (**??**)).

$$n^{ss} \leq \frac{m}{\lambda t - 1} \tag{1.10}$$

Equation (**??**) only applies when step heats are long enough (roughly 5-24 hours depending on temperature and ampoule geometry, Fig. **??**) to assume steady state permeation ($\lambda t >\sim 5$), which requires that G and K are known or can be conservatively estimated. It also assumes that the production rate of helium within the ampoule due to degassing of the encapsulated natural sample is constant over time at a given temperature. Typically, the helium production rate $\Omega$ decreases over time in most experiments, which would produce a smaller steady state He concentration than what is predicted by Eq. (**??**). $\Omega$ decreases over time for helium loss governed by volume diffusion (Wolf, Farley, and Silver, 1996; Reiners and Farley, 1999; Farley and McKeon, 2015; Farley, 2018; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024), or first order processes (O. V. Yakubovich, Y. A. Shukolyukov, et al., 2010; Wilson and Bisson, 1973), except for the case of

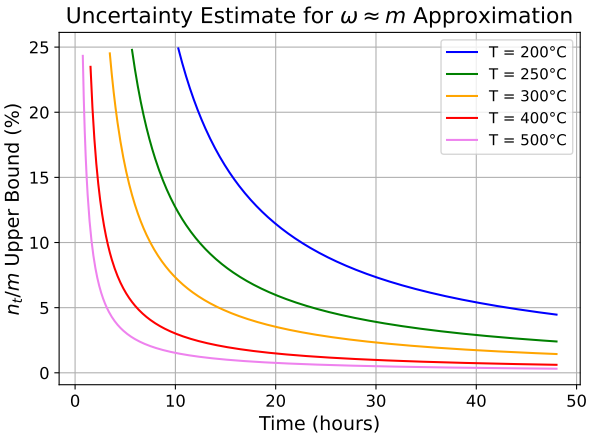



Figure 1.8: For long steps and high temperatures, the abundance of helium within the ampoule will reach a steady state and will be constant as the measurable helium outside the ampoule in the lamp cell increases. As the step gets longer, this amount becomes small relative to the amount of measurable helium, and the measurable helium can be used to approximate the total amount of degassed helium with only minor inaccuracy. Eq. (**??**) is plotted here to show the upper bound relative amount of helium trapped within the ampoule normalized to the measurable amount. The geometric factor for these calculations is 4350 $cm^{-2}$, corresponding to an ampoule with an inner and outer diameter of 0.6 and 1 mm respectively. Permeability values ($K$) are for 4He in silica glass and are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

initially inhomogeneous distributions at low helium loss fractions (Goldsmith et al., 2020; Ketcham et al., 2011; Shuster, Farley, et al., 2004; Farley, Wolf, et al., 1996) or radiation damage annealing (Cherniak, 2019; Guenthner et al., 2013; Flowers, Shuster, et al., 2007; Flowers, Ketcham, et al., 2009; Shuster, Flowers, et al., 2006). For experiments where these factors are of interest, the permeation step method (§**??**), which handles permeation lag explicitly, is superior. Additionally, Eq. (**??**) is conservative whenever the value of $\lambda$ used does not exceed the true one, because a lower bound on $\lambda$ yields an upper bound on the residual. Any $\lambda$ that can be independently shown to underestimate the ampoule's true rate constant is therefore admissible. The bounding method is consequently an excellent fallback when the small permeation step yields of retentive phases cannot be well resolved.

Using the steady state concentrations calculated with Eq. (**??**) from a long duration step (1) and the previous step (0) as upper bound estimates in Eq. (**??**) yields the inequality that can be used to bound the amount of helium evolved

from the sample during step 1 without permeation steps:

$$m_1 - \frac{m_0}{(\lambda t)_0 - 1} \leq \omega_1 \leq m_1 \left(1 + \frac{1}{(\lambda t)_1 - 1}\right) \tag{1.11}$$

The relative uncertainty $\left(\frac{m}{n^{ss}} = \frac{1}{\lambda t - 1}\right)$ is plotted in Fig. **??** as a function of time and temperature for a standard ampoule with geometric factor $G$ of 4350.26 $cm^{-2}$. To achieve relative uncertainties below ~ 5%, steps longer than 24 hours are typically required at temperatures below 300°C.

## 1.5 Analytical Methods

Permeabilities were calculated for the empty ampoule experiments by solving Eq. (**??**) for permeability $K$.

Besides the encapsulated Durango experiment, which contained a helium source, the helium contents ($n_0$, $n_t$) of the other ampoules changed only by decreasing due to helium permeation through silica glass throughout the experiments. These experiments were concluded when measured helium permeate of a high temperature step was indistinguishable from blank. The values of $n_0$ and $n_t$ for each step were directly quantified after the experiments concluded using the total yield. Assuming that the helium permeated during the short pump-out time of the lamp cell is negligible, the total yield is simply the sum of all the measured abundances of helium for each step. The atmosphere-equilibrated empty tube experiment on the Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer was pumped for 15 minutes between steps, the encapsulated apatite experiment was pumped for 5 minutes between steps, and the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ experiments on silica glass ampoules equilibrated in 2-20 torr tank helium were pumped for only 1 minute between steps. This pump-out time was short enough to neglect for all but the atmosphere-equilibrated empty tube, whose longer 15-minute pump-out and short (45-minute) heated steps required small explicit pump-out and gas-preparation corrections using Eq. (**??**); see the supplement, §**??**, for the full derivation.

One high temperature measurement – the last step of the empty ampoule experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer – showed unusual, non-linear signal evolution and required a bespoke recalculation to recover its 4He and 3He yields; see the supplement, §**??**, for details.

The encapsulated apatite experiment included high temperature steps ranging

from 100-400°C, each preceded and followed by a sequence of two or three permeation steps. Equation (**??**) was applied to solve for the helium contents of the ampoule ($n_0$) between steps for permeability corrections. Only the last of each sequence of room temperature measurements (shown in **bold** in Table **??**) was used to solve for $n_0$ using Eq. (**??**), because the temperature records showed that the encapsulated apatite had not yet cooled to room temperature by the time the first permeation step at room temperature began, although each pair of permeation steps always yielded values of $n_0$ within uncertainty ($2\sigma$) of one another. Measured helium abundances of the other permeation steps taken before reestablishing an equilibrium steady state concentration profile (shown in *italics* in Table **??**) were added or subtracted to the $n_0$ value to propagate the determined helium contents of the ampoule back or forward in time to the high temperature experimental steps for permeation lag corrections using Eq. (**??**). Measurement uncertainties are estimated using standard deviations of sensitivities and blanks determined by standards. These measurement uncertainties are propagated through Eqs. (**??**) and (**??**) in quadrature, in addition to a general 10% uncertainty for the use of Eq. (**??**) following the recommendations of this work (see discussion). 4 of the 25 high temperature experimental steps of the encapsulated Durango apatite produced corrected yields within error ($2\sigma$) of 0 and were excluded from Fig. **??** (see figure caption). Uncertainty for a step's fractional cumulative yield was estimated as the sum of the uncertainty of its fractional yield plus the uncertainties of the measured fractional yields of all previous measurements, added in quadrature. The total yield was estimated based on the precisely-measured mass of the encapsulated Durango apatite (3.18 mg) and its helium concentration of 194.2 nccSTP/mg (Farley, 2000), a value independently verified in-lab (supplement, §**??**). No uncertainty in the total yield estimation is propagated through to the diffusivities reported here.

### Numerical Diffusive Permeation Model for Arbitrary Thermal History and Diffusive Disequilibrium

Most of the permeation measurements performed on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer were complicated by additional permeation occurring at variable temperature during long cooling times following high temperature experimental steps. Such a complication can be effectively avoided by limiting the duration of time for which the diffusion cell is opened to the rest of the

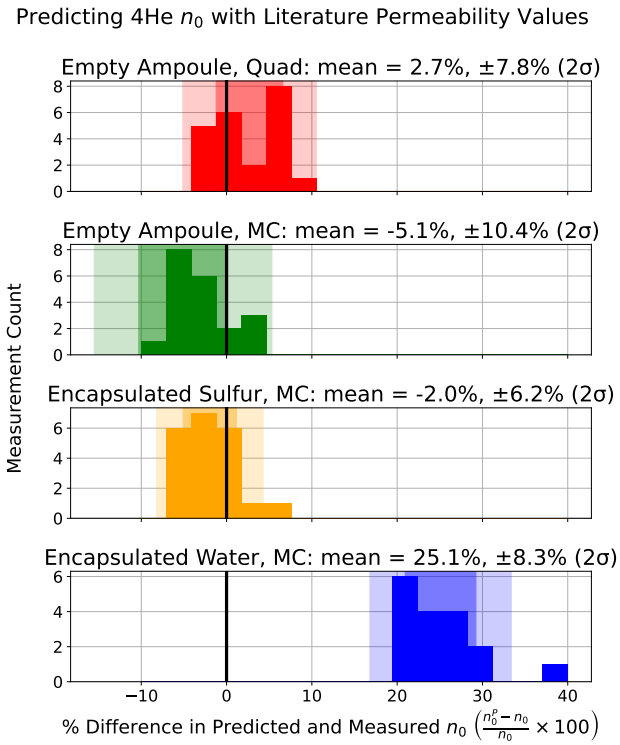



Figure 1.9: Histograms showing the accuracy of 4He $n_0$ predictions using permeabilities of Swets et al. (1961) from either Eq. (**??**) or a numerical diffusion model from the measured value, with shaded regions behind the histograms corresponding to 1 and 2 sigma ($\sigma$) from the average relative difference between measured and predicted values. The measured $n_0$ values of the empty and sulfur-filled ampoules are within $1\sigma$ of the predicted values, suggesting that the permeation model and literature values apply well to those systems, and such models can be used to reliably recover helium contents of permeating ampoules for use in permeation lag corrections. On the other hand, measured and predicted 4He $n_0$ for water-filled ampoules are well resolved beyond $2\sigma$, suggesting that their helium permeability differs strongly from the literature values. Internal reproducibilities ($1\sigma$) of a gas standard repeatedly analyzed during these experiments were better than 1% for 4He, requiring that most of the scatter in these data be related to factors outside of analytical precision, such as long/inconsistent ramp times during heating or uncertainties or rounding of heating times.

vacuum line, or by keeping the sample at-temperature during this equilibration time. To address this, a numerical diffusive permeation model is used to calculate the ampoule's expected permeation fraction ($n_t/n_0$) for each step with a complex thermal history (see supplement, §**??**, for details).

## 1.6 Results

Predicted and measured fractional yields for all permeation steps agree well (within $1\sigma$; Fig. **??**, supplementary Figs. **??**–**??**) with the predictive equations presented in this work and with the permeabilities reported by Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953) for the empty and sulfur-filled ampoules across all studied temperatures (24-300°C) and step fractional yields (up to ~80%), but not for the water-filled ampoule.

Conversely, helium permeation for the ampoule containing water was inconsistent with the permeabilities reported by Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953). For these hydrothermal step heat experiments, measured helium partial yields are systematically high by about 25% relative to the expected values (supplementary Figs. **??**, **??**), meaning that permeation was systematically faster than expected for the ampoule filled with water. An analysis of this discrepancy and a hypothesis for its origin is presented in the discussion.

Permeation ratios for 3He and 4He measured in the empty tube experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer are plotted in supplementary Fig. **??**. These data present significant scatter, but generally agree with the reported results of Jones (1953), except for measurements at room temperature, which cluster tightly at a permeation ratio of 1:1 for the two isotopes. Additionally, fields corresponding to the ratios of apparent permeabilities for the water-filled and sulfur-filled experiments are plotted for the temperature ranges of those experiments. Results for those experiments are plotted as fields because each step integrated permeation behavior over a complex (non-isothermal) cooling history. These experiments also agree with the results of Jones (1953) and the empty ampoule experiment. The qualitative result of Jones (1953) that silica glass is only slightly more permeable for 3He than 4He is supported by these data, which are in marked contrast to the reported extreme differences in 3He and 4He diffusivity in silica glass of McMurtry et al. (2019), who report instantaneous isotopic fractionations up to a factor of 1000.

The permeation lag-corrected helium diffusivities for the encapsulated Durango apatite experiment are within uncertainty of the Arrhenius relationship for 150µm radii Durango apatite reported by Farley (2000), except for the first two plotted points and the 400°C step (Fig. **??**). Farley (2000) also observed some low apparent diffusivities for helium in Durango apatite in early steps,

although rounding of the concentration profile by diffusive loss or alpha ejection is not expected for interior fragments of large gemmy apatites. The high temperature downward curvature of the apparent diffusivities in Fig. **??**, however, is well-understood. Wolf, Farley, and Silver (1996) and Farley (2000) discuss similar downward curvature of the diffusion array of Durango apatite at high temperatures. The annealing of radiation damage 'traps' and crystalline defects is the favored explanation for this irreversible change in diffusivity at high temperatures for Durango apatite (Farley, 2000; Shuster, Flowers, et al., 2006). Overall, the permeation lag-corrected apparent diffusivities for encapsulated Durango Apatite reproduce the same results of unencapsulated Durango apatite (Fig. **??**), suggesting that permeation lag can be reasonably deconvolved from thermal helium emission from minerals or other solid materials of interest when performing step heat experiments to characterize helium retentivity and loss mechanisms in solids.

Table 1.3: Step heat data for the silica glass encapsulated Durango apatite experiment. ${}^{He}F_{Apatite}$ is the permeation lag-corrected cumulative fractional yield of helium released from the apatite. $n_0$ values (initial $^4$He content of the ampoule, Eq. (**??**)) are shown in **bold** for permeation steps used directly to solve for $n_0$, and in *italics* for all other steps, where $n_0$ is instead propagated forward or backward in time from the nearest bolded permeation step using Eq. (**??**). Blank "Type" entries denote room-temperature measurements preceding the permeation step used to solve for $n_0$, taken before the diffusive steady state concentration profile was reestablished (see text). Uncertainties are $2\sigma$. Corrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ values shown as "–" correspond to steps where the corrected apatite yield ($\omega$) was within $2\sigma$ of 0 and were excluded from the Arrhenius plot (Fig. **??**).

| Type | Time (min) | Temp. (°C) | $m$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $n_0$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $\omega$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | ${}^{He}F_{Apatite}$ | Corrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ | Uncorrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Permeation | 15 | 24.3 | 0.00704 ± 0.00046 | **1.48 ± 0.18** | | | | |
| Experimental | 240 | 100.0 | 0.1700 ± 0.0011 | *1.47 ± 0.18* | 0.05 ± 0.24 | 0.00803% | – | -28.39 |
| | 15 | 28.0 | 0.00721 ± 0.00039 | *1.35 ± 0.16* | | | | |
| | 15 | 24.0 | 0.00639 ± 0.00039 | *1.34 ± 0.16* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.00630 ± 0.00039 | **1.34 ± 0.16** | | | | |
| Experimental | 240 | 150.0 | 0.3090 ± 0.0023 | *1.33 ± 0.16* | 0.01 ± 0.21 | 0.00983% | – | -26.98 |
| | 15 | 28.1 | 0.00542 ± 0.00039 | *1.03 ± 0.13* | | | | |
| | 15 | 24.3 | 0.00484 ± 0.00039 | *1.03 ± 0.13* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.2 | 0.00485 ± 0.00039 | **1.02 ± 0.13** | | | | |
| Experimental | 240 | 200.1 | 0.9416 ± 0.0085 | *1.02 ± 0.13* | 1.64 ± 0.23 | 0.276% | -23.80 ± 0.28 | -25.02 |
| | 15 | 29.9 | 0.00947 ± 0.00041 | *1.72 ± 0.19* | | | | |
| | 15 | 23.8 | 0.00786 ± 0.00040 | *1.71 ± 0.19* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.00804 ± 0.00040 | **1.70 ± 0.19** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 250.2 | 1.097 ± 0.011 | *1.69 ± 0.19* | 3.70 ± 0.48 | 0.874% | -20.21 ± 0.20 | -24.01 |
| | 15 | 33.0 | 0.02653 ± 0.00050 | *4.30 ± 0.44* | | | | |
| | 15 | 23.5 | 0.02016 ± 0.00046 | *4.27 ± 0.44* | | | | |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Type | Time (min) | Temp. (°C) | $m$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $n_0$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $\omega$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $^{He}F_{Apatite}$ | Corrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ | Uncorrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.02003 ± 0.00047 | **4.25 ± 0.44** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 270.3 | 2.508 ± 0.027 | *4.23 ± 0.44* | 5.26 ± 0.83 | 1.73% | -19.04 ± 0.22 | -22.51 |
| | 15 | 33.9 | 0.04414 ± 0.00067 | *6.98 ± 0.70* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.03246 ± 0.00057 | **6.93 ± 0.70** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 290.3 | 4.979 ± 0.058 | *6.90 ± 0.70* | 9.0 ± 1.3 | 3.18% | -17.87 ± 0.20 | -21.10 |
| | 15 | 33.6 | 0.06816 ± 0.00095 | *10.9 ± 1.1* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.05050 ± 0.00078 | **10.8 ± 1.1** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 300.3 | 7.243 ± 0.091 | *10.8 ± 1.1* | 9.5 ± 1.7 | 4.72% | -17.34 ± 0.25 | -20.07 |
| | 15 | 34.2 | 0.0843 ± 0.0012 | *13.1 ± 1.3* | | | | |
| | 15 | 23.5 | 0.06160 ± 0.00094 | *13.0 ± 1.3* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.1 | 0.06097 ± 0.00095 | **12.9 ± 1.3** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 285.3 | 5.919 ± 0.080 | *12.9 ± 1.3* | 3.6 ± 1.7 | 5.30% | -18.04 ± 0.71 | -20.65 |
| | 15 | 36.8 | 0.0729 ± 0.0011 | *10.5 ± 1.1* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.04846 ± 0.00084 | **10.4 ± 1.1** | | | | |
| Experimental | 80 | 275.2 | 5.382 ± 0.077 | *10.4 ± 1.1* | 2.5 ± 1.3 | 5.71% | -18.6 ± 1.1 | -19.80 |
| | 15 | 37.0 | 0.05243 ± 0.00092 | *7.53 ± 0.76* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.03487 ± 0.00070 | **7.48 ± 0.76** | | | | |
| Experimental | 100 | 255.2 | 3.382 ± 0.052 | *7.44 ± 0.76* | 0.60 ± 0.90 | 5.81% | – | -20.22 |
| | 15 | 37.1 | 0.03206 ± 0.00069 | *4.66 ± 0.48* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.02147 ± 0.00056 | **4.63 ± 0.48** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 300.3 | 3.684 ± 0.059 | *4.61 ± 0.48* | 6.68 ± 0.91 | 6.89% | -17.17 ± 0.20 | -20.76 |
| | 15 | 36.3 | 0.0518 ± 0.0010 | *7.60 ± 0.77* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.03513 ± 0.00077 | **7.55 ± 0.77** | | | | |
| Experimental | 120 | 300.2 | 9.78 ± 0.17 | *7.51 ± 0.77* | 11.1 ± 1.2 | 8.69% | -17.13 ± 0.22 | -19.21 |
| | 15 | 35.7 | 0.0595 ± 0.0012 | *8.85 ± 0.90* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.04087 ± 0.00089 | **8.79 ± 0.90** | | | | |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Type | Time (min) | Temp. (°C) | $m$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $n_0$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $\omega$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $^{He}F_{Apatite}$ | Corrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ | Uncorrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Experimental | 180 | 300.1 | 14.58 ± 0.27 | *8.75 ± 0.90* | 13.8 ± 1.2 | 10.9% | -17.08 ± 0.18 | -18.75 |
| | 15 | 35.9 | 0.0547 ± 0.0012 | *7.96 ± 0.81* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.03782 ± 0.00089 | **7.91 ± 0.81** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 320.3 | 7.49 ± 0.14 | *7.87 ± 0.81* | 11.4 ± 1.5 | 12.8% | -15.96 ± 0.18 | -17.94 |
| | 15 | 36.9 | 0.0813 ± 0.0017 | *11.7 ± 1.2* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.5 | 0.0541 ± 0.0012 | **11.7 ± 1.2** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 330.4 | 11.18 ± 0.22 | *11.6 ± 1.2* | 14.5 ± 1.9 | 15.1% | -15.54 ± 0.21 | -18.08 |
| | 15 | 37.4 | 0.1076 ± 0.0023 | *14.9 ± 1.5* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.7 | 0.0691 ± 0.0016 | **14.8 ± 1.5** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 350.4 | 19.78 ± 0.41 | *14.7 ± 1.5* | 28.3 ± 2.8 | 19.7% | -14.61 ± 0.15 | -18.11 |
| | 15 | 37.0 | 0.1615 ± 0.0035 | *23.3 ± 2.4* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.5 | 0.1071 ± 0.0024 | **23.1 ± 2.4** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 370.4 | 32.97 ± 0.71 | *23.0 ± 2.4* | 41.3 ± 4.0 | 26.4% | -13.90 ± 0.15 | -16.15 |
| | 15 | 37.3 | 0.2207 ± 0.0049 | *31.4 ± 3.2* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.5 | 0.1447 ± 0.0033 | **31.1 ± 3.2** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 385.4 | 42.32 ± 0.94 | *31.0 ± 3.2* | 44.8 ± 4.8 | 33.6% | -13.48 ± 0.17 | -15.41 |
| | 15 | 37.8 | 0.2393 ± 0.0055 | *33.5 ± 3.4* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.5 | 0.1548 ± 0.0037 | **33.2 ± 3.4** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 360.4 | 27.53 ± 0.64 | *33.1 ± 3.4* | 15.3 ± 4.1 | 36.1% | -14.35 ± 0.51 | -15.33 |
| | 15 | 39.6 | 0.1620 ± 0.0039 | *20.9 ± 2.1* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.6 | 0.0963 ± 0.0024 | **20.7 ± 2.1** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 340.4 | 14.78 ± 0.35 | *20.6 ± 2.1* | 7.4 ± 2.6 | 37.3% | -15.00 ± 0.90 | -15.63 |
| | 15 | 40.0 | 0.1029 ± 0.0026 | *13.2 ± 1.4* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.5 | 0.0610 ± 0.0017 | **13.1 ± 1.4** | | | | |
| Experimental | 100 | 325.2 | 12.37 ± 0.31 | *13.1 ± 1.4* | 6.8 ± 1.6 | 38.4% | -15.6 ± 1.1 | -13.69 |
| | 15 | 40.1 | 0.0589 ± 0.0017 | *7.50 ± 0.78* | | | | |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Type | Time (min) | Temp. (°C) | $m$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $n_0$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $\omega$ (nccSTP $^4$He) | $^{He}F_{Apatite}$ | Corrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ | Uncorrected $\ln(D/a^2)$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.0351 ± 0.0011 | **7.44 ± 0.78** | | | | |
| Experimental | 240 | 400.1 | 101.1 ± 2.7 | *7.40 ± 0.78* | 110.0 ± 3.2 | 56.2% | -13.281 ± 0.076 | -13.70 |
| | 15 | 34.9 | 0.1096 ± 0.0031 | *16.3 ± 1.7* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.8 | 0.0757 ± 0.0022 | **16.2 ± 1.7** | | | | |
| Experimental | 90 | 350.3 | 14.88 ± 0.41 | *16.1 ± 1.7* | 5.8 ± 1.9 | 57.2% | -14.92 ± 0.92 | -15.42 |
| | 15 | 39.5 | 0.0567 ± 0.0017 | *7.06 ± 0.74* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.0330 ± 0.0011 | **7.00 ± 0.74** | | | | |
| Experimental | 60 | 400.4 | 14.21 ± 0.40 | *6.97 ± 0.74* | 18.1 ± 1.4 | 60.1% | -13.31 ± 0.31 | -15.50 |
| | 15 | 40.4 | 0.0866 ± 0.0026 | *10.9 ± 1.1* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 24.0 | 0.0508 ± 0.0016 | **10.8 ± 1.1** | | | | |
| Experimental | 120 | 300.2 | 7.65 ± 0.22 | *10.7 ± 1.1* | 0.7 ± 1.2 | 60.2% | – | -16.50 |
| | 15 | 39.4 | 0.0291 ± 0.0011 | *3.79 ± 0.41* | | | | |
| Permeation | 15 | 23.7 | 0.01758 ± 0.00077 | **3.76 ± 0.41** | | | | |

## 1.7 Discussion

Except for ampoules with encapsulated water, the experimental results of this work are predicted within 10% when assuming the literature values for permeabilities for 4He from Swets et al. (1961) and the 3He/4He permeability ratio of Jones (1953). This suggests that permeation lag is a tractable complexity, enabling the use of fused silica ampoules to control the sulfur and water fugacity of helium step heat experiment, but that literature values for helium permeability do not apply to hydrothermal experiments, which instead require the ampoule's rate constant to be measured in situ (§**??**).

### Resolving the Paradoxically High Apparent Helium Permeability in Water Filled Tubes

The high measured permeability of helium for water-filled silica glass ampoules (supplementary Figs. **??**, **??**) is initially surprising and warrants further explanation, as the dissolved water and/or hydroxyl ion content of fused silica glass is only known to decrease helium permeability (Tsuru et al., 2011; Shelby, 1972; Masaryk, 1968). It is hypothesized here to result from an increase in the partial pressure of helium within the gas phase of the ampoule due to volume displacement of the gas phase by liquid water. This results from the low solubility and high diffusivity of helium in water, which allow for helium to be concentrated within the gas phase while remaining in equilibrium with the glass throughout the entire ampoule, even where obstructed by water.

The diffusivity of helium in water is about $7 \times 10^{-5}$ cm$^2$/s at room temperature (Verhallen et al., 1984), whereas the diffusivity of helium in glass is three orders of magnitude slower: about $2 \times 10^{-8}$ cm$^2$/s (Swets et al., 1961). Helium diffusion in water can be considered instantaneous relative to the timescales of helium diffusion through glass, so the helium concentration in the gas phase is expected to be in equilibrium with the glass throughout the entire tube even where mediated by liquid water. Therefore, adding water to an ampoule changes the volume available for the gas phase while not affecting the effective area of permeation.

Helium partial pressures in the gas phase can be increased by volume displacement assuming that helium strongly partitions into the gas phase over glass and water. Helium solubilities in water are similar to but slightly lower than glass. At room temperature, the solubility of helium in water is ~

$4 \times 10^{-6} \frac{moles}{m^3 * Pa}$ (Sander, 2015) or $\sim 2 \times 10^{17} \frac{atoms}{cm^3 * atm}$. The solubility of helium in silica glass is $\sim 6 \times 10^{17} \frac{atoms}{cm^3 * atm}$ (Swets et al., 1961), a factor of 3 higher. At room temperature, the concentration of helium atoms in glass and in water is about 3% and 1% respectively of the concentration of helium atoms in the gas phase (supplementary Eq. (**??**)). The net result of this differential partitioning is that the effective permeability of helium roughly scales with the inverse volume fraction of the gas phase, following the equation:

$$K_{eff} = K_{dry} \frac{V_{water} + V_{gas}}{V_{gas}} \tag{1.12}$$

Where $K_{eff}$ is the effective helium permeability, $K_{dry}$ is the nominal helium permeability at anhydrous conditions, and $V_{water}$ and $V_{gas}$ are the relative volumes of water and gas respectively. This effect is potentially larger than the decrease in helium permeability of fused silica glass due to elevated water contents; therefore an ampoule that is filled with significant water may paradoxically permeate helium faster than the same ampoule without water, despite the lower helium permeability of the glass itself.

**Evolving Helium Permeability in Water Filled Tubes**

Helium permeability measurements of water-filled ampoules show decreasing fractional yields for identical steps (Fig. **??**). This observation is consistent with previous studies that show decreased helium permeability in silica glass following hydrothermal treatment (Tsuru et al., 2011; Masaryk, 1968). Other studies have shown that diffusion of water in silica glass is complex, but it is always significantly slower than diffusion of helium in silica glass. At 250°C, the effective diffusivity of both hydroxyl groups and molecular water in silica glass is initially ~$10^{-11}$ $cm^2/s$ and further slows by a factor of 4 over the first 500 hours of observation (Oehler and Tomozawa, 2004). Helium, on the other hand, has a diffusivity of ~$10^{-6}$ $cm^2/s$ at 250°C (Swets et al., 1961). For a 200 µm thick silica ampoule, the diffusive timescale ($\tau = \frac{L^2}{D}$) of water is about 76 years, whereas the diffusive timescale of helium in the same ampoule is less than 7 minutes. Even so, we observe a gradual decrease in helium permeability of about 7% over the course of a few days at 100°C in this work (Fig. **??**). The implication of this observation is that the helium permeability in water-filled tubes must be continuously monitored by measuring the rate constant in situ (§**??**; Eqs. (**??**), (**??**)) during a hydrothermal step heat experiment to track (or

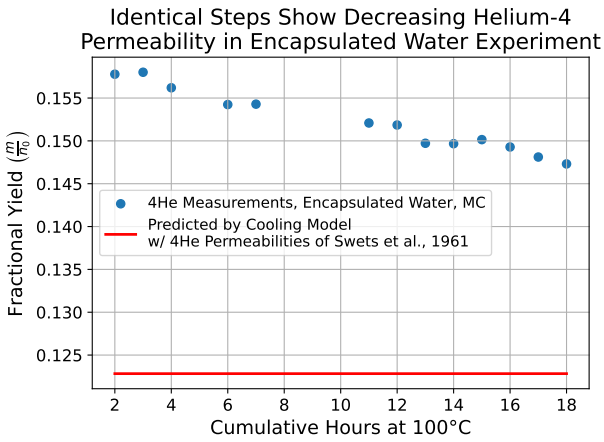



Figure 1.10: Identical permeation steps at 100°C with identical cooling times of the encapsulated water tube show higher 4He fractional yields than predicted with a numerical diffusion model and literature values of permeability from Swets et al. (1961). These identical steps also show a striking systematic decrease in fractional yields as the ampoule is held at 100°C, suggesting that the permeability of the ampoule is slowing during the experiment, possibly due to diffusion of water and hydroxyl groups into the silica glass (Tsuru et al., 2011; Oehler and Tomozawa, 2004). This trend is not visible in the 3He data due to higher scatter in the data.

exclude) significant temporal evolution of helium permeability throughout the experiment.

Previous studies have shown that the diffusion of water-derived species ($OH^-$, $H_2O$, $H^+$) into silica glass slows significantly as the water concentration increases within the glass (Oehler and Tomozawa, 2004; Davis and Tomozawa, 1995). Thus, it may be possible that a hydrothermal pretreatment (or early high-temperature heating steps) could sufficiently increase the trace water content of the silica glass for it to enter a regime of slower solubilization of water, thereby stabilizing the trace water content and helium permeability of silica glass for hydrothermal experiments. This hypothesis would be a fruitful direction for future work related to hydrothermal helium step heat experiments in silica glass ampoules.

## 1.8 Conclusions

Encapsulating minerals in pure silica glass allows helium step heat experiments to be conducted within controlled microenvironments of high water or sulfur partial pressure. Helium permeation through fused silica glass is a rapid but

non-instantaneous first-order process that complicates the interpretation of step heat data; however, its effects can be reliably deconvolved from the sample's true helium release using the equations and procedures described above. A general workflow combining the two approaches described above is suggested below:

1. Pull a fused silica tube (e.g., 3 mm inner diameter, 4 mm outer diameter stock) into a pipette with the desired inner diameter and wall thickness for the experiment.

2. Load the mineral sample and the desired buffering phase (e.g., water or sulfur) into the ampoule and seal it, taking care not to heat the sample itself during sealing.

3. If possible, measure the ampoule's inner and outer diameters with a calibrated microscope. This is not strictly necessary, but is helpful for planning the experiment: these measurements give the geometric factor $G$ (Eq. (**??**)), which, combined with literature permeability values, allows the rate constant of permeation $\lambda$ to be estimated in advance.

4. Before beginning the experiment, and after each high-temperature step thereafter, hold the ampoule at a permeation temperature low enough for the sample to be effectively closed to helium loss for at least the diffusive timescale $\tau = \frac{L^2}{D}$, where $L$ is the ampoule's wall thickness and $D$ is the diffusivity of helium in fused silica glass (e.g., from Swets et al., 1961). This resting period allows a steady state helium concentration profile to establish within the glass, which is required for accurate permeation corrections (Eqs. (**??**), (**??**)).

5. Perform the permeation step measurement after establishing the steady state concentration profile. Use this measurement to solve Eq. (**??**) to determine the residual helium content in the ampoule to recover the sample's helium yield using Eq. (**??**). Accounting for the helium lost during the permeation steps, this measurement applies for both the previous and subsequent high temperature experimental steps through the relation of Eq.(**??**).

6. At several points throughout the experiment, run a series of at least three consecutive permeation steps to determine the permeation rate

constant $\lambda$ in situ (§**??**; Eq. (**??**)). Do this in every experiment rather than relying on literature permeabilities, and repeat it through the run for hydrothermal experiments, where $\lambda$ may drift as the glass takes up water.

For high temperature experiments of retentive phases, where low temperature permeation steps may yield signals indistinguishable from blank, experimentalists may instead use the bounding method (§**??**) to constrain the ampoule's residual helium from above rather than measuring it. This requires only a lower bound on the rate constant of permeation at the experimental temperature, and can only be done for steps where $\lambda t > 5$. No permeation steps are necessary for this approach, although a series of them remains the most reliable way to establish the rate constant it depends on.

# Supplementary Information

for Chapter 1: *A Simple Method for Helium Step Heat Experiments at High Water or Sulfur Fugacity*

## 1.1s A Fick's Law Formulation Describing Helium Migration Across Semi-Permeable Membranes

We derive the relevant equations describing helium permeation through glass by beginning with Fick's Law, similarly to previous works (Rogers et al., 1954; Altemose, 1961).

$$J = -D\frac{d\varphi}{dx} \tag{1.13}$$

Where $J$ is the area-normalized Fickian diffusive flux in units of $\frac{atoms}{s \times cm^2}$, $D$ is the diffusivity (of helium in glass) in units of $\frac{cm^2}{s}$, and $\frac{d\varphi}{dx}$ is the concentration gradient, in units of $\frac{\left(\frac{atoms}{cm^3}\right)}{cm}$ or $\frac{atoms}{cm^4}$.

For steady state permeation across a planar membrane, the concentration gradient is constant. If we take $l$ to be the glass thickness and we rewrite the Fickian flux $J$ as $\frac{F}{A}$, where F is the absolute atom flux in units of $\frac{atoms}{s}$, and A is simply the membrane area, we can rewrite Fick's law as:

$$F = -DA\frac{\Delta\varphi}{l} \tag{1.14}$$

Finally, we assume that the concentration of helium within the glass membrane is Henrian, i.e. proportional to the gas pressure in contact with the membrane. Experimental work has shown that helium permeation through silica glass is Henrian at pressures of several hundred bars and lower (Shelby, 1976), well above the experimental helium partial pressures for this work. We define this proportionality factor as the solubility, $S$, in units of $\frac{atoms}{atm \times cm^3}$. Now we may write the expression in terms of the gas pressure gradient, or the difference of helium partial pressures on each side of the membrane.

$$F = -DA\frac{S\Delta P}{l} \tag{1.15}$$

Diffusivity and solubility are material properties that are functions of temperature following the Arrhenius equation, and therefore their mathematical product (permeability, $K$) also follows an Arrhenius relation with temperature (Rogers et al., 1954; Swets et al., 1961). Now, recognizing that K = DS, we may express the equation in terms of permeability $\frac{atoms}{s \times cm \times atm}$.

$$F = -\frac{KA\Delta P}{l} \tag{1.16}$$

Studt (1962) and Masaryk (1968) also use this equation to describe helium permeation through silica glass, taken from Darcy's Law for gas flow through semi-permeable membranes (Carman, 1956). This ordinary, first-order differential equation is well suited for describing permeation through a silica membrane when the permeate pressures on each side of the membrane are constant (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961). Cases where permeate partial pressure changes during the experiment (such as this work) require solving the first order ODE above to relate the abundance of an analyzed permeate to the abundance of unanalyzed permeate remaining in the depleting reservoir.

Recalling that F is an atomic flux in units of $\frac{atoms}{s}$ that could be notated as $\frac{dn}{dt}$:

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = -\frac{KA\Delta P}{l} \tag{1.17}$$

We assume that the helium partial pressure in the ultra-high vacuum (UHV) heating cell surrounding the ampoule is 0, so that the pressure gradient equals the partial pressure within the ampoule ($\Delta P = P$). This is a valid assumption for this work because the heating cell is 4-5 orders of magnitude more voluminous than the glass ampoule. The assumption therefore is only appreciably violated for the trivial case in which effectively all the helium present within the tube is permeated out and the helium partial pressures within and outside of the ampoule are equal. In this case, net helium flux goes to zero even though the ampoule is not entirely evacuated. Relative to the amount of helium within the ampoule at time 0 ($n_0$), the amount of helium remaining in the ampoule after infinite time *($n_{eqm}$)* will be set by the volume ratio of the ampoule and the lamp cell.

$$\frac{n_{eqm}}{n_0 - n_{eqm}} \approx \frac{n_{eqm}}{n_0} = \frac{V_{ampoule}}{V_{lamp\ cell}} \approx 10^{-4}$$

For this experimental setup, only 1 part in 10000 helium atoms will remain in the ampoule after infinite time in the closed heating cell.

Before integrating Eq. (**??**), it is useful to experimentalists working with mass spectrometry to express the pressure term $P$ in terms of atoms $n$, the atomic abundance of helium within the ampoule. Helium is well-approximated as an ideal gas at experimental conditions, so the ideal gas law (PV = nRT) relates the pressure, $P$, to the atomic abundance, $n$, yielding Eq. (**??**):

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = -\frac{AKnRT}{lV} \tag{1.18}$$

Where $R$ is the gas constant $\left(1.36 \times 10^{-22} \frac{cm^3 atm}{K\ atoms}\right)$, $T$ is the temperature in Kelvin, and $V$ is the volume in $cm^3$. It is now obvious that the helium atoms in the gas phase ($n$) decrease over time. Because Eq. (**??**) assumes a steady state helium concentration profile in the glass walls of the ampoule in equilibrium with the helium partial pressure inside the ampoule, one must make another essential assumption to continue: that the permeation timescale be small with respect to the diffusive timescale so that the helium concentration profile of the glass effectively remains in an equilibrium with the helium atoms in the gas phase ($n$). If the inner gas volume is small relative to the volume of the ampoule glass, then $\frac{dn}{dt}$ will be relatively large and the helium atoms in the gas phase ($n$) will decrease faster than diffusion's ability to maintain an equilibrium concentration profile in the glass, violating the assumption of a steady state concentration profile in equilibrium with the inner gas phase. Then, Eq. (**??**) and all equations derived from it will be invalid. In other words, the timescale of diffusion must be much smaller than the timescale of permeation ($\tau_D \ll \tau_P$) for Eq. (**??**) and all derived equations to apply. A more thorough analysis of this assumption is presented in *Diffusive Steady State Assumption for Permeation.*

Eq. (**??**) can be simplified by defining a geometric factor ($G$) in units of $cm^{-2}$ that incorporates the spatial parameters for area, volume, and length of the experimental glass ampoule:

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = -GKnRT \tag{1.19}$$

Eq. (**??**) can be integrated using a straightforward separation of variables to get a useful general equation describing helium reservoirs depleting via permeation.

$$n_t = n_0 e^{-KGRTt} \tag{1.20}$$

Where $n_t$ is the amount of helium atoms within the reservoir after time $t$ in seconds, and $n_0$ is the amount of helium atoms within the reservoir at time t = 0.

Eq. (**??**) can equivalently be expressed in terms of the fraction of the initial helium reservoir that has permeated during time $t$, which is often a more

intuitive quantity when relating this equation to a measured amount of helium. Defining the fractional permeation yield ${}^{He}F \equiv \frac{m}{n_0}$, where $m \equiv n_0 - n_t$ is the amount of helium permeated and available to be measured during time $t$, Eq. (**??**) can be recast as:

$$ {}^{He}F = \frac{m}{n_0} = 1 - e^{-KGRTt} \tag{1.21}$$

Eq. (**??**) can be solved for permeability ($K$) for use in experimentally determining permeability for experiments in which the permeating helium source is significantly depleted during the experiment, yielding Eq. (**??**):

$$ K = -\frac{\ln(n_t) - \ln(n_0)}{GRTt} \tag{1.22}$$

In typical experimental measurements of helium permeability through glass, permeation rates are measured in real time, and the pressure gradient is constant throughout the measurement, so an equation like Eq. (**??**) is used to solve for permeability instead (Norton, 1953; Swets et al., 1961; Altemose, 1961).

**Permeation Through Cylindrical Membranes**

For non-planar membranes, the effective area of permeation, $A$, is not straightforward to evaluate because the surface area on each side of the membrane differs. Masaryk (1968) gives the effective area of permeation for a cylinder (such as for this experiment) as:

$$ A = \frac{2\pi hl}{\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)} \tag{1.23}$$

Where $a$ is the cylinder's internal radius, $b$ is the cylinder's external radius, and $h$ is its length. This effective area of permeation (Eq. (**??**)) can be used with the equation for the internal volume of the cylinder: $V = h\pi a^2$ to evaluate the geometric factor $G$ (Eq. (**??**)) for a cylinder in terms of the ampoule geometry. Reducing yields Eq. (**??**):

$$ G = \frac{2}{a^2 \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)} \tag{1.24}$$

Interestingly, $h$ cancels so that the permeation rate has no dependence on the ampoule length when permeation through the top and bottom are negligible. Eq. (**??**) displays the intuitive behavior that thinner walls and narrower tubes lead to more efficient permeation. Where $G$ is used elsewhere in this work, it refers to the cylindrical geometric factor given in Eq. (**??**). Most silica ampoules sealed at Caltech for helium step heat experiments were 0.6-1.2 mm wide with 150-300 µm thick glass, translating to values of $G$ between 2000-7000 $cm^{-2}$. In this work, if no value of $G$ is specified, then a typical 200 µm thick ampoule with an outer diameter of 1 mm is assumed, corresponding to $a = 0.03$ cm, $b = 0.05$ cm and $G = 4350.26$ $cm^{-2}$.

## 1.2s Diffusive Steady State Concentration Profiles in Cylindrical Membranes

To establish a steady state concentration profile, the diffusive timescale must be much faster than the permeation timescale, otherwise the helium concentration profile within the glass will respond too slowly to maintain equilibrium with the rapidly depleting internal gas phase (Fig. **??**). The ratio of the permeation timescale and diffusive timescale is a strong function of the ratio of the ampoule's glass and internal gas volumes with a very minor dependence on temperature (Fig. **??** below). An ampoule with a glass/gas volume ratio of 2 has a diffusive timescale that is ~5.6% of the permeation timescale (Eq. (**??**) below). Numerical diffusion-permeation simulations show that Eq. (**??**) accrues less than 1% error due to deviation from the idealized helium concentration profile (Figs. **??** and **??** below). Smaller glass/gas volume ratios are better: the ampoules in the main text have glass/gas volume ratios ~1.25-1.5. Numerical simulations show that this error is determined nearly entirely by the volume ratio of the ampoule glass and gas and is otherwise insensitive to ampoule geometry (Figs. **??** and **??** below).

The derivation for Eq. (**??**) always assumes an equilibrium steady state helium concentration profile across the ampoule. The most important corollary of this assumption is that the timescale of permeation must be much larger than the diffusive timescale ($\tau_D \ll \tau_P$) for Eq. (**??**) and all derived equations to apply. An analysis is presented here exploring the ampoule geometries that permit the use of the analytical solutions for helium permeation through silica glass.

The diffusive timescale is the timescale at which diffusion is generally expected

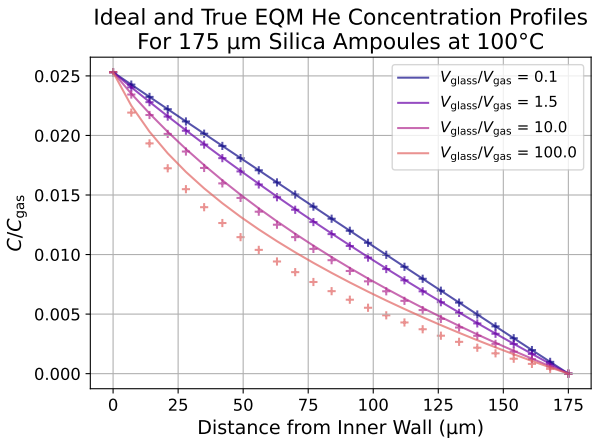



Figure 1.11: A visualization of ideal diffusive steady state concentration profiles (demarcated by the '+' symbols) are contrasted with the numerically calculated "effective" steady state concentration profile, represented by the solid lines. These effective concentration profiles are not strictly in steady state, but they are effectively in equilibrium with a rapidly decreasing internal helium reservoir. These profiles are retrieved by numerically simulating a model ampoule permeating helium for at least one diffusive timescale. At low glass/gas volume ratios, the idealized and true concentration profiles are indistinguishable. Ideal steady state concentration profiles for cylindrical membranes are strongly curved at high glass/gas volume ratios and become linear as the glass/gas volume ratio approaches 0. For closed ampoules where internal pressure is not constant, but instead decreases due to permeation, the internal pressure decreases faster than the glass concentration profile can respond to the new internal helium pressure, so the concentrations are higher (and less curved) than the ideal profile, because of memory of higher internal helium pressures. 4He diffusivities and solubilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

to establish a steady state concentration profile between two (effectively) constant reservoirs. For a diffusive domain size $L$, the timescale is given as:

$$\tau_D = \frac{L^2}{D} \tag{1.25}$$

The permeation timescale is analogous to an "e-folding time" or "mean life" in radioactive decay, the time after which point the original abundance of something decaying by a first order process following the form $\frac{dn}{dt} = -\lambda n$ would have decreased by a factor of Euler's number $(1/e)$. After one permeation timescale has passed, more than half of the original helium has permeated through the ampoule walls, leading to the intuition that the dimensionless timescale ratio $\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P} \ll 1$ in order for Eq. (**??**) and Eq. (**??**) to apply, because

only vanishingly small changes in the total helium are allowed within one diffusive timescale in order for an equilibrium helium concentration profile to be stabilized and maintained.

$$\tau_P = \frac{1}{\lambda} = \frac{1}{GRTK} \tag{1.26}$$

The ratio of these two timescales is a weak function of temperature and a strong function of the ratio of ampoule glass and internal gas volumes $\left(\frac{V_{glass}}{V_{gas}}\right)$ (Fig. **??**). By the equation for the volume of cylinders:

$$V_{\frac{glass}{gas}} = \frac{h\pi\left(b^2 - a^2\right)}{h\pi a^2} = \frac{\left(b^2 - a^2\right)}{a^2} \tag{1.27}$$

$\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P}$ can be expanded and recast to be a function of only temperature and $V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}$. Recalling that L = b-a and K = SD, and the identity of $G$ for cylinders from Eq. (**??**).

$$\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P} = \frac{L^2}{D}GRTK = \frac{(b-a)^2}{D}\frac{2}{a^2\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)}RTSD$$

Factoring $(b^2 - a^2) = (b-a)(b+a)$, substituting, and simplifying:

$$\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P} = V_{\frac{glass}{gas}} \bullet \frac{(b-a)}{(b+a)}\frac{2}{\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)}RTS$$

Now using Eq. (**??**) to relate the terms containing $a$ and $b$ to $V_{glass/gas}$, all spatial terms can be expressed in terms of this ratio.

$$\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) = \sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}} + 1}$$

For example:

$$b = a\sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}} + 1}$$

$$(b-a) = a\left(-1 + \sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}} + 1}\right)$$

$$(b+a) = a\left(1+\sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}+1}\ \right)$$

$$\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P} = S(T)\bullet\ RT\ \bullet V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}\bullet\ \frac{-1+\sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}+1}}{1+\sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}+1}}\ \bullet\ \frac{2}{\ln\left(\sqrt{V_{\frac{glass}{gas}}+1}\right)} \quad (1.28)$$

Eq. (**??**) is plotted for three temperatures as a function of glass/gas volume ratio in Fig. **??**. $\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P}$ increases monotonically and nearly linearly in log-log space with the glass/gas volume ratio of ampoules, whereas temperature plays only a minor role. Ampoules with high glass/gas volume ratios and $\frac{\tau_D}{\tau_P}$ ratios can be considered "glass dominated". For these glass-dominated ampoules, the relative difference in surface area between the inner and outer surfaces is large; resulting in a more profoundly curved ideal concentration profile (Fig. **??** above, Eq. (**??**)). For glass dominated ampoules, this ideal curved concentration profile is only realized if the internal pressure is held constant, otherwise, this internal helium partial pressure decays rapidly due to permeation relative to the rate of diffusion within the glass, thereby stabilizing a helium concentration profile in the glass that will be less curved and higher than the idealized steady state of Eq. (**??**) (Fig. **??** above). When normalized to the concentration, quantity, or pressure of helium within the gas phase of the ampoule, this quasi-steady state concentration profile is reached within one diffusive timescale and remains constant as diffusion and permeation proceeds, regardless of the ratio of glass and gas volumes (this property was tested by varying the permeation time between one and ten diffusive timescales, which had no effect of the concentration profile normalized to the concentration, abundance, or partial pressure of helium in the gas phase). Indeed, all model ampoule calculations from Figs. **??**–**??** were initialized to have this effective steady state concentration profile, which is done by allowing the model ampoule to permeate and diffuse for one diffusive timescale, after which the concentration profile is multiplied by the simulated $\frac{n_0}{n_t}$ to renormalize it to the original helium contents of the ampoule. The helium content of the gas is then recalculated using the relation $n_{gas} = n_0 - n_{glass}$, and the permeated helium outside of the ampoule is reset to 0. Numerical simulations of model ampoules with glass/gas volume ratios above $\sim 0.1$ that were initialized to the ideal steady state of Eq. (**??**) recorded an early spike in relative error with Eq. (**??**) that

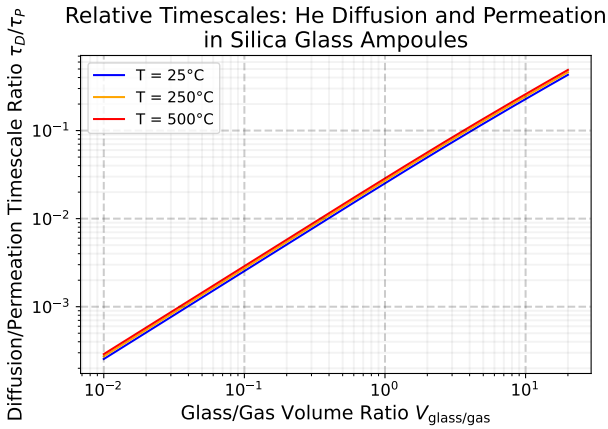



Figure 1.12: The accuracy of Eq. (**??**) and equations derived from it is dependent on a steady state concentration profile in equilibrium with the helium gas concentration inside the ampoule. If the timescale of permeation is comparable to or lower than the timescale of diffusion for the ampoule, then the gas concentration inside the ampoule will change faster than the response of the concentration profile within the glass, and these equations will become inaccurate. In other words, these equations are only accurate when $\tau_D/\tau_P \ll 1$. For helium permeation in silica glass ampoules, the ratio of the diffusive and permeation timescales is a strong function of the ratio of glass and gas volume, and a weak function of temperature. $\tau_D/\tau_P$ is nearly linear with $V_{glass}/V_{gas}$ in log-log space, forming subtly-offset parallel arrays at different temperatures. 4He solubilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

was maximized before one diffusive timescale because of an incorrect initial steady state assumption. This artifact vanished completely when the true steady state profile was used.

Numerical simulations of model ampoules of varying dimensions, thicknesses, and geometric factors show that the only geometric parameter that directly affects the accuracy of the analytical solutions, e.g. Eq. (**??**), is the glass/gas volume ratio of the ampoules (Figs. **??**–**??**). This geometric dependence is much more important than subtle effects of temperature (Figs. **??**; **??**). Ampoules from this work have glass/gas volume ratios between 1.2 and 1.6; for which Eq. (**??**) is accurate to within 1% for temperatures less than 500°C (Fig. **??**). For more precise handling, odd thermal schedules, or for ampoules with higher glass/gas volume ratios, permeation fractions would need to be numerically solved to achieve sufficient accuracy to use a permeation measurement to constrain the helium contents of an ampoule.

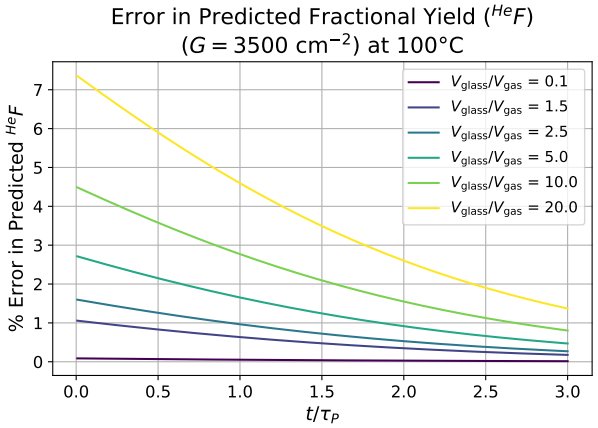



Figure 1.13: Numerical simulations confirm that Eq. (**??**) is accurate for ampoules with low glass/gas volume ratios. For ampoules with higher glass/gas volume ratios, the relative error is not constant but depends on the duration of the step. The relative error reaches a maximum at a step shorter than the permeation timescale ($\tau_P$) for ampoules with glass/gas volume ratios higher than 1, then decreases as steps continue and most of the original gas within the ampoule has been permeated. 4He diffusivities, solubilities, and permeabilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

To understand the steady state helium concentration profile in the glass, it is necessary to model the radial diffusion through a symmetrical, hollow cylinder. Carslaw and Jaeger (1959) give the equation for the change in concentration by diffusion in a cylinder (eqn. 5, page 17, second edition), expressed here in terms of concentration and diffusivity.

$$\frac{dC}{dt} = D\left[\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial C}{\partial r} + \frac{1}{r^2}\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial \theta^2} + \frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial z^2}\right] \tag{1.29}$$

For typical ampoules used in this work, the surface area of the top and bottom together is about 5-10% of the surface area of the walls, but they are neglected here for simplicity. Assuming that the concentration profiles are radially symmetrical and uniform with height (z), Eq. (**??**) is reduced to:

$$\frac{dC}{dt} = D\left[\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial C}{\partial r}\right] \tag{1.30}$$

At steady state, $\frac{dC}{dt} = 0$, so

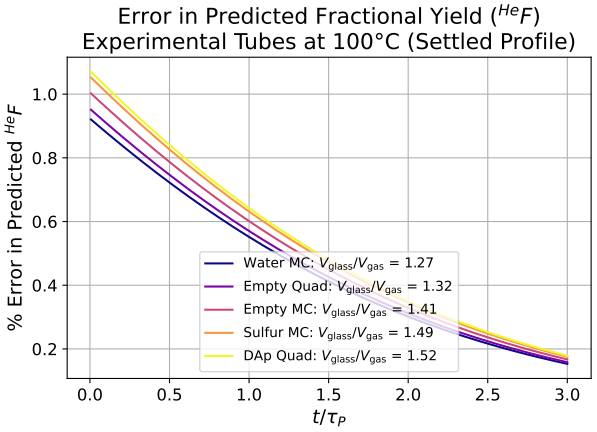



Figure 1.14: Numerical experiments of this work show that these equations will be accurate to within 1% for ampoule glass/gas volume ratios less than 2 for temperatures less than 500°C, which corresponds to $\tau_D/\tau_P < 0.056$. Experimental ampoules at Caltech have glass/gas volume ratios generally between 1.25 and 1.5, and thus Eq. (**??**) is accurate to within 1% for ampoules with concentration profiles in steady state. 4He diffusivities, solubilities, and permeabilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

$$\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial C}{\partial r} = 0$$

Which, by the product rule, can be expressed as:

$$\frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial}{\partial r}\left(r\frac{\partial C}{\partial r}\right) = 0$$

Now, the $\frac{1}{r}$ term can be dropped, and both sides can be integrated with respect to r to yield:

$$r\frac{\partial C}{\partial r} = A$$

Where $A$ is a constant of integration. Now both sides are integrated again with respect to r, leaving the equation describing the geometry of the diffusive steady state concentration profile of a cylinder (Eq. (**??**)):

$$\frac{\partial C}{\partial r} = \frac{A}{r}$$

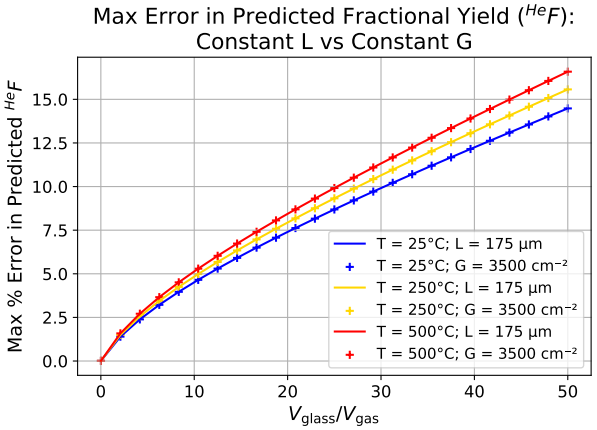



Figure 1.15: Numerical simulations of two suites of model ampoules with varying glass/gas volume ratios and a constant thickness ($L$) or permeation geometric factor ($G$) show that the only factors that determine the applicability of Eq. (**??**) for helium permeation of closed ampoules are glass/gas volume ratio (primarily) and temperature (secondarily). These two suites have different geometries and permeation rates, yet the deviation of the numerical model from Eq. (**??**) is the same for different ampoules with the same glass/gas volume ratio at the same temperature. This is clear evidence that the ratio of diffusive and permeation timescales is the primary control on the accuracy of Eq. (**??**). 4He diffusivities, solubilities, and permeabilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961).

$$C(r) = \int \frac{A}{r} dr$$

$$C(r) = Aln(r) + B \tag{1.31}$$

Where B is another constant of integration. Constants $A$ and $B$ can be solved for once the boundary conditions are defined, that is, the helium concentrations at the inner and outer walls of the glass ampoule. The concentration of helium at the outer wall is effectively 0 because the high vacuum heating cell is essentially an infinite volume compared to the glass ampoule. At the inner wall, the concentration is governed by the solubility and helium partial pressure of the encapsulated volume. Letting $a$ be the radius of the ampoule inner wall, $b$ be the radius of the outer wall, and $P_{He}^{gas}$ be the partial pressure of helium in the encapsulated gas of the ampoule, the following boundary conditions are enforced:

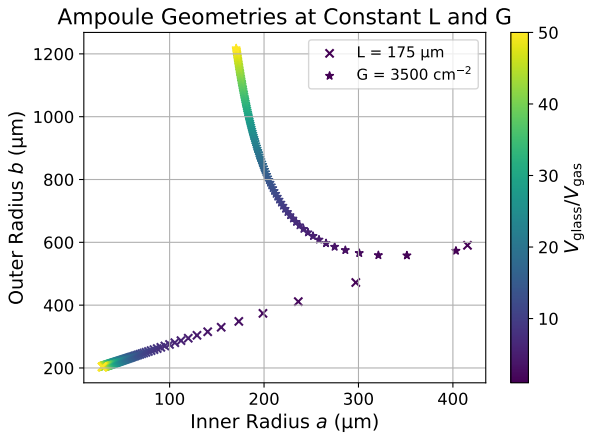



Figure 1.16: Model ampoules with uniformly distributed glass/gas volume ratios between 0.01 and 50 and one other constraint (either constant thickness or constant geometric permeation factor $G$, Eq. (**??**)) have defined inner and outer radii. These are the same suites of ampoules for which helium permeation was numerically simulated in Fig. **??**.

$$C(r = b) = 0$$

$$C(r = a) = S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas}$$

Now a system of equations can be formulated so that $A$ can be solved first, then $B$.

$$0 = Aln(b) + B$$

$$S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas} = Aln(a) + B$$

$$S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas} = Aln(a) - Aln(b)$$

$$S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas} = A\ ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)$$

$$A = \frac{S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas}}{ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)}$$

$$B = -\frac{S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas}}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)} ln(b)$$

Substituting $A$ and $B$ back into Eq. (**??**):

$$C(r) = \frac{S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas}}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)} \ln(r) - \frac{S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas}}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)} \ln(b)$$

$$C(r) = S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas} \bullet \frac{\ln\left(\frac{r}{b}\right)}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)} \tag{1.32}$$

Using the ideal gas law and the volume for the cylinder, the partial pressure of helium within the ampoule can be related to the geometry of the ampoule and the abundance of helium atoms within the ampoule:

$$P_{He}^{gas} = \frac{n_{He}^{gas} RT}{V_{gas}}$$

$$V_{gas} = \pi a^2 h$$

$$P_{He}^{gas} = \frac{n_{He}^{gas} RT}{\pi a^2 h}$$

$$C(r) = S(T) \bullet \frac{n_{He}^{gas} RT}{\pi a^2 h} \bullet \frac{\ln\left(\frac{r}{b}\right)}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)} \tag{1.33}$$

Where $h$ is the length of the ampoule.

Because the concentration profile of the ampoule is radially symmetrical, Eq. (**??**) can be expressed as a radial density of helium atoms instead to eliminate the dependence on $h$. The concentration ($C(r)\frac{atoms}{cm^3}$) can be converted into a radial density ($\epsilon(r)\frac{atoms}{cm}$) by multiplying by the circumference of a circle with radius $r$ and the cylinder height $h$.

$$\epsilon(r) = C(r) * 2\pi r h \tag{1.34}$$

Substituting in $C(r)$ from Eq. (**??**) and the geometric constant of permeation $G$ from Eq. (**??**) $\left(G = \frac{2}{a^2 \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right)} = -\frac{2}{a^2 \ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)}\right)$:

$$\epsilon(r) = \ S(T) \bullet \frac{2 n_{He}^{gas} r RT}{a^2} \bullet \frac{\ln\left(\frac{r}{b}\right)}{\ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)}$$

$$\epsilon(r) = \ -S(T) \bullet n_{He}^{gas} GRTr \ln\left(\frac{r}{b}\right) \tag{1.35}$$

To find the proportion of helium within the glass at steady state, the radial density is integrated from $r = a$ to $r = b$.

$$n_{He}^{glass} = \int_a^b \epsilon(r) dr = \int_a^b -S(T) \bullet n_{He}^{gas} GRTr \ln\left(\frac{r}{b}\right) dr$$

$$n_{He}^{glass} = -S(T) \bullet n_{He}^{gas} GRT \bullet \int_a^b \left[ rln(r) - rln(b) \right] dr$$

Applying the sum rule, then integration by parts to one term yields the indefinite integral:

$$\int \left[ rln(r) - rln(b) \right] dr = \frac{1}{2} r^2 \ln(r) - \frac{r^2}{4} - \frac{1}{2} r^2 \ln(b) + C$$

Evaluating the definite integral from the bounds of $r = a$ to $r = b$ yields:

$$\int_a^b \left[ rln(r) - rln(b) \right] dr = \frac{1}{2} b^2 \ln(b) - \frac{b^2}{4} - \frac{1}{2} b^2 \ln(b) - \frac{1}{2} a^2 \ln(a) + \frac{a^2}{4} + \frac{1}{2} a^2 \ln(b)$$

Reducing and simplifying:

$$\int_a^b \left[ rln(r) - rln(b) \right] dr = \frac{1}{2} a^2 \left( \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2} \right) - \frac{b^2}{4}$$

$$n_{He}^{glass} = -S(T) \bullet n_{He}^{gas} GRT \bullet \left( \frac{1}{2} a^2 \left( \ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2} \right) - \frac{b^2}{4} \right) \tag{1.36}$$

Eq. (**??**) can be easily expressed in terms of total helium in the ampoule by substituting for the relationship $n_{He}^{gas} = n_0 - n_{He}^{glass}$

$$n_{He}^{glass} = -S(T) \bullet \left(n_0 - n_{He}^{glass}\right) GRT \bullet \left(\frac{1}{2}a^2\left(\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\right) - \frac{b^2}{4}\right)$$

$$\frac{\left(n_0 - n_{He}^{glass}\right)}{n_{He}^{glass}} = \left[-S(T) \bullet GRT \bullet \left(\frac{1}{2}a^2\left(\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\right) - \frac{b^2}{4}\right)\right]^{-1}$$

$$\frac{n_0}{n_{He}^{glass}} = 1 + \left[-S(T) \bullet GRT \bullet \left(\frac{1}{2}a^2\left(\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\right) - \frac{b^2}{4}\right)\right]^{-1} \tag{1.37}$$

**A Numerical Model for Diffusive Permeation of Helium Through Silica Glass Ampoules**

A numerical model to estimate diffusive permeation is invaluable, as it provides a flexible way to estimate the permeation fraction $\left(\frac{m}{n_0}\right)$ even when the required assumptions for the analytical solutions are not met. For example, a numerical approach can calculate the expected permeation fraction for a non-isothermal time-temperature history, and it needn't obey the assumption that the helium concentration profile in the glass is in diffusive equilibrium with the partial pressure of helium in the encapsulated gas phase. As will be investigated below, the equilibrium concentration profile assumption is ephemerally broken when temperatures are changed, and for ampoules with high glass/gas ratios it is never true.

We numerically solve the radial diffusion equation for cylinders (Eq. (**??**)) using the Forward-Time Central-Space (FTCS) Finite Difference Method (FDM) along a radial transect of a model ampoule of arbitrary geometry for small, discrete time intervals. The system is spatially discretized into 100 cells along a radial transect, and numerical stability was ensured by solving for the time interval of a single step, $\Delta t$, such that $\frac{D\Delta t}{\Delta x^2} = 0.5$, satisfying the Courant-Friedrichs-Lewy (CFL) condition.

Helium concentrations along the transect (except for the boundaries, where r = a and r = b) are updated according to the following equation, an FTCS discretization of the radially symmetric diffusion equation for a cylinder (Eq. (**??**)):

$$\frac{dC_r}{dt} = D\left[\frac{\partial^2 C}{\partial r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{\partial C}{\partial r}\right]$$

$$\Delta C_r \approx \Delta t \ \bullet D\left[\frac{C_{r-\Delta r} - 2C_r + C_{r+\Delta r}}{\Delta r^2} + \frac{1}{r}\frac{C_{r+\Delta r} - C_{r-\Delta r}}{2\Delta r}\right] \tag{1.38}$$

Dirichlet boundary conditions were enforced at the inner and outer boundaries. The concentration at the model ampoule's outer boundary (where r = b) was held at 0, while the concentration at the inner boundary (where r = a) was calculated at each discrete step by multiplying the solubility (in units of $\frac{atoms}{atm \times cm^3}$) by the helium partial pressure within the ampoule, according to Eq. (**??**) or (**??**).

$$C_{He}^{glass} = S(T) \bullet P_{He}^{gas} \tag{1.39}$$

Eq. (**??**) can be related to the atomic abundance of helium in the gas phase using the ideal gas law and the formula for the volume of a cylinder:

$$P_{He}^{gas} = \frac{n_{gas} RT}{V_{gas}}$$

$$V_{gas} = \pi a^2 h$$

$$C_{He}^{glass} = S(T) \bullet \frac{n_{gas} RT}{\pi a^2 h} \tag{1.40}$$

For simulations where the internal pressure is not constant, $n_{gas}$ changes after every step and Eq. (**??**) is reapplied to the inner boundary cell where r = a. While the helium concentrations in the glass and in the encapsulated gas phase are both dependent on the length of the ampoule ($h$), they compensate for one another such that the absolute atom flux into and out of the ampoule is not a function of $h$. Within the numerical model, $h$ was varied by orders of magnitude and the results of the simulations did not change, confirming this property.

It is sometimes useful to normalize the helium concentration of the glass to the concentration of helium in the gas. To do this, the internal helium partial pressure is related to an atomic or molar concentration using the ideal gas law:

$$C_{He}^{gas} = \frac{n}{V} = \frac{P_{He}^{gas}}{RT}$$

The pressure term vanishes in the ratio of the two concentrations and depends only on temperature:

$$C_{He}^{glass/gas} = \frac{C_{He}^{glass}}{C_{He}^{gas}} = S(T) \bullet RT \tag{1.41}$$

Eq. (**??**) is plotted in Fig. **??**. It shows that this partitioning ratio strongly favors the gas and is only a weak function of temperature, varying between 2.5 and 2.8% between 0 and 300°C. This implies that departures from the equilibrium steady state assumption due to temperature changes will be small and perhaps negligible, which is confirmed in Fig. **??**.

In order to simulate permeation, the atomic abundances of helium within the gas phases both outside the ampoule (at high vacuum) and inside the ampoule must be tracked, as do the fluxes between the glass and these two gas phases. These fluxes were calculated simply as the diffusive flux in $\frac{atoms}{s \bullet cm^2}$ as is given by Fick's law (Eq. (**??**)). For spatially discrete cells throughout the ampoule at any radius except for the boundaries, the diffusive flux can be approximated with the finite difference:

$$J_r = -D\frac{\partial C_r}{\partial r} \approx -D\frac{C_{r+\Delta r} - C_{r-\Delta r}}{2\Delta r} \tag{1.42}$$

However, Eq. (**??**) cannot be applied at the ampoule's inner wall when r = a or outer wall when r = b because there is no remaining glass on one side of the cell. In that case, second order terms from Taylor expansions centered at $a + \Delta r$ and $b - \Delta r$ can be used to better approximate the $\frac{\partial C_a}{\partial r}$ and $\frac{\partial C_b}{\partial r}$ terms. Letting $f(r) = \frac{\partial C_r}{\partial r}$ and $f'(r) = \frac{\partial^2 C_r}{\partial r^2}$:

$$J_a = -D\frac{\partial C_a}{\partial r} \approx -D\left(\frac{\partial C_{a+\Delta r}}{\partial r} + \frac{\partial^2 C_{a+\Delta r}}{\partial r^2}\Delta r\right) \approx -D\left(\frac{C_{a+2\Delta r} - C_a}{2\Delta r} + \frac{C_a - 2C_{a+\Delta r} + C_{a+2\Delta r}}{2\Delta r^2}\Delta r\right) \tag{1.43}$$

$$J_b = -D\frac{\partial C_b}{\partial r} \approx -D\left(\frac{\partial C_{b-\Delta r}}{\partial r} - \frac{\partial^2 C_{b-\Delta r}}{\partial r^2}\Delta r\right) \approx -D\left(\frac{C_b - C_{b-2\Delta r}}{2\Delta r} - \frac{C_b - 2C_{b-\Delta r} + C_{b-2\Delta r}}{2\Delta r^2}\Delta r\right) \tag{1.44}$$

The helium contents in the measurable (external, high vacuum) reservoir and the inner encapsulated gas phase are updated every step using fluxes determined from Eq. (**??**) and (**??**) respectively. To convert these area-normalized fluxes into absolute atomic abundances, these fluxes are multiplied by the time

increment ($\Delta t$) and the surface area of the cylinder at the outer and inner walls respectively.

### Modeling permeation for ampoules that experienced complex thermal histories

In order to compare the experimental results for ampoules that experienced complex cooling histories with the expectations of the first order permeation model developed in this work, the numerical model developed above was used. The model predicts the relative helium permeation for the three experiments on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer for both 4He and 3He by simulating helium permeation of a model ampoule with the same dimensions and thermal history of the real experiment. For ampoules with multiple measurements of the geometric dimensions, the smaller set of measurements is used for the numerical model.

To simulate permeation during cooling of an ampoule, the temperature is decreased at every step following a parabolic rate law determined using the Watlow temperature records of the cooling ampoule. A parabolic function is fit to cooling rates evaluated as a function of temperature. Cooling rates were algorithmically calculated for discrete time intervals using the Watlow temperature files of the relevant ampoule in Python. Temperatures were taken to be the mid-point between the maximum and minimum temperatures of the interval over which the temperature change was evaluated. The quadratic functions fit to these data were forced to have a single root at T = 24°C so that the simulated ampoules would cool to a final temperature of 24°C, a common room temperature of the Noble Gas Laboratory at Caltech.

The model ampoules were initially assigned an arbitrary and unitless amount of helium, and the permeation predictions were output as step fractional yields $\left(\frac{n_t}{n_0}\right)$, where $n_0$ was the amount of helium in the ampoule at the beginning of the step. Before the first heating step was simulated, the ampoule was assumed to be in diffusive steady state at 24°C. Afterwards, the ampoule was not assumed to be in diffusive equilibrium except for isothermal steps at times longer than the diffusive timescale at that temperature, so that the concentration profile of the model ampoule was tracked throughout the entire heating history. For steps above room temperature, the ampoule was simulated to immediately transition to the target temperature, then the helium concentration profile, influx, and

outflux of the glass was tracked for the nominal (programmed) heating times for times smaller than the diffusive timescale at that temperature. After a heated step, an equilibrium concentration profile was reinitialized at that temperature only if the equilibrium equation (Eq. (**??**)) was used for permeation timescales longer than the diffusive timescale, then the temperature of the ampoule was cooled continuously according to the quadratic rate law determined from the experimental ampoule's thermal history while helium diffusion and permeation was continuously simulated.

**Errors related to violation of the steady state concentration profile assumption due to temperature change**

The equilibrium concentration profile is always a function of temperature because the partitioning of helium between the gas phase and the glass at the ampoule's inner boundary is temperature dependent (Shackelford et al., 1972). A new steady-state helium concentration profile must be established every time the temperature is changed. Because of this behavior, it is advantageous to characterize the timescales necessary to achieve a steady state diffusive profile at different temperatures, as well as the magnitude of the uncertainties that result from applying Eq. (**??**) immediately after a temperature change, when the diffusive steady state concentration profile is violated.

A new steady state concentration profile must first be established when the temperature is changed for Eq. (**??**) to strictly apply. It is possible to design experiments where permeation measurements are taken only after a diffusive steady state concentration profile is established within the ampoule, which is further discussed below.

It may unduly inconvenience the experimentalist to experimentally enforce the diffusive steady state condition when the uncertainties introduced by violating the assumption are small. In Fig. **??**, Eq. (**??**) is plotted for relevant experimental temperatures using the solubilities reported by Swets et al. (1961). Fig. **??** shows that the helium volume density of glass at the ampoule's inner boundary will be between 2.5 and 3% of the volume density of equilibrated gaseous helium. The overall variation in helium partitioning is small ($\leq$12%) across temperatures relevant to step heat experiments on encapsulated goethite (0-300°C). There will be excess helium within the glass when changing from a higher temperature experimental step ($\geq$175°C) to a lower temperature

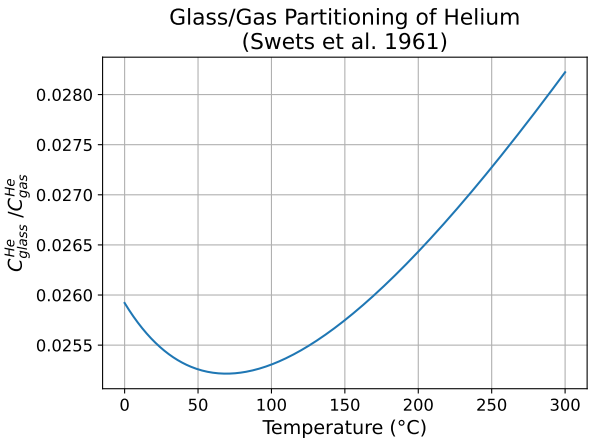



Figure 1.17: Helium preferentially partitions into the gas phase over silica glass. Eq. (**??**) is plotted here: $\frac{C^{glass}_{He}}{C^{gas}_{He}} = S \cdot RT$. It is the ratio of concentrations (in units of atoms/mL) for helium in silica glass over gas at equilibrium using solubility values of 4He from Swets et al. (1961). This partitioning is only a weak function of temperature, so the concentration ratio is between 2.5% and 2.9% for temperatures between 0 and 300°C.

permeation step (≤120°C) that would result in a slightly higher measured value than what would be predicted by Eq. (**??**). Other temperature shifts could also result in a deficit of dissolved helium instead of an excess (e.g. when shifting temperatures from 70°C to 25°C: Figs. **??**, **??**).

$$Disequilibrium\ Excess = \ n^{glass}_{He}\ (T_1) - n^{glass}_{He}\,(T_2) \tag{1.45}$$

The disequilibrium excess of Eq. (**??**) can be made into a relative error by dividing by the ideal amount of permeated helium measured in a permeation step from Eq. (**??**).

$$Relative\ Disequilibrium\ Error\ = \frac{n^{glass}_{He}\ (T_1) - n^{glass}_{He}\,(T_2)}{n_0(1 - e^{-\lambda(T_2)t})} \tag{1.46}$$

To evaluate Eq. (**??**) and (**??**), $n^{glass}_{He}$ must be calculated. An upper bound can be done by assuming a steady state diffusion profile and an ideal open tube geometry (with small tops and bottoms neglected for simplicity). Assuming that the helium partial pressure outside of the ampoule is 0 and defining the abundance of helium within the gas phase as $n^{gas}_{He}$ . The radial concentration profile at diffusive steady state as a function of radius and temperature is given

in Eq. (**??**). Radially integrated, the total amount of helium dissolved within the glass is given in Eq. (**??**), which can be solved for $n_{He}^{glass}$ , yielding Eq. (**??**).

$$n_{He}^{glass} = \frac{n_0}{1 + \left[-S(T) \bullet GRT \bullet \left(\frac{1}{2}a^2\left(\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\right) - \frac{b^2}{4}\right)\right]^{-1}} \tag{1.47}$$

Where $a$ is the radius of the ampoule's inner wall and $b$ is the radius of the ampoule's outer wall. For legibility, the terms that are not a function of temperature are grouped as the parameter $H$.

$$H = -GR \bullet \left(\frac{1}{2}a^2\left(\ln\left(\frac{b}{a}\right) + \frac{1}{2}\right) - \frac{b^2}{4}\right)$$

Now Eq. (**??**) can be expressed as:

$$n_{He}^{glass} = \frac{n_0}{\left(\frac{1}{HTS} + 1\right)}$$

$\frac{n_{He}^{glass}}{n_0}$, the fraction of helium atoms within the ampoule dissolved within glass, is a function only of temperature for a given ampoule. This quantity is evaluated using Eq. (**??**) for several tubes of varying glass/gas volume ratios that share a geometric factor for permeation of $G = 4350$ cm$^{-2}$ and plotted in Fig. **??**. Although these model tubes would all permeate helium at the same rate in diffusive steady state, they have different sizes, thicknesses, and relative internal (gas) and glass volumes, which affect how long they would need to achieve a steady state diffusive concentration profile after thermal perturbation and how severely diffusive disequilibrium would cause the amount of permeated helium to vary from the predicted amount from Eq. (**??**). Fig. **??** gives the intuitive result that ampoules containing more glass relative to gas will produce larger helium excesses/deficits when permeating immediately after thermal perturbation.

Now that the amount of helium atoms dissolved in the glass is defined as a function of temperature, Eq. (**??**) evaluated at the old and new temperatures ($T_1$ and $T_2$ respectively) can be substituted into Eq. (**??**) to estimate the relative measured helium excess caused by thermal perturbation as a function of time. Considering that the predicted value of $n_0$ is proportional to the measured amount of helium in a permeation step according to Eq. (**??**), the

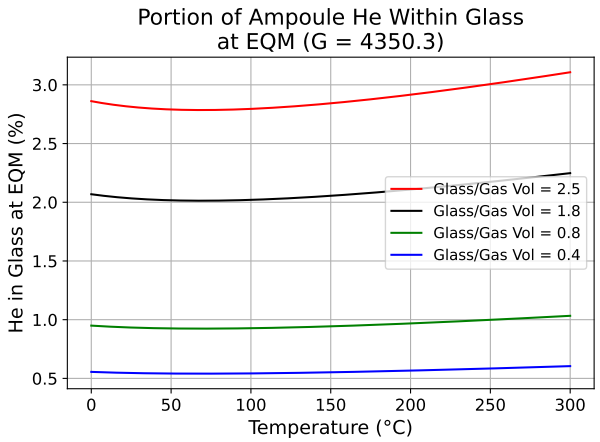



Figure 1.18: Most helium trapped within the ampoules of this work resides in the gas phase. Permeation from ampoules with more glass relative to gas will deviate more strongly from the expected permeation at diffusive steady state (Eq. (**??**)) after thermal perturbation. At diffusive equilibrium, the concentration of helium at the ampoule's inner wall is defined by the equilibrium concentration ratio with the gas phase plotted in Fig. **??**. The concentration at the outer wall is effectively 0. The concentration profile at any point along a transect through the tube is defined by Eq. (**??**). Eq. (**??**) integrates this concentration profile along the radius to calculate the total amount of helium within the glass, and this value is divided by the total amount of helium within the gas to show the relative distribution of helium between glass and gas for ampoules as a function of inner and outer radii and temperature. It is solved here using solubilities of 4He from Swets et al. (1961) for several tubes with varying glass/gas volume ratios that share the same geometric constant of permeation $G$. Red, black, green, and blue lines correspond to inner radii $a$ of 270, 300, 400, and 500 microns and outer radii of 507, 500, 533, and 601 microns respectively. The black line follows the "standard ampoule" of this work.

*Relative Disequilibrium Excess* defined below applies to both the measured value of helium atoms $m$ and to the calculated value of helium within the ampoule at the beginning of the permeation step $n_0$.

$$\textit{Relative Disequilibrium Excess} = \frac{\left(\frac{n_0}{\left(\frac{1}{HT_1S_1}+1\right)} - \frac{n_0}{\left(\frac{1}{HT_2S_2}+1\right)}\right)}{n_0(1-e^{-KGRT_2t})}$$

Upon factoring and simplifying, $n_0$ cancels out, removing the dependence of this error estimation on knowledge of the true initial helium content of the ampoule.

$$\textit{Relative Disequilibrium Excess} = \frac{\left(\frac{1}{\left(\frac{1}{HT_1S_1}+1\right)} - \frac{1}{\left(\frac{1}{HT_2S_2}+1\right)}\right)}{1-e^{-KGRT_2t}} \tag{1.48}$$

The relative excess helium that would be measured in a permeation step following a high-temperature experimental step is plotted in percent in Fig. **??** as a function of permeation time according to Eq. (**??**) for several initial experimental temperatures and permeation temperatures. This relative error decreases as the new equilibrium concentration profile is established, approaching the permeation behavior expected from Eq. (**??**). These excesses assume an instantaneous transition from experimental step to permeation step and therefore are upper bounds. These excesses are dependent also on the ampoule dimension; in Fig. **??**, a standard ampoule ($a = 0.03$ cm, $b = 0.05$ cm) is assumed. Thicker ampoules will produce higher magnitudes of excesses (or deficits) for the same heating schedules. Within the temperature range 0-300°C the maximum excess helium that could be introduced into a permeation step measurement due to diffusive disequilibrium would be for an 80°C permeation step following an experimental step at 300°C. Even for those circumstances, the maximum relative error would be $\leq$2% for a 3-hour permeation step (Fig. **??**). It is important to recognize, however, that this error estimation does not account for non-instantaneous cooling, although fast thermal response for similar experiments and the exponential temperature dependence of diffusion and permeation typically permit experimentalists to neglect fast but non-instantaneous heating and cooling (Farley, Reiners, et al., 1999). These calculations show that, at least for ampoules of similar dimensions to those sealed at Caltech, the error in Eq. (**??**) resulting from violating the diffusive steady state assumption of Eq. (**??**) is small.

For cases where more precise determinations of $n_0$ and $n_t$ from the application of Eq. (**??**) on a permeation step are desired, it is possible to experimentally ensure compliance with the diffusive steady state concentration assumption. For example, the ampoule could be programmed to be held at the target permeation temperature (for example, 80°C) immediately after a high temperature experimental step instead of completely cooling (to ~25°C) while evolved gasses are processed and helium is purified from the high temperature experimental step. To do this, one must be aware of the timescale necessary

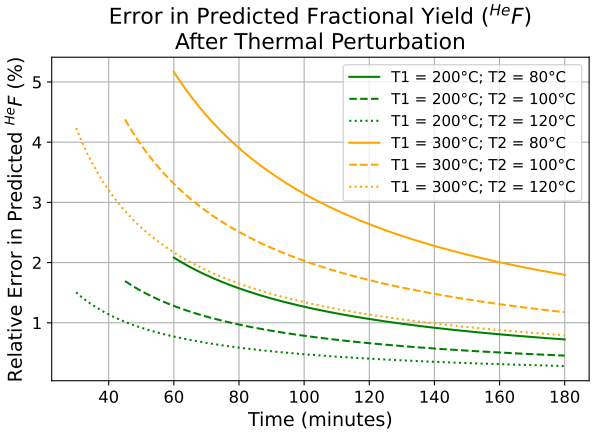



Figure 1.19: When changing temperatures, the inner boundary condition and diffusive steady state concentration profile of helium within a silica glass ampoule change, so the amount permeated will be different from the expected permeate amount of Eq. (**??**) that assumes a diffusive steady state profile has already been established at the new temperature. This difference is calculated here as the difference of helium dissolved within the tube at the starting and final temperature (neglecting the change in helium abundance in the gas phase) and is normalized to the expected permeation amount at the final temperature as a function of time for several temperature jumps, using Eq. (**??**) and solubilities of 4He from Swets et al. (1961) for a standard ampoule (with inner and outer radii of $a = 300$ microns and $b = 500$ microns respectively). Generally, larger temperature jumps produce larger relative errors. For a standard ampoule, the error of Eq. (**??**) will be less than 2% for any permeation step 3 hours or longer following a 300°C experimental step.

to reach diffusive equilibrium at a given temperature. At Caltech, helium purification after heating steps typically takes 30 minutes, which is only enough time to establish steady state concentration profiles for ampoules <175 µm thick at 100°C (main text Fig. **??**). For larger ampoules or cooler permeation step temperatures, an additional delay may need to be programmed in order to experimentally enforce the diffusive steady state assumption. Alternatively, expected permeation fractions for any arbitrary thermal schedule can be numerically solved, provided that the solubility and diffusivity are each known for the experimental temperature range.

The Fourier number can be used to determine the time necessary to establish diffusive equilibrium of the helium concentration profile within the ampoule. The Fourier number is a dimensionless number that describes the extent of diffusive equilibration or homogenization of a system by heat or mass transfer

given a characteristic length scale and time (Ostrogorsky and Glicksman, 2015). It is the time divided by the diffusive timescale:

$$Fo = \frac{Dt}{L^2} = \frac{t}{\tau} \tag{1.49}$$

Where $t$ is time and $L$ is the diffusive length scale. For the purposes of helium permeation through silica glass ampoules, $L$ is the glass thickness of the ampoule. When *Fo > 1*, a system is generally said to be effectively homogenized or at equilibrium with respect to diffusion, but it is somewhat arbitrary to define a specific Fourier number at which one can confidently say that diffusion has effectively re-established an equilibrium concentration profile (Ostrogorsky and Glicksman, 2015). To test the value of *Fo = 1* as the relevant minimum value, we use the numerical diffusive permeation model described above for a characteristic ampoule where a = 300 µm and b = 500 µm. Dirichlet boundary conditions are imposed at the ampoule's inner and outer boundaries, where r = a and r = b, holding $C^{Glass}_{r=b} = 0$ and $C^{Glass}_{r=a} = C^{Gas}_{He} \bullet \frac{C^{Glass}_{He}}{C^{Gas}_{He}}_{EQM}$ as calculated in Eq. (**??**) and plotted in Fig. **??**. For the analysis of the Fourier number during the approach to the diffusive equilibrium concentration profile in Figs. **??** and **??**, $C^{Gas}_{He}$ is arbitrary and held constant, so plotted concentrations are normalized to $C^{Gas}_{He}$. A steady state concentration profile (Eq. (**??**)) is taken as the initial condition. The absolute concentration is technically dependent on the ampoule height, but this dependence on $h$ vanishes when normalizing the glass concentration to the gas concentration. The results of these calculations are plotted in Figs. **??** and **??**, where Fig. **??** shows the transition from an equilibrium concentration profile at 300°C to 100°C, and Fig. **??** shows the more dramatic establishment of an equilibrium concentration profile at 100°C from an initial helium concentration of 0 throughout, such as could be expected after suddenly introducing helium into an ampoule that previously contained no helium. Both figures show that an equilibrium concentration profile is well-established for Fourier number *Fo = 1,* and Fig. **??** in particular shows that the difference in concentration profiles is small and nearly reestablished even when the Fourier number *Fo = 0.1.* We conclude that the timescale associated with *Fo = 1* is the relevant time needed to hold the ampoule to ensure that Eq. (**??**) strictly applies without errors due to thermally-forced disequilibrium in the helium concentration profile. The diffusive timescales associated with *Fo = 1* for permeability values taken from Swets et al. (1961)

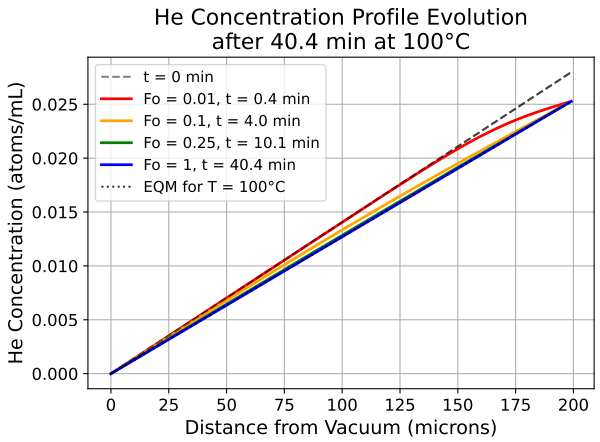



Figure 1.20: A numerical simulation of the evolution of 4He concentration profiles in silica glass ampoules from steady state at 300°C to steady state at 100°C. The steady state concentration profile is only subtly different for different temperatures. The diffusive timescale $\tau = L^2/D$ corresponding to a Fourier number of 1 is effectively sufficient to reestablish a steady state concentration profile at the new temperature. The concentration is arbitrary and is normalized to the concentration of helium in the gas phase of the ampoule, which is held constant for this simulation (therefore the ideal steady state of Eq. (**??**) applies regardless of the glass/gas volume ratio). The inner boundary condition is determined as a function of temperature using the values of Eq. (**??**), plotted in Fig. **??**. The ampoule simulated here is a standard ampoule with an outer radius of 500 microns and inner radius of 300 microns.

are plotted in main text Fig. **??** for a few different thickness values ($L$) as a function of temperature for typical permeation step temperatures used in this study.

## 1.3s Estimating permeation lag uncertainty for uncorrected, long heating steps

The uncertainty of the helium evolution of the encapsulated natural material during a heating step ($\omega$) due to permeation lag correction can be estimated by calculating the maximum possible helium residing in the tube between steps, i.e. for the values for $n_{0,}$ and $n_t$: $n_0^{UB}$ and $n_t^{UB}$. From the permeation lag equation (main text Eq. (**??**)), upper bound estimates for $n_{0,}$ and $n_t$ bound the encapsulated material contribution $\omega$ within:

$$m - n_0^{UB} \leq \omega \leq m + n_t^{UB} \tag{1.50}$$

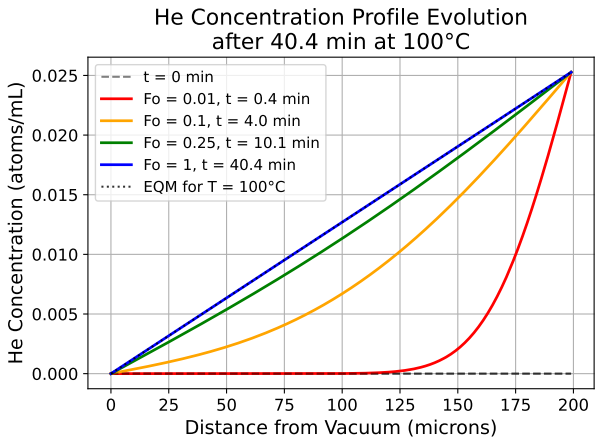



Figure 1.21: Similar to Fig. **??**, but starting from a helium concentration of 0 throughout the ampoule. This is most useful to visualize the incomplete establishment of a steady state concentration profile for timescales corresponding to Fourier numbers up to 0.25. When the Fourier number is 1, the concentration profile is in diffusive steady state.

Upper bounds for $n_t$ for a given high temperature experimental step can be calculated if step heats are long enough to assume steady state permeation, assuming G and K are known or can be conservatively estimated. To proceed, one must make the generally conservative assumption that the production rate of helium within the ampoule due to degassing of the encapsulated natural sample ($\Omega = \frac{\omega}{t}$) is constant over time at a given temperature. In reality, $\Omega$ will decrease over time for helium loss governed by first order processes (O. V. Yakubovich, Y. A. Shukolyukov, et al., 2010; Wilson and Bisson, 1973) or diffusion (except for the case of initially inhomogeneous distributions, the memory of which is often erased early in any diffusion experiment: Shuster, Farley, et al., 2004). Eq. (**??**), given below, shows that the amount of helium trapped in the tube ($n_t$) is proportional to the rate of helium outgassing from the natural encapsulated sample ($\Omega$), so the approximation that this rate is constant will overestimate the amount of unanalyzed helium remaining in the ampoule after a high temperature experimental step. The rate of helium degassing over time will decrease for degassing controlled by second-order volume diffusion *except* for the minor case of the alpha-ejection effect at low He-release fractions (Farley, Wolf, et al., 1996; Ketcham et al., 2011) or for the more serious effects of radiation damage annealing (Goldsmith et al., 2020) and mineral decomposition (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). In any case, sequential isothermal steps immediately reveal when $\frac{\omega}{t}$ increases over time.

A new first order differential equation like Eq. (**??**) is formulated, now incorporating a constant source term ($\Omega$) to conservatively approximate the helium influx into the ampoule from the degassing natural sample.

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = \Omega - \lambda n \tag{1.51}$$

Where $\Omega = \frac{\omega}{t}$ and $\lambda = KGRT$. Immediately, the steady state quantity of helium atoms ($n_{ss}$) present in the ampoule can be found by solving Eq. (**??**) for the steady state condition where $\frac{dn}{dt} = 0$.

$$n_{ss} = \frac{\Omega}{\lambda} = \frac{\omega}{\lambda t} \tag{1.52}$$

Additionally, the helium concentration within the ampoule during the approach to the steady state concentration can be solved for by integrating Eq. (**??**) with respect to $t$. First, the integrating factor for Eq. (**??**) is identified: $I = e^{\lambda t}$, which is multiplied to both sides to yield Eq. (**??**).

$$e^{\lambda t}\frac{dn}{dt} + e^{\lambda t}\lambda n = e^{\lambda t}\Omega \tag{1.53}$$

Then both sides are integrated with respect to *t:*

$$\int \left( e^{\lambda t}\frac{dn}{dt} + e^{\lambda t}\lambda n \right) dt = \int e^{\lambda t}\Omega dt$$

Because $\frac{d}{dt}(ne^{\lambda t}) = e^{\lambda t}\frac{dn}{dt} + e^{\lambda t}\lambda n$ by the product rule Eq. (**??**) reduces to:

$$n_t e^{\lambda t} = \frac{\Omega}{\lambda}e^{\lambda t} + C \tag{1.54}$$

Where $C$ is an unknown constant introduced by indefinite integration. This expression becomes more intuitive when both sides are divided by the integration factor and by substituting the steady state concentration from Eq. (**??**).

$$n_t = n_{ss} + Ce^{-\lambda t} \tag{1.55}$$

The integration constant $C$ can be solved by enforcing the condition that $n_t(t = 0) = n_0$, leading to:

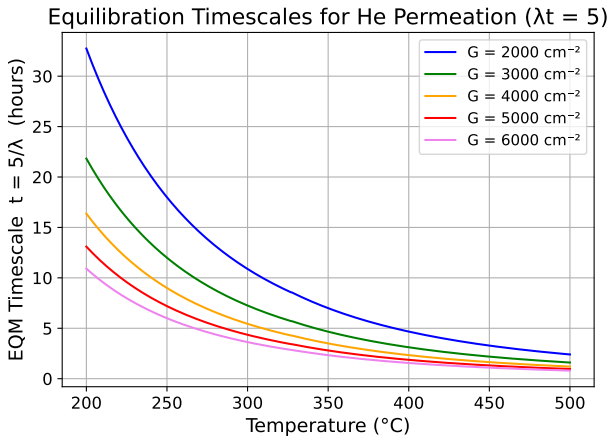



Figure 1.22: The upper limit of helium contents within the ampoule between high temperature experimental steps can be reasonably estimated without further measurement, provided permeative equilibrium has been reached. For typical ampoules with geometric factors between 3000 and 4000 $cm^{-2}$, this criterion is generally met for steps longer than 24 hours, or within 5 hours at 350°C or higher.

$$n_0 = n_{ss} + C \tag{1.56}$$

Solving Eq. (**??**) for $C$ and substituting into Eq. (**??**) yields Eq. (**??**). Now an inequality is assigned to the equation to reflect the initial assumption that the isothermal helium outgassing rate ($\Omega$) is constant *or decreasing*.

$$n_t \leq \ n_{ss} + (n_0 - n_{ss})\, e^{-\lambda t} \tag{1.57}$$

For long timescales (i.e. when $e^{-\lambda t} \approx 0$), Eq. (**??**) reduces to $n_t \leq \ n_{ss}$. This is effectively true for steps long enough such that $t \geq \frac{5}{\lambda}$, for which $e^{-\lambda t} \leq 0.007$. It is advisable to only consider the bounding method for steps of sufficiently long duration such that $t \geq \frac{5}{\lambda}$ so that the estimation for $n_t$ can be reduced to simply the steady state value and not be dependent upon the estimation for $n_0$ or its uncertainties. The timescales required to reach permeation equilibrium are plotted as a function of temperature in Fig. **??** below for some select values of $G$, the geometric factor.

To estimate the upper bound on the permeation lag ($n_t^{UB}$), one must consider the circumstances that would produce the highest possible value for $n_t$. In addition, the constraint that $t \geq \frac{5}{\lambda}$ is enforced so that previous heating steps

are not significant, simplifying the problem significantly. Because $n_t$ scales with $\omega$ by Eq. (**??**), the upper bound estimate $n_t^{UB}$ must assume the upper bound estimate for $\omega$, which is given in Eq. (**??**) as $m + n_t^{UB}$. Substituting $\omega^{UB} = m + n_t^{UB}$ into Eq. (**??**) to express $n_t^{UB}$ in terms of the measured value $m$:

$$n_t^{UB} = n_{ss}(\omega^{UB} = m + n_t^{UB}) = \frac{m + n_t^{UB}}{\lambda t}$$

Solving for $n_t^{UB}$ yields Eq. (**??**):

$$n_t^{UB} = \frac{m}{\lambda t - 1} \tag{1.58}$$

The upper bound amount of helium-4 within the ampoule normalized to the measured value in percent at steady state permeation is plotted in main text Fig. **??** using Eq. (**??**) $\left(\frac{n_t^{UB}}{m} = \frac{1}{\lambda t - 1}\right)$, assuming a standard tube where G = 4350.26 cm$^{-2}$ and the permeability values given in Swets et al. (1961). Main text Fig. **??** shows that, in order to push this uncertainty to be less than 5%, even very hot steps require long step durations. For a 5% uncertainty using this method, a 10-hour step duration is required even at 400°C. Much longer durations are required for the same precision at lower temperatures: at 250°C, a step duration of 35 hours is required to push the uncertainty beneath 5%.

### 1.4s Comparison to Literature Permeability Values

Predicted and measured fractional yields for all permeation steps in ampoules besides the encapsulated water experiment agree well (within $1\sigma$: Figs. **??**, **??**) with the predictive equations presented in this work and with the permeabilities reported by Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953) for all studied temperatures (24-300°C; Fig. **??**) and step fractional yields (up to ~80%). One outlier measurement on the empty tube experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer was excluded from Figs. **??** and **??**.

Permeation ratios for 3He and 4He measured in the empty tube experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer are plotted in Fig. **??**. These data present significant scatter, but generally agree with the reported results of Jones (1953), except for measurements at room temperature, which cluster tightly at a permeation ratio of 1:1 for the two isotopes. Additionally, fields corresponding to the ratios of apparent permeabilities for the water-filled

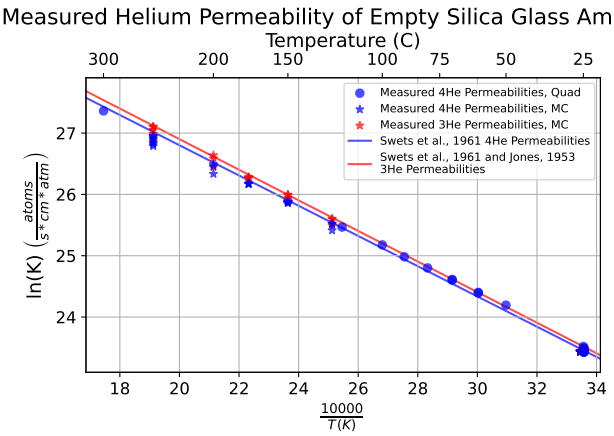



Figure 1.23: Helium permeabilities measured in silica glass ampoules at Caltech on a quadrupole mass spectrometer (4He only) and on a Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ (both 3He and 4He) multi-collector mass spectrometer are compared to literature values. Permeabilities of 3He and 4He are very similar, but 3He permeates slightly faster. The final measurement on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer is an outlier and is excluded from the plot, as it is most sensitive to the value of the total yield remaining in the ampoule. These experiments on empty tubes at Caltech show excellent agreement with the literature values with allowance for some scatter. This result shows that existing understanding of helium permeability in glass can be reasonably leveraged for use in helium step heats of silica glass encapsulated geological samples. Literature 4He permeabilities are taken from Swets et al. (1961); whereas 3He permeabilities from the literature are calculated by multiplying the 3He/4He permeability ratios of Jones (1953) with the 4He permeabilities of Swets et al. (1961).

and sulfur-filled experiments are plotted for the temperature ranges of those experiments. Results for those experiments are plotted as fields because each step integrated permeation behavior over a complex (non-isothermal) cooling history. These experiments also agree with the results of Jones (1953) and the empty ampoule experiment. The qualitative result of Jones (1953) that silica glass is only slightly more permeable for 3He than 4He is supported by these data, which are in marked contrast to the reported extreme differences in 3He and 4He diffusivity in silica glass of McMurtry et al. (2019), who report instantaneous isotopic fractionations up to a factor of 1000.

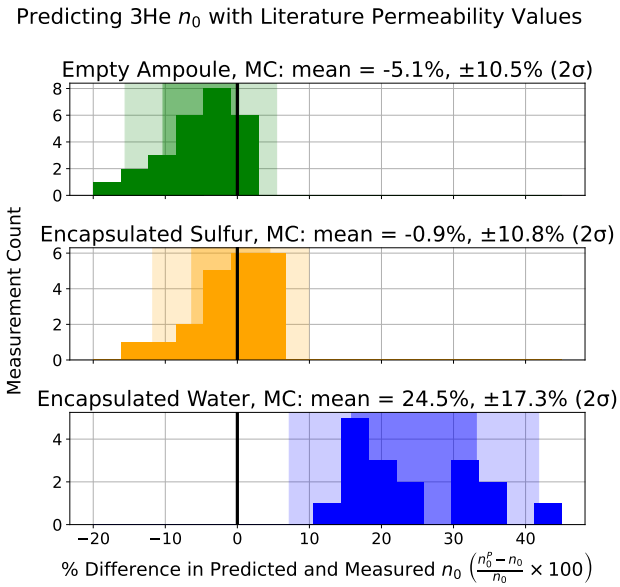



Figure 1.24: Similar to Fig. **??**, but with 3He permeabilities taken from Jones (1953) and Swets et al. (1961). Shaded regions behind the histograms correspond to 1 and 2 sigma ($\sigma$) from the average relative difference between the predicted and measured values. The 3He permeation model and literature permeability values apply well to empty and sulfur-filled ampoules, and such models can be used to reliably recover 3He contents of permeating ampoules for use in permeation lag corrections. On the other hand, measured and predicted values of 3He $n_0$ for water-filled ampoules are well resolved beyond $2\sigma$, suggesting that their permeability differs strongly from the literature values. Internal reproducibilities ($1\sigma$) of a gas standard repeatedly analyzed during these experiments were better than 3% for 3He, requiring that much of the scatter in these data be related to factors outside of analytical precision such as long/inconsistent ramp times during heating or uncertainties or rounding of heating times.

## 1.5s Additional Analytical Corrections for the Empty Ampoule Calibration Experiments

### Pump-Out and Gas-Preparation Corrections for the Atmosphere-Equilibrated Empty Ampoule

Using the helium permeability values of Swets et al. (1961) for silica glass, an ampoule with a geometric factor ($G$) of 6000 cm$^{-2}$ would permeate 0.2‰ of its helium in 1 minute at 26°C (Eq. (**??**)), which is negligible for the scope of this work. The atmosphere-equilibrated empty ampoule with a geometric factor ($G$) of ~4785 cm$^{-2}$ would permeate 2.8‰ of its helium in its 15-minute pumping time between steps. For that experiment only, helium loss during pumping is accounted for by applying the permeation relationship of Eq. (**??**)

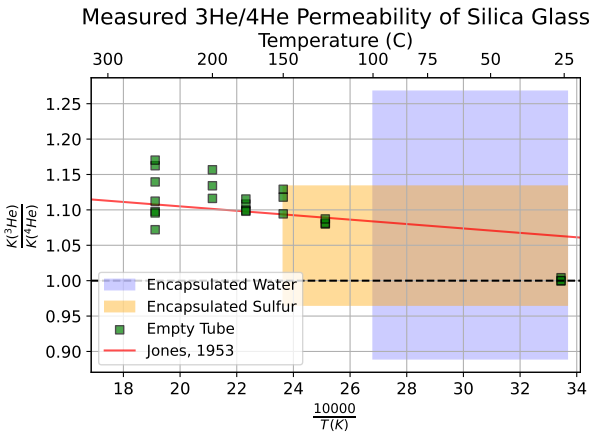



Figure 1.25: Ratios of calculated permeabilities from step heat experiments on silica glass ampoules on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer at Caltech. The last measurement on the empty tube experiment is an outlier and was excluded from the plot. Experiments on encapsulated water and encapsulated sulfur were allowed to cool before isotopic measurements. Because of slow cooling rates, simple corrections could not be applied to these two experiments, which effectively queried permeabilities at a range of temperatures within a single step. Therefore, the ratios of their apparent permeabilities are plotted as a field with $2\sigma$ standard deviation across the experimental temperature range. These three experiments show general, albeit imprecise, agreement to the results of Jones (1953), except for the measurements at room temperature. Jones (1953) was likely able to measure the relative permeabilities of 4He and 3He with much higher precision because his experimental vessel was charged with 3He at a partial pressure of around 0.5 atmospheres, over one billion times higher than the 3He partial pressure within the fused silica ampoule used in this work. Interestingly, three room-temperature measurements of helium permeation of an empty tube at Caltech yielded essentially identical permeability of 3He and 4He.

($n_0 = n_t/(1 - {}^{He}F)$) to solve for $n_0$, the amount of helium in the ampoule before pump-out, from $n_t$, the amount remaining after pumping with T = 25°C and t = 15 minutes. A permeability coefficient ($K$) for helium in silica glass had to be assumed in order to apply this correction, so the value of $1.54 \times 10^{10}$ $\frac{atoms}{s \times cm \times atm}$ at 25°C given by the Arrhenius law reported by Swets et al. (1961) was used. The validity of this choice is supported by the data; the average calculated permeability at room temperature for this experiment after correcting for helium lost during the 15-minute pump out is also $1.54 \times 10^{10}$ $\frac{atoms}{s \times cm \times atm}$.

For that experiment only, a correction was also applied to the high temperature

steps because they were heated for short durations (45 minutes for all but one heated step), so that the permeation of the ampoule at room temperature during gas cryofocusing represented a significant portion of the step's yield. This was similarly corrected by calculating the expected fractional yield at room temperature during the gas preparation time, which is the step's total time minus the pump out time and the heated time, (29-31 minutes for all heated steps). For that correction, the permeation relationship of Eq. (**??**) ($n_0 = n_t/(1 - {}^{He}F)$) is applied again to solve for the unknown $n_0$, the amount of helium within the ampoule immediately after the completion of the heated step, from $n_t$, the amount of helium within the ampoule when the gas is inlet into the mass spectrometer about 30 minutes later after spiking and helium purification. This cooling and gas preparation correction is not applied to the room temperature measurements for which the temperature remained constant during gas preparation.

**Anomalous Signal Recalculation for the Tank Helium-Soaked Empty Ampoule**

The last high temperature step of the empty ampoule experiment on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer had an unusual and non-linear signal evolution at the beginning of the measurement for both 3He and 4He. For this measurement, 4He was recalculated using a linear regression on the last three of six measurement cycles with an $R^2$ of 0.985 to regress to the 4He content at time 0. Typically, the signal evolution for a measurement like this would have a negative slope because the helium in the mass spectrometer is consumed as it is ionized and measured, but the slope for this measurement was positive. 3He from this measurement was calculated based on the recalculated 4He and an assumed isotope ratio for the measurement of 0.07 Ra. Three more measurements were taken over the next few days to ensure complete degassing of the ampoule. Two of these measurements yielded helium above blank, but were small compared to the final high temperature step. The yields of these steps were all considered in the calculation of the experiment's total yield.

**Independent Verification of the Encapsulated Durango Apatite Mass**

The total yield for the encapsulated Durango apatite experiment (main text, §**??**) is estimated from the precisely-measured mass of the encapsulated apatite (3.18 mg) and a helium concentration of 194.2 nccSTP/mg (Farley, 2000). This

concentration is independently supported by the measurement of 8 different >0.5 mg aliquots of the same Durango apatite sample in-lab, which yield a concentration of 194 ± 9 nccSTP/mg.

## 1.6s Sample Preparation and SEM Imaging of Buffered and Decomposed Sulfides

Samples of pyrite, arsenopyrite, and marcasite were crushed under ethanol, and grains larger than 100 µm were dried for each mineral and subdivided into four populations: one control, and three for heat treatment in atmosphere, ultra-high vacuum, or encapsulated within a glass ampoule along with an excess of fused sulfur (or realgar: As3S3 for arsenopyrite). The encapsulated populations were loaded into 3 mm inner diameter, 4 mm outer diameter silica glass tubes with fused bottoms and open tops, along with sufficient fused sulfur or crystalline realgar to guarantee vapor saturation at 400°C. These tubes were interfaced with a vacuum line and were pumped to 60 millitorr before the tops of the tubes were sealed.

The open-air populations for each mineral were carefully placed on glass microscope slides within borosilicate petri dishes and the encapsulated populations were submerged in pure quartz sand within capped, deep petri dishes. These petri dishes containing the encapsulated and open-air populations of sulfides were placed on a temperature controlling hot plate under a fume hood and were held at 400°C for 8-11 hours, at which point the hot plate was turned off and the samples were left to cool.

The ultra-high vacuum population for pyrite and marcasite were loaded into copper packets and mounted to a type K thermocouple within a high vacuum line. A silver wool based sulfur trap was installed between the samples and the turbo pump. The high-vacuum line was closed and pumped to <10-5 torr. A Watlow temperature controller held the samples at 400°C for 4.5 hours with a projector lamp illuminating the sample through a sapphire window. This procedure was repeated for each mineral sample of pyrite and marcasite. The arsenopyrite sample was not heated in vacuum to avoid contaminating the line with arsenic. To simulate thermal decomposition in an anoxic environment, a population of arsenopyrites was thermally treated in a large glass capsule similarly to the encapsulated populations, but without a realgar "buffer".

The control and thermally treated samples were mounted to carbon tape and

carbon coated, then were loaded in the Zeiss 1550 Scanning Electron Microscope (SEM) at Caltech. Images of the surface topography of each population were taken using the secondary electron detector and an Electron High Tension (EHT) of 10 kV at a working distance of 10-15 mm.

### 1.7s Supplementary Data Tables

The following tables present the reduced step-by-step helium permeation data underlying the empty-tube, encapsulated-water, and encapsulated-sulfur calibration experiments summarized in the ampoule dimensions table of the main text, Table **??** and the permeability/isotope-ratio comparison figures above. $m$ is the measured helium abundance of the step; $n_0$ and $n_t$ are the helium contents of the ampoule at the beginning and end of the step (Eq. (**??**)); $n_t/n_0$ predicted and measured are the fractional yields expected from the permeability of Swets et al. (1961) (and, for 3He, the isotope ratios of Jones (1953)) and as measured, respectively.

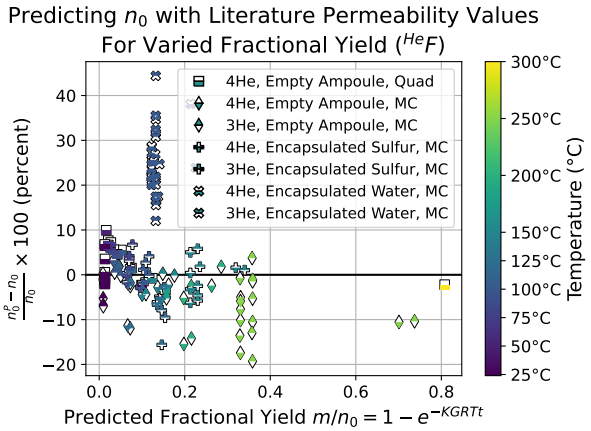



Figure 1.26: Helium measurements ($m$) of a permeating ampoule are related to the initial helium contents of the ampoule ($n_0$) by Eq. (**??**), using permeability values taken from Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953) (for 3He only). The $n_0^P$ variable is the predicted value of $n_0$, the true value. For the empty ampoules, except for 3 measurements on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$, predicted values ($n_0^P$) are calculated using Eq. (**??**) (with some corrections applied to the quadrupole experiment: see main text for details). For the encapsulated sulfur and water ampoules, as well as 3 measurements of the blank ampoule on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$, predicted values ($n_0^P$) were determined by forward modeling diffusion and permeation on ampoules as they were held at high temperature and subsequently allowed to cool (see main text for details). This plot shows that the predicted values are correct to within ~10% for empty and sulfur-filled ampoules regardless of temperature or extent of permeation, whereas $n_0^P$ values for water-filled ampoules are systematically high. The final Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ measurement on the empty ampoule yields an outlier $n_0^P$ that was ~80% high — this measurement is not plotted here.

Table 1.4: Distilled helium permeation data for the empty silica glass ampoule equilibrated with atmosphere, measured by isotope dilution on the Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer ("Empty Tube, Pfeiffer Quad" in the ampoule dimensions table of the main text, Table **??**). $n_0$ and $n_t$ are the initial and final helium contents of the ampoule for each step (Eq. (**??**)); $n_t$ "before cooling" is only populated for high-temperature experimental steps, for which the room-temperature pump-out/cool-down correction discussed in the main text is applied to obtain the "after cooling" value used to calculate permeability. $\ln(K)$ values are the natural log of the permeability coefficient in $\frac{atoms}{s \times cm \times atm}$.

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $m$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_0$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t$ 4He (before cooling) (nccSTP) | $n_t$ 4He (after cooling) (nccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ measured | $10000/T$ ($K^{-1}$) | $\ln(K)$ measured |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 25 | 77 | 0.1877 | 12.87 | | 12.68 | 0.9854 | 33.56 | 23.52 |
| 25 | 77 | 0.1793 | 12.64 | | 12.47 | 0.9858 | 33.56 | 23.49 |
| 50 | 45 | 0.2902 | 12.43 | 12.21 | 12.14 | 0.9819 | 30.96 | 24.19 |
| 24.8 | 74 | 0.1593 | 12.11 | | 11.95 | 0.9868 | 33.58 | 23.46 |
| 100 | 45 | 0.7129 | 11.92 | 11.26 | 11.2 | 0.9452 | 26.81 | 25.18 |
| 24.7 | 74 | 0.145 | 11.17 | | 11.03 | 0.9870 | 33.59 | 23.44 |
| 60 | 45 | 0.3094 | 11 | 10.75 | 10.69 | 0.9771 | 30.03 | 24.40 |
| 70 | 45 | 0.3619 | 10.66 | 10.35 | 10.3 | 0.9712 | 29.15 | 24.60 |
| 80 | 45 | 0.4225 | 10.27 | 9.902 | 9.849 | 0.9640 | 28.33 | 24.80 |
| 24.7 | 74 | 0.1272 | 9.823 | | 9.696 | 0.9870 | 33.59 | 23.44 |
| 24.8 | 74 | 0.1252 | 9.67 | | 9.545 | 0.9871 | 33.58 | 23.44 |
| 24.8 | 75 | 0.1238 | 9.519 | | 9.395 | 0.9870 | 33.58 | 23.43 |
| 70 | 45 | 0.3209 | 9.37 | 9.098 | 9.049 | 0.9709 | 29.15 | 24.61 |
| 60 | 45 | 0.2534 | 9.025 | 8.82 | 8.771 | 0.9773 | 30.03 | 24.39 |
| 24.8 | 74 | 0.113 | 8.748 | | 8.635 | 0.9871 | 33.58 | 23.44 |
| 90 | 45 | 0.4231 | 8.611 | 8.231 | 8.188 | 0.9558 | 27.55 | 24.98 |
| 119.8 | 45 | 0.6625 | 8.166 | 7.543 | 7.504 | 0.9236 | 25.46 | 25.47 |
| 24.8 | 74 | 0.09578 | 7.484 | | 7.388 | 0.9872 | 33.58 | 23.43 |
| 150 | 45 | 0.9371 | 7.368 | 6.465 | 6.431 | 0.8775 | 23.64 | 25.89 |
| 25 | 581 | 0.6179 | 6.414 | | 5.796 | 0.9037 | 33.56 | 23.43 |
| 300 | 90 | 4.549 | 5.78 | 1.238 | 1.231 | 0.2141 | 17.45 | 27.36 |
| 24.7 | 74 | 0.01673 | 1.228 | | 1.211 | 0.9864 | 33.59 | 23.49 |
| 400 | 90 | 1.178 | 1.208 | | 0.03073 | | | |
| 24.7 | 74 | 0.00117 | 0.03065 | | | | | |

Table 1.5: Distilled 3He permeation data for the empty silica glass ampoule equilibrated with high-purity tank helium, measured on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer ("Empty Tube, Helix MC" in the ampoule dimensions table of the main text, Table **??**). Rows marked '–' in the predicted and measured $n_t/n_0$ and permeability columns are cooling-only intervals for which no isothermal permeability was calculated (see main text).

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $m$ 3He (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (pccSTP) | $n_0$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured | 3He $K$ measured ($\frac{atoms}{s\ cm\ atm}$) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 26 | 73.6 | 0.0516 | $6.16\times10^{-4}$ | 5.787 | 5.736 | 0.9902 | 0.9911 | $1.53\times10^{10}$ |
| – | 113.3 | 0.269 | $3.89\times10^{-3}$ | 5.736 | 5.467 | | | |
| 26 | 73.7 | 0.048 | $8.51\times10^{-4}$ | 5.467 | 5.419 | 0.9902 | 0.9912 | $1.50\times10^{10}$ |
| 26 | 75.3 | 0.0485 | $9.92\times10^{-4}$ | 5.419 | 5.37 | 0.9900 | 0.9910 | $1.50\times10^{10}$ |
| – | 112.9 | 0.271 | $5.67\times10^{-3}$ | 5.37 | 5.099 | | | |
| – | 126.6 | 0.418 | $8.80\times10^{-3}$ | 5.099 | 4.682 | | | |
| 125 | 52.9 | 0.299 | $6.31\times10^{-3}$ | 4.682 | 4.382 | 0.9275 | 0.9361 | $1.18\times10^{11}$ |
| 125 | 53.1 | 0.311 | $6.57\times10^{-3}$ | 4.382 | 4.071 | 0.9273 | 0.9290 | $1.31\times10^{11}$ |
| 125 | 53.1 | 0.291 | $6.15\times10^{-3}$ | 4.071 | 3.78 | 0.9273 | 0.9285 | $1.32\times10^{11}$ |
| – | 73.6 | 0.422 | $8.67\times10^{-3}$ | 3.78 | 3.358 | | | |
| 150 | 73.6 | 0.502 | $8.56\times10^{-3}$ | 3.358 | 2.856 | 0.8512 | 0.8506 | $1.95\times10^{11}$ |
| 150 | 52.9 | 0.299 | $4.47\times10^{-3}$ | 2.856 | 2.557 | 0.8907 | 0.8952 | $1.86\times10^{11}$ |
| 150 | 88.4 | 0.45 | $6.28\times10^{-3}$ | 2.557 | 2.107 | 0.8240 | 0.8240 | $1.94\times10^{11}$ |
| 175 | 53.1 | 0.318 | $4.55\times10^{-3}$ | 2.107 | 1.788 | 0.8427 | 0.8489 | $2.59\times10^{11}$ |
| 175 | 53.1 | 0.272 | $4.00\times10^{-3}$ | 1.788 | 1.516 | 0.8427 | 0.8478 | $2.61\times10^{11}$ |
| 175 | 53.1 | 0.228 | $3.54\times10^{-3}$ | 1.516 | 1.288 | 0.8427 | 0.8498 | $2.57\times10^{11}$ |
| 175 | 53.1 | 0.193 | $3.15\times10^{-3}$ | 1.288 | 1.095 | 0.8427 | 0.8504 | $2.56\times10^{11}$ |
| – | 53.1 | 0.164 | $2.82\times10^{-3}$ | 1.095 | 0.9317 | | | |
| 200 | 53.2 | 0.174 | $3.23\times10^{-3}$ | 0.9317 | 0.7582 | 0.7843 | 0.8139 | $3.07\times10^{11}$ |
| 200 | 53.1 | 0.16 | $3.16\times10^{-3}$ | 0.7582 | 0.5978 | 0.7847 | 0.7887 | $3.55\times10^{11}$ |
| 200 | 73.6 | 0.175 | $3.80\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5978 | 0.4224 | 0.7146 | 0.7070 | $3.75\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 53.2 | 0.152 | $3.93\times10^{-3}$ | 0.4224 | 0.2704 | 0.6410 | 0.6406 | $6.02\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 53.1 | 0.0977 | $2.95\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2704 | 0.1727 | 0.6413 | 0.6396 | $6.06\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 53.1 | 0.0607 | $2.12\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1727 | 0.1119 | 0.6413 | 0.6499 | $5.85\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 53.1 | 0.0379 | $1.56\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1119 | 0.07407 | 0.6414 | 0.6639 | $5.58\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 52.9 | 0.0249 | $1.13\times10^{-3}$ | 0.07407 | 0.04914 | 0.6427 | 0.6634 | $5.57\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 53.1 | 0.016 | $7.70\times10^{-4}$ | 0.04914 | 0.03315 | 0.6415 | 0.6746 | $5.32\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 159.9 | 0.026 | $1.31\times10^{-3}$ | 0.03315 | 0.007191 | 0.2625 | 0.2169 | $6.86\times10^{11}$ |
| 250 | 52.9 | 0.00494 | $2.52\times10^{-4}$ | 0.007191 | 0.00225 | 0.6424 | 0.3129 | $1.58\times10^{12}$ |
| High T | 52.2 | 0.00225 | | 0.00225 | 0 | | | |

Table 1.6: Distilled 4He permeation data for the same empty silica glass ampoule experiment as Table **??**. $K(3/4)$ is the ratio of the measured 4He to 3He permeability coefficients for each step; 3/4 He measured (Ra) is the measured 3He/4He ratio of the step, normalized to the atmospheric ratio.

| Temp | Time | $m$ 4He | $\pm 2\sigma$ | $n_0$ 4He | $n_t$ 4He | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured | 4He $K$ measured | $K_3/K_4$ | 3He/4He measured (Ra) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| (°C) | (min) | (nccSTP) | (nccSTP) | (nccSTP) | (nccSTP) | | | $(\frac{atoms}{s\,cm\,atm})$ | | |
| 26 | 73.6 | 263.7 | 1.33 | 29670 | 29410 | 0.9908 | 0.9911 | $1.52\times10^{10}$ | 1.0031 | 0.1408 |
| – | 113.3 | 1282 | 7.99 | 29410 | 28130 | | | | | 0.1509 |
| 26 | 73.7 | 247.4 | 1.95 | 28130 | 27880 | 0.9908 | 0.9912 | $1.51\times10^{10}$ | 0.9984 | 0.1396 |
| 26 | 75.3 | 250 | 2.34 | 27880 | 27630 | 0.9905 | 0.9910 | $1.50\times10^{10}$ | 0.9990 | 0.1397 |
| – | 112.9 | 1322 | 13.1 | 27630 | 26310 | | | | | 0.1475 |
| – | 126.6 | 1971 | 20 | 26310 | 24340 | | | | | 0.1524 |
| 125 | 52.9 | 1446 | 14.9 | 24340 | 22890 | 0.9332 | 0.9406 | $1.09\times10^{11}$ | 1.0786 | 0.1489 |
| 125 | 53.1 | 1509 | 15.6 | 22890 | 21380 | 0.9330 | 0.9341 | $1.21\times10^{11}$ | 1.0795 | 0.1483 |
| 125 | 53.1 | 1413 | 14.6 | 21380 | 19970 | 0.9330 | 0.9339 | $1.21\times10^{11}$ | 1.0856 | 0.1483 |
| – | 73.6 | 2032 | 20.8 | 19970 | 17940 | | | | | 0.1495 |
| 150 | 73.6 | 2399 | 22.2 | 17940 | 15540 | 0.8630 | 0.8663 | $1.73\times10^{11}$ | 1.1271 | 0.1505 |
| 150 | 52.9 | 1498 | 12.7 | 15540 | 14040 | 0.8996 | 0.9036 | $1.70\times10^{11}$ | 1.0922 | 0.1438 |
| 150 | 88.4 | 2238 | 16.7 | 14040 | 11800 | 0.8377 | 0.8406 | $1.74\times10^{11}$ | 1.1155 | 0.1447 |
| 175 | 53.1 | 1626 | 10.8 | 11800 | 10170 | 0.8556 | 0.8622 | $2.34\times10^{11}$ | 1.1053 | 0.1409 |
| 175 | 53.1 | 1404 | 8.46 | 10170 | 8771 | 0.8556 | 0.8620 | $2.34\times10^{11}$ | 1.1121 | 0.1395 |
| 175 | 53.1 | 1211 | 6.28 | 8771 | 7560 | 0.8556 | 0.8619 | $2.34\times10^{11}$ | 1.0959 | 0.1353 |
| 175 | 53.1 | 1042 | 4.8 | 7560 | 6518 | 0.8556 | 0.8622 | $2.34\times10^{11}$ | 1.0939 | 0.1332 |
| – | 53.1 | 895.4 | 3.67 | 6518 | 5623 | | | | | 0.1314 |
| 200 | 53.2 | 952.2 | 3.41 | 5623 | 4670 | 0.8020 | 0.8306 | $2.77\times10^{11}$ | 1.1107 | 0.1311 |
| 200 | 53.1 | 887.5 | 2.99 | 4670 | 3783 | 0.8023 | 0.8100 | $3.15\times10^{11}$ | 1.1275 | 0.1300 |
| 200 | 73.6 | 987.1 | 3.27 | 3783 | 2796 | 0.7370 | 0.7391 | $3.26\times10^{11}$ | 1.1485 | 0.1278 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $m$ 4He (nccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (nccSTP) | $n_0$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured | 4He $K$ measured $(\frac{atoms}{s\,cm\,atm})$ | $K_3/K_4$ | 3He/4He measured (Ra) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 250 | 53.2 | 898 | 3.01 | 2796 | 1898 | 0.6693 | 0.6788 | $5.23\times10^{11}$ | 1.1520 | 0.1218 |
| 250 | 53.1 | 609.8 | 2.07 | 1898 | 1288 | 0.6696 | 0.6787 | $5.24\times10^{11}$ | 1.1569 | 0.1153 |
| 250 | 53.1 | 412.2 | 1.42 | 1288 | 875.7 | 0.6696 | 0.6799 | $5.21\times10^{11}$ | 1.1231 | 0.1059 |
| 250 | 53.1 | 278.8 | 0.995 | 875.7 | 596.9 | 0.6697 | 0.6817 | $5.18\times10^{11}$ | 1.0778 | 0.0978 |
| 250 | 52.9 | 187.7 | 0.689 | 596.9 | 409.2 | 0.6709 | 0.6855 | $5.13\times10^{11}$ | 1.0868 | 0.0955 |
| 250 | 53.1 | 128.8 | 0.486 | 409.2 | 280.4 | 0.6697 | 0.6852 | $5.11\times10^{11}$ | 1.0411 | 0.0893 |
| 250 | 159.9 | 215.4 | 0.953 | 280.4 | 64.98 | 0.2990 | 0.2318 | $6.56\times10^{11}$ | 1.0452 | 0.0867 |
| 250 | 52.9 | 41.86 | 0.205 | 64.98 | 23.12 | 0.6706 | 0.3558 | $1.40\times10^{12}$ | 1.1246 | 0.0849 |
| High T | 52.2 | 23.12 | | 23.12 | 0 | | | | | 0.0700 |

Table 1.7: Distilled 3He isothermal permeation data for the silica glass ampoule containing distilled water, equilibrated with high-purity tank helium, measured on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer ("Encapsulated Water, Helix MC" in the ampoule dimensions table of the main text, Table **??**). Predicted $n_t/n_0$ values marked '–' correspond to steps for which the ampoule had not yet reached a diffusive steady state concentration profile (see main text).

| Temp (°C) | Hot Time (min) | Cold Time (min) | $m$ 3He (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (pccSTP) | $n_0$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 100 | 60 | 26 | 0.116 | $1.22\times10^{-3}$ | 0.6447 | 0.5289 | – | 0.8204 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.0942 | $1.00\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5289 | 0.4347 | 0.8677 | 0.8219 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 0.0757 | $8.06\times10^{-4}$ | 0.4347 | 0.359 | 0.8678 | 0.8259 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.0578 | $6.18\times10^{-4}$ | 0.359 | 0.3012 | 0.8678 | 0.8389 |
| 100 | 60 | 53.5 | 0.053 | $5.72\times10^{-4}$ | 0.3012 | 0.2482 | 0.8589 | 0.8241 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.2 | 0.0382 | $4.34\times10^{-4}$ | 0.2482 | 0.21 | 0.8678 | 0.8459 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.0337 | $4.06\times10^{-4}$ | 0.21 | 0.1763 | 0.8678 | 0.8396 |
| 100 | 60 | 795.6 | 0.0493 | $2.52\times10^{-4}$ | 0.1763 | 0.127 | 0.7741 | 0.7201 |
| 100 | 60 | 28.1 | 0.0197 | $9.42\times10^{-5}$ | 0.127 | 0.1072 | 0.8666 | 0.8446 |
| 100 | 60 | 43.7 | 0.0173 | $8.39\times10^{-5}$ | 0.1072 | 0.08988 | 0.8622 | 0.8382 |
| 100 | 60 | 24.9 | 0.0138 | $6.99\times10^{-5}$ | 0.08988 | 0.0761 | 0.8673 | 0.8467 |
| 100 | 60 | 24.9 | 0.0132 | $7.60\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0761 | 0.06295 | 0.8678 | 0.8272 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 0.00977 | $6.32\times10^{-5}$ | 0.06295 | 0.05318 | 0.8678 | 0.8448 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.00952 | $6.36\times10^{-5}$ | 0.05318 | 0.04366 | 0.8679 | 0.8210 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.00764 | $5.16\times10^{-5}$ | 0.04366 | 0.03602 | 0.8678 | 0.8250 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 0.00572 | $3.86\times10^{-5}$ | 0.03602 | 0.0303 | 0.8678 | 0.8413 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 0.00578 | $3.90\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0303 | 0.02451 | 0.8678 | 0.8091 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.00363 | $2.45\times10^{-5}$ | 0.02451 | 0.02089 | 0.8679 | 0.8520 |
| REST | | | 0.0209 | $1.39\times10^{-4}$ | 0.02089 | 0 | | |

Table 1.8: Distilled 4He isothermal permeation data for the same encapsulated-water ampoule experiment as Table **??**.

| Temp (°C) | Hot Time (min) | Cold Time (min) | $m$ 4He (nccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (nccSTP) | $n_0$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured | 3He/4He measured (Ra) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 100 | 60 | 26 | 604 | 1.77 | 3871 | 3267 | – | 0.8440 | 0.1379 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 515.5 | 1.52 | 3267 | 2751 | 0.8772 | 0.8422 | 0.1315 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 434.8 | 1.29 | 2751 | 2317 | 0.8772 | 0.8420 | 0.1252 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 361.9 | 1.07 | 2317 | 1955 | 0.8772 | 0.8438 | 0.1150 |
| 100 | 60 | 53.5 | 325.4 | 0.965 | 1955 | 1629 | 0.8688 | 0.8335 | 0.1171 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.2 | 251.3 | 0.745 | 1629 | 1378 | 0.8772 | 0.8458 | 0.1095 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 212.6 | 0.63 | 1378 | 1165 | 0.8772 | 0.8457 | 0.1140 |
| 100 | 60 | 795.6 | 344.8 | 0.802 | 1165 | 820.7 | 0.7858 | 0.7042 | 0.1029 |
| 100 | 60 | 28.1 | 127.2 | 0.276 | 820.7 | 693.5 | 0.8761 | 0.8450 | 0.1116 |
| 100 | 60 | 43.7 | 111.3 | 0.222 | 693.5 | 582.2 | 0.8719 | 0.8395 | 0.1122 |
| 100 | 60 | 24.9 | 88.54 | 0.166 | 582.2 | 493.7 | 0.8768 | 0.8479 | 0.1120 |
| 100 | 60 | 24.9 | 74.96 | 0.121 | 493.7 | 418.7 | 0.8773 | 0.8481 | 0.1262 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 62.69 | $8.84\times10^{-2}$ | 418.7 | 356 | 0.8772 | 0.8503 | 0.1121 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 53.28 | $7.18\times10^{-2}$ | 356 | 302.7 | 0.8773 | 0.8503 | 0.1285 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 45.45 | $6.11\times10^{-2}$ | 302.7 | 257.3 | 0.8772 | 0.8499 | 0.1209 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 38.41 | $5.30\times10^{-2}$ | 257.3 | 218.9 | 0.8773 | 0.8507 | 0.1071 |
| 100 | 60 | 25 | 32.42 | $4.81\times10^{-2}$ | 218.9 | 186.4 | 0.8772 | 0.8519 | 0.1284 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.1 | 27.46 | $4.35\times10^{-2}$ | 186.4 | 159 | 0.8773 | 0.8527 | 0.0950 |
| REST | | | 159 | 0.258 | 159 | 0 | | | 0.0945 |

Table 1.9: Distilled 3He isothermal permeation data for the silica glass ampoule containing fused sulfur, equilibrated with high-purity tank helium, measured on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer ("Encapsulated Sulfur, Pfeiffer Quad" in the ampoule dimensions table of the main text, Table **??**; note this isothermal calibration series was run on the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$).

| Temp (°C) | Hot Time (min) | Cold Time (min) | $m$ 3He (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (pccSTP) | $n_0$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t$ 3He (pccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 80 | 60 | 25.6 | 0.699 | $2.78\times10^{-2}$ | 9.569 | 8.87 | 0.9299 | 0.9270 |
| 80 | 60 | 61.3 | 0.736 | $2.89\times10^{-2}$ | 8.87 | 8.134 | 0.9222 | 0.9170 |
| 80 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.591 | $2.17\times10^{-2}$ | 8.134 | 7.543 | 0.9300 | 0.9274 |
| 80 | 60 | 25 | 0.544 | $1.83\times10^{-2}$ | 7.543 | 6.999 | 0.9301 | 0.9279 |
| 80 | 60 | 25 | 0.494 | $1.60\times10^{-2}$ | 6.999 | 6.505 | 0.9301 | 0.9294 |
| 100 | 60 | 91.8 | 0.759 | $2.42\times10^{-2}$ | 6.505 | 5.746 | 0.8831 | 0.8834 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.9 | 0.601 | $2.01\times10^{-2}$ | 5.746 | 5.145 | 0.8966 | 0.8955 |
| 100 | 60 | 52.0 | 0.575 | $2.06\times10^{-2}$ | 5.145 | 4.57 | 0.8912 | 0.8882 |
| 100 | 60 | 26 | 0.463 | $1.72\times10^{-2}$ | 4.57 | 4.108 | 0.8966 | 0.8988 |
| 100 | 60 | 89.9 | 0.498 | $2.04\times10^{-2}$ | 4.108 | 3.609 | 0.8834 | 0.8787 |
| 120 | 60 | 24.8 | 0.51 | $2.27\times10^{-2}$ | 3.609 | 3.099 | 0.8537 | 0.8586 |
| 120 | 60 | 52.8 | 0.457 | $2.18\times10^{-2}$ | 3.099 | 2.641 | 0.8481 | 0.8524 |
| 120 | 60 | 24.9 | 0.356 | $1.76\times10^{-2}$ | 2.641 | 2.286 | 0.8537 | 0.8653 |
| 120 | 60 | 61.3 | 0.318 | $1.56\times10^{-2}$ | 2.286 | 1.967 | 0.8460 | 0.8607 |
| 120 | 60 | 25.1 | 0.243 | $1.17\times10^{-2}$ | 1.967 | 1.724 | 0.8537 | 0.8766 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 0.42 | $2.00\times10^{-2}$ | 1.724 | 1.304 | 0.7695 | 0.7562 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 0.283 | $1.32\times10^{-2}$ | 1.304 | 1.021 | 0.7696 | 0.7828 |
| 150 | 60 | 690.8 | 0.351 | $1.03\times10^{-2}$ | 1.021 | 0.6699 | 0.6598 | 0.6563 |
| 150 | 60 | 25 | 0.147 | $3.98\times10^{-3}$ | 0.6699 | 0.5226 | 0.7696 | 0.7802 |
| 150 | 60 | 53.3 | 0.125 | $3.33\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5226 | 0.3972 | 0.7643 | 0.7601 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 0.0893 | $2.40\times10^{-3}$ | 0.3972 | 0.308 | 0.7695 | 0.7752 |
| remainder | | | 0.308 | $8.48\times10^{-3}$ | | | | |

Table 1.10: Distilled 4He isothermal permeation data for the same encapsulated-sulfur ampoule experiment as Table **??**.

| Temp (°C) | Hot Time (min) | Cold Time (min) | $m$ 4He (nccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ (nccSTP) | $n_0$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t$ 4He (nccSTP) | $n_t/n_0$ predicted | $n_t/n_0$ measured | 3He/4He measured (Ra) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 80 | 60 | 25.6 | 3354 | 10.8 | 52330 | 48980 | 0.9348 | 0.9359 | 0.1499 |
| 80 | 60 | 61.3 | 3617 | 12 | 48980 | 45360 | 0.9276 | 0.9262 | 0.1464 |
| 80 | 60 | 25.1 | 2949 | 10 | 45360 | 42410 | 0.9349 | 0.9350 | 0.1441 |
| 80 | 60 | 25 | 2760 | 9.6 | 42410 | 39650 | 0.9350 | 0.9349 | 0.1419 |
| 80 | 60 | 25 | 2587 | 9.13 | 39650 | 37060 | 0.9350 | 0.9348 | 0.1373 |
| 100 | 60 | 91.8 | 3980 | 15.3 | 37060 | 33080 | 0.8913 | 0.8926 | 0.1371 |
| 100 | 60 | 25.9 | 3088 | 13.5 | 33080 | 30000 | 0.9041 | 0.9066 | 0.1399 |
| 100 | 60 | 52.0 | 2978 | 14.7 | 30000 | 27020 | 0.8990 | 0.9007 | 0.1389 |
| 100 | 60 | 26 | 2517 | 13.1 | 27020 | 24500 | 0.9041 | 0.9068 | 0.1322 |
| 100 | 60 | 89.9 | 2687 | 14.4 | 24500 | 21810 | 0.8916 | 0.8903 | 0.1334 |
| 120 | 60 | 24.8 | 2769 | 14.6 | 21810 | 19040 | 0.8646 | 0.8731 | 0.1327 |
| 120 | 60 | 52.8 | 2551 | 13 | 19040 | 16490 | 0.8592 | 0.8661 | 0.1290 |
| 120 | 60 | 24.9 | 2097 | 10.4 | 16490 | 14400 | 0.8646 | 0.8728 | 0.1221 |
| 120 | 60 | 61.3 | 1948 | 9.38 | 14400 | 12450 | 0.8572 | 0.8647 | 0.1176 |
| 120 | 60 | 25.1 | 1573 | 7.36 | 12450 | 10870 | 0.8645 | 0.8736 | 0.1110 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 2435 | 11.3 | 10870 | 8439 | 0.7868 | 0.7761 | 0.1242 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 1806 | 8.2 | 8439 | 6633 | 0.7868 | 0.7859 | 0.1128 |
| 150 | 60 | 690.8 | 2151 | 8.5 | 6633 | 4481 | 0.6807 | 0.6756 | 0.1173 |
| 150 | 60 | 25 | 924.6 | 3.42 | 4481 | 3557 | 0.7868 | 0.7937 | 0.1146 |
| 150 | 60 | 53.3 | 753.9 | 2.75 | 3557 | 2803 | 0.7818 | 0.7880 | 0.1197 |
| 150 | 60 | 25.0 | 560.4 | 2.08 | 2803 | 2242 | 0.7868 | 0.8001 | 0.1146 |
| remainder | | | 2242 | 8.72 | | | | | 0.0988 |

*Chapter 2*

# HELIUM STEP HEATS ON GOETHITE AT WATER SATURATED CONDITIONS SHOW DIFFUSIVE HELIUM LOSS AND HIGH RETENTIVITY AT SURFACE TEMPERATURES

*U-Th/He geochronology of goethite (FeOOH) is a powerful method to quantitatively date weathering and erosion processes on Earth's surface; however, precise interpretation of goethite U-Th/He dates is challenging because uncertainty persists regarding the mineralogical and environmental conditions under which radiogenic helium is retained and how it may be lost over time. Standard vacuum step heating experiments have been successfully used on a variety of mineral phases to characterize helium migration, but the results of such experiments on goethite predominantly record dehydroxylation-induced helium loss, raising questions about their relevance to helium retention and loss in nature (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Observations that thermal decomposition of goethite is greatly suppressed in the presence that thermal decomposition of goethite is greatly suppressed in the presence of high water pressure led us to develop a new method to conduct helium step heat experiments under water-saturated conditions up to 300°C within standard experimental setups. Using this method, we report results from the first helium step heat experiment of proton-irradiated goethite under hydrothermal conditions. Irradiated goethite sample Win-06-01b of the Flinders Ranges, South Australia and distilled water were encapsulated in a pure silica glass ampoule and were subjected to multiple prograde and retrograde thermal cycles over a temperature range of 170°C to 250°C under water vapor saturated conditions with step durations ranging from 2 hours to over a week. The results show apparent helium diffusivities approximately seven log units lower than those observed in vacuum, converging to a reproducible linear array on an Arrhenius plot with an activation energy of 157.1± 5.3kJ/mol and a closure temperature of 98.1± 8.6°C at a cooling rate*

*of 10°C/Ma. These results are consistent with a volume-diffusion helium loss mechanism and show high helium retentivity for natural goethite that extrapolates to near-quantitative helium retention at surface conditions over billion-year timescales. Reanalysis of published vacuum step heats of the same sample shows that they record first-order conversion to hematite, whereas the hydrothermal release records diffusion. Thermodynamic and nucleation-kinetic modeling calibrated on vacuum step heat experiments on the same sample explains this difference and shows that conducting step heats with this method is expected to slow dehydroxylation of Win-06-01b by many orders of magnitude, effectively suppressing dehydroxylation on experimental timescales. This analysis applies only to Win-06-01b, and can only be extended to other goethite samples for which kinetic data or vacuum step heat data are available due to the diversity and complexity of goethite morphologies and grain sizes. The method presented in this work can be systematically applied to experimentally investigate effects of crystallite size, chemical composition, and radiation damage to refine these results and to assess the applicability of existing vacuum step heat data to helium retention and loss in goethite in nature.*

## 2.1 Introduction

Goethite (FeOOH) crystallization is datable only by U-Th/He geochronology (Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2005; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Goethite is a powerful chronometer for dating surface processes such as weathering and ferruginization directly: laterite and duricrust formation and recrystallization (H. S. Monteiro, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2014; Allard et al., 2018; Ansart et al., 2022), and the ferruginization of organic matter and paleosols (Heim et al., 2006; Yapp and Shuster, 2011; P. M. Vasconcelos et al., 2013; Danišík et al., 2013; Hofmann, Reichenbacher, et al., 2017).

Interpreting a goethite U-Th/He date requires knowing the conditions under which the mineral retains radiogenic helium. As with any radiochronometer, meaningful geological interpretation of a measured age depends on knowing when the system is open to loss or gain of parent or daughter nuclides. For goethite, step heats of proton-irradiated, crystalline samples are used to reveal the degree of partial helium loss by the 4He/3He method (Shuster, P. M. Vas-

concelos, et al., 2005), and suggest that helium loss fractions in nature are always non-zero but modest, ranging from 2 to 30% (Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2005; Heim et al., 2006; Hofmann, Reichenbacher, et al., 2017; Deng et al., 2017). Although one study attempts to explain the variable loss principally as a result of variable radiation damage (Bassal et al., 2022), the effects of temperature, crystallite size, and chemical composition have not been determined experimentally and remain unresolved, because goethite decomposes to hematite ($Fe_2O_3$) in the step heat experiments used to characterize it (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024).

Laboratory experiments of helium migration under controlled conditions have proven extremely useful in understanding the mechanisms and rates of helium migration in geological materials and have produced sensible results that are predominantly explainable by thermally activated volume diffusion (Reiners and Farley, 1997; Farley, 2000; Farley, 2007; Cherniak and Watson, 2011; Farley, 2018), albeit variably complicated by the effects of radiation damage and annealing (Shuster, Flowers, et al., 2006; Guenthner et al., 2013). This approach has also been leveraged for goethite; however, some complications arise when applying this approach to goethite. Above surface temperatures, goethite decomposes to hematite and water, often along crystallite elongation directions (Goss, 1987). Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) measured evolved water by capacitance manometry during vacuum step heats and found helium and water release to be tightly correlated even below 200°C, indicating that decomposition, rather than helium migration through an unchanging crystal, governs the release. Vacuum step-heat results for goethite therefore need not describe helium behavior in nature.

Still, existing helium step heat measurements of goethite in vacuum likely remain informative to an extent, as goethite dehydration kinetics are highly influenced by some of the same factors that could be responsible for variable helium retention in natural goethite, like variable grain size (Navrotsky et al., 2008; Guo and Barnard, 2011; Goss, 1987), crystallinity (Schwertmann et al., 1985) or substitution of aluminum or other cations within the goethite structure (Majzlan, Grevel, et al., 2003; Bassal et al., 2022). For example, Shuster et al. (2005) initially conducted vacuum step-heating experiments on two vitreous, polycrystalline goethite samples, in which uniformly distributed 3He was introduced by proton irradiation for comparison with radiogenic 4He

that was partially lost in nature. The results of Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al. (2005) could be well-fit with a model of two distinct diffusion domains or migration mechanisms with significant differences in helium retention under surface conditions, e.g. crystallite interiors and intergranular space. Although these results may have been impacted by dehydration in vacuum, certain aspects may remain applicable to helium loss in goethite in nature if helium loss in nature and the laboratory advance through the samples with similar geometries. One important point is that if laboratory experiments degas domains in order of their helium retentivity in nature, even if the rates of loss are affected by goethite dehydration, then a $^{4}He/^{3}He$ experiment in vacuum can still be used to measure helium loss (Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2005; P. M. Vasconcelos et al., 2013).

An additional complexity is that natural goethite almost always occurs as aggregates of minute crystallites with cross-sections smaller than 1 µm in nature. Neglecting to account for multiple diffusion domains can lead to inaccurate determinations of activation energy ($E_a$) and frequency factor ($D_o/a^2$) for helium diffusion (Farley, 2018). Detailed step-heating with temperature cycling, as has been done for hematite (Farley and Flowers, 2012; Farley, 2018), is needed to characterize domain size and activation energy for polycrystalline samples.

Molecular simulations indicate that helium diffusion in perfectly crystalline goethite should be highly anisotropic, essentially reducing to 1-dimensional diffusion along the b-axis (typically the long axis of the polycrystalline aggregate) that would amount to near-instantaneous helium escape from goethite (Bassal et al., 2022), which is clearly disputed by observed (U–Th)/He dates as old as ~275 Ma (Waltenberg, 2012) and dates that are concordant with $^{40}Ar/^{39}Ar$ ages of other phases (P. M. Vasconcelos et al., 2013). However, the models presented by Bassal et al. (2022) suggest that crystallographic defects caused by radiation damage could block these channels, thereby reducing He loss. While these simulations are informative, they alone are insufficient for drawing conclusions about the mineralogical and environmental conditions needed for accurately dating the crystallization of goethite with the (U–Th)/He method and require experimental verification.

Goethite dehydration is suppressed at high water pressure (Langmuir, 1971; Navrotsky et al., 2008), so a step heat conducted under hydrothermal conditions may interrogate helium loss rather than decomposition kinetics. Until

now, no studies have reported helium step-heating results for goethite under hydrothermal (high $pH_2O$) conditions, which could help stabilize goethite or slow its decomposition to illuminate the processes relevant to helium loss in natural settings. If experimental conditions can be controlled to slow the decomposition of goethite such that the rate of natural helium loss in goethite greatly exceeds the rate of goethite decomposition into hematite and water, it would open up an experimental approach to systematically assess how factors like crystallite size, temperature, radiation damage, and chemical composition could affect helium mobility and retentivity in nature.

Early trials of the method were encouraging (§**??**). SEM imagery taken of thermally treated natural goethites in vacuum and open air showed the development of contraction cracks on the outside and throughout the interior of goethite grains heat treated in vacuum and in open air (Figs. **??**, **??**), while goethite heat-treated when encapsulated with water or gypsum did not form cracks (Fig. **??**). Goethite heat treated in open air turned red, whereas goethite heat treated in vacuum remained black.

We test this premise with the first helium step heat experiment on goethite under water-saturated conditions, and compare it with published vacuum step heats of the same sample (§**??**–**??**). A thermodynamic and kinetic analysis of goethite dehydroxylation then explains why water has this effect (§**??**–**??**).

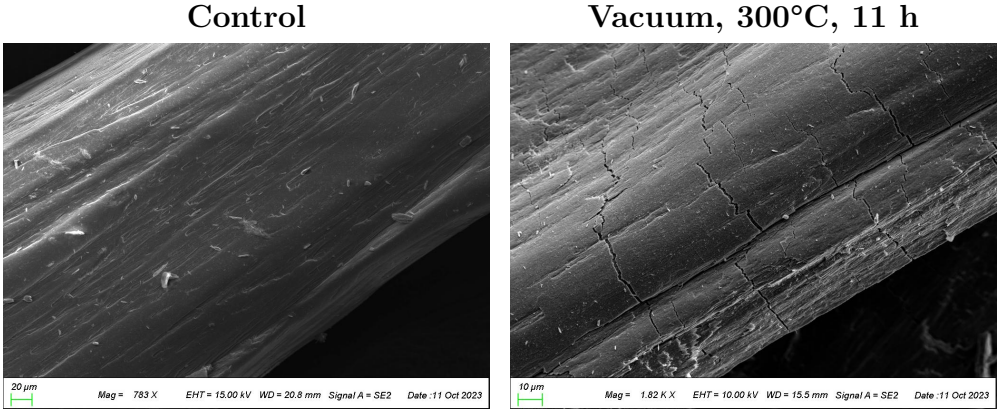



Figure 2.1: Secondary electron images of Bahia goethite aggregate before heat treatment (control) and after heat treatment at 300°C for 11 hours in vacuum. Cracks developed in the vacuum-heated sample both parallel and perpendicular to the long axis of the polycrystalline aggregate, representing volume contraction due to dehydration/decomposition of goethite into hematite. The buffered treatments at the same temperature are shown in Fig. **??**.

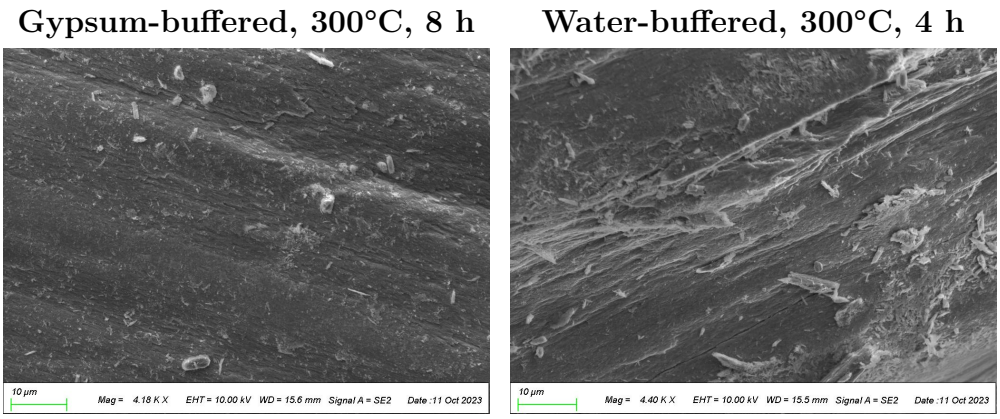



Figure 2.2: Secondary electron images of Bahia goethite aggregate heated at 300°C in a sealed glass tube with gypsum (8 hours) and with water (4 hours). Despite treatment at high heat, no cracks indicative of dehydration were visible on either goethite surface. In the gypsum experiment, the gypsum dehydrated first and produced enough water pressure to stop or slow dehydration of the goethite and prevent the development of microscopic cracks; at higher temperatures goethite and gypsum reacted, forming a surface layer of other minerals. For the water-buffered sample, no cracks were observed when investigating the goethite at scales similar to Fig. **??**, and most of the aggregate's surface resembled the gypsum-buffered panel; the area pictured had the roughest texture on the grain. A very small crack parallel to the long axis may indicate some amount of dehydration had occurred, or it could have been inherited from before hydrothermal treatment, since even the untreated control grain (Fig. **??**) had some rough surfaces and rare long-axis-parallel cracks.

## 2.2 Experimental Methods

This study builds upon previous helium step heat studies of the dense colloform goethite sample Win-06-01b (occasionally referred to as Win0601b) collected within float at the Flinders Ranges in South Australia (Waltenberg, 2012; H. Monteiro, 2017). It yields one of the oldest known goethite U-Th/He ages: 180-135 Ma (Waltenberg, 2012). To produce a homogeneous distribution of 3He, Win-06-01b was irradiated with 220 MeV protons for 24 hours at the Francis H. Burr Proton Therapy Center, Massachusetts General Hospital, following standard procedures (Shuster and Farley, 2005) and subsequently was subjected to helium step heat measurements in vacuum by H. Monteiro (2017) and Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024). In their step heat experiment of Win-06-01b, Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) additionally measured evolved water using capacitance manometry to show that helium and water release were tightly correlated for goethite step heats in vacuum. Although they

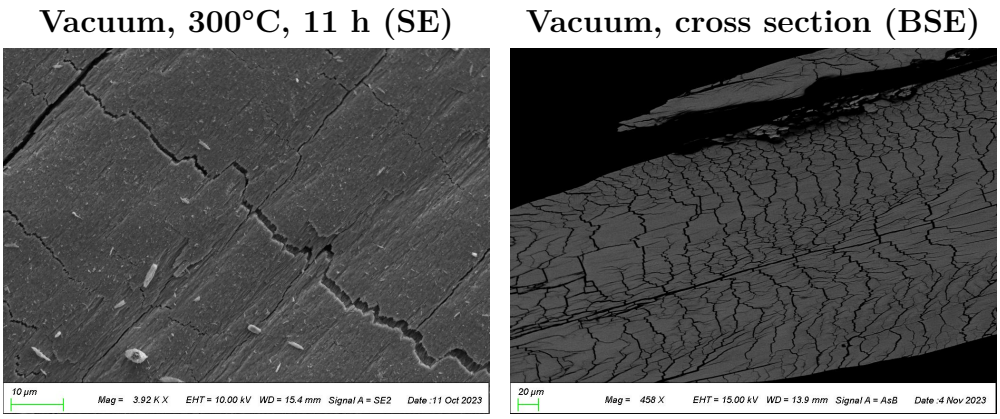



Figure 2.3: Vacuum-heated Bahia goethite at higher magnification and in cross section. Left: secondary electron image of goethite heated at 300°C for 11 hours in vacuum, at the same scale as the buffered samples of Fig. **??**, showing rough cracks at various scales both parallel and orthogonal to the long axis of the goethite aggregate. These are the typical decomposition features that would be expected in Fig. **??** if significant decomposition had occurred there. Right: backscatter electron image of a polished cross section of epoxy-mounted, vacuum-heated Bahia goethite, from the same subsample as the vacuum-heated grain of Fig. **??**, exposing the grain's interior. This image clearly shows that the cracks visible on the exterior of dehydrated goethite are pervasive throughout the interior as well.

used subtly different heating schedules, the results of Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) clearly agree well with H. Monteiro (2017).

In this study, an aliquot of the same irradiated Win-06-01b goethite used by H. Monteiro (2017) and Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) was encapsulated with MilliQ water within a silica glass tube. Silica glass was chosen over other laboratory glasses such as borosilicate because it is the most permeable glass type to helium (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961). To prepare the silica glass tube, 10 cm long segments of pure silica glass tubes with an outer diameter of 4 mm and an inner diameter of 3 mm were submerged and sonicated within acetone, ethanol, then MilliQ water baths in sequence, and then were dried overnight in a 100°C oven. The glass tubes were hand-pulled into thinner pipettes using a natural gas and oxygen glass-welding torch and the pipette ends were fused closed. After the glass had cooled, 1.18 mg of irradiated Win-06-01b goethite blades less than 2 mm in length were carefully transferred to the bottom of the tube in the presence of an ionizing fan. Less than a microliter of distilled water was transferred to the sealed pipette using a thin glass capillary, submerging

the goethite, after which the tube was gently tapped to liberate the bubbles and ensure that the water and goethite were efficiently packed at the bottom of the pipette. To seal the pipette, the contents of the ampoule were flash-frozen in liquid nitrogen and transferred to a saltwater-ice bath at a temperature of -10°C. While the pipette end of the tube remained frozen in the saltwater-ice bath, the top was interfaced with a vacuum line and the tube was pumped to a pressure of <0.1 torr. The advantage of this approach was that water would remain solid within the tube, only slowly sublimating to vacuum while atmospheric gasses would be readily pumped away. While it was desirable to remove atmospheric gasses to reduce experimental complexity by removing potentially reactive gasses like oxygen, the primary motivation for pumping the tube to rough vacuum was to aid the sealing process. When the tube contents were under vacuum, fused glass would deform inwards and self-seal, greatly improving the ease and quality of the seal while requiring far less heat input from the torch. After an acceptably low pressure was attained, the tube was closed to the vacuum line and the saltwater-ice bath was quickly replaced with a liquid nitrogen bath, ensuring that no ice was melted. The liquid nitrogen bath was preferable during sealing as it more effectively protected the goethite and ice from the high temperatures of the glass-welding torch. A fine-flamed welding torch was used to seal the top of the ampoule, which dropped into the liquid nitrogen bath and was retrieved by passing the liquid nitrogen through a sieve. Fig. **??** shows the sealed ampoule after the completion of the step heats with all of the original water remaining, a testament to the quality of the ampoule's seal, which had sustained a massive pressure gradient of over 11 orders of magnitude across the ampoule walls, with an inner vapor pressure of about $3x10^4$ torr (~40 bars: Haar et al. (1984)) against the ~$10^{-7}$ torr ultra-high vacuum of the lamp cell while the ampoule was held at 250°C for over a week.




Figure 2.4: A view of the entire experimental ampoule after the completion of the step heat experiment before it was broken for the final step in the resistance furnace. At room temperature, the tube is approximately half-filled with gas, one-third filled with liquid water, and one-sixth filled with <2 mm long shards of irradiated Win-06-01b goethite. A gel-like substance was observed lining the inner walls of the tube, which is likely to be amorphous silica dissolved from the tube and redeposited by the thermally-cycled, high pressure liquid water phase.

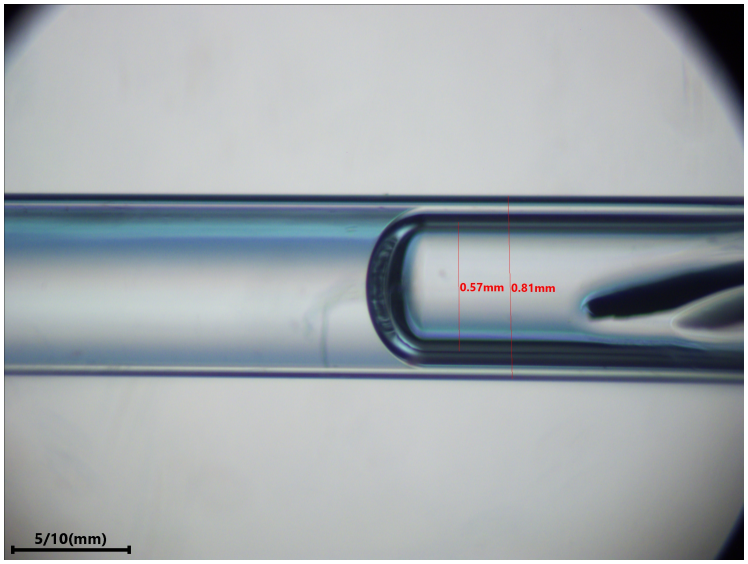



Figure 2.5: Measurements of the inner and outer diameter of the ampoule used in the hydrothermal step heats of Win-06-01b. The inner walls of the ampoule are only clearly visible within air bubbles.

The sealed ampoule, now referred to as HT-Win-06-01b, was placed in a copper foil packet and mounted to a K-type thermocouple within an ultra-high vacuum projector lamp heating cell described in more detail by Farley, Reiners, et al. (1999). Before the experiment began, the ampoule was loaded in the lamp cell, pumped to high vacuum, and was held at 70°C for 4 days to degas atmospheric helium entrained within the ampoule.

HT-Win-06-01b was subjected to multiple prograde-retrograde heating cycles to investigate possible MDD behavior. Step durations varied from 2 hours to about a week; the total experiment was conducted over about 40 days and included experimental steps ranging from 170-250°C. We elected not to heat the sample hotter because high temperatures generated very high vapor pressures. In early trials, we found that similar ampoules most often withstood the ~86 bar vapor pressures associated with liquid water saturation at 300°C (Haar et al., 1984), but they would explode when further heated to temperatures beyond 315°C.

Experimental temperature records show ~1°C amplitude oscillations around the target temperature. While we cannot exclude the possibility that sustained temperature gradients were present throughout the sample due to the use of the comparatively large ~1 mm thick ampoule, we are confident that the conclusions of this work are robust. The ampoule was in direct contact with the thermocouple junction and was in front of the thermocouple junction with respect to the projector lamp heating source, suggesting that if there were a temperature discrepancy, the sample would have been hotter than the recorded temperature, which would not affect the conclusions of this work. Additionally, during early trials of this method for helium step heats, silica-glass encapsulated Durango apatite had been subjected to step heats at Caltech and gave indistinguishable corrected 4He yields to unencapsulated Durango apatite, suggesting that the temperature recorded by the thermocouple for our experimental setup is sufficiently accurate.

Helium isotope measurements of evolved gasses from hydrothermal steps heats of glass-encapsulated irradiated HT-Win-06-01b goethite were acquired at Caltech on a Thermo Fisher Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer in peak hopping mode from January 31$^{st}$, 2024 to March 13$^{th}$, 2024. Helium was purified by exposing evolved gasses to a charcoal trap held in liquid nitrogen, a titanium sponge getter, then a SAES NP10 getter before freely expanding

into the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$. 3He was measured with a pulse-counting electron multiplier, while 4He was detected on a Faraday detector. The majority of the analysis time was spent measuring 3He. Every few hours, the background was mass-scanned to set the 3He and 4He measure points; each was taken to be a constant mass offset from the background $HD^+$ peak. These mass offsets are precisely measured when tuning the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ for helium isotope analysis. Months of helium measurements with the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ at Caltech have shown this approach to be reliable, reproducible, and accurate for helium isotope analysis. Additionally, an electron multiplier monitored atomic mass 3.5 to detect 4He overspray, which was never significant during the experiment. Measurements of high 3He MM gas standard were analyzed every 8 hours (totaling 116 measurements) to track instrumental drift of 3He and 4He sensitivities and to quantify internal reproducibility.

A cold blank was measured at the beginning of the experiment, showing a negligible 3He blank and a 4He blank signal corresponding to about 1.25 pccSTP, which was similar to 4He values attained during low temperature permeation step measurements. Permeation steps were thus assumed to measure shifting 4He blanks during the experiment, and the entire blank correction was added to all 4He uncertainties.

For the final step, the HT-Win-06-01b ampoule was broken and dried overnight in a 50°C oven, then completely degassed by heating to ~1100 °C in a resistance furnace. The final step measurement was conducted on a Thermo Fisher Helix SFT mass spectrometer. A hot furnace blank subjected to the same volume splits as the final HT-Win-06-01b measurement gave a 3He blank of 6.8 fccSTP and a 4He blank of 0.31 nccSTP. This blank correction was less than 1% of the measured 4He and negligible for 3He. A re-extract of HT-Win-06-01b immediately following the measurement yielded above-blank 3He and 4He signals, which were added to the total measurement, although both constituted less than 1% of the final step yield. Sensitivity was calculated by measuring a 3He-enriched air standard with known 3He and 4He contents immediately before the measurement.

Helium released by the sample reaches the mass spectrometer only after permeating the ampoule wall, so each measured step yield lags the true release. Step yields were corrected for this permeation lag with the bounding method of Chapter **??** (§**??**), which gives lower-bound, central and upper-bound values

for every step (Tables **??** and **??**). The correction and the ampoule permeabilities measured during the experiment are described in the Supplementary Information (§**??**), together with the diffusivity inversions, the isotope-ratio uncertainties and the kinetic analysis of the published vacuum step heats (§**??**).

**Kinetic and Diffusive Reductions of Step-Heat Data**

We reanalyzed the published vacuum step heats of irradiated Win-06-01b by Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) (hereafter *KAF*) and H. Monteiro (2017) (hereafter *HDM*), together with the water-saturated step heat of this study, by reducing every as both a first-order conversion rate constant and as an apparent diffusivity. For the kinetic reduction, $^3$He is assumed to be immediately released from the goethite lattice upon conversion to hematite, except for a fraction $\phi$ that is inherited by the hematite product. The fraction of helium released in each step is then $F_i = (1-\phi)\,\alpha_i$, where $\alpha_i$ is the fraction of goethite converted in step $i$.

We describe the kinetics of goethite dehydroxylation with a first-order rate law,

$$\frac{d\alpha}{dt} = k(T)\,(1-\alpha), \qquad k(T) = A\exp\!\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT}\right), \tag{2.1}$$

For a schedule of isothermal steps of duration $\Delta t_j$ at $T_j$, Eq. (**??**) integrates to

$$\alpha_i = 1 - \exp\left[-A\sum_{j\le i},\Delta t_j \exp\!\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT_j}\right)\right], \tag{2.2}$$

Inverting Eq. (**??**) step by step gives an apparent rate constant for every step that is independent of any fitted parameter except $\phi$:

$$k_i = -\frac{1}{\Delta t_i}\ln\frac{1-\alpha_i}{1-\alpha_{i-1}}, \qquad \alpha_i = \frac{F_i}{1-\phi}. \tag{2.3}$$

For comparison, the diffusion parameter of each step is obtained with the same Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966) inversion for a sphere that is applied to the hydrothermal experiment (§**??**).

Additionally, in both experiments release stalls at $F \approx 0.9$. The fitted $\phi = 0.101$ is the same for KAF and HDM. In HDM, the remaining ∼10% is released slowly between 340 and 500 °C and on fusion. We interpret this fraction as $^3$He inherited by the hematite product and subsequently released by the much slower diffusion out of hematite. The conversion and the plateau correspond to

the "Stage 2" and "Stage 3" release of Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024), whose transition near $F \approx 0.9$ is independent of heating schedule (and tracked by a distinct shift in $^4He/^3He$: Fig. **??**). The kinetic inversions (Eq. (**??**)) for these latest steps are highly sensitive to the choice of $\phi$ and are excluded from the fits of the kinetic parameters. The KAF steps run with the trap isolated are also excluded from the Arrhenius regression.

Both vacuum experiments show a maximum bulk normalized $^4He/^3He$ ratio of ~ 1.1 at or before $\Sigma F_{3He} \approx 0.9$ , after which the bulk normalized $^4He/^3He$ decreases to ~0.9. This behavior is tightly correlated with a decrease in apparent diffusivity interpreted to result from hematite inheritance of helium from dehydroxylated goethite (§**??**). The two experiments' agreement for this feature in the $^4He/^3He$ spectra suggests that these values are independent of heating schedule and may reflect a material property of Win-06-01b.

**SEM Study of Thermally Treated Goethite**

In early trials of the "glass tube method" for helium step heat experiments with controlled microenvironments presented here, sub-samples of goethite morphologically similar to Win-06-01b from Igarapé Bahia (Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2005; H. Monteiro, 2017) were heated in vacuum using the projector lamp heating apparatus of Farley, Reiners, et al. (1999) and in sealed glass ampoules with gypsum or water additionally added to provide moisture to slow/prevent dehydration of goethite. All samples were held at 300°C for 4-11 hours, and the glass ampoules were broken and the goethites were allowed to air dry before all samples were placed on carbon tape and carbon coated. These samples were imaged at Caltech on Secondary Electron mode by the ZEISS 1550VP Field Emission SEM. Synthetic goethite pigment, a commercial yellow iron-oxide pigment of acicular crystals ∼1 µm long, was treated in the same way but only with water, without vacuum or open-air runs: at least five larger silica glass ampoules, each loaded with pigment and an excess of water and fused shut at ambient pressure, were held at 200–250 °C for about a day in an oven whose voltage was adjusted by hand. These runs were a rapid, qualitative test; details of individual runs (temperature histories, durations, water-to-solid ratios) were not recorded, and reaction was assessed by color (yellow goethite, red hematite) before imaging.

## 2.3 Results

### Water-Saturated Step Heat of HT-Win-06-01b

The complete corrected step-heat dataset underlying the diffusivities, delta plots, and Arrhenius regressions discussed below is reported in Tables **??** and **??**, including the lower-bound, central, and upper-bound values from the bounding method's permeation-lag correction for $^{3}$He and $^{4}$He respectively.

Table 2.1: $^3$He step-heat dataset for HT-Win-06-01b under the bounding method: measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), the lower- and upper-bound true step production ($\omega_{\mathrm{LB}}$, $\omega_{\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities. "–" denotes early steps with $\lambda t < 4$, for which bounds could not be determined (see §**??**). Six rows have derived values marked with "*": these steps have measured $^3$He $< 0.1$ pccSTP and are excluded as low-signal from all plots (Fig. **??** and others derived from this dataset).

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{LB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 170 | 300 | 0.9630 | 0.0000 | 1.1660 | – | – | – | – | – |
| 180 | 463 | 0.5442 | 0.9630 | 0.2413 | – | – | – | – | – |
| 190 | 550 | 0.5292 | 1.6241 | 0.1538 | – | – | – | – | – |
| 200 | 500 | 0.5190 | 2.2112 | 0.1430 | 0.3651 | 0.6619 | -22.158 | -21.775 | -21.503 |
| 210 | 475 | 0.5770 | 2.7646 | 0.1440 | 0.4341 | 0.7210 | -21.715 | -21.406 | -21.160 |
| 220 | 450 | 0.6333 | 3.3799 | 0.1447 | 0.4894 | 0.7781 | -21.345 | -21.068 | -20.843 |
| 230 | 425 | 0.7899 | 4.0551 | 0.1685 | 0.6452 | 0.9584 | -20.823 | -20.604 | -20.392 |
| 225 | 908 | 0.7513 | 4.8885 | 0.0716 | 0.5827 | 0.8229 | -21.516 | -21.246 | -21.148 |
| 215 | 450 | 0.1415 | 5.6842 | 0.0349 | 0.0699 | 0.1764 | -22.836 | -22.124 | -21.900 |
| 205 | 520 | 0.0763 | 5.8529 | 0.0184* | 0.0413* | 0.0947* | -23.479* | -22.863* | -22.646* |
| 195 | 1106 | 0.0670 | 5.9491 | 0.0080* | 0.0487* | 0.0750* | -24.053* | -23.731* | -23.618* |
| 185 | 740 | 0.0227 | 6.0246 | 0.0049* | 0.0147* | 0.0276* | -24.839* | -24.404* | -24.207* |
| 175 | 920 | 0.0180 | 6.0610 | 0.0036* | 0.0131* | 0.0216* | -25.168* | -24.847* | -24.665* |
| 200 | 260 | 0.0224 | 6.0814 | 0.0163* | 0.0189* | 0.0388* | -23.534* | -23.360* | -22.812* |
| 210 | 520 | 0.0812 | 6.1081 | 0.0181* | 0.0649* | 0.0993* | -22.984* | -22.758* | -22.554* |
| 220 | 1167 | 0.5766 | 6.1914 | 0.0447 | 0.5585 | 0.6213 | -21.587 | -21.553 | -21.475 |
| 230 | 370 | 0.3577 | 6.7796 | 0.0903 | 0.3130 | 0.4480 | -20.948 | -20.811 | -20.579 |
| 240 | 320 | 0.6767 | 7.1563 | 0.1776 | 0.5864 | 0.8543 | -20.062 | -19.913 | -19.667 |
| 245 | 250 | 0.5549 | 7.8582 | 0.1888 | 0.3773 | 0.7437 | -20.176 | -19.778 | -19.474 |
| 250 | 210 | 0.6934 | 8.4743 | 0.2786 | 0.5047 | 0.9721 | -19.626 | -19.296 | -18.942 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{LB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 245 | 270 | 0.4659 | 9.2086 | 0.1413 | 0.1872 | 0.6071 | -20.801 | -19.874 | -19.601 |
| 240 | 320 | 0.2857 | 9.7206 | 0.0749 | 0.1445 | 0.3606 | -21.176 | -20.487 | -20.250 |
| 235 | 370 | 0.2199 | 10.0357 | 0.0517 | 0.1450 | 0.2716 | -21.284 | -20.864 | -20.650 |
| 230 | 420 | 0.1400 | 10.2736 | 0.0303 | 0.0883 | 0.1703 | -21.885 | -21.421 | -21.224 |
| 225 | 652 | 0.1494 | 10.4279 | 0.0206 | 0.1191 | 0.1700 | -22.009 | -21.781 | -21.650 |
| 230 | 500 | 0.1550 | 10.5908 | 0.0271 | 0.1344 | 0.1820 | -21.605 | -21.462 | -21.299 |
| 235 | 450 | 0.1951 | 10.7582 | 0.0361 | 0.1681 | 0.2313 | -21.258 | -21.107 | -20.936 |
| 240 | 400 | 0.2425 | 10.9638 | 0.0483 | 0.2063 | 0.2908 | -20.913 | -20.750 | -20.566 |
| 245 | 350 | 0.3150 | 11.2328 | 0.0690 | 0.2667 | 0.3840 | -20.495 | -20.326 | -20.125 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3716 | 11.5689 | 0.0939 | 0.3026 | 0.4656 | -20.181 | -19.973 | -19.743 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3640 | 11.9627 | 0.0899 | 0.2700 | 0.4539 | -20.261 | -19.959 | -19.734 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3452 | 12.3490 | 0.0852 | 0.2553 | 0.4304 | -20.285 | -19.979 | -19.755 |
| 250 | 10250 | 8.4829 | 12.7167 | 0.0494 | 8.3977 | 8.5324 | -19.989 | -19.976 | -19.969 |
| 240 | 785 | 0.2261 | 21.2187 | 0.0209 | 0.1767 | 0.2470 | -21.026 | -20.778 | -20.689 |
| **Total** | | | 146.1483 | | | | | | |

Table 2.2: $^4$He step-heat dataset and absolute $^4$He/$^3$He ratios for HT-Win-06-01b under the bounding method, structured as in Table **??**. "–" denotes steps for which bounds could not be determined. The Total row reports the bulk (total-yield) $^4$He/$^3$He ratio, i.e. the normalizing value used to bulk-normalize these ratios for the plot in Fig. **??**. Six rows have derived values marked with "*": these steps have measured $^3$He $< 0.1$ pccSTP and are excluded as low-signal from all plots, as in Table **??**.

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^4$He meas. (nccSTP) | Cum. $^4$He (nccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{LB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{UB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_m$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 170 | 300 | 0.0192 | 0.0000 | 0.0280 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – |
| 180 | 463 | 0.0305 | 0.0192 | 0.0152 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – |
| 190 | 550 | 0.0558 | 0.0660 | 0.0179 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – |
| 200 | 500 | 0.1024 | 0.1375 | 0.0313 | 0.0845 | 0.1337 | -26.207 | -25.965 | -25.619 | – | 197.3 | – |
| 210 | 475 | 0.1460 | 0.2500 | 0.0404 | 0.1147 | 0.1864 | -25.314 | -25.022 | -24.717 | 248.2 | 253.0 | 268.8 |
| 220 | 450 | 0.2091 | 0.4055 | 0.0530 | 0.1686 | 0.2620 | -24.407 | -24.152 | -23.876 | 326.3 | 330.1 | 349.3 |
| 230 | 425 | 0.3243 | 0.6319 | 0.0760 | 0.2714 | 0.4004 | -23.425 | -23.213 | -22.956 | 403.7 | 410.6 | 432.3 |
| 225 | 908 | 0.3483 | 0.9799 | 0.0363 | 0.2722 | 0.3845 | -23.807 | -23.527 | -23.413 | 442.6 | 463.6 | 474.4 |
| 215 | 450 | 0.0716 | 1.3487 | 0.0196 | 0.0353 | 0.0912 | -24.945 | -24.225 | -23.976 | 429.1 | 505.9 | 537.1 |
| 205 | 520 | 0.0385 | 1.4359 | 0.0103* | 0.0189* | 0.0487* | -25.661* | -24.942* | -24.701* | 392.4* | 504.2* | 534.6* |
| 195 | 1106 | 0.0336 | 1.4912 | 0.0043* | 0.0233* | 0.0379* | -26.165* | -25.796* | -25.675* | 446.7* | 500.9* | 515.3* |
| 185 | 740 | 0.0079 | 1.5467 | 0.0019* | 0.0037* | 0.0098* | -27.586* | -26.808* | -26.592* | 224.7* | 350.1* | 369.1* |
| 175 | 920 | 0.0152 | 1.6020 | 0.0033* | 0.0133* | 0.0185* | -26.475* | -26.340* | -26.141* | 843.2* | 843.2* | 982.0* |
| 200 | 260 | 0.0107 | 1.6351 | 0.0091* | 0.0073* | 0.0198* | -25.787* | -25.411* | -24.791* | 375.6* | 475.5* | 554.7* |
| 210 | 520 | 0.2166 | 1.6547 | 0.0535* | 0.2075* | 0.2701* | -23.067* | -23.021* | -22.786* | 2667.1* | 2667.1* | 3103.8* |
| 220 | 1167 | 0.3187 | 1.8714 | 0.0269 | 0.2652 | 0.3456 | -23.499 | -23.302 | -23.214 | 471.7 | 552.7 | 563.2 |
| 230 | 370 | 0.2113 | 2.6766 | 0.0590 | 0.1844 | 0.2703 | -22.391 | -22.249 | -21.993 | 575.1 | 590.8 | 628.0 |
| 240 | 320 | 0.4286 | 3.1616 | 0.1243 | 0.3697 | 0.5529 | -21.360 | -21.203 | -20.931 | 612.1 | 633.4 | 674.8 |
| 245 | 250 | 0.3988 | 3.6430 | 0.1521 | 0.2746 | 0.5510 | -21.289 | -20.899 | -20.556 | 665.9 | 718.7 | 778.4 |
| 250 | 210 | 0.4440 | 4.2359 | 0.2020 | 0.2918 | 0.6460 | -20.906 | -20.469 | -20.072 | 541.7 | 640.2 | 702.8 |
| 245 | 270 | 0.3123 | 4.7263 | 0.1053 | 0.1103 | 0.4176 | -22.043 | -20.981 | -20.680 | 469.1 | 670.4 | 721.4 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^4$He meas. (nccSTP) | Cum. $^4$He (nccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{LB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\omega_{\mathrm{UB}}$ (nccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_m$ | $(^4\mathrm{He}/^3\mathrm{He})_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 240 | 320 | 0.1927 | 5.0846 | 0.0559 | 0.0874 | 0.2485 | -22.376 | -21.575 | -21.315 | 505.5 | 674.3 | 718.4 |
| 235 | 370 | 0.1517 | 5.3031 | 0.0393 | 0.0958 | 0.1910 | -22.386 | -21.922 | -21.688 | 599.8 | 689.6 | 729.9 |
| 230 | 420 | 0.0991 | 5.4714 | 0.0236 | 0.0598 | 0.1227 | -22.956 | -22.448 | -22.232 | 608.3 | 707.9 | 745.9 |
| 225 | 652 | 0.0995 | 5.5835 | 0.0151 | 0.0760 | 0.1146 | -23.136 | -22.863 | -22.721 | 608.2 | 666.5 | 689.2 |
| 230 | 500 | 0.1051 | 5.6969 | 0.0202 | 0.0900 | 0.1253 | -22.679 | -22.523 | -22.345 | 652.1 | 678.1 | 707.5 |
| 235 | 450 | 0.1369 | 5.8251 | 0.0279 | 0.1167 | 0.1648 | -22.290 | -22.128 | -21.940 | 674.6 | 701.7 | 734.0 |
| 240 | 400 | 0.1781 | 5.9762 | 0.0390 | 0.1502 | 0.2171 | -21.892 | -21.719 | -21.518 | 705.1 | 734.6 | 770.9 |
| 245 | 350 | 0.2305 | 6.1807 | 0.0556 | 0.1915 | 0.2861 | -21.479 | -21.290 | -21.070 | 694.4 | 731.9 | 771.7 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.2777 | 6.4385 | 0.0758 | 0.2221 | 0.3535 | -21.134 | -20.906 | -20.659 | 703.3 | 747.3 | 793.3 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.2654 | 6.7374 | 0.0725 | 0.1896 | 0.3379 | -21.250 | -20.908 | -20.661 | 653.7 | 729.2 | 774.1 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.2489 | 7.0231 | 0.0680 | 0.1764 | 0.3169 | -21.282 | -20.932 | -20.647 | 646.8 | 721.0 | 765.4 |
| 250 | 10250 | 6.8042 | 7.2901 | 0.0430 | 6.7362 | 6.8472 | -20.704 | -20.691 | -20.682 | 800.6 | 802.1 | 803.3 |
| 240 | 785 | 0.1853 | 14.1156 | 0.0187 | 0.1423 | 0.2040 | -21.688 | -21.422 | -21.325 | 770.5 | 819.4 | 838.0 |
| **Total** | | | 145.8145 | | | | | | | | 997.7 | |

The diffusivities determined from the step heat 3He and 4He yields for HT-Win-06-01b are always significantly lower than the diffusivities determined from step heat experiments on the same sample in vacuum, and evolutions that are distinct from those determined from the vacuum experiments. The Arrhenius plot of the 3He diffusivities initially follow a declining concave-up trend until ~3.5% cumulative 3He yield, then slowly decreasing in sub-parallel arrays during prograde and retrograde heating cycles from 3.5-7% cumulative 3He yields (Fig. **??**, Fig. **??**). The Arrhenius plot of the 4He diffusivities differs in shape: it is concave-down to about 5% cumulative 3He yield, after which it follows a roughly linear array about one log unit below the 3He array (Fig. **??**). The 3He diffusivities settled into a linear array which was suitable for linear regression after ~7% of the cumulative 3He yield was lost (Fig. **??**b). All remaining diffusivity measurements of the experiment were included in the linear regression, so that diffusivities from 3He loss fractions of about 7-15% were included. The linear regression yields an $R^2$ of 0.989, an activation energy of 157.1± 5.3kJ/mol, and a closure temperature of 98.1± 8.6°C assuming a cooling rate of 10°C/Ma and considering only the uncertainty in the regression intercept ($D_0/a^2$).

A delta plot was generated using the intercept and slope parameters from the 3He regression as a reference line, similarly to previous work (Farley, 2018). The 3He apparent diffusivity delta values monotonically decrease until a cumulative 3He loss of 7%, after which the delta values are within error of Delta = 0: the reference line (Fig. **??**). A series of low-yield measurements on the first retrograde cycle produce high-error, scattered diffusivities which are omitted for clarity.

**Kinetic Reanalysis of Vacuum Step Heats**

All steps are plotted in Fig. **??**, for both the kinetic and diffusion reductions, but the fits use only KAF steps 5–22 (185–280 °C) and HDM steps 8–26 (180–296 °C).

An unweighted least-squares fit of $\ln k_i$ against $1/T_i$ for the 35 steps in the fitting window gives

$$E_a = 137.0 \pm 2.7 \text{ kJ mol}^{-1}, \qquad \ln A = 21.91 \pm 0.66 \tag{2.4}$$

KAF alone gives 139.3±6.2 and HDM alone 135.4±2.5 kJ mol$^{-1}$), in agreement with the cumulative fit. The result does not depend on the fitting window:

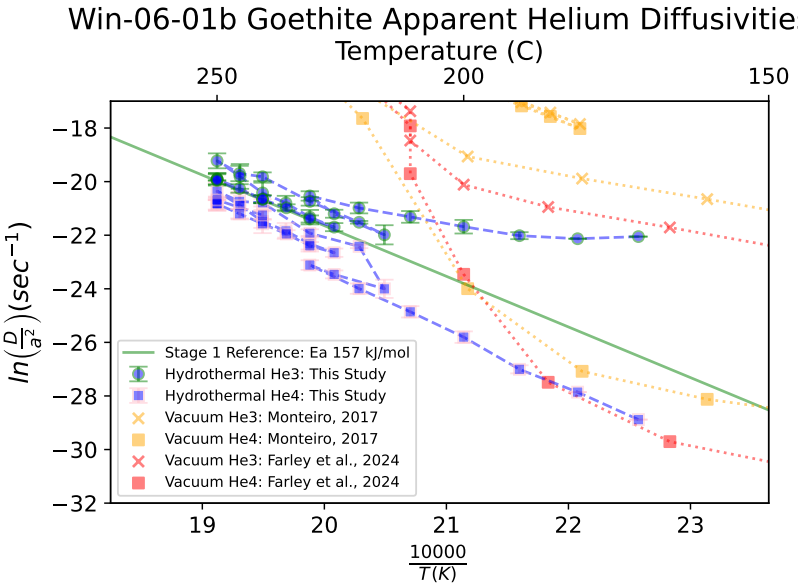



Figure 2.6: Linear regression of the last 12 measurements of 3He diffusivities in HT-Win-06-01b defining the "Stage 1" reference line. Apparent diffusivities under hydrothermal conditions are approximately seven natural log units lower than in vacuum. A diffusion domain corresponding to the Stage 1 reference line has a closure temperature of 98.1±8.6°C assuming a cooling rate of 10°C/Ma. Apparent diffusivities calculated from 4He step heats are sometimes within error of those calculated for 3He, however they are occasionally resolved at the $2\sigma$ level and are about a single log unit lower than apparent diffusivities calculated for 3He after a cumulative fractional yield of 14% 3He.

fitting all steps instead gives $E_a = 122.7$ kJ mol$^{-1}$ and the same ranking of models (§**??**).

The kinetic rate parameters fitted to KAF alone predict the independent HDM schedule with an rms misfit in $F$ of 0.018 over the fitting window. A single-domain spherical diffusion model fits both vacuum step heats worse, even when given the same hematite-inherited fraction ($\phi = 0.101$) as the first-order fit (Table **??**).

KAF steps 1–4 and HDM steps 2–7 (below ∼180 °C) release $^3$He 0.5–3 orders of magnitude faster than the extrapolated conversion rate (Fig. **??**). This component amounts to less than 2% of the $^3$He.

In two KAF steps the trap was isolated and evolved water accumulated in the line. At 230 °C the step rate constant fell to 0.33 times the mean of its neighbors at the same temperature, and at 240 °C to 0.22 times. The rate recovered fully

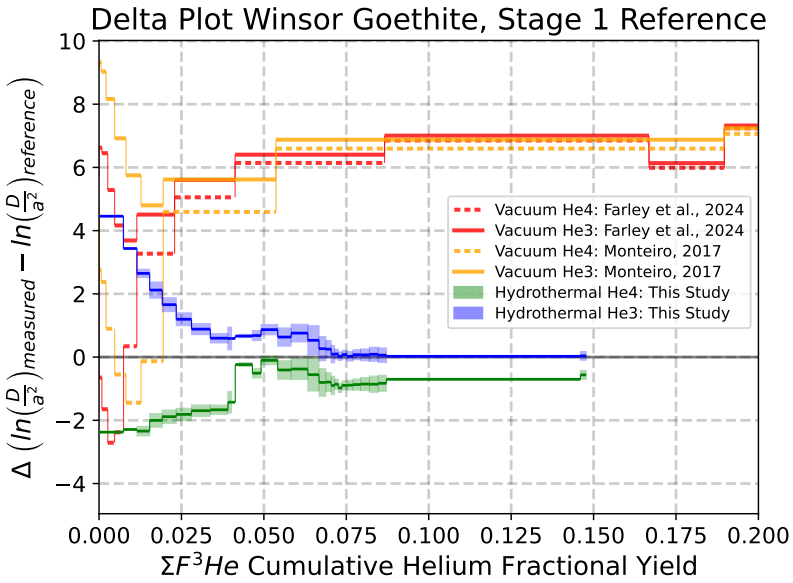



Figure 2.7: Delta plot similar to those presented in (Farley, 2018), or r/r0 plots in Lovera et al. (1991) and Farley and Flowers (2012). Delta plots are the difference between apparent log diffusivities and a reference line; they are designed to remove the temperature dependence of the dominant process of helium migration to reveal how apparent diffusivities evolve as an experiment proceeds. Six measurements from the water-saturated experiment are omitted for clarity due to low signals and high errors. For visual continuity, the gap left behind is bridged and no uncertainty is shown. 3He monotonically decreases until settling on the reference line from 7–15% 3He fractional yield. 4He diffusivities and delta values are generally highly uncertain but initially show an increase in delta values that settles to a slow increase or plateau about one log unit below the 3He reference line by a 3He fractional yield of 5%, which is consistent with diffusive loss of radiogenic 4He in variably retentive domains. Apparent diffusivities for helium in Win-06-01b in hydrothermal conditions are up to 7 log units lower than the same sample in vacuum.

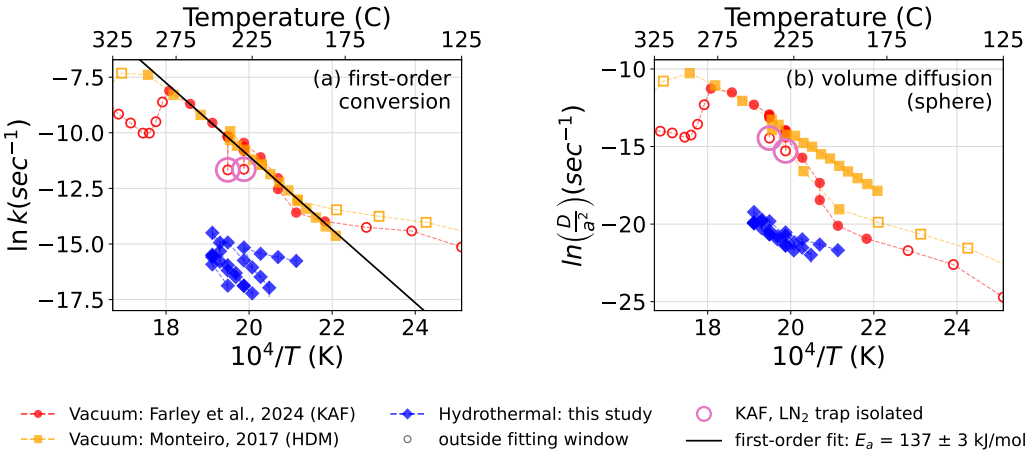



Figure 2.8: The $^3$He release of every step of the two vacuum step heats of Win-06-01b (red circles: KAF, Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. 2024; orange squares: HDM, H. Monteiro 2017) and of the hydrothermal step heat of this study (blue diamonds), reduced in two ways: (a) as first-order conversion rate constants $k_i$ (Eq. (**??**), $\phi = 0.101$), and (b) as apparent diffusivities $D/a^2$ for a sphere (Fechtig and Kalbitzer, 1966). Only the filled points are used for the linear regressions. Large pink circles mark the two KAF steps with the $LN_2$ trap isolated. Six low-signal steps of the water-saturated experiment are excluded for clarity. The black line is a first-order Arrhenius fit to filled points of both vacuum experiments. These fitted parameters are given in Eq. (**??**). Below ∼180 °C both vacuum experiments depart from the first-order line. Steps with $F > 1 - \phi$ have no defined $k$ and are absent from (a).

when the trap was restored. Water and $^3$He were suppressed together. We return to these two steps in §**??**, where they calibrate the nucleation model.

### Isothermal Discrimination Test at 250 °C

Sequences of isothermal steps can be particularly powerful in discriminating first and second order processes. Diffusion slows quickly as the diffusion front moves inward, depleting the grain rims of helium, whereas the rate of first-order conversion slows less for similar yields. We harnessed the principle to conduct a sensitive test by performing a series of 4 consecutive, long isothermal steps at 250 °C at the end of the water-saturated experiment: three consecutive 5-hour steps and one 170.8-hour step. Using the first three 5 h steps at 250 °C, we invert for both kinetic rate constants and apparent diffusivities, then use each model to project the yield for 170.8 h step.

Both the first-order and diffusion models yield reproducible results for the three

5-hour calibration steps (Fig. **??**), but their projections sharply diverge for the long step. Diffusion projects a final fractional cumulative yield of $F = 0.149$ against an observed $F = 0.146$, a much stronger agreement than the first-order model prediction of $F = 0.173$, which overpredicts the helium yield for that step by 46% (Fig. **??**). The data's uncertainty is too small to affect this result. In the interest of thoroughness, we also tested the contracting-geometry and Avrami models of §**??**, which fit the vacuum data less well. Calibrated the same way, they project cumulative fractional yields within 0.174–0.212, which diverge even more strongly from the data.

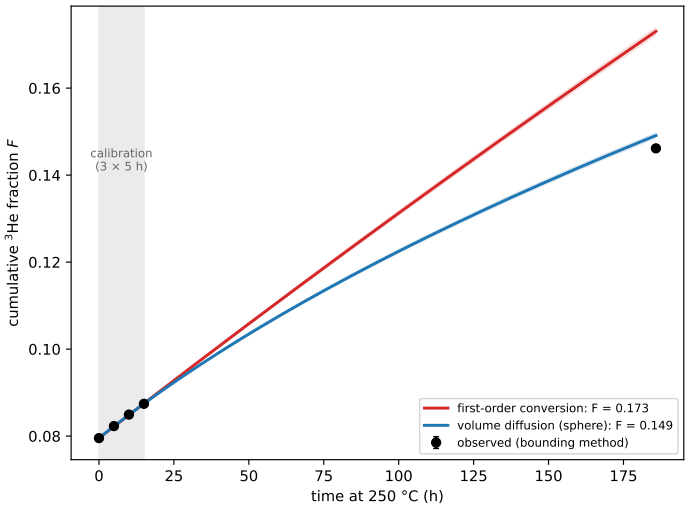



Figure 2.9: The isothermal 250 °C sequence of the water-saturated experiment. Black markers are measured cumulative $^3$He fraction. The first-order conversion and spherical volume diffusion models are each calibrated on the three 5 h steps (grey band) and projected through the 170.8 h step.

## 2.4 Discussion

### Dehydroxylation Kinetics in Vacuum Step Heats of Win-06-01b

Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) showed that evolved helium in vacuum step heats of Win-06-01b (and many other goethite samples) is controlled by the conversion of goethite to hematite. Here, we present a reanalysis of the vacuum step heat data of Win-06-01b from KAF and HDM to show that the helium release of Win-06-01b is better described by a model of first-order reaction kinetics for goethite dehydroxylation than by a second order diffusion model.

We postulate that the early $^3$He released faster than the extrapolated conversion rate (§**??**) is diffusively lost from the least retentive domains; it corresponds to "Stage 1" helium release of Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024). The kinetic reduction yields simpler, more interpretable Arrhenius plots for the vacuum experiments than the diffusion inversion does. The kinetic inversion collapses the prograde steps at the beginning of the vacuum experiments onto a single line that the diffusion reduction instead shows as an irreversible increase in diffusivity (Fig. **??**). This initial helium release is most easily read as a diffusive-related loss from a broad distribution of small, poorly retentive domains in the goethite. The Arrhenius plot of the kinetic reduction makes it clear that helium release from the initial steps is in excess of the rate of dehydroxylation, which is not obvious from the Arrhenius plot produced with the diffusion reduction. This shift in the dominance from diffusive loss to dehydroxylation-related loss offers a clear explanation for the change in behavior between "Stage 1" and "Stage 2" in vacuum step heat experiments described by Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024).

Thermogravimetric studies of goethite dehydroxylation report somewhat higher apparent activation energies, $154 \pm 15$ to $169 \pm 8$ kJ mol$^{-1}$, for a reaction controlled by a two-dimensional phase boundary, with a different mechanism at early stages and low temperature (Goss, 1987). This may simply be due to a difference in samples: goethites from different sources have different particle sizes, morphologies, and aluminum contents, all of which affect the kinetics of dehydroxylation (Langmuir, 1971; Yapp, 1983; Tardy and Nahon, 1985; Majzlan and Navrotsky, 2003).

**Helium Release under Water-Saturated Conditions Is Diffusive**

The goal of this work was to attempt to slow the goethite dehydroxylation process below the rate of thermal helium loss in unchanging goethite. The thermal schedule included several prograde-retrograde heating cycles which together would have completely dehydroxylated goethite in vacuum, using the vacuum kinetics of Eq. (**??**). Even so, only 14.7% of the $^3$He was released in the water-saturated experiment; we argue below that the helium loss in the water-saturated experiment is controlled by diffusion rather than by conversion.

Fig. **??** compares the kinetic and diffusion inversions of the step heat data. These plots show the opposite trend for the vacuum and hydrothermal experiments: the hydrothermal experiment collapses into a simpler, coherent linear array with the diffusivity reduction, whereas the kinetic inversion of the same data record a continuously declining $k$ for any given temperature as the experiment proceeds, forming a zig-zag pattern. This is the expected behavior for a second-order (diffusion-controlled) process for which helium loss slows more strongly than a first-order process as the experiment proceeds. Fig. **??** shows that helium loss is first-order for vacuum experiments and second order for the water-saturated experiment. Section **??** shows that these observations require the conversion rate at water saturation to be at least $10^{2.5}$ times slower than in vacuum, and that a nucleation control on the dehydroxylation kinetics explains suppression far greater than that.

While it is difficult to prove that decomposition or recrystallization is not playing a role in the results presented in this work, the results presented here suggest that a second-order process (likely volume diffusion) is the dominant mechanism of helium loss for Win-06-01b goethite in water-saturated conditions.

**Consistency with MDD Systematics**

All existing helium step heat data on goethites are from naturally occurring polycrystalline aggregates with unclear and potentially widely variable grain sizes (H. Monteiro, 2017; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024), which likely could follow MDD systematics (Farley, 2018). In MDD systems, apparent bulk diffusivities of a homogeneously distributed diffusant at a single temperature will decrease as an experiment proceeds, or for a system where the activation energy of diffusion is known, the temperature dependence can be removed by referring to the data in relation to a temperature-dependent reference line, as

in delta or r/r0 plots (where $\Delta = ln\left(\frac{D}{a^2}\right)_{measured} - ln\left(\frac{D}{a^2}\right)_{reference}$) (Lovera et al., 1991; Farley, 2018). For the activation energy of 157.1 kJ/mol retrieved by regression in this work, the homogeneously distributed 3He step heat data follow the expected MDD systematics and monotonically decrease within a delta plot (Fig. **??**), which is consistent with volume diffusion in a MDD system.

The strong plateau in the delta plot of the water-saturated goethite experiment and the statistically robust regression over a wide range of fractional cumulative 3He yield (from 7-15% $\Sigma F_{3He}$ with an $R^2$ of 0.989) suggests that the frequency factor obtained by the regression may be dominated by a single diffusion domain for $F_c \geq 7\%$ rather than a mix of diffusion domains as is most often observed in the apparent diffusivities for polycrystalline hematite (Farley, 2018).

**Thermodynamic Model of Goethite Dehydroxylation**

The preceding sections establish from helium step heat data alone that the vacuum step heats of Win-06-01b record first order conversion to hematite, whereas the water-saturated step heat records second order diffusion without detectable dehydroxylation. Here we use the thermodynamics of goethite dehydroxylation to explain why water has this effect and to estimate how much solid-state conversion could have occurred in the hydrothermal experiment (§**??**).

Goethite breaks down to hematite by the dehydroxylation reaction

$$2\,\alpha\text{-FeOOH} \rightleftharpoons \alpha\text{-}Fe_2O_3 + H_2O_{(\text{fluid})}, \tag{2.5}$$

whose Gibbs energy change, written per mole of hematite formed, is

$$\Delta G_r(T,P) = G_{\text{hem}}(T,P) + G_{\text{w}}(T,P) - 2\,G_{\text{goe}}(T,P) + \Delta G_{\text{surf}}. \tag{2.6}$$

where $\Delta G_r$ is the Gibbs energy change of the reaction and $G_{\text{hem}}$, $G_{\text{w}}$, and $G_{\text{goe}}$ are the Gibbs energies of hematite, water, and goethite, respectively. $\Delta G_{\text{surf}}$ is the surface energy contribution, which must be considered to reproduce observed phase stability (Navrotsky et al., 2008). Goethite is stable where $\Delta G_r > 0$ and hematite plus water where $\Delta G_r < 0$. The values and equations used to evaluate each of these terms are given in the supplement: §**??**.

This model can be used to calculate the stability field for goethite with respect to dehydroxylation to hematite and water in $\log P_{H_2O}$–$T$ space (Fig. **??**). This phase diagram communicates several important features of the goethite–hematite–water system that are relevant to the experiments considered here:

1. Goethite is not stable at the conditions of any of the experiments considered here, in water or in vacuum, in spite of the evidence that it did not react in the water-saturated experiment. Thus, we hypothesize that the reaction is kinetically inhibited for goethite under these conditions.

2. The stability of goethite is strongly dependent on the partial pressure of water below and up to water saturation. Above the saturation pressure, water is liquid and contributes far less to the reaction volume than it does as a gas, becoming a secondary control on goethite's stability.

3. The stability of goethite is strongly dependent on grain size, with smaller grains being more stable than larger grains. At water saturation, bulk goethite is stable below 18 °C, 100 nm goethite below 28 °C, and 10 nm goethite below 108 °C.

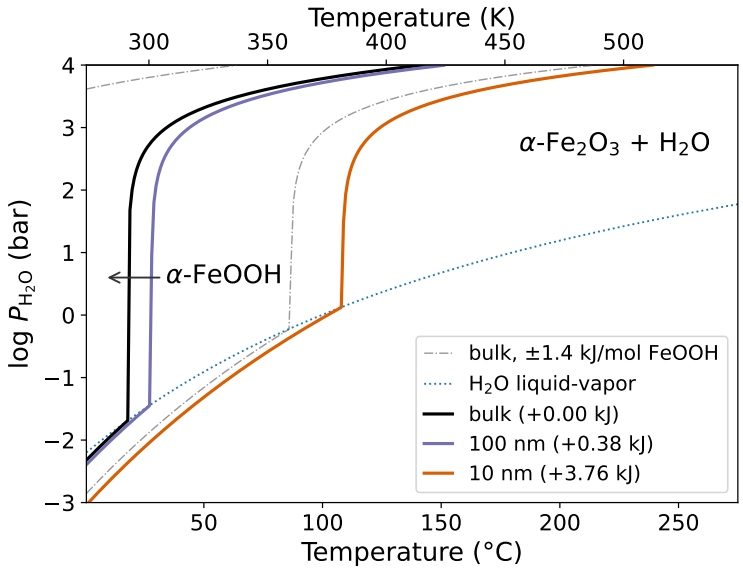



Figure 2.10: Goethite–hematite–water equilibrium in log $P_{H_2O}$–$T$ space for bulk goethite and for 100 and 10 nm grains with hydrated surfaces, compared at equal surface area per mole of Fe (Eq. (**??**)). Goethite is stable above and to the left of each curve. The dash-dot curves illustrate the absolute uncertainty: it is the bulk stability boundary shifted by the ±1.4 kJ mol$^{-1}$ FeOOH uncertainty of Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003). The blue dotted curve shows the water vapor saturation pressure; liquid water is present at and above this curve. The thermodynamic data used to compute the phase diagram are in Table **??**.

Stability alone does not determine what happens in a step heat; the rate of conversion controls whether this equilibrium state is reached or if the reaction

proceeds at all, and that depends on the chemical potential of the reaction: $\Delta\mu$. Table **??** gives the bulk driving forces at the experimental temperatures, evaluated with IAPWS-95 water. At saturation, $\Delta\mu$ is 6–11 kJ, only 1.6–2.4 times $RT$. Under the vacuum of a step-heating line ($P_{H_2O} \approx 10^{-8}$ atm) it is 76–106 kJ, about ten times larger. The chemical potential of water is therefore the key variable separating the two experimental settings.

Table 2.3: Bulk driving force for hematite formation, $\Delta\mu = -\Delta G_r$ (kJ per mole $Fe_2O_3$), at water saturation and at $P_{H_2O} = 10^{-8}$ atm.

| $T$ (°C) | $P_{sat}$ (bar) | $\Delta\mu_{sat}$ | $\Delta\mu_{sat}/RT$ | $\Delta\mu_{vac}$ | $(\Delta\mu_{vac}/\Delta\mu_{sat})^2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 150 | 4.76 | 5.68 | 1.61 | 75.8 | 178 |
| 175 | 8.93 | 6.88 | 1.84 | 83.4 | 147 |
| 200 | 15.55 | 8.11 | 2.06 | 91.0 | 126 |
| 225 | 25.50 | 9.37 | 2.26 | 98.5 | 111 |
| 250 | 39.76 | 10.66 | 2.45 | 106.0 | 99 |

**Water Pressure Control on the Hematite-in-Goethite Nucleation Barrier**

The hydrothermal data bound how fast goethite could have converted to hematite in water. Under the vacuum kinetics of Eq. (**??**), the hydrothermal schedule gives $\sum_i k_{vac}(T_i)\,\Delta t_i \approx 60$, enough to convert the sample completely. If water lowers the conversion rate by a factor $R = k_{sat}/k_{vac}$, then even if all of the observed $^3$He release came from conversion ($\alpha = F/(1-\phi) = 0.147/0.899 = 0.16$), $R$ can be at most $10^{-2.5}$. The release is second order volume diffusion (§**??**). Limiting dehydroxylation fraction to below 1%, requires $R \leq 10^{-3.8}$. Here we show that classical nucleation theory, calibrated on the vacuum data alone, predicts an even stronger rate suppression under water-saturated conditions.

*Nucleation barrier.* In classical nucleation theory (Gibbs, 1878; Volmer and Weber, 1926; Becker and Döring, 1935), reviewed by Christian (2002), Kashchiev (2000) and, for mineral systems, De Yoreo and Vekilov (2003) and Lasaga (1998), a spherical hematite nucleus of radius $r$ has free energy

$$\Delta G(r) = -\frac{4}{3}\pi r^3 \frac{\Delta\mu}{V_{hem}} + 4\pi r^2\gamma, \tag{2.7}$$

where $\Delta\mu$ is the driving force per mole of $Fe_2O_3$ (Table **??**), $V_{hem}$ the molar volume and $\gamma$ the energy of the interface surrounding the nucleus. Nuclei larger

than the critical radius $r^* = 2\gamma V_{\mathrm{hem}}/\Delta\mu$ grow, and the energetic barrier to forming one is

$$\Delta G^* = \frac{16\pi\,\gamma^3\,V_{\mathrm{hem}}^2}{3\,\Delta\mu^2}. \tag{2.8}$$

In the first-order limit of §**??**, the rate constant is a nucleation rate of the form derived by Turnbull and Fisher (1949),

$$k = A\exp\!\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT}\right)\exp\!\left(-\frac{\Delta G^*}{k_B T}\right),$$
$$\frac{\Delta G^*}{k_B T} = \frac{C\gamma^3}{T\,\Delta\mu^2}, \qquad C \equiv \frac{16\pi V_{\mathrm{hem}}^2}{3k_B} = 1.112\times10^{15}\ \mathrm{m^6\,K\,J^{-1}\,mol^{-2}}, \tag{2.9}$$

where $A\exp(-E_a/RT)$ describes the atomic mobility and $\exp(-\Delta G^*/k_BT)$ is the equilibrium fraction of sites occupied by critical nuclei. Because the barrier scales as $\gamma^3/\Delta\mu^2$, the tenfold drop in $\Delta\mu$ between vacuum and water saturation raises the energetic barrier $\Delta G^*$ a hundredfold (Table **??**).

*Internal nucleation.* Goethite dehydroxylates topotactically: hematite nucleates within the parent crystal, inherits its oxygen framework and orientation, and the pseudomorph develops pores and twinned hematite domains (Lima-de-Faria, 1963; Watari, Van Landuyt, et al., 1979; Watari, Delavignette, et al., 1983; Cudennec and Lecerf, 2005). We therefore consider only internal nucleation, in which the new interface of the burgeoning nuclei is between hematite and goethite. We know of no measured or calculated energy for that interface, so $\gamma$ is replaced by an effective parameter $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$, calibrated from the data.

*Calibration.* When Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) isolated the liquid nitrogen trap from the heated goethite, they raised $P_{\mathrm{H_2O}}$ in the line and lowered $\Delta\mu$, and the isothermal rate fell by a factor $s$ (§**??**). With $A$ and $E_a$ unchanged, Eq. (**??**) gives

$$\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}} = \left[\frac{T\ln(1/s)}{C\left(\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}}^{-2} - \Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}}^{-2}\right)}\right]^{1/3}, \tag{2.10}$$

with $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}}$ evaluated at $P_{\mathrm{H_2O}} = 10^{-8}$ atm and $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}}$ at an upper bound on the water pressure with the trap isolated. This pressure estimate of the water released depends on the volume of the experimental apparatus and the water content emitted by the goethite, which was measured with capacitance manometry (§**??**). This gives $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}} = 0.16\ \mathrm{J\,m^{-2}}$ (range 0.14–0.19). Under vacuum the corresponding critical nucleus is smaller than a formula unit ($r^* = 0.08 - -0.11$ nm) and the barrier is only 0.5–1.3 $k_BT$: conversion in

vacuum is effectively barrierless, consistent with the simple Arrhenius behavior of both vacuum experiments. At this scale classical nucleation theory has no literal meaning, so $\gamma_{\text{eff}}$ is best read as the single parameter of a rate law in which $\ln k$ falls as $-1/\Delta\mu^2$, not as an interface energy. At saturation, $r^* \approx 1$ nm and the barrier is 51–129 $k_B T$.

*Translation to water saturation.* For the same sample, only $\Delta\mu$ changes between vacuum and saturation:

$$\frac{k_{\text{sat}}}{k_{\text{vac}}} = \exp\left[-\frac{C\gamma_{\text{eff}}^3}{T}\left(\frac{1}{\Delta\mu_{\text{sat}}^2} - \frac{1}{\Delta\mu_{\text{vac}}^2}\right)\right]. \tag{2.11}$$

Applied step by step to the hydrothermal schedule, Eq. (**??**) predicts a total conversion ($\sum_i \frac{k_{\text{sat}}}{k_{\text{vac}}}(T_i)\, k_{\text{vac}}(T_i)\, \Delta t_i$) of $10^{-20.5}$, $10^{-31.4}$ and $10^{-53.7}$ for $\gamma_{\text{eff}} = 0.14$, 0.16 and 0.19 J m$^{-2}$, and $10^{-67.3}$ to $10^{-15.7}$ (95%) when the uncertainties in the calibration and in the thermodynamic data are propagated (§**??**). The exact values reflect the assumed $\Delta\mu^{-2}$ dependence; what matters is that the model predicts suppression far beyond the $10^{-3.8}$ that the data require.

*Assumptions.* This is a consistent physical explanation of the data, not a proof. It is not exhaustive. This analysis assumes (i) that the trap-isolated slowdown acts through $\Delta\mu$, rather than, for example, through water blocking reactive sites; (ii) that $\gamma_{\text{eff}}$, $A$ and $E_a$ are the same in vacuum and in water; (iii) that the barrier depends on the bulk driving force without significant contribution from surface terms (this analysis extended to 10 nm grains raises the predicted conversion only to $\sim 10^{-23}$; §**??**); and (iv) that conversion is solid-state. Conversion by dissolution of goethite and precipitation of hematite from the fluid is not described by Eq. (**??**) (see §**??**). The calibrated $\gamma_{\text{eff}}$ absorbs contributions from the sample's microstructure and cannot be transferred to other goethites.

### Goethite Dehydration and/or Recrystallization During Helium Step Heat Experiments

The aim of helium step heat experiments is to characterize the mechanisms and rates helium loss in nature to aid in the interpretation of geochronologic and helium geochemical data. The results of this experiment are encouraging in that they differ remarkably from experiments on the same samples in vacuum that are primarily controlled by dehydration processes (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024), but we cannot exclude that this experiment may have been affected

to some degree by processes aside from volume diffusion that are unrelated to helium loss in goethite in nature. We consider two processes outside of volume diffusion that could have contributed to the helium released in the water-saturated experiment: (i) recrystallization of goethite or (ii) fluid-mediated conversion of goethite to hematite. If either of these processes affected the helium release, then the apparent diffusivities reported here would represent upper bounds for diffusive helium loss in goethite in nature.

The helium step heat data at water-saturated conditions reported here are better fit with a diffusion model than with a conversion model (§**??**).The kinetic analysis of §**??**, and the nucleation analysis of §**??** indicate that topotactic dehydroxylation has a nucleation barrier that is insurmountable for experimental conditions and timescales; however, this model has no bearing on fluid-mediated dehydroxylation. Equilibrium thermodynamics predict that goethite is unstable with respect to hematite and water at these conditions (Majzlan, Grevel, et al., 2003) (§**??**) and therefore dehydroxlation of in the experiment cannot be outright excluded.

The process of recrystallization is another potential complication in interpreting helium step heats of goethite in hydrothermal conditions. Poorly crystalline synthetic goethite held in hydrothermal conditions is known to recrystallize into more orderly, crystalline goethite aggregates, even at temperatures as low as 125°C in as little as 16 hours (Schwertmann et al., 1985). In this study, natural goethite was held in contact with liquid water and water vapor at hydrothermal conditions as harsh as ~40 bars and 250°C for many days. These conditions appear to have visibly dissolved and reprecipitated silica from the ampoule's inner walls (Fig. **??**), qualitatively testifying to the ability of the hydrothermal fluid to dissolve and recrystallize rock-forming oxides. It is unquestionable that recrystallization of some goethite could have occurred under these conditions; however, it is unclear if conditions were favorable to recrystallize this specimen of goethite, Win-06-01b, which is amongst the most helium-retentive and crystalline dated goethite samples (Waltenberg, 2012; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Less crystalline goethites in nature are commonly recrystallized, which appears to result in helium loss, resetting the U-Th/He age (H. S. Monteiro, P. M. P. Vasconcelos, et al., 2018; H. S. Monteiro, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2014; Heim et al., 2006). Recrystallization could be the dominant process controlling helium loss in this experiment, but only if

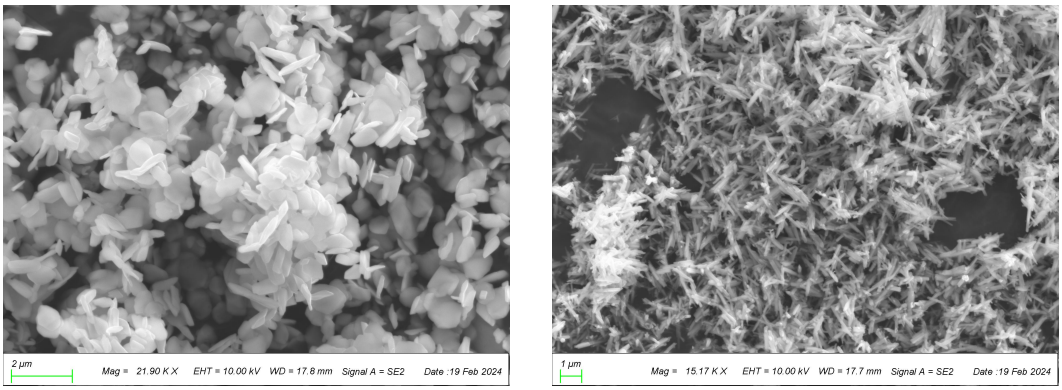
it is faster than diffusive loss, in which case the data presented here would represent new upper bounds for apparent diffusivities for helium in Win-06-01b goethite. Recrystallization might also be faster than volume diffusion of helium in goethite in nature over geologic timescales even if it did not occur in this experiment. In that case, recrystallization could be the primary driver of helium loss in nature regardless of the results of this experiment.

### Fluid Mediated Conversion of Synthetic Goethite Pigment

We observed the spontaneous conversion of synthetic goethite pigment (§**??**) to hematite when heated in ampoules with excess water at experimental temperatures. Roughly equal proportions of ampoules were completely reacted (red), completely unreacted (yellow), or contained both reacted and unreacted material in isolated patches. In the mixed ampoules, the red and yellow portions were entirely isolated from one another, separated by gas bubbles. Unreacted pigment retains its original acicular habit (Fig. **??**b). The reacted hematite product is instead composed of equant to platy crystals ∼0.5–1 µm across (Fig. **??**a). The change of shape rules out pseudomorphic dehydroxylation like that observed to occur in goethite heated in vacuum (Figs. **??**, **??**, and **??**) indicating dissolution of goethite and nucleation and growth of hematite from the fluid, a pathway outside the solid-state nucleation model developed in §**??**.

Conversion either went to completion within a fluid-connected volume or did not occur at all, even where reacted and unreacted pigment shared the same ampoule and thermal history. We posit that the fluid-mediated reaction requires some threshold of dissolved Fe(III) in the fluid to nucleate hematite, but because the reaction consumes and produces dissolved Fe(III) in equal proportions, it is not self-limiting and proceeds quickly to completion once that threshold is reached.

We conclude that water-saturated conditions do not by themselves exclude fluid-mediated conversion of goethite, even where topotactic conversion is suppressed (§**??**). Whether that pathway operates likely depends on the solution chemistry. Still, the helium step heat data for Win-06-01b-HT show no evidence for the abrupt abrupt and extreme helium loss that would be expected to accompany a fluid-mediated reaction. The step heat data are instead consistent with a smooth, history-dependent release of helium, as expected for diffusive loss (§**??**).




(a) Reacted (red) product (b) Unreacted (yellow) pigment

Figure 2.11: Secondary electron images of synthetic goethite pigment after hydrothermal treatment at 200–250 °C for about a day (§**??**). (a) Material from a completely reacted (red) ampoule: the acicular goethite has been replaced by equant to platy hematite crystals ∼0.5–1 µm across. (b) Material from an unreacted (yellow) ampoule, which retains the unchanged acicular habit of the starting pigment. The change in crystal habit requires dissolution of goethite and precipitation of hematite from the fluid, and the all-or-nothing outcome of the experiments indicates that the reaction is fast once it begins.

Grain size and bulk thermodynamics cannot explain why the pigment blades reacted when the natural polycrystalline goethite did not. At 1 µm, the surface contribution to $\Delta G_r$ is only ∼0.04 kJ, and the bulk driving force at saturation is the same 6–11 kJ for both materials (Table **??**). The most likely difference is the fluid itself. Commercial iron-oxide pigments are commonly produced by precipitation from iron-salt solutions. They can carry residual soluble salts such as iron and alkali sulfates or nitrates, and they are often surface-treated with organometallic compounds (Legodi and Waal, 2007; Almeida Silva et al., 2017; Xu et al., 2021). Such contaminants would change the pH and ionic strength of the water they are heated in, and with them the solubility of Fe(III). The dissolution–precipitation pathway is limited by how much iron the fluid carries, so a modest increase in Fe(III) solubility could make a nucleation-limited reaction viable. The natural Win-06-01b goethite, by contrast, was heated in distilled water, where near-neutral Fe(III) solubility is very low, potentially offering an explanation for the divergent outcomes.

### High Helium Retentivity of Win-06-01b-HT

The apparent diffusivities of the water-saturated experiment are approximately seven natural log units lower than those obtained from the same sample in

vacuum by H. Monteiro (2017) and Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) (Fig. **??**b, Fig. **??**, Fig. **??**). This high helium retentivity is explored through three lenses: closure temperature of cooling samples (Dodson, 1973), isothermal diffusion (Wolf, Farley, and Kass, 1998), and through comparison with step heats of other polycrystalline samples.

If the slope and intercept on the regression of 3He apparent diffusivities from this experiment are taken to represent a real diffusion domain for goethite, then a closure temperature can be calculated for this domain. Considering uncertainty only in the intercept ($D_0/a^2$) term and a cooling rate of 10°C/Ma, the closure temperature for that domain would be 98.1± 8.6°C.

Goethite is formed near Earth's surface and thus U-Th/He geochronology is most typically applied to date surface processes (Heim et al., 2006; Yapp and Shuster, 2011; P. M. Vasconcelos et al., 2013; Danišík et al., 2013; H. S. Monteiro, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al., 2014; Hofmann, Reichenbacher, et al., 2017; Allard et al., 2018). For crystals of goethite grown and collected near the surface, the concept of a closure temperature is poorly applicable, as it necessarily assumes a cooling rate (Dodson, 1973). In such cases, a better measure of retentivity is an analysis of isothermal retentivity over time (Wolf, Farley, and Kass, 1998), which is commonly expressed in terms of t'/t, where t' is the helium age and t is the isothermal holding time (most often the 'real age'). For an isothermal holding time of 100 Ma at 40°C, a diffusive domain with the parameters obtained from the regression of 3He apparent diffusivities of Win-06-01b-HT has a t'/t = 0.968, where t'/t = 1 corresponds to perfect retentivity. Fig. **??** shows isothermal holding time against helium age for this same domain for 4 different temperatures. At 25°C, this domain is nearly quantitatively retentive of helium even at billion-year time scales. The results presented here qualitatively support that goethite is highly retentive of helium at surface conditions, even at 100-million-year timescales.

It is difficult to use Arrhenius plots to compare many samples' helium retentivities. Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) report that linear regressions on apparent diffusivities calculated from helium step heat data on goethite in vacuum can be fit to yield widely variable diffusive parameters even for a single sample (e.g. activation energies ranging from 107 to 176 kJ/mol within a single experiment on YAN-0201 AC). Similarly, regressions on helium step heat data of polycrystalline materials can yield erroneous activation energies when

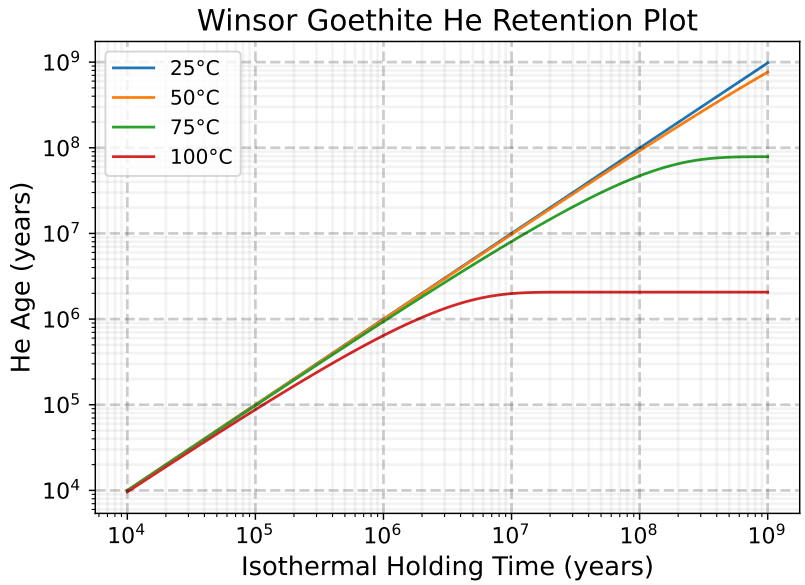



Figure 2.12: Isothermal retention plot (Wolf, Farley, and Kass, 1998) for helium in goethite corresponding to the "Stage 1" reference line regression on the hydrothermal experiment. Helium hosted in a diffusion domain with these diffusion parameters would be nearly perfectly retentive at billion-year timescales at 25°C. At 40°C, the equilibrium age for this domain (the helium age at which radiogenic helium production and diffusive loss are equal) is 33.2 billion years, attained after 50.4 billion years.

not applied carefully (Farley, 2018). Because of the complexity of comparing Arrhenius plots of calculated apparent diffusivities for polycrystalline samples with differing heating schedules, it is advantageous to convert heating schedules to some parameter that can be compared easily between experiments. One effective way to reduce the complexity of step heat experiments to visualize helium retentivity is to "flatten" a thermal history to a dimensionless diffusive timescale: the Fourier number ($Fo = Dt/a^2$). This approach offers similar benefits to Delta plots (Farley, 2018) or r/r0 plots (Lovera et al., 1991), but is optimized to qualitatively compare the helium retentivities of polycrystalline samples for a given thermal history (expressed as diffusive time).

For a given diffusive domain, a Fourier number of $Fo \approx 1$ corresponds to the complete degassing of that domain. Complex heating schedules can be converted to Fourier numbers by assuming a reference line similarly to a Delta or r/r0 plot (Lovera et al., 1991; Farley, 2018). This procedure is especially useful for MDD (Multiple Diffusion Domain) systems, where the apparent diffusivities decrease

over the course of a step heat experiment as the least retentive domains are degassed. For a single spherical diffusion domain, the fraction of helium released is a function of the Fourier number alone (Crank, 1979; Fechtig and Kalbitzer, 1966). If the activation energy of the reference Fourier number is the same as the activation energy of diffusion, then the amount of helium released in that domain then is an exact function of the reference Fourier number multiplied by a constant. Thus, a plot with reference Fourier numbers against cumulative fractional helium yields for different samples will yield the same geometries and interrelationships regardless of the intercept used to calculate the reference Fourier numbers; the values of the reference Fourier numbers will be arbitrary and only meaningful as relative diffusive time. Another implication is that different aliquots of the same sample should appear identical in this space regardless of heating schedule (see the vacuum step heats of Win-06-01b and the overlapping hematite samples in Fig. **??**). Many such plots were generated with a variety of activation energies between 149 kJ/mol to 171 kJ/mol, but the relative positions of the degassing curves for all samples are preserved, illustrating the utility of this approach even for comparing helium retentivity between different minerals.

Fig. **??** compares the step heat results of Win-06-01b-HT with 11 step heat experiments of 3 samples of polycrystalline hematite and 9 step heat experiments of 2 samples of goethite in vacuum, including Win-06-01b. In a thermal-history normalized space, it is obvious that goethite in vacuum and hematite define well-separated populations and goethite in vacuum is far less retentive of helium than hematite. Most interestingly, the most retentive sample on these plots is clearly the Win-06-01b-HT goethite under water-saturated conditions, at least for the 14.7% of the total 3He hosted in the least retentive domains. This plot shows that step heat results for different, unrelated goethite samples in vacuum are more similar to one another than step heat results of the same sample at different water activities.

This study of a single sample has no bearing on potential complexities related to aluminum content, radiation damage, or crystal defects on bulk diffusion (Bassal et al., 2022), nor does it permit estimation of the diffusivity at infinite temperature (D0); this would require experiments on controlled grain sizes.

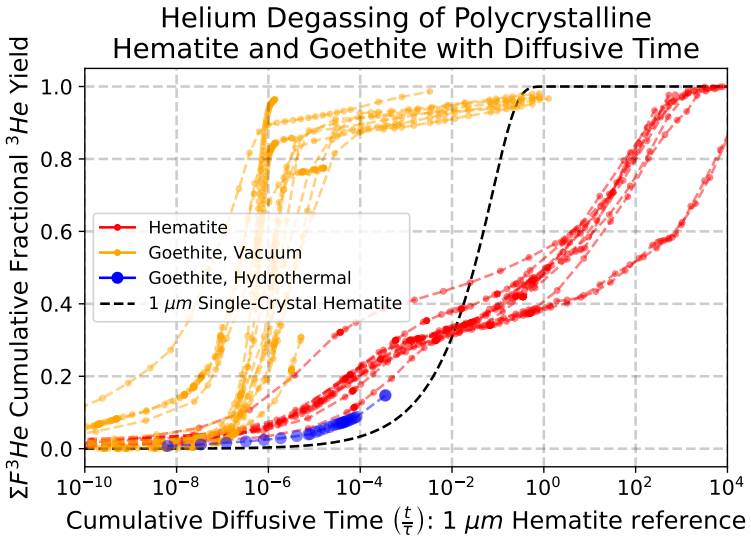



Figure 2.13: Heating schedules for polycrystalline goethite and hematite samples are flattened to reference Fourier numbers, dimensionless numbers that can be thought of as an integrated thermal history, allowing for easy intercomparison of helium step heat experiments with distinct thermal schedules. Curves on the left of the plot degas earlier within a given thermal history than the curves on the right. Hematite and goethite step heats in vacuum each cluster closely together, forming distinct populations. Most strikingly, the hydrothermal Win-06-01b-HT experiment is the most helium-retentive polycrystalline sample on the plot, at least until the experiment's end at a cumulative fractional yield ∼15% F3He. The differences in the curves here primarily reflect differences in grain size distributions. Vacuum step heats of 11 aliquots of 4 samples of polycrystalline hematite from the Grand Canyon, Arizona (Farley and Flowers, 2012) and the Gogebic Range, Michigan (Farley and McKeon, 2015), and 9 aliquots of Win-06-01b and Capao goethite from Minas Gerais, Brazil (H. Monteiro, 2017; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024) are plotted here. The reference $D/a^2$ values are calculated for 1µm domains of hematite ($\ln(D_0) = 0.66$; $E_a = 171$ kJ/mol: (Farley, 2018)).

**Profiling Radiogenic Helium Loss with $\frac{^4He}{^3He}$ Ratios of Win-06-01b-HT**
Bulk-normalized $^4$He/$^3$He ratios in step heats of irradiated samples measure the rounding of concentration profiles of radiogenic helium by natural helium loss, if the loss mechanism in nature and in the laboratory share the same geometry (Shuster, Farley, et al., 2004; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Aside from the first experimental step, bulk-normalized $^4$He/$^3$He ratios for all experiments begin at vanishingly small values and steeply increase at first, with the rate of increase slowing as the experiments proceed (Fig. **??**). This behavior is consistent with complete then partial loss of radiogenic helium in nature in the least retentive domains and is observed in all step heat experiments on irradiated goethite (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). These least retentive domains could represent fine goethite grains, or they could represent interstitial helium trapped between crystallite grain boundaries. Goethite aggregates are known to have interstices that are filled by chemisorbed non-stoichiometric water that represents the earliest water to be lost in vacuum (Naono et al., 1987). Non-stoichiometric hydrogen is known to persist in goethite even after heating to 140°C (Yapp and Poths, 1995). It is therefore reasonable to posit that artificial 3He observed in less-retentive domains may be trapped by non-stoichiometric water or hydroxyl groups within interstices of goethite aggregates. Dehydration of non-stoichiometric interstitial water may be associated with early fractions of degassing 3He from goethite samples during step heats, and could potentially represent the LRD (low retention domain) of Shuster, P. M. Vasconcelos, et al. (2005), and the 3He offgassed during "Stage 1" in vacuum step heats (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). The high variability of the portion of 3He hosted in early-degassing "Stage 1" fractions within vacuum step heats is sensible considering observations that goethite formed at different conditions is known to have highly variable crystallinity, crystallite ordering, surface area, and non-stoichiometric water contents (Schwertmann et al., 1985).

The hydrothermal experiment records lower bulk-normalized $^4$He/$^3$He ratios than the vacuum experiments at any given $\Sigma F_{3\mathrm{He}}$ for the duration of the experiment. Similarly, the approach to the $^4$He/$^3$He plateau varies between the three experiments: a high bulk normalized $^4$He/$^3$He plateau is most decisively represented in the Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024) experiment, whereas the $^4$He/$^3$He ratios in the step heats of H. Monteiro (2017) transition more gradually before reaching a plateau later in the experiment, while the increase in $^4$He/$^3$He ratios is slowest for the hydrothermal experiment (Fig. **??**). This

suggests that the geometry of helium loss differs between the hydrothermal and vacuum experiments, and could be explained by the relative dominance of dehydration processes or their mode of spatial propagation as a function of water pressure, where the smoothest $^4$He/$^3$He spectra are generated by higher water pressures. We interpret this experimental control on the $^4$He/$^3$He spectra to reflect the relative importance of goethite dehydration and helium diffusion through crystalline goethite in governing the geometry of helium loss from the sample.

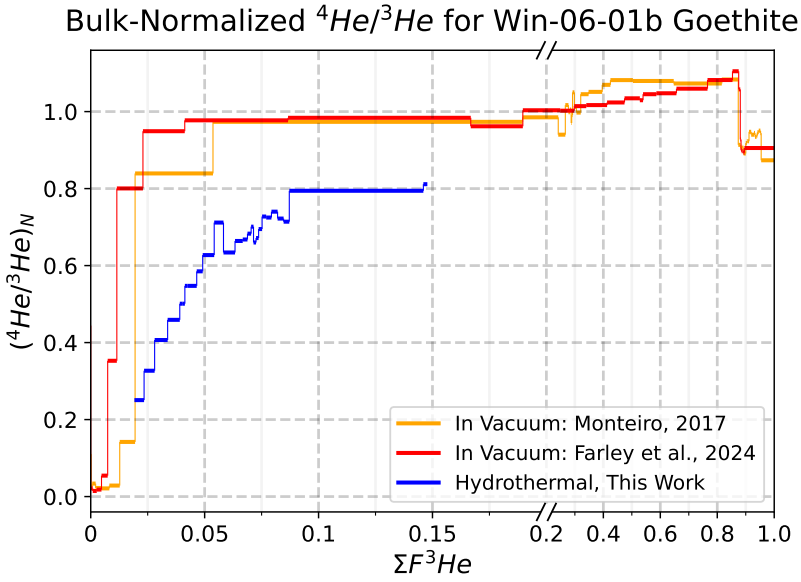



Figure 2.14: Bulk-normalized $^4$He/$^3$He ratios for Win-06-01b goethite step heats against cumulative fractional $^3$He yield. The hydrothermal experiment shows lower bulk-normalized $^4$He/$^3$He ratios at a given $\Sigma F_{^3\mathrm{He}}$ for the duration of the experiment, suggesting that $^4$He/$^3$He spectra are dependent on the partial pressure of water and that the geometry of goethite dehydroxylation differs from the geometry of helium diffusion through goethite. For all experiments, $^4$He/$^3$He ratios begin at very small values and increase steeply at first, which is consistent with complete then partial loss of radiogenic helium in nature for the least retentive helium domains. Six measurements from the water-saturated experiment are omitted for clarity due to low signals and high errors. For visual continuity, the gap left behind is bridged. The horizontal axis changes scale at $\Sigma F_{^3\mathrm{He}} = 0.2$ (double slash) to emphasize the portion of the plot where data exist for the water-saturated experiment.

If the geometry of helium loss due to dehydration and due to diffusion differ, then the $^4$He/$^3$He spectra of goethite measured in vacuum may not straightforwardly encode the geometry or history of helium loss in the way that such data

faithfully encode this history in phases such as hematite or apatite (Farley and McKeon, 2015; Shuster, Farley, et al., 2004). This claim rests entirely upon the correctness of the $^4$He data reported here, for which each step yield is somewhat small, most often between 0.15 and 0.5 nccSTP. More $^4$He/$^3$He spectra of goethite under hydrothermal conditions, with stronger $^4$He signals, are needed to investigate this hypothesis further.

These ratios also bear on the natural thermal history of Win-06-01b. Throughout the range of $\Sigma F_{3He}$ that defines the Stage 1 reference line (7–15%), step $^4$He/$^3$He ratios remain at 0.67–0.82 of the bulk value (Table **??**). Radiogenic $^4$He is depleted relative to the uniformly distributed $^3$He in this domain, so even this retentive domain lost helium in nature. A domain with the Stage 1 parameters is nearly quantitatively retentive at Earth-surface temperatures (§**??**), so this loss is difficult to attribute to thermally activated diffusion at surface conditions. Either Win-06-01b experienced temperatures well above surface conditions after it formed, for example if it grew in a hydrothermal setting, or non-thermal processes such as fluid-mediated recrystallization caused partial helium loss in nature.

## 2.5 Conclusions

Predicting the degree of helium retention and loss to guide interpretation of U-Th/He dates of natural goethite based on factors such as grain size, crystallinity, radiation damage, defect density, impurities, and aluminum substitution remains challenging. Previous efforts to understand helium loss in natural goethite with step heating experiments in vacuum have instead queried the kinetics of dehydration (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Because goethite dehydration is suppressed at high water pressure, helium step heats under hydrothermal conditions are more likely to interrogate the processes controlling radiogenic helium loss in natural goethite. The method presented in this study leverages the high helium permeability of silica glass to easily conduct helium step heat experiments under water-saturated conditions, achieving internal water pressures up to 86 bars at 300°C using standard ultra-high vacuum experimental setups (Farley, Reiners, et al., 1999). Natural crystalline goethite does not develop the visible dehydration-induced contraction cracks when heated at water-saturated conditions like vacuum-heated goethite does.

The experiment conducted on irradiated Win-06-01b represents the first helium

step heat experiment for goethite at water-saturated conditions. Vacuum step heats of the same sample follow first-order conversion to hematite, whereas the hydrothermal release shows the history and time dependence of diffusion. The hydrothermal experiment gives apparent diffusivities approximately seven natural log units below those obtained from the same sample in vacuum. The corrected $^3$He array is linear between 7–15% cumulative yield, with an activation energy of 157.1± 5.3kJ/mol. Extrapolated to surface conditions, a domain with these parameters is essentially quantitatively retentive of helium at billion-year timescales at 25°C. The $^4$He data require that this domain experienced helium loss in nature, suggesting either that Win-06-01b was hydrothermal in origin, or that non-thermal processes such as fluid-mediated recrystallization contributed to helium loss in nature.

The $^4$He/$^3$He spectrum observed for this sample is distinct from that of the same sample in vacuum, suggesting that the geometry of helium loss induced by goethite dehydration is distinct from that of diffusion. More hydrothermal step heat experiments of goethite are necessary to confirm this hypothesis.

A thermodynamic and kinetic analysis of goethite dehydroxylation explains why water seems to stabilize goethite up to 250°C at experimental timescales. The hydrothermal release itself requires solid-state conversion to be at least $10^{2.5}$ times slower in water than in vacuum. At water saturation, the roughly tenfold smaller driving force raises the barrier to hematite nucleation enough to suppress solid-state conversion far below this limit. Fluid-mediated conversion, which transformed synthetic goethite pigment in similar conditions, is rapid and would be accompanied by abrupt and extreme helium loss, which is not observed in the hydrothermal step heat data. This divergent outcome may be explained by different solution chemistry between the two experiments, which would affect the availbility of aqueous Fe(III) that supplies the reaction. Recrystallization, however, cannot be excluded. If it contributed, the diffusivities reported here would be upper bounds and the retentivity a lower bound. Distinguishing these possibilities, and separating the effects of crystallite size, chemical composition, and radiation damage, will require further hydrothermal experiments on irradiated single-crystal goethite of controlled size. The method described here makes such experiments straightforward.

# Supplementary Information

for Chapter 2: *Helium Step Heats on Goethite at Water Saturated Conditions Show Diffusive Helium Loss and High Retentivity at Surface Temperatures*

## 2.1s Permeation Lag Correction and Ampoule Permeability

### Permeation Lag Correction

Because HT-Win-06-01b was encapsulated in an imperfectly helium-transmissive silica glass ampoule, permeation lag was an expected complication in these measurements. To address this, experimental steps at temperatures at or above 170°C were bracketed by low temperature (<120°C) steps where the helium in goethite at high pH2O was effectively immobile at experimental timescales, following the permeation step method (Chapter **??**, §**??**). For 3He, measured signals at these low temperature permeation steps were entirely controlled by the process of permeation through silica glass, and therefore could be used to estimate the amount of helium remaining within the ampoule between high-temperature experimental steps. However, for 4He, the measured signals at low temperature permeation steps were most often indistinguishable from the blank, so Eq. (**??**) (Chapter **??**) could not be applied to 4He and the permeation step method could not be carried through for that isotope.

As a result, permeation lag is instead addressed using the bounding method described in Chapter **??** (§**??**), which constrains the ampoule's residual helium from above rather than measuring it. In this approach, an upper bound constraint for the helium content of the ampoule at the end of each high-temperature step was calculated using Eq. (**??**) (Chapter **??**). 3He was reduced this way as well, for consistency with 4He; because 3He can also be reduced by the permeation step method, the two reductions can be compared directly, and that comparison is used below (§**??**) as an internal test of the bounding method.

Both routes require the ampoule's permeation rate constant $\lambda$, which was measured during the experiment itself rather than assumed from the literature (Chapter **??**, §**??**). This in-experiment measurement is not an alternative method of handling permeation lag but a prerequisite of the permeation step method and, here, the empirical basis for choosing a conservative $\lambda$ for the bounding method. It is indispensable in this experiment: the permeability of ampoules used in hydrothermal step heats cannot reasonably be assumed to match literature values for anhydrous silica glass.

10 series of 3-4 consecutive permeation steps held at a single temperature between 90-110°C for 120-180 minutes each with 26 minutes of cooling time before being inlet into the Helix-MC-Plus10k were identified as suitable for

this exercise. The 3He measurements in these series were fit to Eq. (**??**) using a non-linear least squares optimization (Fig. **??**). This is accomplished with the Levenberg-Marquardt algorithm implemented in the curve_fit function in the SciPy package of Python (Virtanen et al., 2020), weighted by each measurement's own uncertainty. One additional series that otherwise qualified was not well fit by this model and was not used further for clarity, though its fit value of $\lambda$ was within uncertainty of the other series' fit values for $\lambda$.

An initial guess of $\lambda \approx 6\text{x}10^{-6}$ sec$^{-1}$ and $n_0 \approx \frac{m_i}{1-e^{-\lambda t_i}}$ (evaluated at the first measurement of a series) pccSTP was passed to the optimizer for each series. Uncertainties from the model fits were calculated using the covariance matrices generated for each of the model fits. Although the initial helium amount $n_0$ was a free parameter in the optimizations, the rate constant of permeation ($\lambda$) was the only parameter of interest for this exercise. The fitted rate constants span $2.7 \times 10^{-5}$ to $6.3 \times 10^{-5}$ s$^{-1}$, with $2\sigma$ uncertainties of 0.08 to 0.46 log units and no trend resolvable against step duration:

All measured apparent 3He permeabilities were equal to or in excess of the literature values for anhydrous silica glass (Fig. **??**), similar to observations discussed in Chapter **??** (§**??**). 4He permeability itself could not be independently measured in this experiment due to blank-level signals during the low temperature permeation steps and is assumed to similarly exceed the literature values for anhydrous silica glass. To evaluate the uncertainty due to the permeation lag, we use the literature values as a conservative (lower bound) estimate of the true permeability; a $\lambda$ that underestimates the ampoule's true rate constant yields a conservative (higher) upper bound on the residual helium (Chapter **??**, §**??**). $\lambda t$ (where $\lambda = GRTK$) is estimated here using the 4He permeability $K$ reported by Swets et al. (1961), while the 3He permeability is taken to be the product of the 4He permeability and the relative 3He/4He permeability reported by Jones (1953). The geometric constant $G$ is calculated using the measured inner and outer diameter of the ampoule (Fig. **??**).

The first three experimental steps had values of $\lambda t$ lower than 4, and therefore the upper bound of the helium content of these steps could not be determined. These measurements are omitted from further analysis. Later experimental steps with values of $\lambda t$ lower than 4 could be determined using Eq. (**??**) from the supplement to Chapter **??** because upper bounds on previous steps' residual helium content could be evaluated.

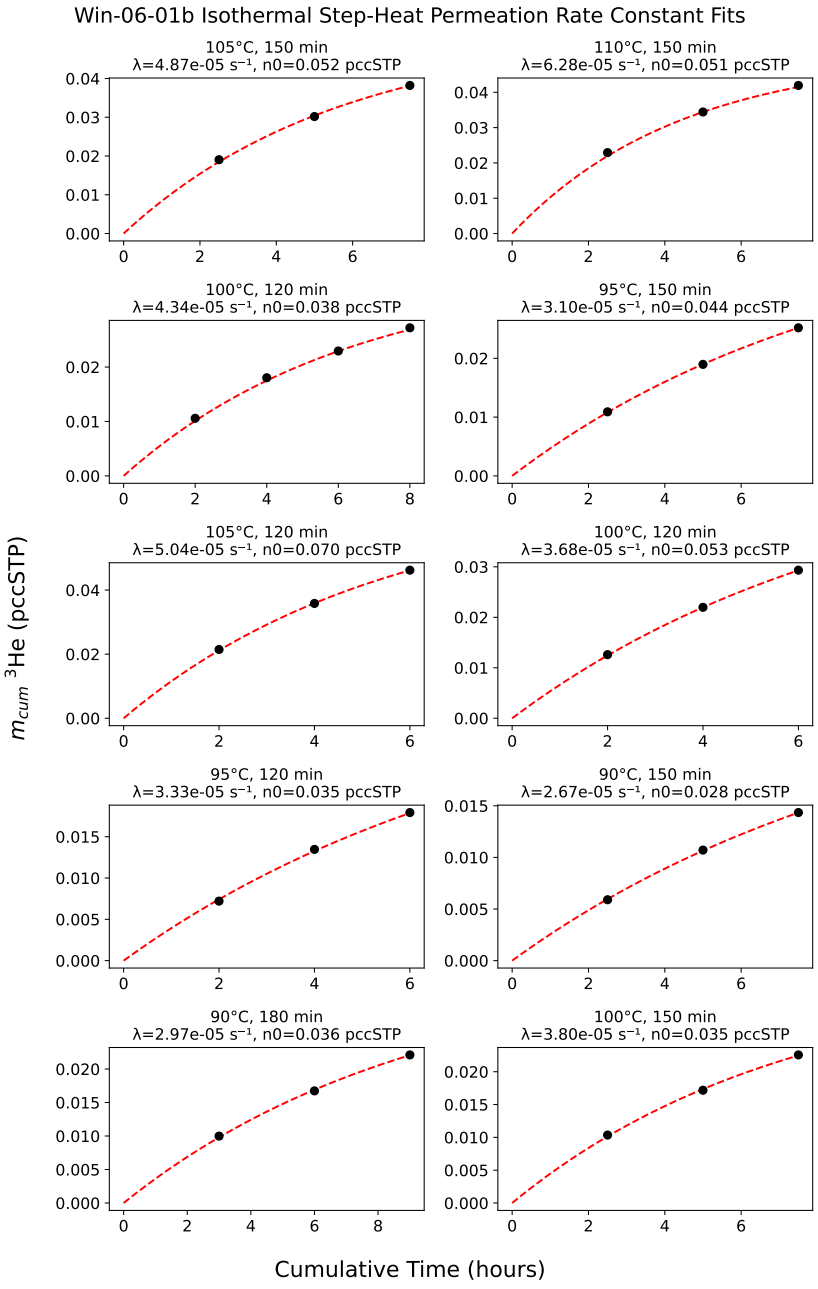



Figure 2.15: Cumulative yield against cumulative time for helium-3 yields for isothermal permeation steps. A non-linear least squares optimization fits $\lambda$ and $n_0$ of Eq. (**??**) (Chapter **??**) to data from a series of permeation steps like these. The permeability $K$ is calculated according to the relation $K = \lambda/GRT$ and is plotted as a function of temperature in Fig. **??**. The curvature of each series is what conditions the fit: a series in which the permeation rate has not yet slowed appreciably constrains $\lambda$ and $n_0$ only weakly.

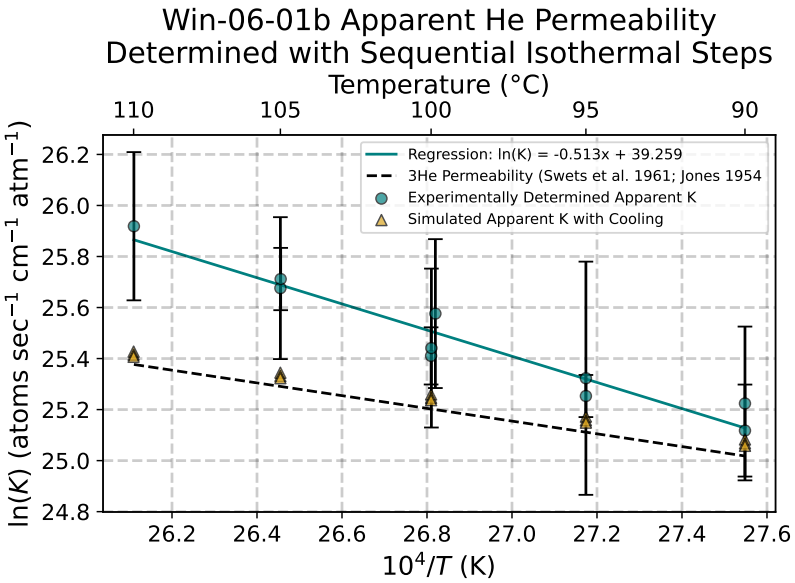



Figure 2.16: Arrhenius plot of apparent permeation coefficients as a function of inverse temperature for HT-Win-06-01b, converted from the rate constants fitted in Fig. **??** via $K = \lambda/GRT$. The activation energy is higher than anhydrous silica glass, as expected (Masaryk, 1968; Shelby, 1972). It is unexpected that the glass ampoule of HT-Win-06-01b has higher apparent 3He permeability than the literature values of Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953), but this can be explained by an increase in the partial pressure of the gas phase within the tube due to displacement by high He diffusivity, low He solubility water. Yellow points labeled "Diffusion Model with cooling, Anhydrous" were produced to evaluate the expected excess apparent permeability due to the 25 minute cooldown period before measurement. This is accomplished by simulating the measured apparent permeability for a dry silica glass ampoule that continued to permeate helium while cooling for an additional 26 minutes before measurement after being held at 90–110°C for 120–180 minutes, similarly to the measured values. Variability in these points is due to differences in the length of time the ampoule was heated but is very small. They show a near constant offset from the expected values of Swets et al. (1961) and Jones (1953) that is much smaller than the uncertainty in the regression of the fit values determined experimentally in teal.

**Measurement and Numerical Simulation of Apparent Permeability of Experimental Ampoule**

The apparent permeability values used in the numerical simulation (§**??**) are taken from the literature (Swets et al., 1961; Jones, 1953) and explicitly apply to an ampoule without water. However, the purpose of these simulations was simply to quantify the excess apparent permeabilities that would be observed for ampoules with a cooling history similar to that of the hydrothermal experiments. Because the predicted offset is universally small and a weak function of temperature or permeability, these simulations demonstrate that the much larger experimentally observed permeability is not an artifact of the cooling history of the hydrothermal experiments, reaffirming the conclusion that the hydrothermal experiments are indeed more permeable than the vacuum experiments.

The difference in log permeability between the actual and apparent permeabilities of the anhydrous simulation were significantly smaller than nearly all the $2\sigma$ uncertainties of the apparent permeabilities determined above for the hydrothermal Win-06-01b experiment, which ranged from 0.08 to 0.46 log units. Thus, no trends with step duration could be identified in the effective permeability values.

Therefore, the literature values underestimate the helium permeabilities of the ampoule used in this experiment, which is permissible because these values are used to calculate an upper bound constraint of the helium content of the ampoule, and lower permeabilities produce more conservative (higher) upper bound constraints.

A linear regression of $\ln(K)$ against inverse temperature (Fig. **??**) fit to these isothermal 3He permeation measurements over 90-110°C yields an $R^2$ of 0.936 and an activation energy of 42.6±7.9 kJ/mol (2 s.e.), significantly higher than expected for pure silica glass with or without water (Swets et al., 1961; Jones, 1953; Masaryk, 1968; Shelby, 1972), but similar to glasses with a high abundance of network-modifying cations such as Na, K, Pb, or Li (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961). Because 4He signals during these isothermal steps were blank-level, only the ampoule's 3He permeability could be measured directly this way, using the fitting procedure described above.

Every 3He permeability measurement for HT-Win-06-01b equals or exceeds the anhydrous literature value, which runs counter to expectations for a hy-

drothermal experiment: water and hydroxyl groups dissolved in silica glass are reported to *decrease* helium permeation at all temperatures (Tsuru et al., 2011; Shelby, 1972; Masaryk, 1968), under the common paradigm that species such as $(OH)^-$ occupy interstitial space within the amorphous glassy network (Norton, 1953; Shackelford, 1999). The offset is nonetheless real: it cannot be accounted for by the ampoule's extended permeation during cooling before measurement (§**??**), and a similarly elevated permeability was independently observed at 100°C in a separate silica glass ampoule at Caltech partially filled with MilliQ water and equilibrated with ~0.1 torr of tank helium, as discussed in Chapter **??** (§**??**).

The likely explanation is geometric. Helium is only sparingly soluble in water and diffuses through it rapidly, roughly $7 \times 10^{-5}$ cm$^2$/s at room temperature (Verhallen et al., 1984) against about $2 \times 10^{-8}$ cm$^2$/s in silica glass (Swets et al., 1961). On the timescale of permeation through the glass wall, transport through the water is effectively instantaneous, so the gas phase stays in equilibrium with the glass over the entire inner surface of the ampoule, including where liquid water contacts it. Helium partitions strongly into the gas phase over both water and glass: helium concentrations in the glass and water are about 3% and 1%, respectively, of the gas-phase concentration, using solubilities from Sander (2015) and Swets et al. (1961). Displacing gas-phase volume with water therefore raises the helium partial pressure without changing the surface area available for permeation, and because the rate of permeation is proportional to the gas-phase partial pressure (Norton, 1953; Altemose, 1961; Swets et al., 1961; Masaryk, 1968), the ampoule's rate constant scales with the inverse volume fraction of the gas phase (Chapter **??**, Eq. (**??**)), generalized here to any condensed payload: $\lambda_{ampoule} = \lambda_{empty} \left(V_{condensed} + V_{gas}\right) / V_{gas}$. This observed complexity emphasizes the need to measure the ampoule's rate constant in-experiment as described in Chapter **??** (§**??**).

**Consistency of the Bounding Method with Direct Permeation-Step Quantification: The Complete Degas Test**

All Win-06-01b step heat data presented in this chapter are reduced using the bounding method (Eq. (**??**)), because 4He permeation-step yields were near blank level and could not support the permeation step method directly. As an internal check on this choice, the ampoule's 3He inventory was also reconstructed directly from the permeation steps themselves, using the in-experiment rate

constants of Fig. **??** (§**??**). Reducing 3He by the bounding method gives Stage 1 activation energies between 157.1 and 160.6 kJ/mol and closure temperatures between 97.5 and 101.2°C across its lower-bound, central, and upper-bound reductions, a spread comparable to the regression uncertainty itself. Fig. **??** compares the two: $n_t$, the ampoule's residual helium quantified directly from a permeation step, against $n_{t,SS}$ (equivalent to $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ used elsewhere in this chapter), the upper bound on that same residual calculated independently from the preceding high-temperature step. For every ordinary permeation step in the experiment, $n_t \leq n_{t,SS}$, exactly as expected if the steady-state approximation genuinely bounds the ampoule's residual helium from above. This agreement is the justification for reducing the 4He dataset by the bounding method alone, since no analogous direct check of 4He is possible.

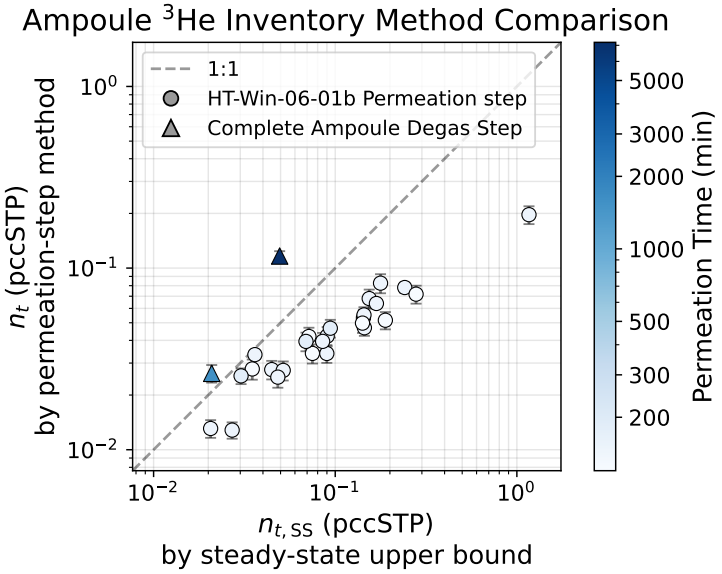



Figure 2.17: Two independent estimates of the ampoule's residual 3He inventory, $n_t$, following each permeation step of HT-Win-06-01b: quantified directly from the permeation step itself (*permeation step method*, $y$-axis, §**??**), against the upper bound calculated independently from the preceding high-temperature step (*bounding method*, $x$-axis, Eq. (**??**)). Color indicates the duration of the permeation step. Circles are ordinary steps; triangles are the two "attempted complete degas" steps, held at 100°C for far longer than any other permeation step (1580 and 7200 minutes) in an attempt to drive the ampoule's 3He inventory toward zero. The dashed line is 1:1. Excepting the two complete-degas steps, $n_t$ never exceeds $n_{t,SS}$, as required if permeation lag is genuinely bounded above by the steady-state approximation. Both complete-degas steps instead record more helium than their own $n_{t,SS}$ permits.

Beyond the ampoule's residual helium content itself, the two methods' derived apparent diffusivities agree just as closely (Fig. **??**, §**??**): $\ln(D/a^2)$ from the permeation step method tracks the bounding method's central value along the 1:1 line within uncertainty across the full range of the experiment. Fitting the permeation step method's own diffusivities with the same Stage 1 procedure used for the bounding method in the main text (Fig. **??**, §**??**) yields an activation energy of 157.0±4.8 kJ/mol ($R^2$=0.991, n=12) and a closure temperature of 97.5±7.8°C, indistinguishable from the bounding method's own 157.1±5.3 kJ/mol and 98.1±8.6°C (Fig. **??**).

The two "complete degas" permeation steps depart from this pattern. For the longer of the two (7200 minutes; predicted $n_t/n_0 \approx 1 \times 10^{-8}$ under simple first-order decay), the directly measured 3He inventory exceeds $n_{t,SS}$ by a factor of 1.5. For the shorter (1580 minutes; predicted $n_t/n_0 \approx 0.02$), the excess is smaller, 25% over $n_{t,SS}$. A measured inventory in excess of $n_{t,SS}$ requires that the source term ($\Omega$: §**??**) increased during the high temperature experimental step, or the goethite sample was not effectively closed to helium loss during the low temperature permeation step (§**??**), or both. The measured diffusivitiy is constant at a given temperature for these high temperature measurements at the end of the experiment (Figs. **??**, **??**), so there is no evidence the source term ($\Omega$) is increasing during the high temperature measurements.

The size of the two excesses scale with duration of their respective permeation step. The 7200-minute step is associated with the larger (1.5×) excess whereas the 1580-minute step is associated with the smaller (25%) excess. An artifact intrinsic to the the first order process of helium permeation through the ampoule itself, such as an underestimated rate constant, has no reason to strongly scale with the step duration, since both of these long steps would be expected empty the vast majority of the helium inventory of the ampoule. That the excess does scale this way points to open system behavior in the sample. The preferred explanation is short-circuit or fast pathway diffusion (Lee and Aldama, 1992) of residual helium held within the interstitial space of the goethite crystallite aggregate (§**??**), recharged during the preceding high-temperature step, released slowly and with weak temperature dependence during the following extended low-temperature hold. This requires communication between a lattice or grain-boundary source and an interstitial reservoir, a departure from the independent, non-communicating domains of a strict MDD interpretation, but it is consistent

with the interstitial framework already invoked to explain the early, low-retention fraction of 3He release (§**??**). Unlike dehydration, it requires no change in the intrinsic retentivity of the crystalline lattice recorded by the bulk of the experiment.

## 2.2s Analytical Methods

### Finite Difference Diffusion Model of Cooling Tube

One potential concern about the results of the internally measured permeabilities is that some additional helium was permeated during the cooling period after each permeation step. In order to evaluate the significance of this effect, a finite difference model was built in Python to simulate diffusion, influx, and outflux of helium across a hollow glass cylinder containing an arbitrary amount of helium gas within a helium-free chamber using the procedure described in Chapter **??** (§**??**). The glass cylinder was given the same dimensions of the ampoule used in the Win-06-01b hydrothermal experiment, and was subjected to the same heating and cooling schedule as the hydrothermal experiment's permeation steps. The tube was charged with 100 arbitrary units of helium atoms at the end of each experimental step and a steady state concentration profile was assumed for the new arbitrary charge at T = 24°. Permeability values for 3He were assumed as the product of the 4He permeability values given by Swets et al. (1961) and the 3He/4He relative permeabilities given by Jones (1953).

To simulate cooling, a cooling rate had to be assumed. To most accurately simulate the cooling of the experimental ampoule, Watlow temperature records of the experimental ampoule during cooling steps were used to calculate the cooling rate dT/dt for discrete time intervals. A quadratic function was fit to these data points to model the cooling rate as a function of temperature with a single root at T = 24°C such that the temperature would stabilize at T = 24°C by design.

$$\frac{dT}{dt} = -\left(9.23081 \times 10^{-6}\right)(T-24)^2 - \left(7.74304 \times 10^{-4}\right)(T-24)$$

(dT/dt in °C/s, T in °C; $R^2 = 0.9633$).

### Uncertainty for Diffusivity Inversions

Apparent values of $D/a^2$ for 3He and 4He were calculated from times and cumulative measured yields using the equations of Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966). Lower and upper bounds for diffusivity were calculated using the upper bound for the helium contents of the ampoules before and after each step, evaluated using (**??**). Diffusivity for step $i$ is a function of the cumulative fractional yield for step i $\Sigma^i F$ and the cumulative fractional yield of the previous step $\Sigma^{i-1} F$. The diffusivity is maximized when the difference between the fractional

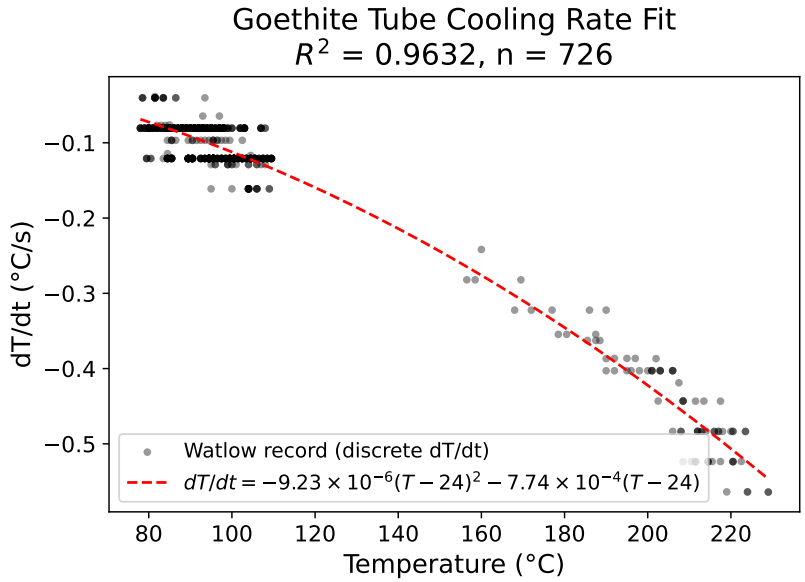



Figure 2.18: Discrete cooling rate (dT/dt) values calculated from the Watlow temperature record for the Winsor Goethite experiment, plotted against temperature, with the quadratic fit used to simulate cooling in the finite difference diffusion model overlain.

yields is largest, and minimized when the difference is smallest. This difference is maximized for the extreme case where the previous step ended with no permeation lag, and the current step ended with the maximum amount of permeation lag (${}^{i}_{SS}n_t$), whereas the opposite is true for the minimum diffusivity.

$$\begin{aligned} {}^{UB}D_\omega &= D\left(\Sigma^{i-1}F_m,\ \Sigma^{i}F_m + {}^{i}_{SS}n_t\right) \\ {}^{LB}D_\omega &= D\left(\Sigma^{i-1}F_m + {}^{i-1}_{SS}n_t,\ \Sigma^{i}F_m\right) \end{aligned} \tag{2.12}$$

For the 3He diffusivities, a linear regression was fit to the steps with cumulative 3He fractional yield ≥7% (12 steps, Fig. **??**), yielding an $R^2$ statistic of 0.989. The fit's slope and intercept are used as a reference line to calculate "Delta" values for the diffusivities of 3He and 4He (Fig. **??**). No uncertainty on the total amounts of 3He and 4He is propagated into the diffusivities because the experiment operated at low cumulative yields where this error affects all diffusivities approximately homogeneously, so it is only relevant for the y-intercept of the regression and the corresponding calculated closure temperature. The uncertainty from the intercept and slope parameters of the linear regression is significantly larger than the uncertainty related to the total yield, so it is

neglected.

**Helium Isotope Ratio Uncertainty**

The upper and lower bounds of the $\frac{^4He}{^3He}$ isotope ratios for each heating step are taken as the maximum and minimum $\frac{^4He}{^3He}$ isotope ratio calculated out of the 4 hypothetical end-member permeation scenarios, which would have been experienced by both helium isotope systems:

1. $n_t = 0,\ n_0 = 0$
2. $n_t = n_t^{\mathrm{UB}},\ n_0 = 0$
3. $n_t = n_t^{\mathrm{UB}},\ n_0 = n_0^{\mathrm{UB}}$
4. $n_t = 0,\ n_0 = n_0^{\mathrm{UB}}$

Intuitively, higher differential permeability between the two helium isotopes ($\delta = \frac{K_{3He}}{K_{4He}}$ here) will result in greater isotope fractionation between the measured $\left(\frac{m_4}{m_3}\right)$ and true $\left(\frac{\omega_4}{\omega_3}\right)$. Furthermore, lower absolute permeabilities will result in stronger permeation lag, additionally producing higher isotope fractionation in the measured value. The 4He permeability is thus conservatively taken to be identical to Swets et al. (1961), an anhydrous literature value which this experiment's own isothermal 3He permeation measurements show to underestimate the ampoule's true permeability (Fig. **??**); 4He permeability itself could not be independently measured in this experiment. For the purposes of evaluating the measured isotope ratios, the relative 3He/4He permeability ($\delta$) is taken to be 1.29, the $2\sigma$ upper bound of the value measured independently for a water-filled ampoule in Chapter **??** (§**??**): $1.10 \pm 0.19$ ($2\sigma$). 1.29 is in great excess of realistic values of the relative 3He/4He permeability, which is expected to be between 1.06-1.11 for the temperature range relevant to this experiment (Jones, 1953). These conservative assumptions taken together guarantee that the calculated upper and lower bounds for the isotope ratios accurately constrain the true value. The upper bounds of the ampoule contents are calculated using the steady-state approximation of Eq. (**??**) (Chapter **??**): $n_{ss} = \frac{m}{\lambda t - 1}$. For the four extreme cases listed above, the following equations apply:

1. $\dfrac{\omega_4}{\omega_3} = \dfrac{m_4}{m_3}$

2. $\frac{\omega_4}{\omega_3} = \frac{m_4 + \frac{m_4}{\lambda t - 1}}{m_3 + \frac{m_3}{\delta\lambda t - 1}}$

3. $\frac{\omega_4}{\omega_3} = \frac{m_4 + \frac{m_4}{\lambda t - 1} - \frac{m_4^{i-1}}{(\lambda t)^{i-1} - 1}}{m_3 + \frac{m_3}{\delta\lambda t - 1} - \frac{m_3^{i-1}}{\delta(\lambda t)^{i-1} - 1}}$

4. $\frac{\omega_4}{\omega_3} = \frac{m_4 - \frac{m_4^{i-1}}{(\lambda t)^{i-1} - 1}}{m_3 - \frac{m_3^{i-1}}{\delta(\lambda t)^{i-1} - 1}}$

Where $m_x^{i-1}$ and $(\lambda t)^{i-1}$ refer to the measured helium content and $\lambda t$ of the previous step, respectively. $\lambda$ here applies explicitly to 4He, whereas $\delta\lambda$ applies to 3He. The upper and lower bounds of the isotope ratios are then taken to be the maximum and minimum of these four extreme cases.

### 2.3s Goethite Permeation Rate Constant Dataset

The in-experiment permeation rate constants used to correct for permeation lag is reported below. Table **??** gives the raw per-step data for all 10 isothermal sequences, and Table **??** gives the lambda/$n_0$ fit to each sequence (Fig. **??**) that together define the Arrhenius regression of Fig. **??**.

Table 2.4: Raw step-heat data ('Fit Lambdas' sheet, cross-checked against 'Raw Data and Corrections') for the 10 isothermal 3He permeation sequences used to determine the ampoule's apparent permeability (Fig. **??**, Fig. **??**). Series are separated by horizontal rules; within a series, steps are listed in the order measured.

| Series | Temp (°C) | Nominal Time (min) | Cooling Time (min) | $^3$He measured (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 105.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0190 | $1.1\times10^{-4}$ |
| 1 | 105.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0111 | $7.4\times10^{-5}$ |
| 1 | 105.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0080 | $5.3\times10^{-5}$ |
| 2 | 109.99 | 150 | 26 | 0.0229 | $1.4\times10^{-4}$ |
| 2 | 110.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0115 | $7.3\times10^{-5}$ |
| 2 | 110.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0075 | $5.2\times10^{-5}$ |
| 3 | 99.86 | 120 | 26 | 0.0106 | $6.1\times10^{-5}$ |
| 3 | 100.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0074 | $4.0\times10^{-5}$ |
| 3 | 100.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0049 | $2.5\times10^{-5}$ |
| 3 | 99.99 | 120 | 26 | 0.0043 | $2.1\times10^{-5}$ |
| 4 | 95.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0109 | $2.8\times10^{-4}$ |
| 4 | 95.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0081 | $2.0\times10^{-4}$ |
| 4 | 95.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0062 | $1.4\times10^{-4}$ |
| 5 | 104.99 | 120 | 26 | 0.0215 | $8.9\times10^{-5}$ |
| 5 | 104.99 | 120 | 26 | 0.0144 | $6.0\times10^{-5}$ |
| 5 | 104.99 | 120 | 26 | 0.0104 | $4.3\times10^{-5}$ |
| 6 | 100.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0126 | $5.6\times10^{-5}$ |
| 6 | 100.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0094 | $3.5\times10^{-5}$ |
| 6 | 100.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0074 | $2.0\times10^{-5}$ |
| 7 | 95.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0072 | $3.0\times10^{-5}$ |
| 7 | 95.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0063 | $2.6\times10^{-5}$ |
| 7 | 95.00 | 120 | 26 | 0.0045 | $1.9\times10^{-5}$ |
| 8 | 90.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0059 | $2.7\times10^{-5}$ |
| 8 | 89.90 | 150 | 26 | 0.0048 | $2.4\times10^{-5}$ |
| 8 | 90.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0036 | $1.9\times10^{-5}$ |
| 9 | 90.00 | 180 | 26 | 0.0100 | $6.2\times10^{-5}$ |
| 9 | 89.92 | 180 | 26 | 0.0067 | $5.1\times10^{-5}$ |
| 9 | 90.00 | 180 | 26 | 0.0054 | $4.8\times10^{-5}$ |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Series | Temp (°C) | Nominal Time (min) | Cooling Time (min) | $^3$He measured (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 10 | 99.99 | 150 | 26 | 0.0104 | $4.3\times10^{-5}$ |
| 10 | 99.98 | 150 | 26 | 0.0068 | $3.5\times10^{-5}$ |
| 10 | 100.00 | 150 | 26 | 0.0054 | $3.4\times10^{-5}$ |

Table 2.5: Fitted $\lambda$ (permeation rate constant) and $n_0$ (residual helium at the start of the series) for each of the 10 isothermal sequences in Table **??**, from the weighted non-linear least-squares fit of Eq. (**??**) (Chapter **??**) described in §**??**. $n$ is the number of steps in the sequence. These are the same per-sequence fits plotted in Fig. **??** and used to build the Arrhenius regression in Fig. **??**.

| Series | Temp (°C) | Duration (min) | $n$ | $\lambda$ ($s^{-1}$) | $\pm 2\sigma$ | $n_0$ (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | 105.00 | 150 | 3 | $4.9\times10^{-5}$ | $1.4\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0521 | $7.8\times10^{-3}$ |
| 2 | 109.99 | 150 | 3 | $6.3\times10^{-5}$ | $1.8\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0508 | $7.3\times10^{-3}$ |
| 3 | 99.86 | 120 | 4 | $4.3\times10^{-5}$ | $1.3\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0377 | $5.2\times10^{-3}$ |
| 4 | 95.00 | 150 | 3 | $3.1\times10^{-5}$ | $2.6\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0444 | $2.2\times10^{-3}$ |
| 5 | 104.99 | 120 | 3 | $5.0\times10^{-5}$ | $6.2\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0696 | $4.7\times10^{-3}$ |
| 6 | 100.00 | 120 | 3 | $3.7\times10^{-5}$ | $4.1\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0534 | $3.4\times10^{-3}$ |
| 7 | 95.00 | 120 | 3 | $3.3\times10^{-5}$ | $1.5\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0348 | $1.1\times10^{-2}$ |
| 8 | 90.00 | 150 | 3 | $2.7\times10^{-5}$ | $4.8\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0279 | $3.5\times10^{-3}$ |
| 9 | 90.00 | 180 | 3 | $3.0\times10^{-5}$ | $9.0\times10^{-6}$ | 0.0357 | $7.0\times10^{-3}$ |
| 10 | 99.99 | 150 | 3 | $3.8\times10^{-5}$ | $1.2\times10^{-5}$ | 0.0351 | $7.0\times10^{-3}$ |

### $^3$He Step Heat Dataset, Corrected with the Permeation Step Method

The complete corrected step-heat dataset produced by the permeation step method, using the in-experiment rate constants above (Fig. **??**), is reported in Table **??**, giving the central value and $2\sigma$ uncertainty for each quantity, analogous to Table **??** in the main text for the bounding method. 4He is not treated by the permeation step method here: 4He permeation-step signals were blank level, so no direct, step-by-step quantification of the ampoule's 4He inventory was possible, and 4He throughout this chapter is instead reduced exclusively by the bounding method of the main text (§**??**). The permeation step dataset reported here is retained only for 3He, as the internal check on the bounding method discussed in §**??**.

Table 2.6: $^3$He step-heat dataset for HT-Win-06-01b under the permeation step method: measured and cumulative $^3$He, the initial and residual ampoule content ($n_0$, $n_t$), the true step production ($\omega$), and the apparent diffusivity $\ln(D/a^2)$, each with its $2\sigma$ uncertainty. Six rows have derived values marked with "*": these steps have measured $^3$He $< 0.1$ pccSTP and are excluded as low-signal, as in Table **??**.

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_0$ (pccSTP) | $\pm2\sigma$ | $n_t$ (pccSTP) | $\pm2\sigma$ | $\omega$ (pccSTP) | $\pm2\sigma$ | $\ln(D/a^2)$ | $\pm2\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 170 | 300 | 0.9630 | 0.0000 | $0.00\times10^{0}$ | $0.00\times10^{0}$ | 0.1968 | $2.22\times10^{-2}$ | 1.1597 | $2.63\times10^{-2}$ | -21.910 | 0.045 |
| 180 | 463 | 0.5442 | 0.9630 | $7.26\times10^{-2}$ | $1.29\times10^{-2}$ | 0.0782 | $4.93\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5497 | $1.60\times10^{-2}$ | -22.184 | 0.089 |
| 190 | 550 | 0.5292 | 1.6241 | $1.95\times10^{-2}$ | $2.54\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0679 | $8.20\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5777 | $1.30\times10^{-2}$ | -21.976 | 0.085 |
| 200 | 500 | 0.5190 | 2.2112 | $3.28\times10^{-2}$ | $5.42\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0532 | $5.77\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5394 | $1.15\times10^{-2}$ | -21.702 | 0.088 |
| 210 | 475 | 0.5770 | 2.7646 | $1.41\times10^{-2}$ | $2.11\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0552 | $5.71\times10^{-3}$ | 0.6182 | $1.17\times10^{-2}$ | -21.311 | 0.082 |
| 220 | 450 | 0.6333 | 3.3799 | $1.10\times10^{-2}$ | $1.80\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0469 | $4.58\times10^{-3}$ | 0.6692 | $1.24\times10^{-2}$ | -20.991 | 0.080 |
| 230 | 425 | 0.7899 | 4.0551 | $5.87\times10^{-3}$ | $1.86\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0639 | $3.48\times10^{-3}$ | 0.8479 | $1.25\times10^{-2}$ | -20.514 | 0.066 |
| 225 | 908 | 0.7513 | 4.8885 | $1.95\times10^{-2}$ | $2.45\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0420 | $4.94\times10^{-3}$ | 0.7738 | $1.42\times10^{-2}$ | -21.200 | 0.121 |
| 215 | 450 | 0.1415 | 5.6842 | $1.31\times10^{-2}$ | $1.85\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0278 | $3.54\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1563 | $6.48\times10^{-3}$ | -22.015 | 0.316 |
| 205 | 520 | 0.0763 | 5.8529 | $7.18\times10^{-3*}$ | $1.23\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0125* | $1.63\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0816* | $8.10\times10^{-3*}$ | -22.788* | 0.829* |
| 195 | 1106 | 0.0670 | 5.9491 | $2.12\times10^{-3*}$ | $4.02\times10^{-4*}$ | 0.0307* | $2.86\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0956* | $3.23\times10^{-3*}$ | -23.370* | 1.094* |
| 185 | 740 | 0.0227 | 6.0246 | $1.25\times10^{-2*}$ | $1.64\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0090* | $1.06\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0192* | $2.00\times10^{-3*}$ | -24.567* | 2.822* |
| 175 | 920 | 0.0180 | 6.0610 | $3.68\times10^{-3*}$ | $5.02\times10^{-4*}$ | 0.0045* | $4.42\times10^{-4*}$ | 0.0189* | $7.42\times10^{-4*}$ | -24.796* | 3.797* |
| 200 | 260 | 0.0224 | 6.0814 | $6.53\times10^{-4*}$ | $1.17\times10^{-4*}$ | 0.0095* | $1.23\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0313* | $1.65\times10^{-3*}$ | -23.022* | 1.495* |
| 210 | 520 | 0.0812 | 6.1081 | $7.48\times10^{-3*}$ | $9.98\times10^{-4*}$ | 0.0145* | $1.32\times10^{-3*}$ | 0.0882* | $3.85\times10^{-3*}$ | -22.669* | 1.135* |
| 220 | 1167 | 0.5766 | 6.1914 | $2.82\times10^{-3}$ | $1.44\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0276 | $3.24\times10^{-3}$ | 0.6014 | $2.45\times10^{-2}$ | -21.504 | 0.184 |
| 230 | 370 | 0.3577 | 6.7796 | $8.68\times10^{-3}$ | $3.96\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0422 | $5.13\times10^{-3}$ | 0.3912 | $1.48\times10^{-2}$ | -20.712 | 0.146 |
| 240 | 320 | 0.6767 | 7.1563 | $1.72\times10^{-2}$ | $2.42\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0826 | $9.94\times10^{-3}$ | 0.7420 | $1.57\times10^{-2}$ | -19.807 | 0.099 |
| 245 | 250 | 0.5549 | 7.8582 | $2.13\times10^{-2}$ | $8.87\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0516 | $5.65\times10^{-3}$ | 0.5852 | $1.46\times10^{-2}$ | -19.710 | 0.125 |
| 250 | 210 | 0.6934 | 8.4743 | $1.08\times10^{-2}$ | $4.52\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0718 | $8.15\times10^{-3}$ | 0.7545 | $1.41\times10^{-2}$ | -19.200 | 0.102 |
| 245 | 270 | 0.4659 | 9.2086 | $2.48\times10^{-2}$ | $3.48\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0498 | $5.84\times10^{-3}$ | 0.4909 | $1.01\times10^{-2}$ | -19.810 | 0.197 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_0$ (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ | $n_t$ (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ | $\omega$ (pccSTP) | $\pm 2\sigma$ | $\ln(D/a^2)$ | $\pm 2\sigma$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 240 | 320 | 0.2857 | 9.7206 | $2.07\times10^{-2}$ | $2.81\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0339 | $4.08\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2989 | $6.58\times10^{-3}$ | -20.433 | 0.312 |
| 235 | 370 | 0.2199 | 10.0357 | $1.66\times10^{-2}$ | $2.20\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0273 | $3.29\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2307 | $5.23\times10^{-3}$ | -20.810 | 0.401 |
| 230 | 420 | 0.1400 | 10.2736 | $1.32\times10^{-2}$ | $1.76\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0255 | $2.53\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1523 | $4.00\times10^{-3}$ | -21.332 | 0.603 |
| 225 | 652 | 0.1494 | 10.4279 | $1.26\times10^{-2}$ | $1.62\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0131 | $1.47\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1499 | $3.42\times10^{-3}$ | -21.772 | 0.747 |
| 230 | 500 | 0.1550 | 10.5908 | $7.34\times10^{-4}$ | $1.67\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0128 | $1.32\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1671 | $3.37\times10^{-3}$ | -21.383 | 0.461 |
| 235 | 450 | 0.1951 | 10.7582 | $2.57\times10^{-3}$ | $4.18\times10^{-4}$ | 0.0334 | $1.85\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2259 | $3.29\times10^{-3}$ | -20.956 | 0.364 |
| 240 | 400 | 0.2425 | 10.9638 | $6.90\times10^{-3}$ | $1.45\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0251 | $3.16\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2607 | $1.23\times10^{-2}$ | -20.672 | 0.318 |
| 245 | 350 | 0.3150 | 11.2328 | $5.79\times10^{-3}$ | $1.05\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0395 | $4.64\times10^{-3}$ | 0.3487 | $9.39\times10^{-3}$ | -20.219 | 0.240 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3716 | 11.5689 | $1.65\times10^{-2}$ | $2.24\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0467 | $5.24\times10^{-3}$ | 0.4018 | $9.62\times10^{-3}$ | -19.888 | 0.209 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3640 | 11.9627 | $2.43\times10^{-2}$ | $4.37\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0339 | $3.82\times10^{-3}$ | 0.3735 | $7.99\times10^{-3}$ | -19.927 | 0.242 |
| 250 | 300 | 0.3452 | 12.3490 | $1.13\times10^{-2}$ | $1.60\times10^{-3}$ | 0.0395 | $4.48\times10^{-3}$ | 0.3733 | $7.91\times10^{-3}$ | -19.895 | 0.244 |
| 250 | 10250 | 8.4829 | 12.7167 | $1.91\times10^{-2}$ | $2.53\times10^{-3}$ | 0.1165 | $7.38\times10^{-3}$ | 8.5804 | $1.28\times10^{-1}$ | -19.958 | 0.189 |
| 240 | 785 | 0.2261 | 21.2187 | $2.90\times10^{-9}$ | $6.85\times10^{-9}$ | 0.0263 | $2.92\times10^{-3}$ | 0.2525 | $2.21\times10^{-2}$ | -20.660 | 0.580 |
| **Total** | | | 146.1483 | | | | | | | | |

**Permeation Step Approach and Concordance with Bounding Approach**

Beyond the ampoule's residual helium content itself (§**??**), the two methods' derived apparent diffusivities also agree closely. Fig. **??** compares $\ln(D/a^2)$ from the permeation-step method against the bounding method's central value for every step in the experiment, with the bounding method's own lower- and upper-bound spread on one axis and the permeation step method's propagated uncertainty on the other. The two diffusivity datasets track the 1:1 line within uncertainty across the full range of the experiment. Fitting the permeation-step method's own diffusivities with the same Stage 1 procedure used for the bounding method in the main text (Fig. **??**) yields an activation energy of 157.0±4.8 kJ/mol ($R^2$=0.991, n=12) and a closure temperature of 97.5±7.8°C, indistinguishable from the bounding method's own 157.1±5.3 kJ/mol and 98.1±8.6°C (Fig. **??**, main text).

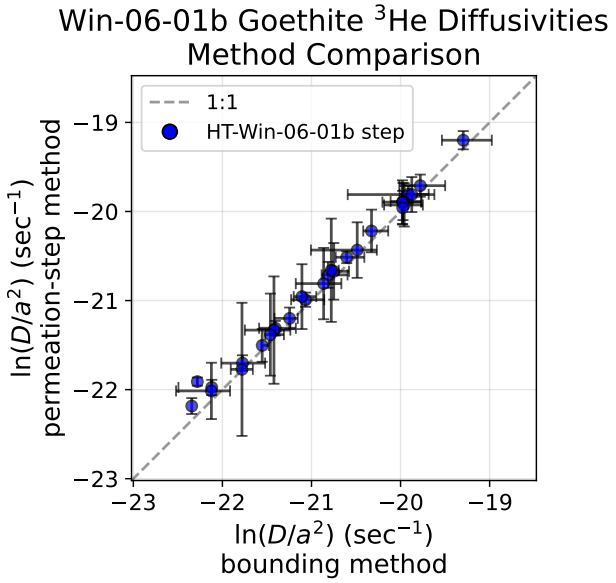



Figure 2.19: Apparent $^3$He diffusivities for HT-Win-06-01b from the permeation-step method ($y$-axis) against the bounding method's central value ($x$-axis, Eq. (**??**)), with the bounding method's lower/upper-bound spread and the permeation step method's own propagated uncertainty plotted on their respective axes. The dashed line is 1:1.

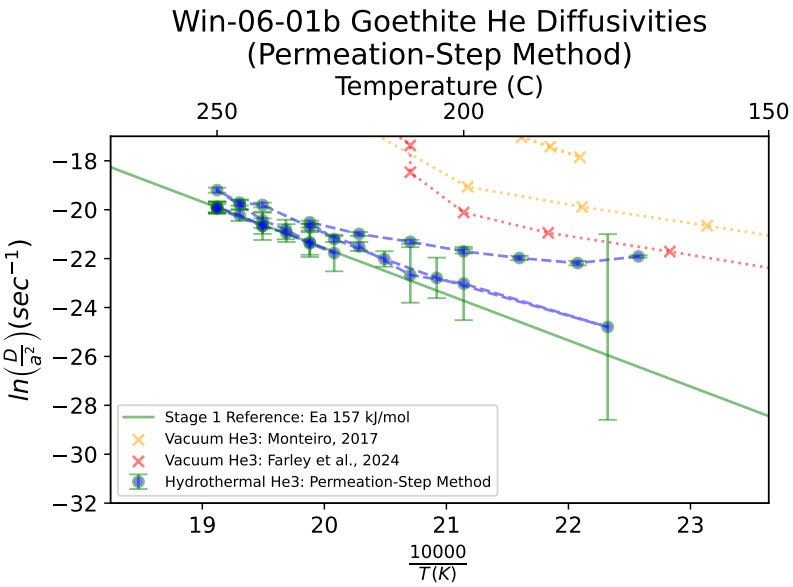



Figure 2.20: Analogue of Fig. **??** (main text) using the permeation-step method's own $^3$He diffusivities and its own Stage 1 linear regression, rather than the bounding method's. The resulting activation energy and closure temperature (157.0±4.8 kJ/mol; 97.5±7.8°C) agree closely with the bounding method's own (157.1±5.3 kJ/mol; 98.1±8.6°C).

### 2.4s Kinetic mechanisms and the limits of a single heating schedule

Solid-state rate laws separate the temperature dependence of the rate from its dependence on the extent of reaction (Vyazovkin et al., 2011):

$$\frac{d\alpha}{dt} = A \exp\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT}\right) h(\alpha), \tag{2.13}$$

where $\alpha$ is the fraction of goethite converted. The reaction model $h(\alpha)$ expresses the mechanism: it describes how the rate changes as conversion proceeds, which depends on where and how the reaction advances through a grain. For first-order kinetics (F1), grains convert independently once nucleated, so the rate is proportional to the goethite remaining, $h = 1 - \alpha$. For a reaction front moving inward from the grain surface (R2, R3), the rate is proportional to the shrinking area of the unreacted core. For random nucleation followed by growth (A2, A3), the rate first accelerates and then slows. For any heating schedule, each rate law gives $\alpha$ as a function of a single variable,

$$x = A \sum_j \Delta t_j \exp\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT_j}\right), \tag{2.14}$$

the Arrhenius-weighted time delivered by the steps up to the current one; for a single isothermal step, $x = kt$. We tested the mechanisms in Table **??**, including spherical diffusion on the same footing: for diffusion, $x$ is the Fourier number $Dt/a^2$ with $D/a^2$ Arrhenius in $T$. Under vacuum, the driving-force factor $1 - \exp(-\Delta\mu/RT)$ is unity to better than $10^{-9}$, so $x$ depends only on the heating schedule. Diffusion and conversion then differ only in the shape of $\alpha(x)$ and in the fitted $E_a$.

Table 2.7: Kinetic models: reaction model $h(\alpha)$ and conversion as a function of the Arrhenius-weighted time, $\alpha(x)$.

| Model | $h(\alpha)$ | $\alpha(x)$ |
|---|---|---|
| R2 contracting cylinder | $2(1-\alpha)^{1/2}$ | $1-(1-x)^2$ |
| R3 contracting sphere | $3(1-\alpha)^{2/3}$ | $1-(1-x)^3$ |
| F1 first order | $1-\alpha$ | $1-e^{-x}$ |
| A2, A3 Avrami ($n = 2, 3$) | $n(1-\alpha)[-\ln(1-\alpha)]^{1-1/n}$ | $1-e^{-x^n}$ |
| D3 sphere diffusion | — | $1-\frac{6}{\pi^2}\sum_{m=1}^{\infty}\frac{e^{-m^2\pi^2 x}}{m^2}$ |

**Fits to the vacuum data**

Table **??** gives the fit of each model to the cumulative KAF $^3$He release within the fitting window. It also gives the misfit of the resulting out-of-sample prediction of HDM, and the fit to the KAF water data. F1 gives the best fit and the best prediction. R3 and R2 are close behind, so we describe the mechanism as nucleation- or interface-controlled rather than claim first order specifically. The Avrami fits reach the lower bound of $E_a$ and fail on both data sets. Spherical diffusion with $\phi = 0$ fits KAF 4.4 times worse than F1 and cannot produce the $F \approx 0.89$ plateau. To compare diffusion on the same footing, we also fit D3 with $\phi$ fixed at the F1 value and with $\phi$ free, over the same 18 KAF steps. The imposed plateau improves the KAF misfit to 0.026 and 0.018, which still ranks below F1, R3 and R2, and the out-of-sample prediction of HDM does not improve (rms 0.057 and 0.055, against 0.018 for F1). These fits also require $E_a$ of 242–287 kJ mol$^{-1}$ and a rate factor $s = 0.73$ for the trap-isolated steps, although a diffusive process should not respond to the water pressure at all.

The fitting window excludes the low-temperature steps, where release is dominated by diffusion from goethite, and the plateau, where it is dominated by diffusion from hematite; the rms misfits are computed over the same steps. Repeating the fits with every step included gives the same result: F1 remains

the best model ($E_a$ = 122.7 kJ mol$^{-1}$, $\phi$ = 0.112, rms 0.0073 for KAF and 0.026 for the HDM prediction), followed by R3 (99.4 kJ mol$^{-1}$; 0.0097, 0.030) and R2 (87.9 kJ mol$^{-1}$; 0.012, 0.033), with D3 at 175.9 kJ mol$^{-1}$ (0.063, 0.061; 0.021 and 0.043 with $\phi$ fixed at the F1 value).

Table 2.8: Kinetic and Diffusive Model fits to the vacuum experiments (from H. Monteiro (2017) and Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al. (2024)). $s$: rate factor for the trap-isolated steps. All rms values are over the same 18 KAF and 19 HDM steps. D3 is fitted with $\phi$ fixed at 0, fixed at the F1 value, and free; the water fit does not depend on $\phi$ and is given once.

| Model | $E_a$ | ln $A$ | $\phi$ | $s$ | rms KAF | rms HDM | $E_a$ (water) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| R2 | 92.8 | 10.63 | 0.149 | 0.50 | 0.0133 | 0.0291 | 66.1 |
| R3 | 103.1 | 12.73 | 0.136 | 0.49 | 0.0114 | 0.0240 | 74.1 |
| F1 | 120.8 | 18.15 | 0.101 | 0.47 | 0.0087 | 0.0176 | 90.9 |
| A2 | 25.5 | −4.73 | 0.000 | 0.20 | 0.0212 | 0.1906 | 20.0[a] |
| A3 | 20.0[a] | −5.85 | 0.203 | 0.00 | 0.0433 | 0.2342 | 20.0[a] |
| D3, $\phi = 0$ | 196.5 | 32.60 | 0.000 | 1.33 | 0.0384 | 0.0478 | 184.6 |
| D3, $\phi = \phi_{\mathrm{F1}}$ | 241.5 | 43.66 | 0.101 | 0.73 | 0.0257 | 0.0567 | — |
| D3, $\phi$ free | 286.8 | 54.72 | 0.185 | 0.48 | 0.0176 | 0.0549 | — |

$E_a$ in kJ mol$^{-1}$, $A$ in s$^{-1}$. [a]At the lower bound of the fit.

## 2.5s Equilibrium Thermodynamics of Goethite Dehydroxylation

*Gibbs energies of the solids.* The Gibbs energy of a phase at $(T, P)$ follows from integrating $dG = -S\,dT + V\,dP$ from the reference state $(T_r, P_r)$ = (298.15 K, 1 bar), first in temperature at $P_r$ and then in pressure at $T$. At $P_r$, $H(T) = H(T_r) + \int_{T_r}^{T} C_p\,dT$ and $S(T) = S(T_r) + \int_{T_r}^{T} (C_p/T)\,dT$, so $G(T, P_r) = H(T) - TS(T)$. Adding $\int_{P_r}^{P} V\,dP$, and treating the solids as incompressible with no thermal expansion, gives

$$G_i(T,P) = \Delta_f H_i^0 + \int_{T_r}^{T} C_{p,i}\,dT \;-\; T\left[S_i^0 + \int_{T_r}^{T} \frac{C_{p,i}}{T}\,dT\right] \;+\; V_i\,(P - P_r), \quad (2.15)$$

where $H(T_r) = \Delta_f H_i^0$ and $S(T_r) = S_i^0$. This is the "apparent" Gibbs energy of formation (Berman, 1988); the element-entropy terms that distinguish it from the true Gibbs energy of formation cancel in any balanced reaction. Compressibility and thermal expansion change $V_i$ by $\lesssim 1\%$ over the conditions considered and are neglected.

Goethite heat capacity uses the Berman–Brown form (Berman and Brown, 1985) refined by Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003), $C_p = k_0 + k_1 T^{-1/2} + k_2 T^{-2} + k_3 T^{-3}$. Hematite uses the same polynomial with the coefficients of Berman (1988),

which Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003) held fixed in their refinement. Both heat capacities are integrated analytically.

*Water.* Water is evaluated with the IAPWS-95 equation of state (Wagner and Pruß, 2002), implemented in CoolProp (Bell et al., 2014), which is valid for liquid, vapor and supercritical water to 1 GPa. In the same apparent convention,

$$G_{\mathrm{w}}(T,P) = \Delta_f H^0_{\mathrm{w}} + [h(T,P) - h(T_r,P_r)] - T\left[S^0_{\mathrm{w}} + s(T,P) - s(T_r,P_r)\right], \tag{2.16}$$

where $h$ and $s$ are the IAPWS-95 molar enthalpy and entropy and the reference state is liquid water at $T_r, P_r$. Table **??** lists all input data. We use the enthalpies and entropies of Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003) refined by mathematical programming against the phase-equilibrium brackets of Voigt and Will (1981).

Table 2.9: Thermodynamic data used for Eq. (**??**).

| | Goethite ($\alpha$-FeOOH) | Hematite ($\alpha$-$Fe_2O_3$) |
|---|---|---|
| $\Delta_f H^0$ ($\mathrm{kJ\,mol^{-1}}$) | $-561.4$ | $-825.8$ |
| $S^0$ ($\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$) | 59.5 | 87.4 |
| $V^0$ ($\mathrm{cm^3\,mol^{-1}}$) | 20.881 | 30.274 |
| $C_p$ coefficients | $k_0 = 133.8765$ | $k_0 = 146.86$ |
| | $k_1 = -738.5577$ | $k_1 = 0$ |
| | $k_2 = -2.177657 \times 10^6$ | $k_2 = -5.5768 \times 10^6$ |
| | $k_3 = 2.165124 \times 10^8$ | $k_3 = 5.2563 \times 10^8$ |
| $C_p$(298 K) ($\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$) | 74.8 | 104.0 |
| $\gamma_{\mathrm{hydrated}}$ ($\mathrm{J\,m^{-2}}$) | $0.60 \pm 0.10$ | $0.75 \pm 0.16$ |
| $\gamma_{\mathrm{anhydrous}}$ ($\mathrm{J\,m^{-2}}$) | $0.91 \pm 0.09$ | $1.90 \pm 0.30$ |

Enthalpy and entropy: Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003); goethite $C_p$: Majzlan, Lang, et al. (2003) and Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003); hematite $C_p$: Berman (1988); surface energies: Navrotsky et al. (2008). Units: $k_0$ $\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$, $k_1$ $\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}\,K^{-1/2}}$, $k_2$ $\mathrm{J\,K\,mol^{-1}}$, $k_3$ $\mathrm{J\,K^2\,mol^{-1}}$; $l_1$ $(\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}})^{1/2}\,\mathrm{K^{-1}}$, $l_2$ $(\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}})^{1/2}\,\mathrm{K^{-2}}$. Water: $\Delta_f H^0_{\mathrm{w}} = -285.83$ $\mathrm{kJ\,mol^{-1}}$, $S^0_{\mathrm{w}} = 69.95$ $\mathrm{J\,mol^{-1}\,K^{-1}}$; IAPWS-95 for $h(T,P)$, $s(T,P)$.

As a check, at 298.15 K and 1 bar with liquid water, Eqs. (**??**)–(**??**) give $\Delta G_r = -0.26$ kJ: hematite plus liquid water is favored by only 0.13 kJ per mole of FeOOH. This is well inside the $\pm 1.4$ $\mathrm{kJ\,mol^{-1}}$ uncertainty that Majzlan, Grevel, et al. (2003) assign to the goethite–hematite free-energy difference; the two assemblages are essentially balanced at ambient conditions. We carry this uncertainty ($\pm 2.8$ kJ per reaction as written) as bounding curves on the phase diagram.

*Surface energy.* A crystal of finite size carries an excess free energy at its surface in addition to the free energy of its bulk (Gibbs, 1878). For a population of

particles of fixed size, this excess is $\gamma A$, where $\gamma$ is the surface energy ($\mathrm{J\,m^{-2}}$) and $A$ the total surface area. Both the bulk and surface terms scale with the amount of material at fixed particle size, so the surface contribution can be written per mole, $G = G_{\mathrm{bulk}} + \gamma A_m$, with $A_m$ the surface area per mole. $A_m$ grows as $1/d$, so the term is negligible for coarse crystals and significant for nanoparticles (Navrotsky et al., 2008). For the reaction as written (one mole of hematite from two moles of goethite),

$$\Delta G_{\mathrm{surf}} = \gamma_{\mathrm{hem}} A_{m,\mathrm{hem}} - 2\,\gamma_{\mathrm{goe}} A_{m,\mathrm{goe}}, \tag{2.17}$$

where $A_{m,\mathrm{hem}}$ is per mole of $Fe_2O_3$ and $A_{m,\mathrm{goe}}$ per mole of FeOOH.

A size must be chosen for each phase. We assume pseudomorphic dehydroxylation, in which hematite inherits the external envelope of the parent goethite, so that both phases share the same external surface area per mole of Fe. This is also the basis of the stability diagrams of Navrotsky et al. (2008). For spherical goethite grains of diameter $d$ this shared area is

$$A_{\mathrm{Fe}} = \frac{6\,V_{\mathrm{goe}}}{d} \quad \text{per mole of Fe.} \tag{2.18}$$

Goethite has one Fe per formula unit, so $A_{m,\mathrm{goe}} = A_{\mathrm{Fe}}$. Hematite has two, so $A_{m,\mathrm{hem}} = 2A_{\mathrm{Fe}}$. Substituting into Eq. (**??**),

$$\Delta G_{\mathrm{surf}} = \gamma_{\mathrm{hem}}\,(2A_{\mathrm{Fe}}) - 2\,\gamma_{\mathrm{goe}}\,A_{\mathrm{Fe}} = 2A_{\mathrm{Fe}}\,(\gamma_{\mathrm{hem}} - \gamma_{\mathrm{goe}})\,. \tag{2.19}$$

The factor of two counts the two moles of Fe that pass through the reaction. It multiplies both terms because both phases carry the same area per Fe. For $d = 10$ nm, $A_{\mathrm{Fe}} = 6 \times 20.881 \times 10^{-6}/10^{-8} = 1.253 \times 10^4\ \mathrm{m^2\,mol^{-1}}$, and with hydrated surface energies $\Delta G_{\mathrm{surf}} = 2 \times 1.253 \times 10^4 \times (0.75 - 0.60) = +3.76$ kJ. The corresponding values are +0.38 kJ at 100 nm and +0.04 kJ at 1 µm. A positive $\Delta G_{\mathrm{surf}}$ stabilizes goethite. If the two phases are instead compared at equal particle diameter, the same hydrated surface energies slightly destabilize fine goethite (−1.41 kJ at 10 nm). The choice affects only the stability discussion; the kinetic analysis uses bulk driving forces.

We use hydrated surface energies. They are referenced to liquid water, so they apply wherever the surfaces are in equilibrium with water at or near saturation, which includes all of the hydrothermal experiments. Anhydrous surface energies apply only to surfaces that have lost their chemisorbed water, i.e. under vacuum.

*Phase diagram.* The phase diagram (Fig. **??**) is computed by solving $\Delta G_r(T, P) = 0$ (Eqs. (**??**)–(**??**)) numerically for $P = P_{\mathrm{H_2O}}$ at each temperature, using Brent's method on $\log_{10} P$ between $10^{-12}$ and $10^4$ bar, with the solids at the fluid pressure. Where no root exists below the melting curve of ice, the curve is truncated.

*Driving force and the role of water.* The quantity that matters for kinetics is the driving force for hematite formation, $\Delta\mu \equiv -\Delta G_r/N_A$ (per mole of $Fe_2O_3$). Water controls $\Delta\mu$ through its own chemical potential, because it is a product of reaction (**??**). $G_{\mathrm{w}}$ in Eq. (**??**) is the chemical potential of $H_2O$ at the prevailing water fugacity. It depends on the partial pressure of water, not on the total pressure. An inert gas, or any other mechanical load, acts only through the solid-volume term $\Delta V_s(P - P_r)$, which contributes $-1.15\ \mathrm{J\,bar^{-1}}$ and slightly favors the denser hematite. At 40 bar that is 46 J, three orders of magnitude smaller than the effect of 40 bar of water. The water-buffered step-heating technique therefore stabilizes goethite primarily by reducing the driving force of the reaction. Surface hydration is a second-order correction that matters only for nanometer grains (Eq. (**??**)).

### 2.6s Calibration of $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$

Equation (**??**) follows from Eq. (**??**) applied to a trap-isolated step and its trapped neighbors, $\ln(1/s) = (C\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}^3/T)(\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}}^{-2} - \Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}}^{-2})$. The driving forces are evaluated as follows.

1. $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}}$ and $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}}$ are bulk driving forces, $-\Delta G_r$ from Eq. (**??**) (§**??**) with $\Delta G_{\mathrm{surf}} = 0$, at the step temperature and with the solids at vacuum.

2. They differ only through the chemical potential of water: $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}}$ is evaluated at $P_{\mathrm{H_2O}} = 10^{-8}$ atm and $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}}$ at the water pressure reached with the trap isolated (below). At these pressures (at most 20 Pa), IAPWS-95 and the ideal gas agree, and $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{on}} - \Delta\mu_{\mathrm{off}} = RT\ln(P_{\mathrm{off}}/P_{\mathrm{on}})$, which is 32–41 kJ for the pressures in Table **??**.

3. Surface terms are omitted in both. The barrier of an internal nucleus depends on the free energy per volume of material transformed, not on the external surface of the host grain. The external surface energy of the grain enters the overall thermodynamic stability (§**??**), but is not a part of the nucleation barrier, which is evaluated for internal neclei.

We bound the water pressure with the trap isolated by assuming that all evolved water was in the vapor, distributed uniformly through an apparatus of volume $V_{\mathrm{app}}$ at 298 K:

$$P_{\mathrm{H_2O}} = \frac{(m_{\mathrm{w}}/M_{\mathrm{w}})\,RT}{V_{\mathrm{app}}}. \tag{2.20}$$

With $m_{\mathrm{w}} = 0.027$ mg at 230 °C and 0.016 mg at 240 °C (1.50 and 0.89 $\mu$mol), and $190 \le V_{\mathrm{app}} \le 600$ mL, Table **??** gives the pressures and the resulting $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$. The pressures are end-of-step values; we also evaluate half of each as a time average for steady accumulation. This is an upper bound on the pressure, because some water adsorbs on the walls of the line; a lower true pressure gives a larger $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ and more suppression at saturation, so the bound is conservative. Pressure enters only through $\ln P$ in $\Delta\mu$ and then through a cube root, so a threefold uncertainty in volume changes $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ by only about 10%. The two steps agree within 15%, and we adopt $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}} = 0.16$ J m$^{-2}$, with a range of 0.14–0.19 J m$^{-2}$.

Table 2.10: Water pressure with the trap isolated and the calibrated $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ (J m$^{-2}$; Eq. (**??**)).

| $T$ (°C) | $s$ | $V_{\mathrm{app}}$ (mL) | $P_{\mathrm{H_2O}}$ (Pa) | $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$, end-of-step $P$ | $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$, $P/2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 230 | 0.333 | 190 | 19.6 | 0.138 | 0.145 |
| 230 | 0.333 | 600 | 6.2 | 0.150 | 0.158 |
| 240 | 0.224 | 190 | 11.6 | 0.164 | 0.173 |
| 240 | 0.224 | 600 | 3.7 | 0.178 | 0.188 |

Figure **??**a shows $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ from Eq. (**??**) as a function of the assumed water pressure during the trap-isolated steps. It spans 0.08–0.20 J m$^{-2}$ over $10^{-5}$–$10^{-1}$ bar and 0.14–0.19 J m$^{-2}$ over the volume-constrained range (Table **??**). Figure **??**b shows the predicted slowdown at saturation (Eq. (**??**)) for the calibrated values and for the most permissive value.

### Uncertainty propagation

The Monte Carlo range quoted in §**??** (4000 draws) samples the trap-isolated step (230 or 240 °C); $s$, log-uniformly between 0.30–0.37 at 230 °C and 0.22–0.23 at 240 °C; the apparatus volume, log-uniformly between 190 and 600 mL; a time-averaging coefficient for the pressure between 0.5 and 1 to account for how quickly the evolved water assumulates in the diffusion cell, and a common offset of $\Delta G_r$, uniformly within ±2.8 kJ per reaction (the ±1.4 kJ per mole FeOOH of Majzlan, Grevel, et al. 2003), which shifts every driving force together. The

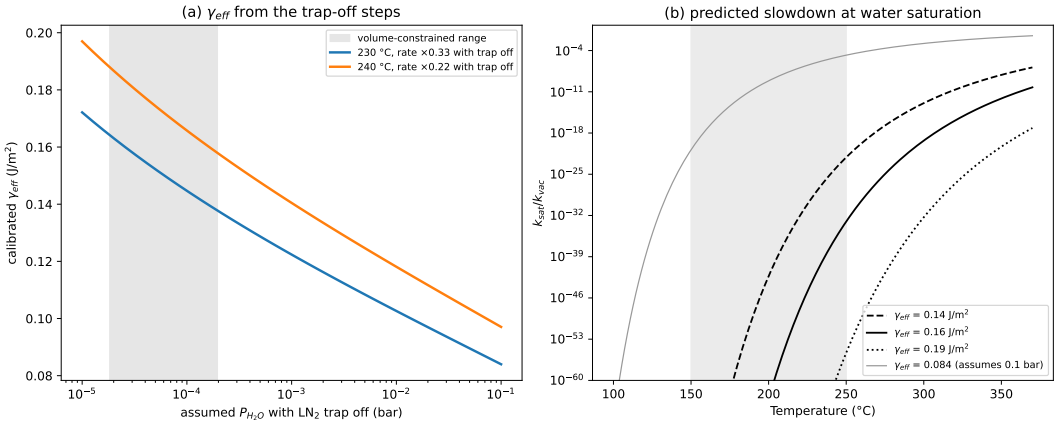



Figure 2.21: (a) $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ calibrated from the two trap-isolated KAF steps as a function of the assumed $P_{\mathrm{H_2O}}$; grey band: range allowed by the apparatus volume (190–600 mL) and the water released in each step. (b) Ratio of conversion rate constants at water saturation and under vacuum (Eq. (**??**)); grey band: temperatures of the hydrothermal experiments.

offset barely changes $\gamma_{\mathrm{eff}}$ (95% range 0.14–0.18 J m$^{-2}$) but contributes most of the spread in the predicted conversion, because it enters the small $\Delta\mu_{\mathrm{sat}}$ (6–11 kJ) squared.

*Chapter 3*

# (U-TH-SM)/HE SULFIDE GEOCHRONOLOGY

*Sulfide mineralization is a near-ubiquitous process in the formation of ore deposits of valuable chalcophile and siderophile elements. Helium isotope studies of sulfides have been applied to infer the origins of mineralizing hydrothermal fluids, and some pioneering studies have applied the U-Th/He method to date sulfides, especially pyrite (O. Yakubovich, Podolskaya, et al., 2020; O. Yakubovich, Vikentyev, et al., 2021). Yet, the interpretation of helium isotope data or U-Th/He ages requires an understanding of the conditions under which helium in sulfides behaves as an open or closed system, as well as the mechanisms of helium loss, a process which is poorly understood in sulfides. Furthermore, sulfides systematically reject U-Th and only produce appreciable radiogenic helium when they contain U-Th-bearing inclusions, further complicating the interpretation of U-Th/He data in sulfides. We explore the systematics of U-Th/He in sulfides through two lenses: 1) an example application of the sulfide U-Th/He geochronometer to two test cases, and 2) helium step heat experiments of sulfide phases. We report pyrite/arsenopyrite U-Th/He ages for Au-ores in the Permo-Triassic Gympie formation of Queensland, Australia, and the Archean Kidd Creek VMS deposit of Ontario, Canada. The Gympie arsenopyrite yields a mean age of 258 ± 35 Ma and spans the range between reported Ar/Ar and K/Ar ages of the country rock and the mineralized quartz veins (Holcombe et al., 1997; Little et al., 1995), suggesting the sulfides predate and were variably reset by the primary mineralization event. Pyrite/arsenopyrite from the 2.7 Ga Kidd Creek VMS deposit of Ontario contain large apatite inclusions ($r \leq 30$ $\mu m$) and span a range of ages from 465-1600 Ma. Although one aliquot can be explained as a perfectly retentive 2.7 Ga sulfide host of apatite inclusions that record a ∼380 Ma cooling age (in agreement with the apatite ages of Sturrock et al. (2024)), the remaining aliquots are too young to be explained by a closed sulfide host and instead*

*require that the sulfides lost significant helium over geologic time.*

*Helium step heat experiments in sulfides are challenging because sulfides readily react/decompose in the high-vacuum, high-temperature conditions of the experiments, producing results that reflect phase decomposition/reaction kinetics that are not geologically relevant. We address this challenge by performing helium step heat experiments at temperatures up to 600°C on natural single-crystal pyrite, arsenopyrite, and galena implanted with uniform 3He through proton bombardment sealed in helium-permeable silica glass tubes stabilized under high sulfur (± arsenic) fugacity to stabilize each phase against decomposition during analysis. We were unsuccessful in extending this method to stabilize chalcopyrite, chalcocite, or marcasite during step heat experiments: the helium retentivity of these phases in nature remains unclear. Retrograde-prograde thermal cycles on sulfur-stabilized galena support a Multiple Diffusion Domain (MDD) helium loss mechanism with an activation energy around 174.8 kJ/mol, but with relatively low helium retentivity that makes it unlikely to be useful as a target for helium isotope studies or U-Th/He geochronology. Comparisons of helium step heat data of sulfur-stabilized pristine and deformed pyrite point towards a multipath diffusion model for deformed pyrites, in which dislocations and fine fractures serve as high activation energy (300.6 ± 7.3 kJ/mol) fast pathways, with bulk volume diffusion following a lower activation energy that is constrained by step heats on pristine pyrite samples: 199.1 ± 3.5 kJ/mol. Helium step heat data of arsenopyrite are complex, potentially complicated by exchange of sulfur and arsenic with the vapor phase, but qualitatively demonstrate very high helium retentivity. These experiments demonstrate that pyrite is similarly helium-retentive to monazite-structure phosphates and is more retentive of helium than natural zircon, apatite, hematite, or goethite. Arsenopyrite is less retentive, more similar to the most helium-retentive zircon.*

## 3.1 Introduction

Sulfide minerals are nearly ubiquitous in the formation histories of economic ore deposits, and indeed are themselves the primary repositories for many base

and precious metals in the crust. The question of when and how they formed is central to understanding ore-forming processes, crustal fluid circulation, and the tectonic contexts in which economic deposits develop. Despite decades of study, the timing of sulfide mineralization remains contested or poorly resolved across a wide range of deposit types, from shallow epithermal systems to deep, high temperature magmatic deposits in mafic intrusions. This uncertainty reflects both the genuine complexity of ore-forming systems (which are frequently multistage, hydrothermal, and overprinted) and the limitations of the geochronological tools available for dating sulfide phases directly.

**An Alternative and Complement to Re-Os Dates in Sulfide Geochronology**

The rhenium-osmium isotope system is the most widely applied method for direct radiometric dating of sulfide minerals, exploiting the relatively high Re concentrations that pyrite, molybdenite, arsenopyrite, and pyrrhotite can accommodate. Re-Os geochronology has produced geologically meaningful ages across a wide range of sulfide-bearing deposit types, and remains indispensable for directly dating ore-forming events (M. Chen et al., 2015; Hnatyshin et al., 2026; Schoenberg et al., 1999; Ostendorf et al., 2019; Selby et al., 2002). Nevertheless, the Re-Os system is vulnerable to a set of well-documented failure modes, and a growing number of published ages exhibit scatter, implausible geologic interpretations, or internal inconsistencies that motivate the development of independent dating methods (Stein et al., 2003; Suzuki et al., 2001; Y. Li et al., 2025; Lyu et al., 2020).

More practically, the highly specialized and costly n-TIMS method for Re-Os dating restricts its application to a select few labs, limiting the scale of its application (Ackerman, 2025). Furthermore, Re-Os dating of sulfides (other than the rare mineral molybdenite) requires gram-quantities (Qi et al., 2010) and is therefore poorly suited to resolve distinct mineralization episodes in multistage systems.

For multistage systems in particular, the co-application of independent radiochronometers is often useful to distinguish the timings for hydrothermal alteration from uplift, cooling, exhumation, and potentially earlier emplacement of host rocks. For example, Selby et al. (2002) demonstrate that Re-Os molybdenite is more likely to accurately record the age of sulfide mineralization in the

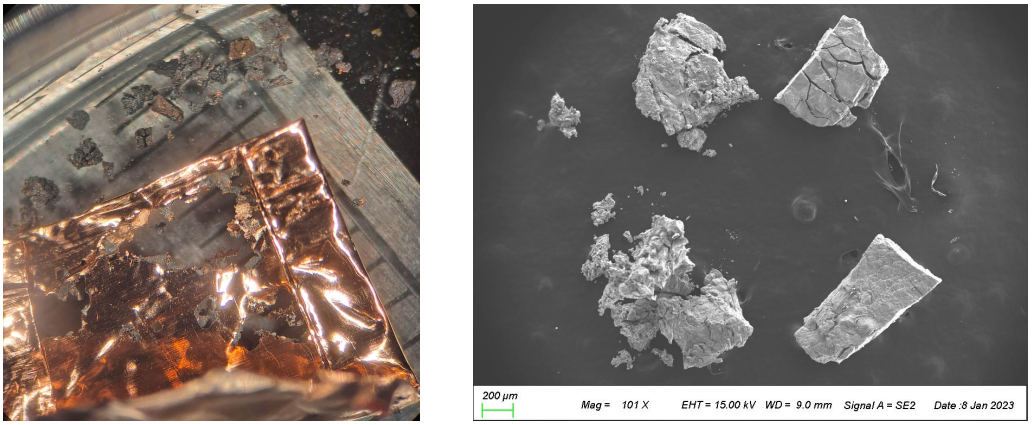
Tintina Gold Belt, Alaska, relative to the comparatively thermally-sensitive Ar-Ar mica ages. However, molybdenite is far from a ubiquitous phase in sulfide-bearing ores, unlike pyrite. A pyrite U-Th/He geochronometer would expand such opportunities to co-apply radiochronometers that interrogate processes operating at different times and temperatures to a much more diverse and expansive array of locales that experienced complex histories. Similar geochronometers developed for other sulfide phases such as arsenopyrite, galena, and sphalerite may offer the opportunity to disentangle multiple episodes of sulfide mineralization and alteration within an ore body, allowing geologists to better understand the sequence of events that lead to economic ore formation.

One such example of an opportunity for applying U-Th/He sulfide geochronology is in the world's largest known platinum-group element deposit, the Bushveld Complex of South Africa, which hosts the Merensky Reef and Platreef PGE deposits in the sulfide-bearing upper critical zone, for which geochronometers yield a surprising diversity of ages: zircon U/Pb ages vary from ≈2057-2060 Ma, while rutile ages are significantly younger at ≈2053 Ma (Scoates et al., 2021), yet Re-Os systematics show evidence for multiple sulfide mineralization events within the same horizon (Schoenberg et al., 1999). The Re-Os and Rb-Sr isochron ages they report are unable to resolve these distinct mineralization events from the zircon U/Pb emplacement age. Unlike Re-Os dating, the U-Th/He system produces distinct ages for every dated aliquot, potentially offering the opportunity to resolve the timings of prolonged volatile activity or late hydrothermal Re-Os disturbance.

Similarly, at the Norilsk-Talnakh deposits of the Siberian Traps, the ore-bearing intrusions can be correlated with a specific transition in flood basalt source and eruptive style (Yao and Mungall, 2021), yet only three of many differentiated intrusions in the region are economic, and the precise timing and mechanism of sulfide saturation relative to trap emplacement are not fully understood. In the 1.1 Ga Sonju Lake Intrusion of Minnesota, USA, stable isotopic evidence suggests that meso/epithermal fluids reacted with primary magmatic sulfides, raising questions about when redistribution occurred and how much metal was moved (Park et al., 2004). These are deposits where independent thermochronometric constraints capable of distinguishing primary crystallization from later hydrothermal reworking are needed.

**Stabilizing Sulfides for Helium Step Heat Experiments**

Our earliest step heat experiments on sulfides were revealed that vacuum experiments produced sudden, profound, irreversible increases in apparent diffusivity at temperatures above 300 °C, similar to the behavior observed of dehydrating goethite (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024). Such experiments occasionally displayed obvious signs of reaction with the copper packet that housed the pyrite grains within the heating cell (Figure **??**).




(a) (b)

Figure 3.1: Evidence of pyrite breakdown during early vacuum step heat experiments. (a) A copper packet recovered after a vacuum step heat experiment, corroded and perforated where it reacted with the enclosed, desulfurized pyrite grains; dark, brittle reaction residues are scattered on the surrounding surface. (b) Secondary-electron image of copper packet residues formed from reaction with sulfur emmited from pyrite during a vacuum step heat experiment, showing pervasive cracking and fragmentation. This step heat experiment only went as hot as 315 °C, yet decomposition was pervasive. This experiment was associated with a dramatic spike in helium release after 300 °C. These experiments in vacuum clearly interogate the decomposition kinetics, motivating another approach to stabilize sulfides for step heat experiments.

Figure **??** shows the sulfur fugacities required to keep pyrite stable over the temperature range of our step heat experiments. Encapsulating pyrite in silica glass tubes using the methods developed in Chapters **??** and **??** with sulfur in sufficient excess to maintain a sulfur liquid phase controls the sulfur fugacity, stabilizing the pyrite against thermal decomposition.

**The Single-Jump Migration Model and its Application to Pyrite**

The Russian school of noble gas geochronology spearheaded by Shukolyukov and Yakubovich approaches the problem of helium migration in minerals

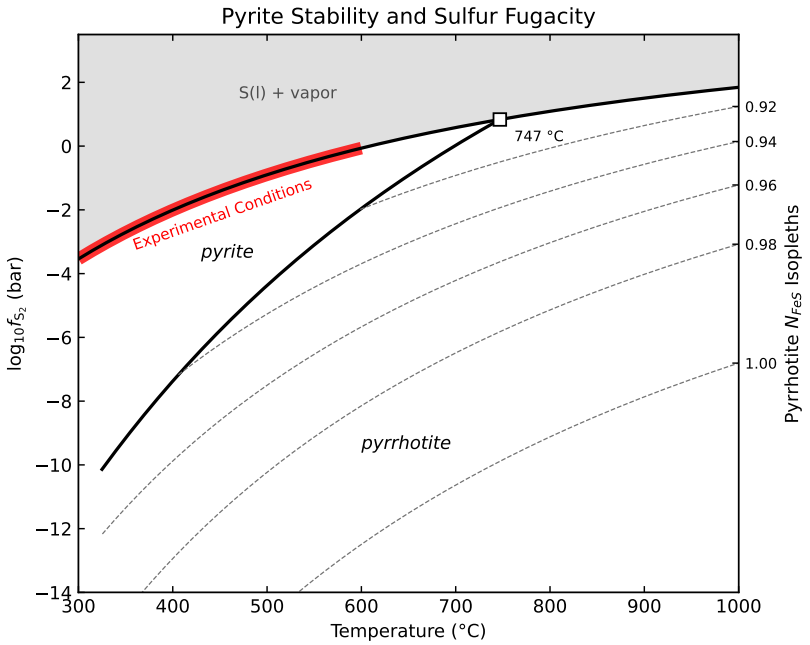



Figure 3.2: Stability of pyrite in $\log_{10} f_{S_2}$–temperature space, figure adapted from Toulmin and Barton (1964). The upper black curve is the sulfur fugacity in equilibrium with pure liquid sulfur, computed from NASA Glenn thermodynamic polynomials (McBride et al., 2002); the grey field above it is inaccessible. The lower black curve is the pyrite–pyrrhotite univariant boundary of Toulmin and Barton (1964), which meets liquid-sulfur saturation at an invariant point near 747 °C. Dashed curves are pyrrhotite composition isopleths from the Toulmin and Barton (1964) pyrrhotite equation, labelled on the right-hand axis by $N_{\mathrm{FeS}}$, the mole fraction of FeS in the FeS–$S_2$ system. The thick red line marks the 300–600 °C range of our step heat experiments for pyrite along liquid-sulfur saturation, clearly well-within pyrite's stability field. Conditions in vacuum experiments (i.e., at very low sulfur fugacity) are well below the pyrite stability field.

through a theoretical framework that differs fundamentally from the volume diffusion model used to describe noble gas migration dominant in the Western thermochronological literature (Dodson, 1973; Harrison et al., 1985; Fortier and Giletti, 1989; Lovera et al., 1991; Wolf, Farley, and Silver, 1996; Farley, 2000; Lee, Williams, et al., 1997). In the Shukolyukov "single-jump model," helium atoms occupy discrete energy minima within the crystal structure, and migration proceeds through thermally activated jumps between these sites (Y. A. Shukolyukov et al., 2009; O. V. Yakubovich, Y. A. Shukolyukov, et al., 2010).

Within this framework, Y. Shukolyukov et al. (2012) developed the $^{190}$Pt-$^{4}$He

system as a new geochronometer for native platinum minerals, demonstrating through thermal desorption analysis that radiogenic $^{4}$He in isoferroplatinum is stable to temperatures approaching the melting point of platinum, and obtaining $^{190}$Pt-$^{4}$He ages from the Galmoenan and Kondyor massifs consistent with independent Sm-Nd and Rb-Sr estimates. He storage in native platinum was attributed to accumulation in vesicles and clusters at dislocation cores and grain boundaries. Western scientists similarly model helium migration in metals with single-jump mechanisms, although these single jumps are not typically modeled to instantaneously liberate helium, instead the modeled single-jump allows the atom to spontaneously travel a distance of some angstroms with some frequency, introducing a spatial scale from which a diffusivity can be evaluated (Rätzke et al., 1992; Cost and Hickman, 1975; Wilson and Bisson, 1973).

O. V. Yakubovich, Mochalov, et al. (2015) extend this method to sperrylite ($PtAs_2$) a rare mineral found in magmatic PGE deposits that is isostructural with pyrite. $^{190}$Pt-$^{4}$He ages from sperrylite at the Kondyor and Norilsk-Oktyabrsky deposits were geologically consistent, and the high He retentivity demonstrated in this arsenide prophesies similar behavior in pyrite.

Without providing any sulfur buffer, O. V. Yakubovich, Gedz, et al. (2019) interpreted ramped-heating experiments for a variety of silica glass encapsulated sulfides under the single-jump step-heating method. Pyrite, in particular, was found to have anomalously high retentivity of helium. The first application of U-Th/He pyrite geochronometry to a natural ore deposit was reported by O. V. Yakubovich, Gedz, et al. (2019) and O. Yakubovich, Podolskaya, et al. (2020) for the Uzelga Cu-Zn VMS deposit of the South Urals, yielding a consistent weighted mean age of 382 $\pm$ 12 Ma that is older than regional prehnite-pumpellyite metamorphism, demonstrating that pyrite can survive a metamorphic overprint without complete isotopic resetting. While these results establish the viability of pyrite as a U-Th/He geochronometer, their analytical approach employs a simple, low-resolution monotonic heating schedule without grain-size scaling experiments, sulfur buffers, and proton-implanted $^{3}$He domain mapping, which leaves the diffusion/migration physics of sulfides undercharacterized. Unsurprisingly, given the rapid heating rates used in their experiments, their results for pyrite generally show abrupt helium loss at temperatures corresponding to the upper stability field of pyrite around 700°C (Toulmin and

Barton, 1964), and therefore are unlikely to contain substantial information about helium loss in natural pyrite over geologic timescales. Extending these initial observations into a robust, predictive thermochronometric framework requires the more rigorous experimental and theoretical treatment that is one of the aims of this work.

### Geologic Setting

Pyrite and arsenopyrite for the geochronologic study were collected from two deposits that strongly differ in the timing and conditions of their formation: the Archean Kidd Creek volcanogenic massive sulfide (VMS) deposit, Ontario, Canada, and the Permo-Triassic orogenic gold system at Gympie, Queensland, Australia. Pairing a ∼2.7 Ga Cu-Zn-Ag VMS sulfide with a ∼235 Ma Au-bearing arsenopyrite provides two independently well-constrained age brackets against which to test He retentivity and closure behavior in pyrite across very different formation temperatures, host lithologies, and post-depositional thermal histories.

### Kidd Creek, Ontario, Canada

Kidd Creek is among the largest and most profitable VMS deposits in the world, with past production and reserves exceeding 138.5 Mt at average grades of 2.4 percent Cu, 6.5 percent Zn, 0.23 percent Pb, and 90 g/t Ag (Hannington et al., 1999). The deposit occurs within the Late Archean Kidd-Munro assemblage of the Abitibi subprovince, Superior Province, hosted at the top of a thickened pile of massive rhyolite flows, felsic volcaniclastics, and coarse epiclastic rocks that attain a maximum thickness of ∼300 m beneath the mine (Hannington et al., 1999). The three main stratiform orebodies (North, Central, and South) formed largely by subseafloor infilling and replacement of permeable volcaniclastic rocks within a subsiding, rift-related graben, rather than by high-temperature venting at the seafloor (Hannington et al., 1999). U-Pb zircon geochronology brackets the ore-forming interval tightly: the oldest footwall rhyolite is dated at 2716.1 ± 0.6 Ma, the onset of bimodal komatiite-rhyolite volcanism at 2717 ± 1.1 Ma, and the youngest, uppermost quartz porphyry unit at 2711.5 ± 1.2 Ma, indicating that mineralization took place during at least one and possibly several million years of intermittent volcanic activity (Hannington et al., 1999). Oxygen isotope studies of the host rhyolites show that, while primary igneous zircon retains magmatic $\delta^{18}O$ values (5.4‰ ± 0.3‰), coexisting quartz phenocrysts

are pervasively shifted to much higher and more heterogeneous values (14.2‰ to 16.1‰), recording extensive subsolidus recrystallization during the same long-lived hydrothermal convection that deposited the sulfides (King et al., 1997).

The interior of the Canadian shield has been a stable platform for hundreds of millions of years, as documented by U-Th/He and fission track dating of apatite (Sturrock et al., 2024). Kidd Creek in particular has been of particular interest for its famously ancient groundwaters that sustain a low-biomass but metabolically active community of sulfate-reducing and alkane-oxidizing microorganisms (Lollar et al., 2019). The Kidd Creek deposit is thus an ideal natural laboratory for testing the long-term He retentivity of pyrite and arsenopyrite.

### Gympie, Queensland, Australia

The Gympie arsenopyrite comes from a very different setting: an accreted, Early Permian bimodal (basalt-dacite) submarine volcanic sequence, the Gympie Group, interpreted as a fragment of an intra-oceanic island arc that rifted from the Gondwana margin before docking against the New England Orogen of eastern Australia (Sivell and Waterhouse, 1988). Drillcore near the Gympie Eldorado Gold Mine resolves at least nine sequentially emplaced magmatic suites and a >2 km thick volcano-sedimentary succession. This arc terrane is inferred to have accreted to the Gondwana margin by about 220 Ma (Early to Middle Triassic), based on cross-cutting granitoid relationships with adjacent New England Orogen terranes (Sivell and McCulloch, 2001).

Gold-bearing pyrite-quartz mineralization at Gympie occurs in fibrous extensional veins developed within sheared, carbonaceous black slates. Alteration associated with this vein set has yielded a K/Ar age of about 235 Ma (Holcombe et al., 1997). Refractory dolerite dykes and later microdiorite-shoshonite dykes cross-cut the mineralized structures and bracket the timing of the auriferous quartz veining from below and above, respectively, giving an independent field constraint on the age of mineralization that is broadly consistent with the K/Ar alteration ages (Sivell and McCulloch, 2001).

The nominal “Early Permian” age assigned to the host rocks to the Gympie deposit, the Highbury Volcanics and Rammutt Formation, however, rests mainly on sparse invertebrate and plant fossil biostratigraphy higher in the

sequence and on lithologic correlation, rather than on direct radiometric dates on the volcanic pile itself. Holcombe et al. (Holcombe et al., 1997) note that the lower Gympie Block volcanics, like the correlative Berserker beds, "may contain older volcanic units," and fold the entire Gympie succession into a long-lived (∼320-280 Ma, peaking at ∼305 Ma) regional magmatic episode. These volcanics may very well be related to nearby ∼300-310 Ma granodiorite magmatism and rapid uplift of the regional epidote-blueschist-facies basement, which record $^{40}Ar/^{39}Ar$ hornblende cooling ages around 297 Ma Little et al. (1995) and Holcombe et al. (1997).

## 3.2 Experimental Methods

### U-Th/He Geochronology

### Sample Preparation

Intact crystals of arsenopyrite (and pyrite from the Kidd Creek deposit) were extracted from Kidd Creek and Gympie samples using a hammer and chisel at Caltech and SELFRAG high-voltage pulse fragmentation at the University of Queensland, respectively. Pyrite is present in the Gympie sample but only in small amounts, and no pyrite dates are reported for it. The majority of the Kidd Creek samples were silver arsenopyrite, but brassy cubes (presumed pyrite) were also analyzed. A subsample of the Gympie arsenopyrites was leached in 1M HCl for 4 hours to remove any surface contamination and then rinsed in MilliQ water and dried. Individual crystals were washed in a sequence of acetone, ethanol, and MilliQ water baths, then promptly dried using clean, lint-free wipes. These samples, along with the hematite MI-43 standard from Gogebic, Michigan (Farley and McKeon, 2015), and the apatite standard from Durango, Mexico (Farley, 2000), were weighed, then encapsulated in silica glass ampoules similarly to the sulfides in §**??**, but without any additional buffer materials. An empty tube was also encapsulated to serve as a procedural blank. Photos and masses of the prepared ampoules were recorded so that the helium and trace metal analyses could be correctly matched.

### Helium Analysis

Encapsulated samples were wrapped in Ni-foil and loaded into a custom-built autosampler with the procedural blank loaded first. The autosampler was wrapped in heating tape, which was used to warm the samples to 80-

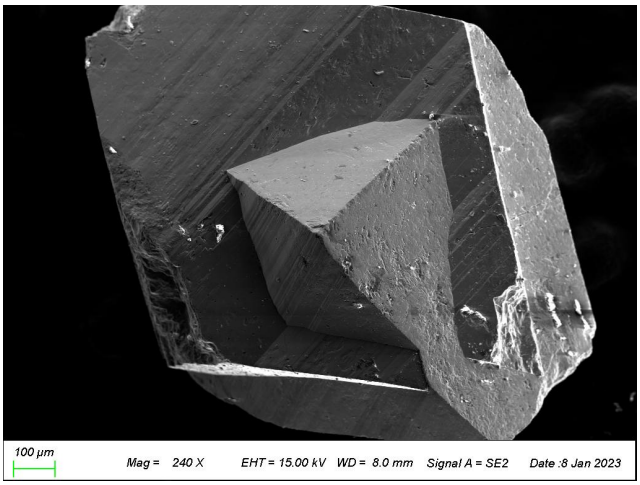



Figure 3.3: Secondary-electron SEM image of crystallographic arsenopyrite twins exceeding 1 cm across, recovered intact from Kidd Creek ore (sample ST05) with a hammer and chisel. Fine-scaled growth striations are preserved on the crystal faces. Euhedral crystals of this size were extracted routinely, showing that simple mechanical excavation preserved crystal faces well.

100°C for at least 12 hours in ultra-high vacuum before the first step heat to allow for atmospheric helium to escape. Initial efforts in method development showed that atmospheric helium contamination was significant (Fig. **??**). This atmospheric helium payload of an ampoule equilibrated with air is on the order of 10s of nccSTP helium per ampoule (Chapter **??**, §**??**). It is difficult to mathematically correct for even when 3He can be accurately measured, because helium diffusion and permeation through silica glass fractionates 3He/4He ratios (Shelby, 1971; Jones, 1953), and the ampoules were each geometrically unique and therefore had different permeation rates. Still, we found the best results when we applied a simple correction to the helium data after substantially mitigating this contamination with the warm (80-100°C) degassing step. To correct for the much smaller remaining atmospheric contamination, we subtract 4He proportionally to measured 3He by the atmospheric 3He/4He isotope ratio: $1.39 \times 10^{-6}$. The procedural blanks showed that atmospheric helium contamination was reduced by a factor of 5-10, which was sufficient for these helium-rich samples with 100s of nccSTP helium (Fig. **??**). Future work may develop a more rigorous approach to experimentally remove atmospheric helium contamination or to mathematically correct for it using the first order framework presented in Chapter **??** (§**??**).

After 12 hours, unheated furnace blank measurements were periodically taken

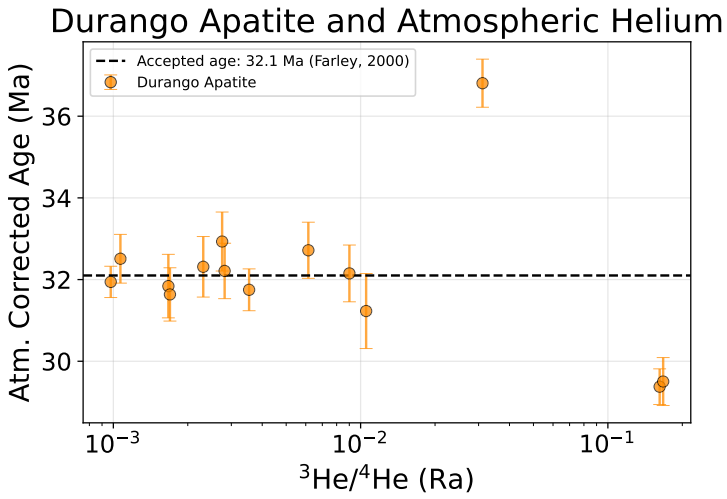



Figure 3.4: The atmosphere-corrected age for encapsulated Durango apatite is plotted against the measured helium isotope ratio ($^3He/^4He$), normalized to atmosphere (Ra), illustrating the atmospheric-contamination problem motivating the experimental correction protocol described in **??**. Aliquots with low measured Ra (i.e. a small atmospheric 4He contribution relative to radiogenic 4He) require insignificant mathematical correction, preserving the accuracy of the ages and agreeing with the 32.1Ma accepted age (Farley, 2000). Aliquots measured before implementing the experimental atmosphere-degassing step contain more 3He and require stronger corrections. Because these corrections are unaware of the true isotopic composition of fractionated atmosphere in the ampoule, they yield inaccurate ages when they are large with respect to the sample's total measured helium. The weighted average age of the aliquots with mass >0.5 mg, 32.1 ± 0.2 Ma, agrees well with the accepted age, affirming the fundamental accuracy of the measurements.

until the measured value was similar to such blanks taken for batches of samples not encapsulated in silica glass, then samples were individually dropped into a resistance furnace and baked at 1000-1200°C for 15 minutes to degas their helium contents. Although pyrite and arsenopyrite are unusually retentive of helium at lower pressures, these temperatures were far above these phases' stability field, and so they were readily degassed. Helium abundances and isotope ratios were measured on a Thermo Fisher Helix SFT mass spectrometer. Gasses evolved during the bake were passed through a charcoal filter held at 77°K, then exposed to an SAES-10 getter and a heated titanium getter before being cryofocused at 14°K, then released at 34°K. Sensitivities were quantified using a calibrated 3He-enriched air standard several times throughout the analysis.

**Trace Metal Analysis**

The encapsulated, now degassed samples were removed from the furnace and were matched to their pre-bake photos and masses. Around 20% of samples would be typically lost during the helium analysis process, with ampoules either broken by the autosampler or by thermal stresses during the bakes. Samples bearing residual nickel-foil that had fused to the surface of the glass were scratched clean with a dental pick, and the remaining glass ampoule was sonicated in a sequence of ethanol then MilliQ water baths. Samples were then placed in an acid-washed Teflon beaker and were broken underwater by an agate pestle, to prevent loss of sample material. The pestle was rinsed with MilliQ water between samples to avoid cross-contamination. Excess water was pipetted away from each sample and disposed of, then the remaining water was evaporated on a hot plate. The vast majority of the samples were then spiked with a U-232 and Th-230, and vanadium enriched spike and digested in concentrated $HNO_3$ in closed Teflon beakers, leaving the glass intact. The uranium and thorium concentrations of the glass ampoules were measured to be $\approx$ 50 and 30 ppb by mass respectively, but this contaminant payload was only delivered when the glass was dissolved in HF; the uranium and thorium contents of concentrated nitric acid in extended contact with broken glass were below detection limits.

After this point, the Kidd Creek pyrite/arsenopyrite and Durango Apatite solutions were pipetted and diluted to an ICPMS-ready solution. The Gympie samples, however, required further processing to dissolve fine U-Th bearing rutile inclusions. The Gympie and MS-43 hematite samples, now mostly digested in concentrated $HNO_3$, were dried down and put back up in small volumes of concentrated HCl, then were loaded into Parr vessels and baked at 200°C for 24 hours. The Gympie samples were then dried down again and put back up in concentrated $HNO_3$ before the concentrated acid was transferred and diluted to an ICPMS-ready solution. U and Th contents were quantified with isotope dilution using an Agilent 8800 ICP-MS. Other trace elements were measured as ratios with spike vanadium. The U-Th contents of the spikes and the sensitivities of the other quantified trace metals relative to vanadium were continuously monitored by analyzing a standard solution of known composition that was spiked with the same U-Th-V spike as the samples. The same empty tube procedural blank used for the helium analysis was also processed through

the same acid digestion and ICPMS analysis, and the measured U, Th, and other trace metal contents were subtracted from the measured values of the samples. The U-Th contents of the procedural blank were below detection limits, and the other trace metals were typically 1-5% of the measured values of the samples.

The Gogebic Iron Range hematite standard (Farley and McKeon, 2015) was carried through this same Parr-vessel digestion step alongside the Gympie arsenopyrite, serving as an in-run check on how completely this digestion protocol recovers a sample's true U-Th-Fe budget. Fig. **??** plots each Gogebic aliquot's measured $^4$He against its eU, normalized by the sample mass calculated from measured Fe content where available and by the pre-analysis balance mass otherwise. Except for one clearly erroneous outlier (with an age in excess of 1.5Ga), these samples agree with two independently published ages for Gogebic, Michigan hematite: 453 Ma (U-Th/$^{21}$Ne, aliquot MI-45; (Farley and McKeon, 2015)) and 579 Ma, (U-Th/He, (Hofmann, Treffkorn, et al., 2020)). Here the outlier is interpreted to have experienced U-loss, as its helium content is similar to the other aliquots, but it has low eU. Although incomplete digestion would also produce erroneous older ages, the apparent helium concentration would be higher and the eU would match the other samples if that was the case.

### Encapsulated Sulfide Step Heat Experiments

#### Samples

Nine helium step heat experiments of sulfides (pyrite, arsenopyrite, chalcopyrite, galena, chalcocite, and sphalerite) sealed in silica glass ampoules performed at the Noble Gas Laboratory at Caltech are discussed here. Table **??** shows the dimensions, geometric factors, and encapsulated materials of this work. All sulfides of this study were sourced from the Caltech Mineral Collection from visually pure, well-formed euhedral crystals with half prism widths greater than 200 microns, often larger than a centimeter. Samples were broken into smaller pieces under ethanol to avoid irreversible trapping of atmosphere (Cox et al., 2022). Except for the Rustenburg pyrite, all step heats measured 3He evolution from an initially homogeneous distribution of spallogenic 3He. To produce a homogeneous distribution of 3He, the samples were irradiated with 220 MeV protons for 24 hours at the Francis H. Burr Proton Therapy Center, Massachusetts General Hospital, following standard procedures (Shuster and

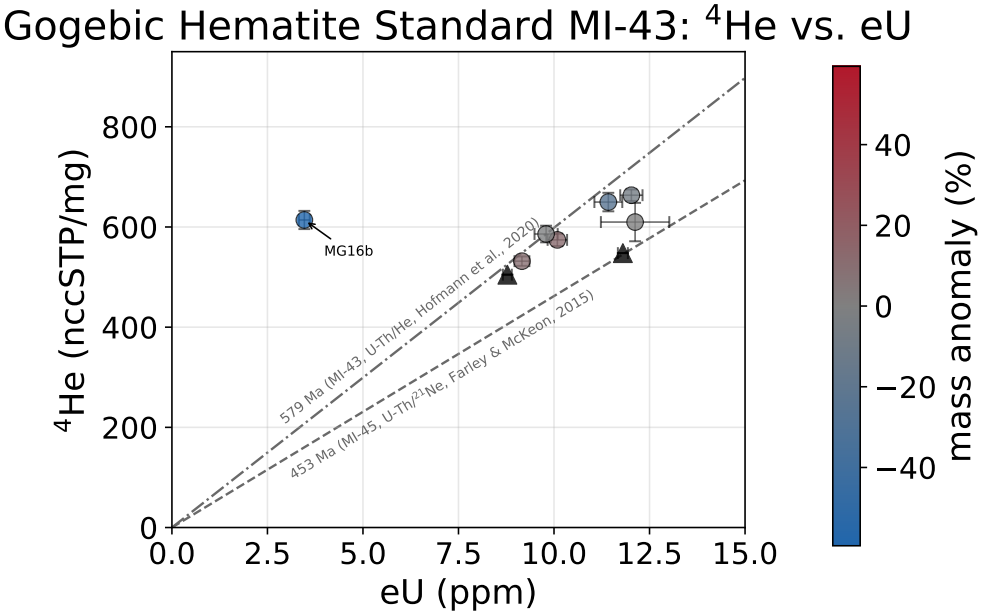



Figure 3.5: Atmosphere corrected $^4$He (nccSTP/mg) vs. eU (ppm), with $2\sigma$ error bars, for the MI-43 Gogebic hematite standard aliquots analyzed alongside Gympie arsenopyrite (Table **??**), normalized by mass calculated from Fe molar abundances measured on ICPMS. Fe was not measured for two samples: they are plotted as triangles using their balance-measured mass. These two measures of mass are compared to assess internal consistency within samples. Points are colored by "mass anomaly" in percent: $\frac{M_{Fe}-M_B}{M_{Fe}} \times 100$. Anomalies are generally small: with absolute values 11% or smaller for all but 2 samples. The old outlier sample 041323MG16b with low eU, however, has a mass anomaly of 59%, meaning that the balanced-measured mass was significantly higher than the mass inferred from the iron abundance. Two isochrons of independently published ages for Gogebic hematite are plotted: 453 Ma (MI-45, U-Th/$^{21}$Ne; (Farley and McKeon, 2015)) and 579 Ma (Hofmann, Treffkorn, et al., 2020). Only the low eU outlier 041323MG16b falls outside of this age range. With anomalously low eU at an otherwise unremarkable $^4$He content, is interpreted here as an example of U-loss. Its large mass anomaly may point to the presence of an insoluble phase such as quartz, however, it is difficult to explain why an insoluble phase would affect only the eU concentration and not the helium concentration of the hematite.

Farley, 2005).

Table 3.1: Silica Glass encapsulated sulfides that were the subject of helium step heat experiments in this work. The Rustenburg Pyrite experiment had evolved radiogenic 4He quantified by isotope dilution using a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer, whereas evolved spallogenic 3He was quantified using a Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer for the remainder of the samples, which were proton-irradiated. Experiments Spal230707 and CCT230707 contained no steps for which the uncertainty due to helium permeation through the silica glass capsule could be estimated, and therefore are discussed in a limited, qualitative capacity only in the Supplementary Information (§??)

| Experiment Name and Phase | Sample Locality | Tube Inner x Outer Diameters | Geometric factor $G$ (*eqn 2.2, Ch.1)* | VR (*eqn 5.4, Ch.1)* | Encapsulated "Buffer" Materials | Mineral Half-prism Width (a) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LVCOPy230630 Pyrite | Leadville, Colorado | *Not Measured* | *3000 cm$^{-2}$* | - | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~200 µm |
| BigLVCOPy230707 Pyrite | Leadville, Colorado | *1300 x 1650 µm* | 1985 cm$^{-2}$ | 1.6 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~400 µm |
| 112123LVCOPyIrr Pyrite | Leadville, Colorado | 830 x 1550 µm | 1859 cm$^{-2}$ | 2.5 | ~ 0.2 mg Fused Sulfur and >5 mg silica glass shards | ~300 µm |
| Rustenburg Pyrite (4He on Quad) | Rustenburg, South Africa | 520 x 810 µm | 6675 cm$^{-2}$ | 1.4 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | 106 µm |
| 112123SalAspIrr Arsenopyrite | Mitterberg, Austria | 530 x 970 µm | 4711 cm$^{-2}$ | 2.3 | ~0.5 mg Crystalline Realgar (AsS) | ~175 µm |
| GalTS230630 Galena | Tri-State District, Missouri | 620 x 920 µm | 5273 cm$^{-2}$ | 1.2 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~200 µm |
| CCpTS230630 Chalcopyrite | Baxter Springs, Kansas | 540 x 1010 µm | 4382 cm$^{-2}$ | 2.5 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~200 µm |
| Spal230707* Sphalerite | Chitwood, Missouri | 1110 x 1490 µm | 2205 cm$^{-2}$ | 0.8 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~200 µm |
| CCT230707* Chalcocite | Messina, South Africa | 1100 x 1520 µm | 2044 cm$^{-2}$ | 0.9 | ~0.2 mg Fused Sulfur | ~200 µm |

### Encapsulation

Before encapsulating the sulfide samples, glass tubes were cleaned and pulled

into pipettes. 10 cm long segments of pure silica glass tubes with an outer diameter of 4 mm and an inner diameter of 3 mm were submerged and sonicated within acetone, ethanol, then MilliQ water baths in sequence, and then were dried overnight in a 100°C oven. The glass tubes were hand-pulled into thinner pipettes using a natural gas and oxygen welding torch and the thin ends were fused closed.

Aliquots of sulfides were weighed and loaded into room temperature glass tubes along with fused sulfur in the presence of an ionizing fan to mitigate static. The arsenopyrite ampoule was loaded with crystalline realgar (arsenic sulfide) instead of fused sulfur, and one pyrite ampoule was loaded with silica glass pieces above and below the pyrite aliquot to separate the pyrite from the sulfur liquid during the experiment. To seal, the top of each pipette was interfaced with a vacuum line and the tube was pumped to a pressure of <60 millitorr, which greatly aided the ease and quality of the final seal. After attaining rough vacuum, a fine-flamed welding torch was used to seal the top of each ampoule. To determine the geometric factors for permeation of the ampoules, the inner and outer diameters of most ampoules were measured using the measurement function of the Amscope stereo microscope software, which was calibrated and tested during early development of this method. LVCOPy230630 was completed without these geometric measurements. For this experiment, a geometric factor of 3000 $cm^{-2}$ was arbitrarily assigned to estimate uncertainties of the measurements due to permeation lag. This assumption is unlikely to affect the interpretation of the results.

The sealed ampoules were placed in copper foil packets and mounted to a K-type thermocouple within an ultra-high vacuum projector lamp heating cell described in detail by Farley, Reiners, et al. (1999). Before the experiment began, each ampoule was washed with ethanol, air-dried, loaded in the lamp cell, pumped to high vacuum, and was held at 100°C for at least 30 minutes under dynamic vacuum to desorb ethanol, water, and other atmospheric species on the ampoule, copper packet, and lamp cell.

**Helium Mass Spectrometry**

Heating steps and 3He measurements for all samples were automated using custom LabView routines on a Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ multi-collector mass spectrometer, or a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer for the Rustenburg Pyrite ampoule. For all ampoules, a Watlow temperature

controller held the ampoule at the temperature set point for a pre-programmed duration, after which the ampoule was allowed to cool while the evolved gas was prepared for measurement for about 25 minutes.

For the irradiated samples, Helium was purified by exposing evolved gasses to a charcoal trap held in liquid nitrogen, a titanium sponge getter, then a SAES NP10 getter before freely expanding into the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$. 3He was measured with a pulse-counting electron multiplier, while 4He was detected on a Faraday detector. The Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ mass spectrometer was operating in peak hopping mode and the majority of the analysis time was spent measuring 3He. Every few hours, the background was mass-scanned to set the 3He and 4He measure points; each was taken to be a constant mass offset from the background $HD^+$ peak. These mass offsets are precisely measured when tuning the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ for helium isotope analysis. Months of helium measurements with the Helix-MC-Plus$^{10K}$ at Caltech have shown this approach to be reliable, reproducible, and accurate for helium isotope analysis. Additionally, an electron multiplier monitored atomic mass 3.5 to detect 4He overspray. 4He signals were near-blank for all experiments of irradiated samples, and no attempt is made here to interpret those data. 4He overspray likewise did not affect 3He signals. Measurements of high 3He MM gas standard were analyzed every 8 hours to track instrumental drift of 3He and 4He sensitivities and to quantify internal reproducibility. These standards show 3He was generally internally reproducible to within 1% ($2\sigma$) for rolling sets of 5 consecutive standards, except for the latest measurements on the 112123SalAspIrr Arsenopyrite, during which the ion source began to fail. Those measurements are excluded from further analysis, and any helium evolved during those steps is likely to be a very small proportion of the total helium contents of the sample (<0.2%) and thus would not significantly affect the calculation of the total helium content of the sample.

After the step heat experiments, the LVCOPy230630 and GalTS230630 ampoules were broken and then completely degassed following the step heat experiments by heating to 1100 °C in a resistance furnace, then $^3$He and $^4$He yield was quantified using a Thermo Fisher Helix SFT. The total $^3$He yields for the remainder of the irradiated pyrite samples were inferred assuming the measured $^3$He concentration of LVCOPy230630. The chalcopyrite experiment was assumed to be entirely degassed in the step heat experiment without the final fusion step. The total $^4$He content of the Rustenburg pyrite was assumed

to be 200 nccSTP, a conservatively low estimate based on the measured $^4$ content of other Rustenburg pyrite aliquots. (*Note: This would be an easy measurement to do in the near future: one aliquot of non-irradiated sulfide in the furnace. Talk with Ken and Jonathan about this.*)

Radiogenic 4He evolved during step heats of the encapsulated Rustenburg Pyrite was quantified using isotope dilution with a high purity 3He spike on a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer. A standard gas with a known amount of 4He was measured before and after the experiment, to monitor drift in the relative sensitivities of 3He and 4He and to estimate reproducibility, which was about 6% ($2\sigma$). After each step, evolved gas from the ampoule in the lamp heating cell was allowed to mix with the 3He spike and the mixture was frozen on charcoal held at 14°K within a cryostat, then helium was selectively released to the mass spectrometer by raising the temperature to 36°K.

**Scanning Electron Microscope Study**

The methodology for the SEM study of the sulfides is described in detail in §??.

**Analytical Methods For Step Heat Experiments**

Similarly to O. V. Yakubovich, Gedz, et al. (2019), these helium step heat experiments were designed according to the assumption that the silica glass ampoule was effectively "helium transparent", or in other words that helium permeation through the silica glass ampoule was nearly instantaneous with respect to the rate of helium evolution from the encapsulated sulfides. Thus, permeation steps (as discussed in Chapters 1 and 2) were rarely used. This assumption was acceptable for most of the pyrite and arsenopyrite step heats, and much of the galena and chalcopyrite step heats. Unfortunately, the assumption was not valid for any of the sphalerite or chalcocite step heats, and for some of the lower temperature steps of the other sulfides, which can only be discussed here qualitatively. The helium yields for steps at high temperatures are approximately the measured value, and the uncertainty of this estimation due to permeation lag is constrained by upper bounds following the uncertainty-bounding approach presented in Chapter ?? (§??). This approach requires no permeation steps or knowledge of the helium content within the ampoule from previous steps, instead calculating the maximum possible helium content

remaining within the ampoule following a given high-temperature measurement, provided the step was long and hot enough for the helium inventory of the tube to have reached a steady state concentration and assuming that the rate of helium evolution from the encapsulated mineral is constant or decreasing as is generally expected for first and second order processes. The steady state assumption is taken to be effectively valid once the ampoule loses memory of the helium content remaining from the previous step. According to eqn. (**??**) in Chapter 1, only 1.8% of the difference between the previous step's remaining helium content and the current step's steady state helium content remains when $\lambda t = 4$. In this work, the steady state assumption is only applied for steps long and hot enough for $\lambda t \geq 4$, where $\lambda = KGRT$, $K$ is the temperature-dependent permeation coefficient for 4He or 3He through silica glass, $G$ is the ampoule geometric factor, $R$ is the gas constant, $T$ is the temperature in Kelvin, and $t$ is the time in seconds. The 4He permeation coefficient $K$ is taken from Swets et al. (1961); and these coefficients are multiplied by the permeation coefficient ratio from Jones (1953) to yield the 3He permeation coefficient.

Many heating steps, especially near the beginning of the experiments where lower temperature steps were used, are not interpreted or plotted in this work because $\lambda t < 4$; however, some steps with $\lambda t < 4$ are used when eqn. (**??**) is used to place upper bound constraints on preceding steps, so that eqn. (**??**) can in turn be used to quantify the uncertainty on the yields of steps that have not reached steady state.

This method of calculating uncertainties produces an asymmetric upper and lower uncertainty for each step. These asymmetric uncertainties are propagated through the diffusivity inversion of Fechtig and Kalbitzer (1966) with eqn. (**??**) in Chapter 2. In general, the $2\sigma$ analytical uncertainties as calculated using the reproducibility of standards are greatly exceeded by the uncertainties due to the permeation lag of the ampoule as constrained by the procedure outlined in §**??**.

## 3.3 Results

### Sulfide Step Heat Experiments

The apparent diffusivities calculated from the helium step heat data are reported in Tables **??**–**??** (one per pyrite/arsenopyrite experiment; the analogous galena and chalcopyrite tables are given in the Supplementary Information, §**??**).

These experiments qualitatively show remarkably high helium retentivity at high temperatures for pyrite and arsenopyrite. For no pyrite or arsenopyrite helium step heat experiment did the final cumulative fractional helium yield exceed 5%, even after repeated heating cycles at $\geq$ 500 °C.

Table 3.2: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Pyrite, Leadville, CO, 200 µm half-prism width (sample LVCOPy230630), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (Arrhenius) and Fig. **??** (delta). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 31 | 475.0 | 100.0 | 0.0075 | 0.4382 | 0.0022 | -24.682 | -24.061 | -23.805 |
| 32 | 465.0 | 120.0 | 0.0048 | 0.4430 | 0.0012 | -25.283 | -24.681 | -24.457 |
| 33 | 455.0 | 140.0 | 0.0047 | 0.4476 | 0.0010 | -25.149 | -24.854 | -24.650 |
| 34 | 510.0 | 60.0 | 0.0105 | 0.4581 | 0.0046 | -23.282 | -23.179 | -22.810 |
| 35 | 520.0 | 60.0 | 0.0126 | 0.4708 | 0.0053 | -23.412 | -22.965 | -22.612 |
| 36 | 530.0 | 60.0 | 0.0177 | 0.4885 | 0.0068 | -22.943 | -22.597 | -22.263 |
| 37 | 539.9 | 60.0 | 0.0204 | 0.5089 | 0.0075 | -22.815 | -22.414 | -22.096 |
| 38 | 555.0 | 60.0 | 0.0315 | 0.5404 | 0.0105 | -22.193 | -21.930 | -21.632 |
| 39 | 545.0 | 60.0 | 0.0181 | 0.5585 | 0.0065 | -23.302 | -22.440 | -22.127 |
| 40 | 535.0 | 80.0 | 0.0175 | 0.5760 | 0.0049 | -23.190 | -22.730 | -22.480 |
| 41 | 525.0 | 100.0 | 0.0136 | 0.5895 | 0.0032 | -23.622 | -23.180 | -22.962 |
| 42 | 515.0 | 120.0 | 0.0114 | 0.6009 | 0.0024 | -23.848 | -23.515 | -23.319 |
| 43 | 505.0 | 140.0 | 0.0078 | 0.6087 | 0.0015 | -24.400 | -24.029 | -23.849 |
| 44 | 560.0 | 60.0 | 0.0252 | 0.6339 | 0.0087 | -22.046 | -21.984 | -21.682 |
| 45 | 570.0 | 60.0 | 0.0371 | 0.6710 | 0.0121 | -21.810 | -21.550 | -21.258 |
| 46 | 580.0 | 60.0 | 0.0465 | 0.7176 | 0.0145 | -21.553 | -21.260 | -20.979 |
| 47 | 590.0 | 60.0 | 0.0604 | 0.7780 | 0.0179 | -21.188 | -20.925 | -20.654 |
| 48 | 600.0 | 60.0 | 0.0690 | 0.8470 | 0.0195 | -20.999 | -20.710 | -20.450 |
| 49 | 604.7 | 60.0 | 0.0691 | 0.9161 | 0.0191 | -20.945 | -20.626 | -20.372 |
| 50 | 595.0 | 60.0 | 0.0381 | 0.9542 | 0.0109 | -21.846 | -21.163 | -20.904 |
| 51 | 585.0 | 60.0 | 0.0244 | 0.9786 | 0.0073 | -22.167 | -21.576 | -21.310 |

Table 3.3: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Pyrite, Leadville, CO, 400 µm half-prism width (sample BigLVCOPy230707), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (Arrhenius) and Fig. **??** (delta). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 16 | 400.0 | 160.0 | 0.0201 | 0.7190 | 0.0099 | -26.075 | -26.029 | -25.779 |
| 17 | 420.0 | 140.0 | 0.0386 | 0.7576 | 0.0189 | -25.357 | -25.204 | -24.951 |
| 18 | 440.0 | 120.0 | 0.0461 | 0.8037 | 0.0234 | -25.072 | -24.815 | -24.554 |
| 19 | 460.0 | 100.0 | 0.0521 | 0.8558 | 0.0289 | -24.734 | -24.449 | -24.170 |
| 20 | 480.0 | 80.0 | 0.0490 | 0.9048 | 0.0322 | -24.619 | -24.229 | -23.914 |
| 21 | 500.0 | 60.0 | 0.0538 | 0.9586 | 0.0483 | -24.174 | -23.791 | -23.402 |
| 22 | 510.0 | 60.0 | 0.0559 | 1.0145 | 0.0454 | -24.262 | -23.696 | -23.332 |
| 23 | 490.0 | 70.0 | 0.0237 | 1.0382 | 0.0178 | – | -24.668 | -24.330 |
| 24 | 470.0 | 90.0 | 0.0109 | 1.0491 | 0.0065 | -27.670 | -25.682 | -25.396 |
| 25 | 450.0 | 110.0 | 0.0053 | 1.0544 | 0.0028 | -27.693 | -26.586 | -26.327 |
| 26 | 430.0 | 130.0 | 0.0033 | 1.0577 | 0.0016 | -27.872 | -27.226 | -26.978 |
| 27 | 410.0 | 150.0 | 0.0007 | 1.0584 | 0.0004 | – | -28.887 | -28.642 |
| 28 | 450.0 | 160.0 | 0.0055 | 1.0640 | 0.0017 | -26.951 | -26.914 | -26.743 |
| 29 | 470.0 | 140.0 | 0.0100 | 1.0739 | 0.0032 | -26.295 | -26.187 | -26.012 |
| 30 | 490.0 | 120.0 | 0.0219 | 1.0958 | 0.0073 | -25.321 | -25.232 | -25.049 |
| 31 | 510.0 | 100.0 | 0.0378 | 1.1336 | 0.0139 | -24.596 | -24.476 | -24.276 |

Table 3.4: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Pyrite, Leadville, CO, sulfur-isolated (glass-shard-separated) (sample 112123LVCOPyIrr), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (Arrhenius) and Fig. **??** (delta). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 46 | 500.0 | 120.0 | 0.0447 | 0.1998 | 0.0138 | -22.605 | -22.576 | -22.268 |
| 48 | 510.1 | 120.0 | 0.0311 | 0.2327 | 0.0090 | -23.201 | -22.736 | -22.461 |
| 49 | 520.1 | 120.0 | 0.0259 | 0.2586 | 0.0070 | -23.204 | -22.796 | -22.543 |
| 51 | 530.0 | 120.0 | 0.0325 | 0.2921 | 0.0082 | -22.643 | -22.453 | -22.213 |
| 53 | 540.0 | 120.0 | 0.0277 | 0.3203 | 0.0066 | -22.823 | -22.507 | -22.283 |
| 55 | 550.0 | 120.0 | 0.0326 | 0.3531 | 0.0073 | -22.460 | -22.249 | -22.036 |
| 57 | 560.1 | 384.0 | 0.1064 | 0.4600 | 0.0061 | -22.099 | -22.041 | -21.978 |
| 58 | 570.1 | 60.0 | 0.0156 | 0.4755 | 0.0080 | -22.460 | -21.968 | -21.543 |
| 59 | 580.0 | 60.0 | 0.0263 | 0.5018 | 0.0125 | -21.756 | -21.400 | -20.997 |
| 60 | 590.0 | 60.0 | 0.0596 | 0.5614 | 0.0263 | -20.721 | -20.497 | -20.107 |
| 61 | 600.0 | 60.0 | 0.0630 | 0.6244 | 0.0265 | -20.852 | -20.332 | -19.959 |
| 62 | 595.0 | 60.0 | 0.0468 | 0.6712 | 0.0206 | -21.358 | -20.542 | -20.162 |
| 63 | 590.1 | 60.0 | 0.0318 | 0.7030 | 0.0146 | -21.891 | -20.867 | -20.480 |
| 64 | 585.1 | 60.0 | 0.0259 | 0.7290 | 0.0122 | -21.846 | -21.031 | -20.637 |
| 65 | 580.1 | 60.0 | 0.0165 | 0.7455 | 0.0082 | -22.786 | -21.452 | -21.045 |
| 66 | 575.1 | 60.0 | 0.0114 | 0.7569 | 0.0058 | -23.073 | -21.808 | -21.390 |
| 67 | 570.1 | 60.0 | 0.0101 | 0.7669 | 0.0053 | -22.775 | -21.915 | -21.489 |
| 68 | 565.2 | 60.0 | 0.0075 | 0.7744 | 0.0041 | -23.431 | -22.203 | -21.761 |
| 69 | 560.1 | 60.0 | 0.0058 | 0.7802 | 0.0033 | -23.671 | -22.444 | -21.988 |
| 70 | 555.2 | 60.0 | 0.0051 | 0.7853 | 0.0030 | -23.638 | -22.572 | -22.104 |
| 71 | 600.1 | 60.0 | 0.0337 | 0.8190 | 0.0138 | -20.747 | -20.655 | -20.303 |
| 72 | 551.7 | 79.4 | 0.0115 | 0.8305 | 0.0047 | – | -21.986 | -21.641 |
| 73 | 550.2 | 60.0 | 0.0044 | 0.8349 | 0.0028 | – | -22.660 | -22.161 |
| 74 | 550.2 | 60.0 | 0.0040 | 0.8388 | 0.0025 | -23.985 | -22.751 | -22.266 |
| 75 | 500.0 | 420.0 | 0.0065 | 0.8453 | 0.0005 | -24.680 | -24.202 | -24.131 |
| 76 | 500.1 | 180.0 | 0.0023 | 0.8476 | 0.0004 | -24.621 | -24.392 | -24.220 |

Table 3.5: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Arsenopyrite, Mitterberg, Austria (sample SalAspIrr), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (Arrhenius) and Fig. **??** (delta, row 1). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 76 | 360.0 | 120.0 | 0.0052 | 0.3258 | 0.0017 | – | -24.590 | -24.302 |
| 78 | 370.0 | 120.0 | 0.0073 | 0.3342 | 0.0022 | – | -24.224 | -23.960 |
| 80 | 380.0 | 120.0 | 0.0059 | 0.3417 | 0.0016 | – | -24.408 | -24.166 |
| 82 | 390.0 | 120.0 | 0.0074 | 0.3504 | 0.0018 | – | -24.159 | -23.935 |
| 84 | 400.0 | 120.0 | 0.0111 | 0.3625 | 0.0025 | – | -23.728 | -23.520 |
| 86 | 395.0 | 120.0 | 0.0075 | 0.3704 | 0.0018 | – | -24.086 | -23.871 |
| 88 | 390.0 | 120.0 | 0.0049 | 0.3763 | 0.0012 | – | -24.499 | -24.277 |
| 90 | 385.0 | 130.0 | 0.0065 | 0.4182 | 0.0015 | – | -24.194 | -23.982 |
| 92 | 380.0 | 140.0 | 0.0044 | 0.4226 | 0.0010 | – | -24.646 | -24.443 |
| 93 | 410.0 | 120.0 | 0.0154 | 0.4379 | 0.0032 | -23.277 | -23.213 | -23.020 |
| 95 | 420.0 | 120.0 | 0.0255 | 0.4693 | 0.0049 | – | -22.647 | -22.466 |
| 97 | 430.0 | 120.0 | 0.0547 | 0.5262 | 0.0097 | – | -21.794 | -21.621 |
| 99 | 440.0 | 120.0 | 0.1123 | 0.6419 | 0.0185 | – | -20.915 | -20.747 |
| 101 | 450.0 | 120.0 | 0.1449 | 0.7912 | 0.0222 | – | -20.455 | -20.297 |
| 102 | 445.0 | 120.0 | 0.0825 | 0.8737 | 0.0131 | -21.171 | -20.871 | -20.716 |
| 103 | 440.0 | 120.0 | 0.0510 | 0.9247 | 0.0084 | -21.566 | -21.276 | -21.119 |
| 104 | 435.0 | 130.0 | 0.0305 | 0.9552 | 0.0048 | -22.142 | -21.825 | -21.678 |
| 105 | 430.0 | 140.0 | 0.0187 | 0.9739 | 0.0028 | -22.651 | -22.361 | -22.221 |
| 106 | 425.0 | 150.0 | 0.0149 | 0.9888 | 0.0021 | -22.849 | -22.644 | -22.510 |
| 107 | 420.0 | 160.0 | 0.0091 | 0.9979 | 0.0012 | -23.453 | -23.189 | -23.060 |
| 108 | 415.0 | 170.0 | 0.0062 | 1.0040 | 0.0008 | -23.848 | -23.624 | -23.499 |
| 109 | 410.0 | 180.0 | 0.0048 | 1.0089 | 0.0006 | -24.113 | -23.926 | -23.804 |
| 110 | 405.0 | 190.0 | 0.0035 | 1.0124 | 0.0004 | -24.501 | -24.304 | -24.184 |
| 111 | 400.0 | 206.0 | 0.0054 | 1.0178 | 0.0007 | -24.021 | -23.937 | -23.823 |
| 112 | 460.0 | 120.0 | 0.0588 | 1.0765 | 0.0084 | -20.992 | -20.981 | -20.844 |
| 113 | 470.0 | 100.0 | 0.0750 | 1.1515 | 0.0123 | -20.608 | -20.493 | -20.336 |
| 114 | 480.0 | 80.0 | 0.0732 | 1.2247 | 0.0147 | -20.409 | -20.230 | -20.041 |
| 115 | 500.0 | 60.0 | 0.1425 | 1.3672 | 0.0353 | -19.292 | -19.189 | -18.954 |
| 116 | 495.0 | 60.0 | 0.0693 | 1.4366 | 0.0178 | -20.532 | -19.831 | -19.596 |
| 117 | 485.0 | 60.0 | 0.0300 | 1.4666 | 0.0083 | -21.527 | -20.634 | -20.387 |
| 118 | 475.0 | 60.0 | 0.0100 | 1.4766 | 0.0030 | -23.470 | -21.718 | -21.458 |
| 119 | 465.0 | 60.0 | 0.0046 | 1.4812 | 0.0015 | -23.503 | -22.482 | -22.204 |
| 120 | 455.0 | 60.0 | 0.0054 | 1.4866 | 0.0019 | -22.649 | -22.328 | -22.025 |
| 121 | 445.0 | 60.0 | 0.0022 | 1.4888 | 0.0009 | -25.234 | -23.223 | -22.887 |
| 122 | 435.0 | 60.0 | 0.0015 | 1.4903 | 0.0006 | -24.523 | -23.620 | -23.261 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 123 | 425.0 | 80.0 | 0.0004 | 1.4907 | 0.0001 | – | -25.195 | -24.929 |
| 125 | 405.0 | 120.0 | 0.0015 | 1.4922 | 0.0003 | -24.385 | -24.298 | -24.102 |
| 126 | 395.0 | 150.0 | 0.0018 | 1.4940 | 0.0003 | -24.512 | -24.317 | -24.151 |
| 127 | 395.0 | 150.0 | 0.0009 | 1.4950 | 0.0002 | -25.402 | -24.974 | -24.808 |
| 128 | 395.0 | 150.0 | 0.0022 | 1.4972 | 0.0004 | -24.203 | -24.122 | -23.956 |
| 129 | 395.0 | 150.0 | 0.0017 | 1.4989 | 0.0003 | -24.635 | -24.372 | -24.206 |
| 130 | 400.0 | 150.0 | 0.0018 | 1.5007 | 0.0003 | -24.527 | -24.336 | -24.176 |
| 131 | 410.0 | 415.0 | 0.0041 | 1.5048 | 0.0002 | -24.597 | -24.519 | -24.468 |
| 132 | 420.0 | 130.0 | 0.0010 | 1.5058 | 0.0002 | -25.025 | -24.780 | -24.619 |
| 133 | 430.0 | 120.0 | 0.0022 | 1.5080 | 0.0004 | -24.001 | -23.918 | -23.754 |
| 134 | 440.0 | 593.0 | 0.0103 | 1.5183 | 0.0003 | -23.988 | -23.950 | -23.921 |

The irradiated Leadville pyrite was the most retentive sample of the sulfide suite. Three separate helium step heat experiments were conducted on this sample, two with varying grain size and a third that attempted to isolate the pyrite from the sulfur liquid by packing glass shards above and below the pyrite grains within the ampoule (Table **??**). The Arrhenius plots for all three experiments show similar diffusivities (Fig. **??**). The three experiments shared a similar slope, and a regression was fit to the most linear region of 9 measurements of the LVCOPy230630 experiment with an $R^2$ of 0.998, yielding an apparent activation energy of 47.59 ± 0.85 Kcal/mol (199.1 ± 3.5 kJ/mol; Fig. **??**), implying a closure temperature of 294.3 ± 6.7°C assuming a cooling rate of 10°C/Ma. The delta plot constructed with this activation energy showed a general agreement between the smaller grain-size experiments, seemingly unaffected by the direct contact with sulfur liquid or lack thereof. The more retentive, larger ampoule yielded lower delta values at the same cumulative fractional yield, revealing that a smaller proportion of its helium resided in these least retentive domains that produce the common diffusivity trend on the Arrhenius plot for the three experiments (Fig. **??**).

The octahedral Rustenburg pyrite is less retentive of helium than the pyritohedral Leadville pyrite. On the down-temperature retrogrades of heating cycles, the Rustenburg pyrite shows clearly developed reproducible linear arrays with the unusually high implied activation energy of 71.8 ± 1.7 Kcal/mol (300.6 ± 7.3 kJ/mol; Fig. **??**: $R^2$ of 0.998 on 5 measurements). This feature is completely absent from the three experiments of proton-irradiated Leadville pyrite (Fig. **??**). The delta plot constructed using this activation energy shows

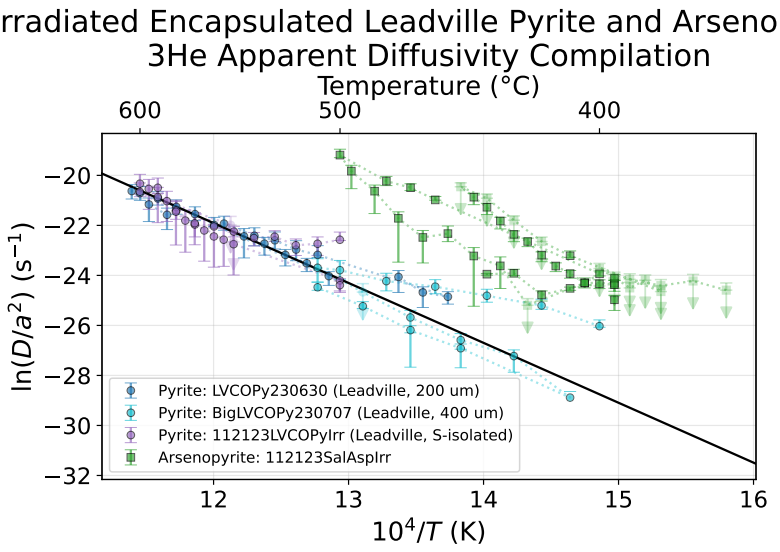



Figure 3.6: Compiled Arrhenius plot of apparent $^3$He diffusivity for the three irradiated Leadville pyrite step-heat experiments (LVCOPy230630, BigLVCOPy230707, 112123LVCOPyIrr) and the proton-irradiated arsenopyrite experiment (112123SalAspIrr), each with permeation-lag uncertainty bars. Downward-pointing arrows mark steps with an unconstrained lower bound (see §**??**). The solid black line is the regression fit to the most linear region of the LVCOPy230630 experiment (9 points, $R^2 = 0.998$, Ea = 47.59 ± 0.85 kcal/mol), used throughout this section as the shared reference line for all three Leadville pyrite experiments and for arsenopyrite.

a monotonic decrease in delta values throughout the duration of the experiment (Fig. **??**).

The encapsulated arsenopyrite helium step heat experiment produced an apparent diffusivity Arrhenius plot that showed generally high helium retentivity, but less so than the Leadville pyrites (Fig. **??**). There were no representative linear regions produced by this experiment that were suitable for linear regression, although the general slope was similar to the Leadville pyrites' and so it was also used as a reference for this experiment. The delta plot using this reference showed complex behavior, where high delta values (far beyond the uncertainty related to the permeation lag of the ampoule itself) were observed for low temperature steps following high temperature steps (Fig. **??**, row 1, Supplementary Information).

Step heat results for galena (GalTS230630) and chalcopyrite (CCpTS230630) are reported in the Supplementary Information (§**??**). Neither mineral seems to be a promising U-Th/He geochronometer or helium isotope target.

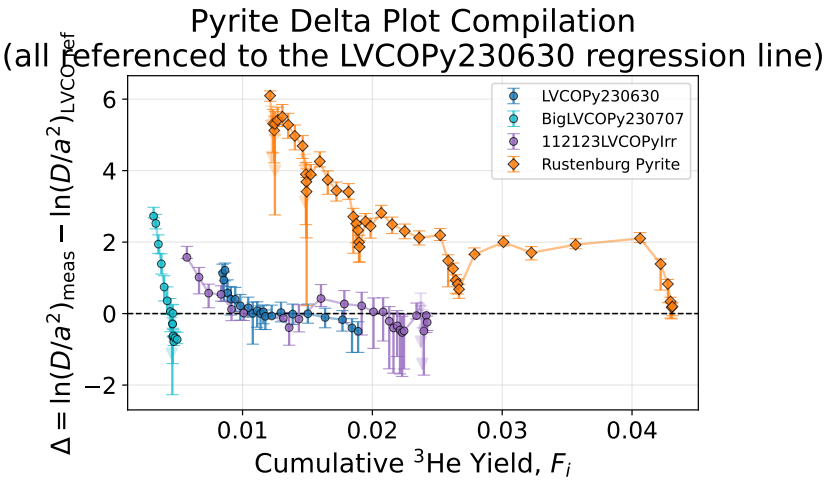



Figure 3.7: Delta plot ($\Delta = \ln(D/a^2)_{\text{meas}} - \ln(D/a^2)_{\text{LVCO ref}}$) vs. cumulative helium yield for all four pyrite step-heat experiments of this study, each referenced to the shared LVCOPy230630 regression line of Fig. **??**. The three irradiated Leadville pyrite experiments (LVCOPy230630, BigLVCOPy230707, 112123LVCOPyIrr) initially decrease, then plateau near $\Delta = 0$, with the large-grained BigLVCOPy230707 aliquot recording lower diffusivities than the other two at a given cumulative fractional yield. The Rustenburg pyrite (§**??**) departs sharply from all three, reaching $\Delta$ values up to +6 at low cumulative yield before decreasing toward $\Delta = 0$ at higher yield.

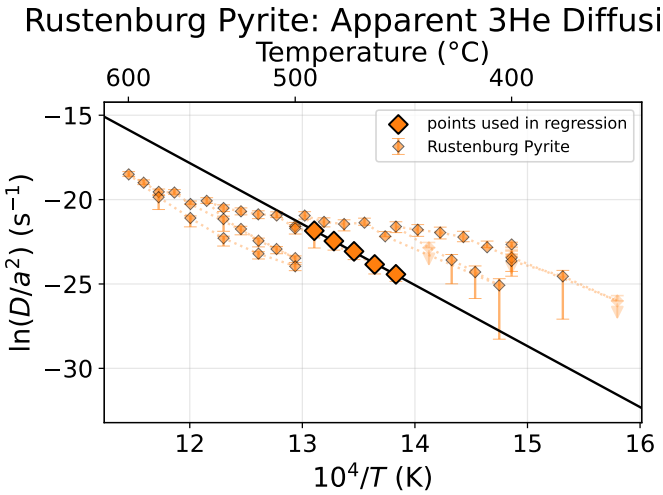



Figure 3.8: Apparent $^4$He diffusivity Arrhenius plot for the Rustenburg pyrite step-heat experiment (isotope-dilution-quantified on a Pfeiffer Prisma QMS 200 quadrupole mass spectrometer; §**??**). The solid black line is the regression fit to the five down-temperature retrograde steps used to define the Rustenburg activation energy (highlighted points; Ea = 71.8 ± 1.7 kcal/mol, $R^2$ = 0.998, n = 5), markedly steeper than the shared Leadville/arsenopyrite reference slope of Fig. **??**.

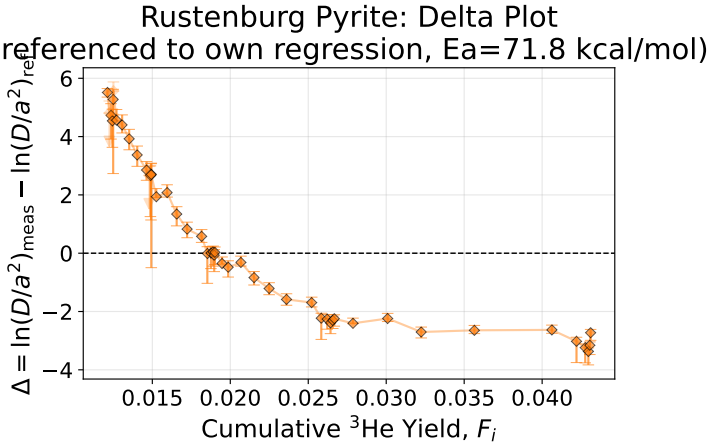



Figure 3.9: Delta plot for the Rustenburg pyrite step-heat experiment, referenced to its own regression (Fig. **??**; Ea = 71.8 kcal/mol). Delta values decrease monotonically from about +5.5 at low cumulative $^4$He yield to about −3.5 at high yield, in contrast to the near-flat delta trends of the three Leadville pyrite experiments (Fig. **??**).

Table 3.6: U-Th/He geochronology results for the four sample suites discussed in the main text: Kidd Creek pyrite, Gympie pyrite, and the Durango apatite and Gogebic (MI-43) hematite standards run alongside them, including U, Th, and Sm (the radiogenic-budget elements quantified by ICPMS, §**??**) plus Zr, also measured as a ratio to spike vanadium; '–' denotes below detection or not measured for that aliquot. The remaining ICPMS trace elements measured the same way (Cu, As, Ag, Sb) are reported separately in the Supplementary Information (Table **??**) rather than here, to keep this table within the page width. Ages are the atmospheric-He-corrected 'Age (Ma Atm=1Ra Corr.)' value; † marks the handful of early aliquots analyzed before a tube blank was available, for which the uncorrected measured age is reported instead. Excluded aliquots (§**??**) are noted in the last column, as are the first four Durango apatite aliquots (2211DApA, 2211DApC, 2211DApD, 2022StDApA), analyzed under the early "old method" protocol that predated the warm atmosphere-degassing step (§**??**, Fig. **??**). The complete compilation, including localities not discussed in the main text, is given in the Supplementary Information (Table **??**).

| Sample | Mass (mg) | U (ppm) | Th (ppm) | Sm (ppm) | Zr (ppm) | eU (ppm) | $^4$He (ncc) | Age (Ma) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Kidd Creek Pyrite (Archean VMS, ∼2716 Ma host)** | | | | | | | | | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_C | 4.77 | 0.918±0.054 | 1.641±0.040 | 0.099±0.006 | – | | 1.312 | 470.80 | 694.9±29.1 |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_A | 3.23 | 0.686±0.013 | 2.640±0.050 | 0.134±0.009 | – | | 1.320 | 305.56 | 644.1±8.4 |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_B | 1.74 | 0.879±0.052 | 1.593±0.033 | 0.203±0.012 | – | | 1.261 | 159.83 | 621.3±25.6 |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_D | 1.98 | 0.659±0.021 | 0.911±0.029 | 0.037±0.005 | – | | 0.878 | 165.82 | 810.8±19.6 |
| 011123KCPyST05C | 1.28 | 0.510±0.019 | 0.732±0.051 | 0.384±0.070 | 9.13±2.64 | | 0.686 | 158.07 | 1595.9±46.0 |
| 011423KCPyST05A | 2.41 | 1.706±0.024 | 4.047±0.115 | 1.176±0.071 | 28.91±2.25 | | 2.678 | 389.20 | 591.0±7.7 |
| 011423KCPyST05B | 4.04 | 1.999±0.052 | 3.383±0.086 | 2.205±0.130 | 41.16±3.86 | | 2.811 | 534.00 | 465.2±8.8 |
| 011423KCPyST05C | 3.93 | 0.834±0.038 | 1.969±0.062 | 0.492±0.047 | 15.46±1.10 | | 1.307 | 281.60 | 539.9±16.3 |
| 011423KCPyST05D | 1.46 | 0.441±0.024 | 0.850±0.088 | 0.073±0.035 | 7.43±2.53 | | 0.645 | 71.24 | 731.3±34.6 |
| 013023KCPyST05As1 | 1.66 | 0.905±0.019 | 7.933±0.215 | 11.476±0.420 | 6.85±1.82 | | 2.809 | 259.45 | 551.5±10.3 |
| 013023KCPyST05Cu1 | 1.05 | 0.324±0.074 | 1.001±0.122 | 0.249±0.085 | 4.91±2.77 | | 0.564 | 55.14 | 860.1±120.5 |
| 013023KCPyST05Cu2 | 1.56 | 0.867±0.018 | 9.902±0.264 | 16.538±0.625 | 8.81±2.16 | | 3.244 | 268.77 | 523.4±10.0 |

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*(continued)*

| Sample | Mass (mg) | U (ppm) | Th (ppm) | Sm (ppm) | Zr (ppm) | eU (ppm) | $^4$He (ncc) | Age (Ma) | | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Gympie Pyrite (Permo-Triassic orogenic Au)** | | | | | | | | | | |
| 013023PVGyPy-1 | 3.81 | 0.065±0.004 | 0.064±0.011 | 0.128±0.022 | 1.22±0.75 | 0.080 | 34.71 | 928.3±50.9 | excl.: early protocol | |
| 013023PVGyPy-2 | 1.15 | 0.272±0.016 | 0.254±0.040 | 0.320±0.065 | 3.58±2.43 | 0.333 | 47.71 | 1008.0±51.7 | excl.: early protocol | |
| 013023PVGyPy-3 | 1.81 | 0.128±0.006 | 0.159±0.024 | 0.173±0.047 | – | 0.167 | 31.64 | 763.3±34.8 | excl.: early protocol | |
| 013023PVGyPy-4 | 1.82 | 0.280±0.041 | 0.358±0.031 | 0.647±0.049 | 7.15±3.71 | 0.366 | 52.23 | 638.1±69.5 | excl.: early protocol | |
| 0413PyGy-1 | 3.54 | 0.462±0.006 | 0.587±0.027 | 0.589±0.069 | 56.95±3.43 | 0.603 | 53.03 | 233.1±3.4 | | |
| 0413PyGy-2 | 1.67 | 0.232±0.014 | 0.362±0.032 | 0.375±0.058 | 40.37±3.17 | 0.319 | 15.12 | 257.4±12.6 | | |
| 0413PyGy-3 | 1.32 | 0.747±0.018 | 0.721±0.047 | 0.775±0.124 | 72.56±3.28 | 0.920 | 30.29 | 235.2±5.3 | | |
| 0413PyGy-4 | 1.85 | 0.862±0.016 | 0.791±0.037 | 0.489±0.071 | 77.41±5.18 | 1.052 | 126.53 | 622.9±10.2 | excl.: outlier | |
| 062123GyPyHClb | 2.15 | 0.636±0.022 | 0.583±0.050 | 0.498±0.028 | 89.48±7.17 | 0.776 | 32.69 | 191.1±6.1 | | |
| 062123GyPyHClc | 9.43 | 0.331±0.007 | 0.394±0.011 | 0.375±0.022 | 65.54±2.35 | 0.425 | 126.01 | 306.4±5.0 | | |
| 230625GyPyHCl | 2.38 | 0.477±0.007 | 0.463±0.041 | 0.971±0.053 | 64.39±2.99 | 0.588 | 35.29 | 227.5±4.5 | | |
| 230625GyPyUnAbr | 2.32 | 0.615±0.011 | 0.518±0.044 | 0.782±0.053 | 61.55±2.84 | 0.739 | 50.13 | 285.0±5.5 | | |
| 230628GyPyHClab | 6.17 | 0.627±0.007 | 0.716±0.034 | 0.785±0.051 | 96.43±3.82 | 0.799 | 133.56 | 264.7±3.6 | | |
| 230628GyPyHClc | 4.03 | 0.585±0.023 | 0.478±0.025 | 0.650±0.045 | 64.98±6.53 | 0.699 | 78.96 | 275.6±9.1 | | |
| 230628GyPyUnAbrA | 2.53 | 0.308±0.013 | 0.371±0.042 | 0.396±0.032 | 63.98±3.08 | 0.397 | 31.76 | 303.6±12.3 | | |
| 230628GyPyUnAbrB | 1.57 | 0.468±0.012 | 0.410±0.068 | 0.632±0.049 | 64.38±6.01 | 0.567 | 23.90 | 261.8±8.9 | | |
| **Durango Apatite Standard (accepted age 32.1 Ma; Farley 2000)** | | | | | | | | | | |
| 2211DApA | 0.81 | 10.375±0.104 | 193.585±3.785 | 25.000±0.909 | – | 56.835 | 141.43 | 31.7±0.5 | old method: pre-degassing | |
| 2211DApC | 0.82 | 10.830±0.127 | 206.180±4.095 | 24.512±0.743 | – | 60.313 | 181.23 | 36.8±0.6 | old method: pre-degassing | |
| 2211DApD | 0.31 | 12.593±0.188 | 272.219±4.710 | 31.500±1.123 | – | 77.926 | 81.50 | 29.4±0.4 | old method: pre-degassing | |
| 2022StDApA | 0.30 | 12.615±0.216 | 230.680±5.529 | 71.500±1.955 | – | 67.979 | 69.61 | 29.5±0.6 | old method: pre-degassing | |
| 011123DAp1 | 0.53 | 10.233±0.205 | 206.604±7.328 | 135.566±5.575 | 10.47±7.17 | 59.818 | 96.71 | 31.2±0.9 | | |
| 011123DAp2 | 0.58 | 10.892±0.116 | 200.372±5.387 | 126.983±5.017 | – | 58.982 | 107.43 | 32.2±0.7 | | |
| 011123DAp3 | 0.79 | 11.203±0.092 | 226.208±5.951 | 120.190±4.386 | – | 65.493 | 164.65 | 32.7±0.7 | | |
| 011423DAp1 | 0.93 | 9.901±0.107 | 196.551±5.118 | 133.065±4.774 | – | 57.073 | 165.93 | 32.2±0.7 | | |

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*(continued)*

| Sample | Mass (mg) | U (ppm) | Th (ppm) | Sm (ppm) | Zr (ppm) | eU (ppm) | $^4$He (ncc) | Age (Ma) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 011423DAp2 | 1.51 | 11.131±0.122 | 204.980±4.486 | 129.139±4.798 | – | 60.326 | 286.66 | 32.5±0.6 | |
| 011423DAp3 | 0.98 | 11.494±0.150 | 223.171±5.900 | 123.673±4.393 | – | 65.055 | 203.52 | 32.9±0.7 | |
| 011423DAp4 | 0.81 | 11.773±0.142 | 235.763±6.994 | 125.741±5.204 | 8.92±4.03 | 68.356 | 170.67 | 31.8±0.8 | |
| 062123DAp | 0.30 | 13.397±0.173 | 266.573±7.381 | 142.947±10.021 | 5.04±2.79 | 77.375 | 72.66 | 32.3±0.7 | |
| 062523DAp | 0.85 | 11.074±0.097 | 211.843±5.315 | 123.774±8.205 | 2.71±1.71 | 61.916 | 161.32 | 31.6±0.7 | |
| 062823DAp | – | – | – | – | – | – | 177.58 | 31.9±0.4 | |
| Average for > 0.5 mg | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | 32.1±0.2 | |
| **Gogebic Iron Range BIF Hematite Standard (MI-43; 571 Ma)** | | | | | | | | | |
| 2211HemMSA | 1.37 | 11.793±0.131 | 0.039±0.012 | 0.344±0.029 | – | 11.802 | 750.58 | 450.1±4.8 | |
| 2211HemMSB | 2.12 | 8.765±0.117 | 0.059±0.007 | 0.343±0.017 | – | 8.779 | 1070.17 | 554.8±7.0 | |
| 041323MG16a | 0.46 | 9.199±0.134 | 0.000±0.000 | 1.559±0.192 | – | 9.199 | 240.72 | 549.4±7.7 | |
| 041323MG16b | 0.49 | 2.153±0.057 | 0.089±0.083 | 0.866±0.154 | 19.36±5.03 | 2.174 | 188.74 | 1539.7±35.2 | |
| 041323MG16d | 0.28 | 11.281±0.193 | 0.000±0.000 | 1.548±0.344 | – | 11.281 | 174.28 | 531.8±8.3 | |
| 041323MG16e | 0.42 | 12.062±0.467 | 0.441±0.268 | 1.864±0.457 | 31.06±24.33 | 12.168 | 257.09 | 489.6±17.8 | |
| 062123MS | 0.32 | 10.072±0.102 | 0.000±0.260 | 1.808±0.101 | – | 10.072 | 187.09 | 561.8±5.5 | |
| 230625MSHm | 0.23 | 11.371±0.121 | 0.000±0.398 | 1.811±0.183 | – | 11.371 | 148.88 | 549.4±6.0 | |
| 230628MSHm | 0.42 | 9.747±0.111 | 0.000±0.204 | 1.633±0.167 | – | 9.747 | 244.96 | 579.5±6.4 | |

**Pyrite/Arsenopyrite U-Th/He Ages from Kidd Creek**

Twelve aliquots of Kidd Creek pyrite/arsenopyrite were dated by U-Th/He step-degassing (Table **??**) and give atmospherically corrected ages ranging from 465 to 860 Ma with the exception of one aliquot (011123KCPyST05C) that gives an older measured age of 1596 Ma (Fig. **??**). The mean age of the remaining eleven aliquots is 639 ± 36 Ma, 1$\sigma$. These dates are decisively older than the independent regional apatite cooling-age of 392 ± 32 Ma (Sturrock et al., 2024), yet far younger than the ∼2716 Ma age of the host rhyolite (Hannington et al., 1999) (§**??**).

**Arsenopyrite U-Th/He Ages from Gympie**

Sixteen aliquots of Gympie arsenopyrite were dated by the same method (Table **??**; Fig. **??**). The first four aliquots analyzed (013023PVGyPy-1 through -4) were prepared under an early iteration of the protocol that predated both the tube-blank atmospheric helium degassing step and the Parr-vessel HCl digestion step (§**??**) later adopted to fully dissolve fine U-Th-Sm-bearing rutile inclusions. The measured ages of these aliquots are unreasonable: ranging from 638 to 1008 Ma (mean 834 Ma, n=4), though it is unclear to what extent the bias is due to atmospheric contamination, incomplete digestion of rutile, or both. The ages of these four early aliquots are therefore considered unreliable and are excluded from further interpretation.

The remaining twelve Gympie aliquots, prepared after both protocol refinements were adopted, define a substantially younger and tighter age population. Eleven of these twelve give atmospherically corrected ages between 191 and 306 Ma (mean 258 ± 35 Ma, 1$\sigma$, n=11; these eleven are plotted in Fig. **??**). The twelfth, 0413PyGy-4, is a clear outlier at 623 Ma and is also anomalous in its measured 4He concentration (68.4 ncc/mg), roughly three times that of the next most helium-rich aliquot in the accepted Gympie suite (230628GyPyHClab, 21.65 ncc/mg: supplementary Fig. **??**). We interpret this combination as evidence for helium implantation from a U-Th-Sm-rich accessory phase concentrated at the sulfide grain margin and not fully digested during trace-element sample preparation. Aliquot 0413PyGy-4 is therefore also excluded from further interpretation.

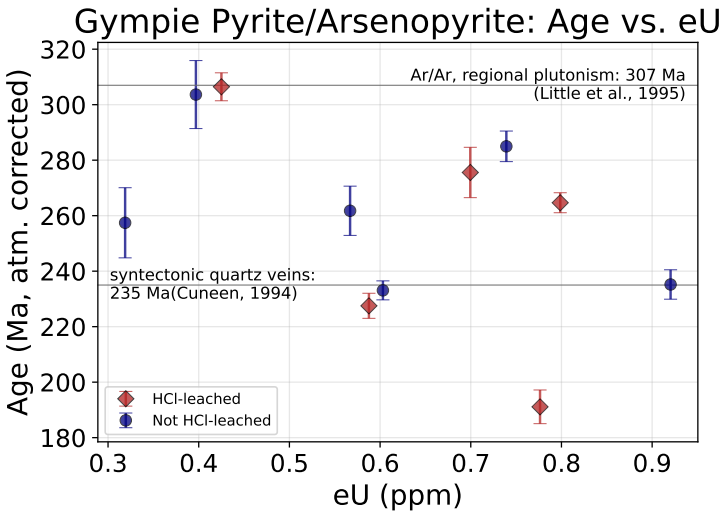



Figure 3.10: Atmospherically corrected age vs. eU for the eleven reliable, newer-protocol Gympie arsenopyrite aliquots (Table **??**), split by HCl-leaching. Reference lines mark the 235 Ma K/Ar syntectonic quartz-vein age (Cuneen, 1994; Holcombe et al., 1997) and the 307 Ma Ar/Ar regional plutonism age (Little et al., 1995). The four early-protocol aliquots and the 0413PyGy-4 outlier (§**??**) are excluded here; see Fig. **??** (SI) for the outlier.

## 3.4 Discussion

### Effectiveness of the Ampoule Method in Stabilizing Sulfides

The methodology for the heating treatments and SEM imagery of pyrite and arsenopyrite surfaces following thermal treatments in different conditions is discussed in §**??**. The SEM imagery reveals deformed, variably raised, ~10 µm cracked surfaces on pyrite and marcasite that are heated in open air, and for arsenopyrite heated in a closed capsule without a realgar buffer (Fig. **??**; Fig. **??**). Pyrite and marcasite samples that are heated in ultra-high vacuum developed recessive ~1 µm rounded craters (Fig. **??**). Contrarily, images of thermally treated, encapsulated pyrite and arsenopyrite with added fused sulfur or realgar show no obvious distinction from the control group: both of which showcase conchoidal fracture (Fig. **??**). The buffered, encapsulated marcasite sample shows a raised layer of angular (presumably pyrite) crystals growing atop its surface (Fig. **??**); evidence of phase transformation is present in all three heat-treated marcasite populations, demonstrating that the encapsulation method is not effective in preventing phase breakdown at elevated temperatures for marcasite. These experiments are not conclusive evidence that thermal phase transformation is prevented for pyrite or arsenopyrite (indeed, arsenopyrite's equilibrium stoichiometry varies with temperature, suggesting that some

reaction during step heats would be expected for this phase: Morimoto and Clark (1961) and Barton (1969)). However, the step heats presented here are consistent with the interpretation that reaction is suppressed, encouraging its application for helium step heat experiments.

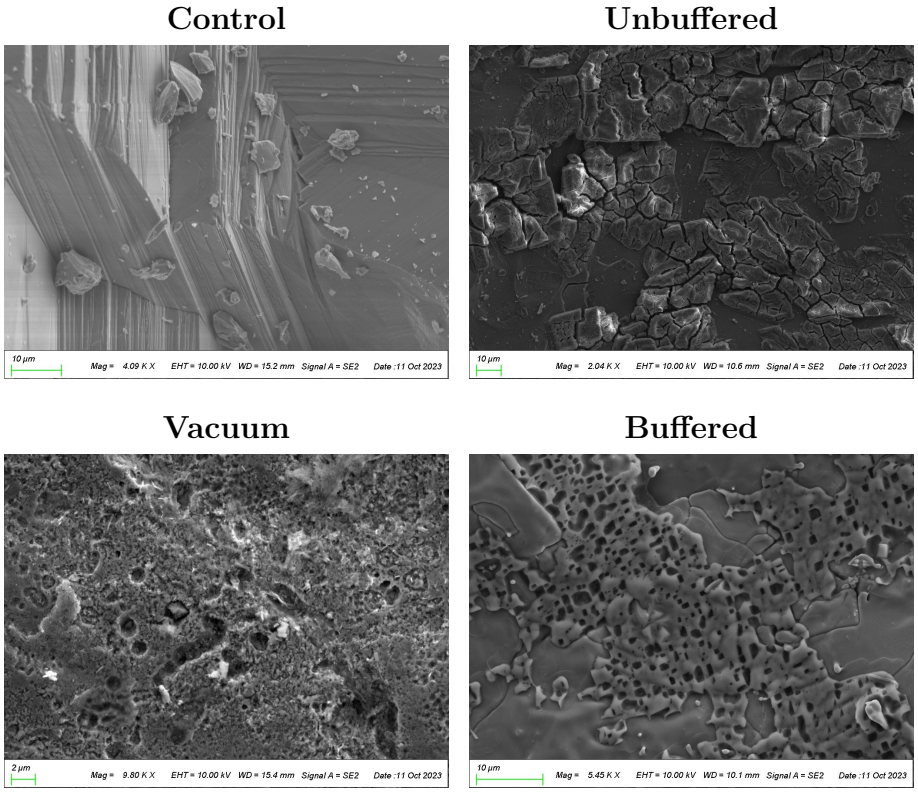



Figure 3.11: Secondary electron SEM images of marcasite surface textures before heat treatment (control) and after heat treatment unbuffered in open air (400°C, 5 hours), in ultra-high vacuum (400°C, 4.5 hours), and buffered (encapsulated in a silica glass ampoule with excess fused sulfur; 600°C, 8 hours). Unlike the buffered pyrite and arsenopyrite of Fig. **??**, which retain their control-group surface texture under equivalent encapsulated treatment, the buffered marcasite instead develops a raised layer of angular, presumably pyrite, crystals, indicating that encapsulation does not suppress phase breakdown for marcasite as it does for the other two sulfides. See the supplement §**??** for experimental methods and sample preparation.

### Remarkable Helium Retentivity of Pyrite and Arsenopyrite

The central finding of this chapter's step heat experiments (§**??**) is that pyrite (and to a lesser extent, arsenopyrite) are extraordinarily retentive of helium against thermal loss: cumulative fractional yields never exceeded 5% for any pyrite or arsenopyrite experiment, even after repeated heating cycles at tem-

peratures between 500-600 °C. These cumulative fractional yields are difficult to interpret without a reference diffusive timescale, so these step heat results are contextualized against the helium retentivity of other phases in Fig. **??**, placing the sulfides of this study on the same diffusive-dose axis as step heat experiments of several minerals reported here or independently well-characterized helium retentivity: single-crystal and polycrystalline hematite, vacuum- and hydrothermally-degassed goethite, zircon, and monazite. To do this, the activation energy of hematite from Farley (2018) is used to convert the time and temperature of each step heat into a cumulative diffusive time, expressed as a Fourier number ($Fo = \frac{D}{a^2}_{\text{ref}} t$). The Fourier number can also be thought of as a dimensionless diffusive time, real time divided by the diffusive timescale of a reference domain, $\tau = \frac{a^2}{D}$. $\tau$ here is referenced to a 1 $\mu$m single-crystal hematite domain. The aim of such a plot is to flatten complex heating histories into a single value so that phases with complex helium migration behavior can be compared on a common scale. Incontrovertibly, this is not strictly correct because the activation energies of different phases (and indeed diffusive domains within a single phase) are not identical; however, this plot preserves the relative ordering of phases regardless of the choice of reasonable activation energy: we tested 149-171 kJ/mol. Therefore, this plot is a useful tool for comparing the relative retentivity of different phases, even though the absolute diffusive dose is not strictly correct.

On this comparison, pyrite and arsenopyrite sit at or beyond the retentive extreme of the entire compilation. Both plot at diffusive doses orders of magnitude beyond where the reference 1 $\mu$m single-crystal hematite domain (Farley, 2018) has gone fully to completion, and beyond essentially the full range spanned by zircon (Guenthner et al., 2013), comparable to or exceeding that of monazite (Farley, 2007). The polycrystalline hematite and vacuum-degassed goethite aggregates, by contrast, sit orders of magnitude further to the left. The hydrothermally degassed goethite (Chapter **??**) plots closer to but less retentive than the sulfides here.

Taken together, this comparison indicates that sulfur-buffered, sulfide-encapsulated pyrite and arsenopyrite are not merely retentive relative to other sulfides (galena, chalcopyrite, chalcocite, sphalerite; §**??**), but are among the most helium-retentive phases yet characterized by step heating, on par with or exceeding zircon and monazite and substantially exceeding both single-crystal and

polycrystalline hematite and vacuum-degassed goethite. This is the empirical basis for treating pyrite (and, by extension, arsenopyrite) as a credible U-Th/He geochronometer in this chapter's Kidd Creek and Gympie case studies (§**??**, §**??**), notwithstanding complexities introduced by the inclusion-hosted origin of the radiogenic budget (§**??**).

### Inferring Bulk Helium Migration Behavior from Low Fractional Yields

Many of the step heats on encapsulated sulfides presented here show very high helium retentivity, and for those experiments only a very small fraction of the total yield evolved (<5% for the arsenopyrite and Rustenburg pyrite; <2% for the Leadville pyrite), similarly to previous work on highly helium retentive phases such as baddeleyite (Baughman and Flowers, 2018). For these sulfides, a mechanism responsible for bulk helium loss besides desulfurization cannot be identified. For some well-studied phases like zircon and titanite, Arrhenius plots of the earliest fractions of evolved helium often reflect processes or conditions that are accessory to the bulk mechanism for helium migration through the mineral, such as radiation damage annealing or surface roughness (Reiners and Farley, 1999; Guenthner et al., 2013), where the primary mechanism for helium migration through the pristine mineral is volume diffusion. These apparent departures from the bulk helium migration behavior can be caused by properties of natural samples, like surface roughness or fine-scale cracks and fractures (Reiners and Farley, 1999) that produce complex grain size distributions even in carefully sieved, (apparently) single grains. Contrastingly, some other complexities in the helium loss behavior at early loss fractions can be ephemeral and altered during experimental heating, such as the annealing of radiation damage (Shuster and Farley, 2009). For radiation damaged samples, understanding the migration behavior of helium before and during annealing is essential to understand the sample's retentivity in nature and therefore the earliest fraction of helium evolved in step heats is the focus of many studies (Shuster and Farley, 2009; Flowers, Ketcham, et al., 2009; Flowers, Shuster, et al., 2007; Shuster, Flowers, et al., 2006).

The fraction of total helium evolved before the predominant migration mechanism's behavior can be characterized in helium step heats varies: Guenthner et al. (2013) show that significantly non-zero delta or ln(r/r0) values persist in zircon until about 2% of the total helium is degassed for typical natural

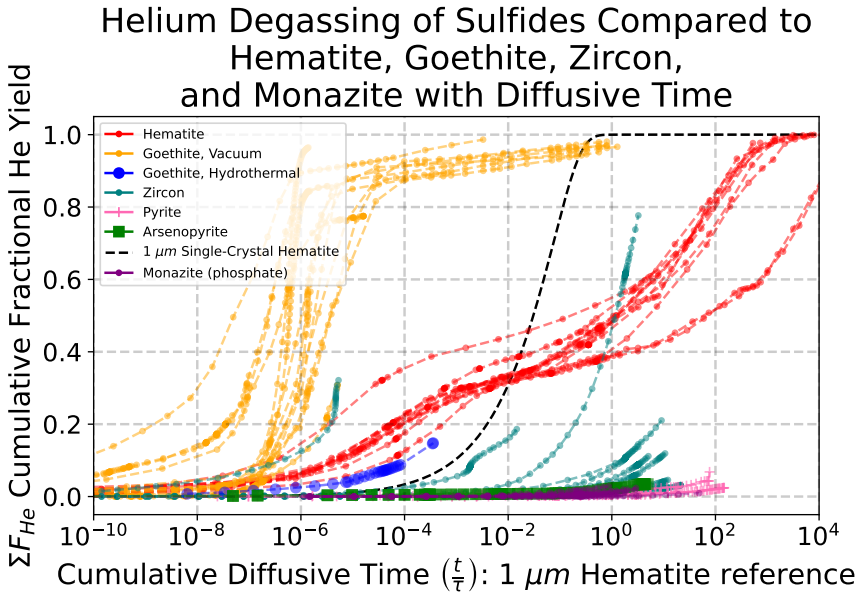



Figure 3.12: Cumulative fractional He yield vs. cumulative diffusive time (Fourier number, $Fo = D_{\text{ref}}t/a^2_{\text{ref}}$) for each heating step of every experiment plotted, referenced to a common 1 $\mu$m single-crystal hematite domain diffusivity (Farley, 2018) ($\ln(D_0/a^2) = 0.66$, $E_a = 171$ kJ/mol). Expressing step power this way, rather than as raw time or temperature, puts experiments run under very different heating schedules, temperatures, and durations onto one common, directly comparable dose axis: a phase reaching a given cumulative yield only at a much larger $Fo$ is more helium-retentive than one reaching the same yield at a smaller $Fo$, regardless of how either was actually heated. Because cumulative fractional yield is dimensionless, isotope-specific normalization is not required to combine step heats of different helium isotopes on one axis: $^3$He step heats of proton-irradiated pyrite, arsenopyrite, zircon, monazite, and vacuum-degassed hematite/goethite are plotted alongside $^4$He step heats of the (non-irradiated, isotope-dilution-quantified) Rustenburg pyrite and the hydrothermally degassed goethite. Plotted data: this chapter's own sulfur-buffered pyrite and arsenopyrite step heats; 11 vacuum step heat aliquots of polycrystalline hematite from the Grand Canyon, Arizona (Farley and Flowers, 2012) and the Gogebic Range, Michigan (Farley and McKeon, 2015); 9 vacuum step heat aliquots of polycrystalline goethite (Win-06-01b and Capão, Minas Gerais, Brazil) (H. Monteiro, 2017; Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024); the hydrothermal step heat of Win-06-01b goethite from Chapter **??** of this dissertation; and proton-irradiated zircon (Guenthner et al., 2013) and synthetic monazite (Farley, 2007) step heats. The dashed black reference curve is the forward-diffusion cumulative-yield curve for the reference 1 $\mu$m hematite domain itself (i.e. $Fo$ vs. its own resulting cumulative yield, with no data plotted against it), included so every other curve's retentivity can be read directly relative to this single benchmark.

samples; Reiners and Farley (1999) observe apparent diffusivities of helium in titanite converging to linearity after 5% of the total helium is evolved. Similar experiments on proton-irradiated synthetic samples seem not to be marred by the same complexities: helium step heat data for synthetic monazite converge nearly immediately to a linear array at very low cumulative helium loss fractions (Farley, 2007).

The step heat experiments on pyrite and arsenopyrite in this study would have benefitted from longer steps at high temperature to degas more helium to better understand the bulk behavior of helium, but even at small loss fractions some key observations about helium loss in sulfides can be made.

**Comparison of Helium Step Heat Experiments of Natural Pyrites**

In this work, four encapsulated, sulfur-buffered aliquots of pyrite taken from two localities are subjected to helium step heat experiments. Step heats for the three irradiated pyrites from Leadville, CO are broadly similar, but contrast markedly from step heats of non-irradiated pyrite from Rustenburg, South Africa; therefore, differences between pyrites of different localities are discussed before the variation within the aliquots from Leadville, CO.

Radiogenic helium evolution during step heats of octahedral pyrite from Rustenburg, South Africa shows that this sample is less retentive than the pyritohedral pyrite from Leadville, Colorado (Fig. **??**). Apparent diffusivities of these samples also have fundamentally distinct geometries when plotted in an Arrhenius plot. The Rustenburg pyrite shows a striking feature of very steep slopes (corresponding to an activation energy of $300.6 \pm 7.3$ kJ/mol) on retrograde-prograde heating cycles at temperatures lower than the previous maximum temperature step heat, whereas the maximum apparent diffusivity for a given temperature seemed to follow a much shallower slope, similar to the lower activation energy of the Leadville, CO pyrite: $199.1 \pm 3.5$ kJ/mol. The geometry of the step heats in an Arrhenius plot for the irradiated Leadville, CO pyrite is generally simpler: generally slowly decreasing in a delta plot, or for isothermal steps (Fig. **??**) as would be expected for helium release governed by MDD systematics (Farley, 2018).

Natural pyrite is known to develop fractures and crystalline dislocations in metamorphic and experimental conditions (Gill, 1969; McClay and Ellis, 1983; Barrie et al., 2011). Abundant fractures of micron-scale widths were clearly

visible in the Rustenburg pyrite of this study (Fig. **??**). Those pyrites were surprisingly easy to crush, presumably breaking easily along fine pre-existing fractures. Although pyrites from Leadville are known to be associated with faulted dolomites, especially along deformation planes which likely served as pathways for mineralizing hydrothermal fluids (Nash, 1979), the samples used here were exceptionally sturdy and visually homogeneous under SEM. Rare veins and coatings of dolomite within and around the pyrites were present but were avoided when preparing the sample for irradiation.

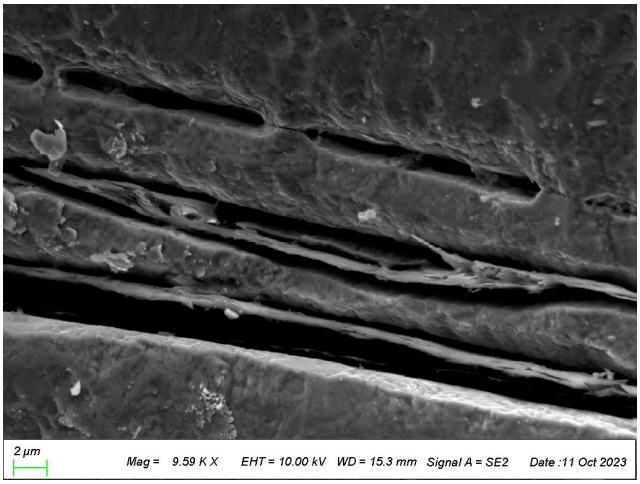



Figure 3.13: Secondary-electron SEM image of Rustenburg (Bushveld Complex) pyrite prior to heat treatment (control), showing the pervasive, micron-scale fractures characteristic of this sample (§**??**). These pre-existing fractures are interpreted as the pathways for the short-circuit helium diffusion mechanism invoked below to explain the Rustenburg pyrite's distinct retrograde Arrhenius behavior (Fig. **??**).

Within this work, a pipe/short-circuit diffusion mechanism (Lee and Aldama, 1992) is favored to explain the helium loss behavior of the Rustenburg pyrite, where helium populates the sample's fine fractures at increasing temperatures due to the primary helium migration mechanism, perhaps volume diffusion through crystalline pyrite. This primary mechanism is interpreted to be the same for all pyrite samples regardless of locality. On retrograde heating steps, short-circuit diffusion of helium out of fine fractures in the Rustenburg pyrite is hypothesized to become the rate-limiting process.

**Leadville, CO Pyrite: Evidence for a Grain Size Control?**

Three helium step heat experiments for the irradiated Leadville, CO pyrite are discussed here. Grain size was varied by a factor of 2 between a half-prism width

of 200 microns for LVCOPy230630 and 400 microns for BigLVCOPy230707 to investigate the dependence of grain size on helium migration in pyrite. The aim of the third experiment, 112123LVCOPyIrr, was to test the effect of isolating the pyrite from the liquid sulfur during the experiment to investigate the role of dissolution and (re)crystallization of pyrite by the ampoule's sulfur fluid. Silica glass shards were added to this ampoule below and above the pyrite aliquot, forcing the pyrite grains to remain in the middle of the ampoule, and not at the edges/bottom, where sulfur liquid is presumed to accumulate. All three samples overlap in their Arrhenius plots (Fig. **??**), and all three samples record declining diffusivities consistent with MDD systematics (Fig. **??**). The larger grained aliquot recorded lower cumulative fractional yields at these common apparent diffusivities. The smaller grained aliquots: LVCOPy230630 and 112123LVCOPyIrr have essentially identical delta plots (Fig. **??**), providing no evidence for a sulfur-liquid control in driving helium loss for these experiments.

Very little helium was evolved from any of the exceptionally retentive Leadville pyrite samples: none evolved more than 3% of its cumulative fractional yield, in spite of the intense heating schedules (at temperatures up to 600°C) they were subjected to. These samples are only resolved by grain size. Because all Arrhenius plots overlap, it is likely that the differences in the delta plots are due to the relative abundance of the smallest domain size: the smaller aliquots contained a greater proportion of the least retentive domains interrogated by these experiments. One potential explanation is that only helium on extraordinarily small dusty material carried on the surfaces of the larger aliquots is degassed, and thus the primary control on the delta plot is the surface area to volume ratio. This is consistent with the observation that the smaller aliquots, with half the half prism width half that of the larger aliquot, record $\Delta$=0 at twice the cumulative fractional yield of the larger aliquot (Fig. **??**).

### Relevance of Helium Step Heat Data of Encapsulated, Sulfur-Buffered Sulfides in Nature

Given the high helium retention of pyrite and arsenopyrite shown in this work, thermal helium loss in nature may be rare. A more likely mechanism for helium loss in these common sulfides in nature may indeed be recrystallization. Pyrite in metamorphic conditions commonly recrystallizes and may either shrink or grow (Craig et al., 1998; McClay and Ellis, 1983). Until more work has

characterized helium loss (or gain) for recrystallizing pyrite or arsenopyrite in metamorphic conditions, helium should cautiously be considered to have behaved as an open or partially open system in sulfides during metamorphic events, although O. Yakubovich, Podolskaya, et al. (2020) report that helium in the Uzelga pyrite was retained through metamorphism.

**Arsenopyrite**

Arsenopyrite (FeAsS) adopts a distorted, lower-symmetry variant of the marcasite structure in which arsenic substitutes irregularly for sulfur (Morimoto and Clark, 1961), in contrast to pyrite's simple cubic lattice. Because the degree of distortion scales with arsenic content (Morimoto and Clark, 1961), Helium diffusion is likewise expected to vary with composition. Unfortunately, equilibrium arsenopyrite composition is not itself fixed: arsenic content increases systematically with formation temperature (Barton, 1969; Morimoto and Clark, 1961), so the same crystal-chemical property expected to govern helium retentivity should also vary with an arsenopyrite sample's thermal history, complicating any attempt to generalize helium retentivity from a single experimental aliquot to arsenopyrite as a mineral species. Similarly, the composition of the arsenopyrite subjected to step heats herein may itself have varied composition during the experiment, further abstractifying these experimental results from helium loss from arsenopyrite in nature.

With that caveat, the step heat results obtained here (§**??**) show the encapsulated arsenopyrite experiment was less helium-retentive than the Leadville pyrite experiments of this study, and it lacking a well-defined linear Arrhenius region. Still, arsenopyrite remained markedly more retentive of helium than any other sulfide examined in this study besides pyrite, in agreement with the relative helium retentivity ranking of sulfides reported by O. V. Yakubovich, Gedz, et al. (2019).

Qualitatively, arsenopyrite appears to be more retentive of helium than most zircon (Fig. **??**, Guenthner et al. (2013)).

**Thermal Helium Migration Systematics for Other Sulfides**

Discussion of the thermal helium migration systematics of the four remaining, non-pyrite/arsenopyrite sulfides of this study (chalcopyrite, chalcocite, sphalerite, and galena) is given in the Supplementary Information (§**??**); neither copper sulfide nor galena is considered a promising U-Th/He geochronometer

or helium isotope target.

**Origin of Radiogenic Helium in Sulfides**

The pyrite and arsenopyrite of this study are not, themselves, appreciably radiogenic minerals. Pyrite in particular has very little affinity for U, Th, or Sm, which are large, highly charged cations poorly suited to substitution for $Fe^{2+}$. Consistent with this, only the aliquots (of any locality or mineral in the compilation, main text or SI) that host measurable U-Th-Sm-bearing accessory phases returned appreciable eU and, correspondingly, appreciable radiogenic 4He. For example, the Leadville pyrite samples are purest, most visually inclusion-free grains selected for the sulfur- buffered step heat experiments of §**??**, and they are essentially non-radiogenic. The U-Th/He ages for sulfides may not date growth of the sulfide lattice directly, even if it is perfectly retentive of helium, because some of the helium retentivity of the sample will be determined by the size, mode, and connectivity of inclusions. Sulfide ages are easiest to interpret for the case when the radiogenic helium-source inclusions are smaller than 10 microns across, when only the helium retentivity of the sulfide is significant (Fig. **??**).

Backscattered-electron imagery of the Kidd Creek arsenopyrite/pyrite directly shows a surprising abundance of apatite inclusions. Superficially, hand-picked crystals appear as optically clean, blocky euhedral crystals set within a finer silicate groundmass (Fig. **??**), but in cross-section the same grains are pervasively spongy, riddled with abundant tiny inclusions rather than being the pure, homogeneous pyrite their exteriors suggest. These inclusions are dominantly apatite (Figs. **??**, **??**), ranging in size from sub-6 micron grains at the limit of SEM resolution up to ∼30 micron half-width. Because apatite preferentially incorporates U, Th, and especially Sm relative to coexisting sulfide and silicate phases, even a small volume fraction of included apatite can dominate a pyrite aliquot's bulk eU budget and, correspondingly, its radiogenic 4He production.

The Gympie arsenopyrite hosts a texturally distinct, but analogously inclusion-hosted, radiogenic budget. SEM imagery (Fig. **??**) shows abundant fine, needle-like rutile inclusions. These rutile are the most likely U-Th-Sm-He source for the Gympie samples, and variable inheritance of older rutile engulfed by later sulfide may be responsible for its observed age dispersion (§**??**).

This inclusion-host origin of radiogenic helium in sulfides has a direct method-

ological consequence: sulfide U-Th/He geochronology cannot be treated as a single, generic protocol applied uniformly across localities. The identity, size distribution, and digestion behavior of the accessory phase or phases actually carrying the U-Th-Sm budget are properties of each deposit's own mineral paragenesis, and differ sharply even between the two localities studied here. Reliable sulfide U-Th/He geochronology of a new locality therefore requires SEM characterization of the dated material to identify its radiogenic inclusion population before analysis, and a dissolution protocol tailored to that population's specific mineralogy and grain size.

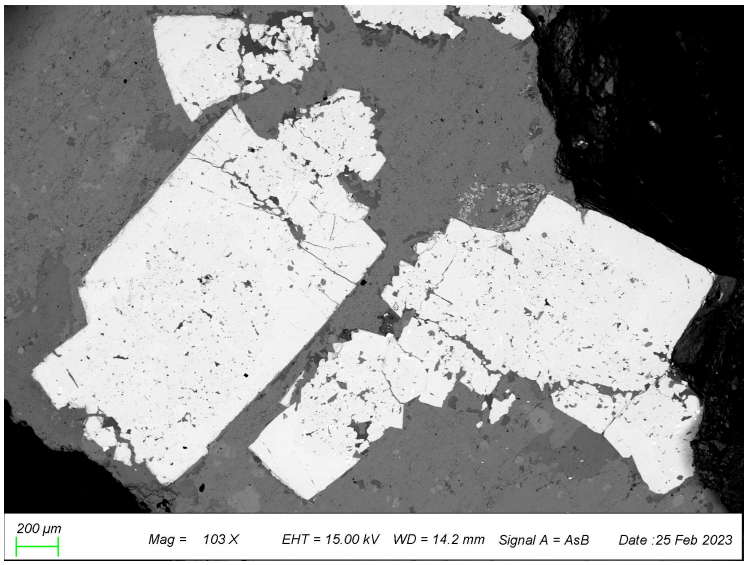



Figure 3.14: Backscattered-electron image of Kidd Creek pyrite (ST05) in cross-section: optically clean, blocky euhedral grains set within a finer-grained groundmass are, internally, spongy and riddled with abundant tiny (predominantly apatite) inclusions rather than homogeneous pyrite.

**Interpretation of Kidd Creek Pyrite/Arsenopyrite Ages: Mixing Between a Retentive, He-Th-Poor Host and Apatite Inclusions**

The Kidd Creek pyrite/arsenopyrite ages are not scattered randomly around some single "true" age. Eleven of the twelve dated aliquots define a coherent array in which the Th- and He-richest aliquots give the youngest ages and the Th- and He-poorest aliquots give the oldest, ranging from 465 to 860 Ma (Fig. **??**). The youngest of the eleven approach, but are always higher than, the $392 \pm 32$ Ma regional apatite (U-Th)/He cooling age reported by Sturrock et al. (2024) for sample 01-OE-69, sampled only ∼90 km from Kidd Creek; the oldest approach ∼860 Ma, implying that this population is significantly more

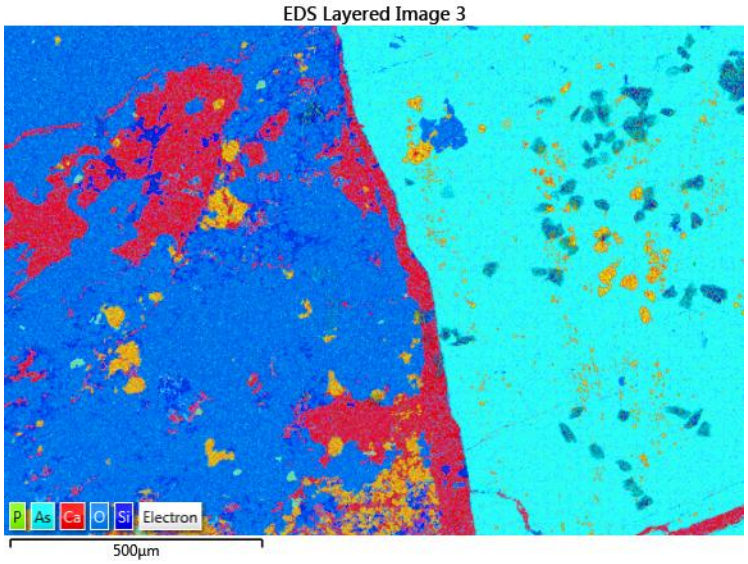



Figure 3.15: Backscattered-electron image of Kidd Creek pyrite showing apatite inclusions, the dominant host of the aliquots' U-Th-Sm budget.

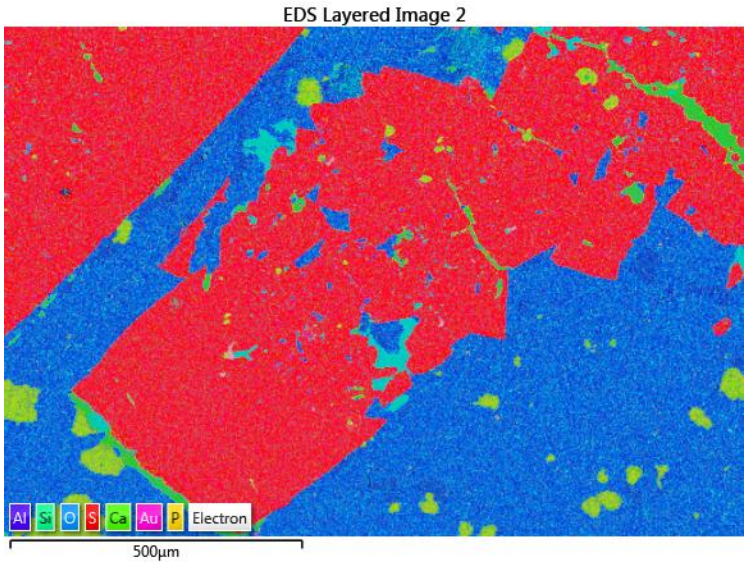



Figure 3.16: Backscattered-electron image of apatite inclusions in Kidd Creek pyrite, ranging from sub-6 micron grains up to ∼30 micron half-width.

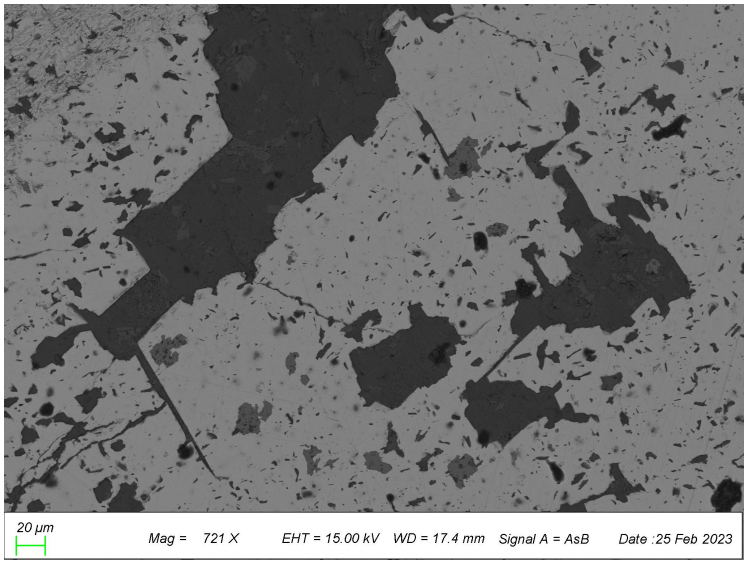



Figure 3.17: Backscattered-electron image of Gympie pyrite showing abundant fine, needle-like rutile inclusions and much larger, blocky feldspar inclusions. Ineffective rutile digestion is implicated in the anomalously old ages discussed in §**??**.

helium-retentive than the apatite it includes.

Given the inclusion-hosted origin of radiogenic helium established above (§**??**), the natural reading of this array is a two-component mixture: an old end-member that is essentially He-Th-poor but comparatively retentive, and a population of included apatite with a much younger (∼392 Ma) cooling age (Sturrock et al., 2024). A Kidd Creek aliquot's bulk age then falls between these two end-members depending on what fraction of its total measured Th and He budget was hosted in (and retained by) apatite inclusions since 392 Ma, versus alpha-ejected into the surrounding, retentive sulfide host and retained there since it was crystallized.

A simple model shows that lower age paired with higher Th and He can be explained with a single-age apatite population of variable inclusion size. Fig. **??** extends the alpha-ejection retention framework of §**??** to compute the apparent bulk He age of a hypothetically perfectly helium-retentive sulfide aliquot hosting a single apatite inclusion of half-prism radius $R$, assuming the sulfide and apatite crystallized 2700 Ma ago, but the apatite itself only began retaining its own self-implanted helium after 380 Ma. At small $R$, nearly all the produced helium recoils out of the inclusion into the retentive sulfide, and the aliquot's bulk age approaches the old, 2700 Ma crystallization age, but at

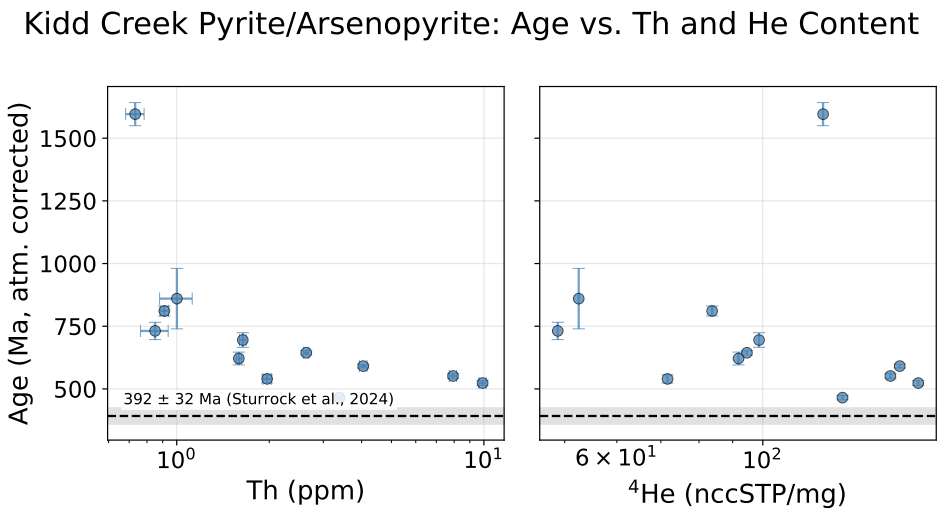



Figure 3.18: Atmospherically corrected Kidd Creek pyrite/arsenopyrite age vs. Th content (left) and vs. measured 4He content (right; nccSTP/mg), sharing a common age axis (§**??**). The shaded band is the independent regional apatite cooling-age estimate of 392 ± 32 Ma for sample 01-OE-69 (Sturrock et al., 2024). Both panels show the same sense of anti-correlation: Th- and He-rich aliquots give younger ages, Th- and He-poor aliquots give older ages.

large $R$, an increasing fraction of the inclusion's own production is retained within the apatite inclusion itself, so the bulk age falls toward 380 Ma. Because a larger inclusion also simply contains more total U-Th-Sm mass, the same increase in $R$ that drives the age down simultaneously drives up an aliquot's bulk Th and He content, producing exactly the anti-correlation seen in Fig. **??**.

At the ≤30 $\mu$m half-width apatite inclusion size actually observed in the Kidd Creek material (§**??**, Fig. **??**), Fig. **??** predicts an apparent age of ∼1.6 Ga or older for a sulfide host that is perfectly closed to helium loss over its entire 2.7 Gyr history. Eleven of the twelve measured Kidd Creek ages, plotted at this inclusion size in Fig. **??**, fall far short of this prediction. This model cannot produce ages as young as 465-860 Ma, so most of these sulfides must have lost a substantial fraction of their radiogenic helium since crystallization, rather than behaving as a closed system simply mixing with variably sized apatite inclusions.

The twelfth, oldest aliquot, 011123KCPyST05C, is the one exception: its 1596 ± 46 Ma age sits close to the closed-system prediction above at the observed ∼30 $\mu$m inclusion size, as though this one aliquot alone retained essentially all of its radiogenic and inclusion-sourced helium since crystallization

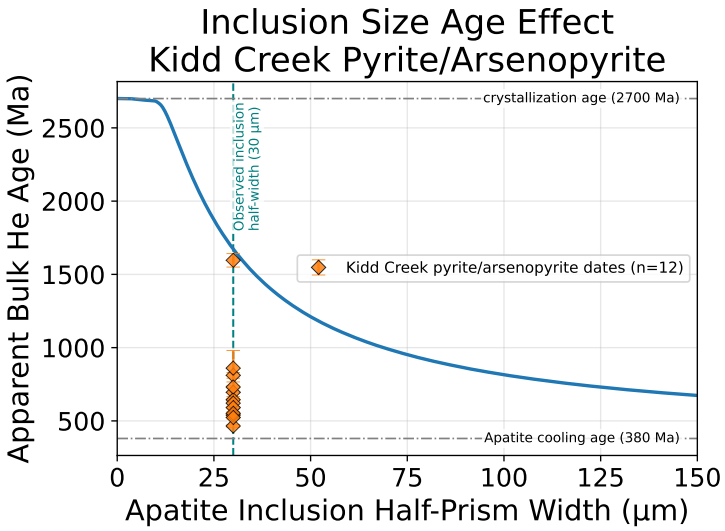



Figure 3.19: Modeled apparent bulk He age of a quantitatively He-retentive, 2.7 Ga Kidd Creek sulfide aliquot hosting a single fluorapatite inclusion serving as its U-Th-Sm source. The apparent age of such a system is a function of the inclusion's half-prism radius $R$. The alpha-ejection retention fraction $F_t(R)$ (fraction of produced helium self-implanted within the inclusion) is computed via a Monte Carlo simulation of $10^6$ decays uniformly distributed by volume within a spherical inclusion with isotropic alpha-ejection directions, using per-isotope ($^{238}$U, $^{235}$U, $^{232}$Th, $^{147}$Sm) stopping distances for fluorapatite and a fixed U:Th:Sm ratio of 1:2:2. This reproduces Farley, Wolf, et al. (1996)'s closed-form retention factor for $R \geq S$ (the stopping distance) and remains accurate for $R < S$, where the closed form is not valid. Helium is then accumulated separately for the inclusion-retained fraction $F_t(R)$, assuming retention only since 380 Ma, and the sulfide-retained fraction $1 - F_t(R)$, assuming retention since a 2700 Ma inclusion/host source age. The two helium contributions are summed to calculate a single apparent bulk age. Reference lines mark the 2700 Ma source age and 380 Ma cooling age end-members. A vertical line marks the maximum ~30 $\mu$m half-width apatite inclusion size actually observed at Kidd Creek (Fig. **??**). Eleven of the twelve pyrite/arsenopyrite ages fall well below the model's closed-system prediction, but the oldest age (011123KCPyST05C, $1596 \pm 46$ Ma) agrees with the model prediction (§**??**).

while the rest of the suite lost helium over time. A single old date is weak evidence for anything on its own: an anomalously old U-Th/He age is also the expected signature of incomplete acid digestion, which would leave some U-Th-Sm-bearing residue undissolved, overestimating the apparent age. We cannot distinguish between these two explanations with the data at hand.

This chapter's own step heat experiments show that sulfur-buffered pyrite is consistently among the most helium-retentive phases measured with step heat experiments, while arsenopyrite, though still strongly retentive, is notably less so (Fig. **??**, Fig. **??**; §**??**). If 011123KCPyST05C were confirmed to be closer to pure pyrite than the rest of the Kidd Creek suite, this retentivity contrast would offer a ready explanation for why it alone approaches closed-system behavior. Indeed, the arsenic measurement (Table **??**) supports this interpretation: 011123KCPyST05C has the lowest measured arsenic concentration of the Kidd Creek aliquots. Unfortunately, this study's arsenic measurements for both the Kidd Creek and Gympie sulfides are not reliable: they are inconsistent with observations of optical habit during sample picking, and they do not agree with estimates of arsenopyrite content implied by mass balance using sample mass and measured Fe.

Whether the rest of the suite's helium loss was thermal or accompanied recrystallization is similarly unclear, but recrystallization seems the less likely explanation, since the most recent regional metamorphic event that could have recrystallized these sulfide porphyroblasts predates 2.6 Ga (Smith et al., 1993; Hannington et al., 1999), well before the 465-860 Ma ages recorded here.

**Arsenopyrite U-Th/He Ages for Gympie Gold Belt**

There is no obvious difference in the geochronological sulfide U-Th-Sm/He data between the HCl leached and non-leached Gympie arsenopyrite populations (Fig. **??**), thus we interpret leaching to be a harmless but unnecessary step in the Gympie arsenopyrite U-Th/He geochronology protocol. This step was originally intended to remove any potential surface contamination, but these data do not support that the scatter in age is related to surface contamination. It is more likely that the scatter in age is related to the variable sizes and interconnectivity of inclusions, which could affect the sulfide's helium retentivity.

Lithostratigraphic age constraints that rely on foraminifera microfossils seem to suggest an Early Permian age for the Gympie Group rocks that host the

gold-vein systems (§**??**, Holcombe et al. (1997)). However, the oldest ages reported here are indeed resolvably older than the inferred Early Permian upper bound, instead suggesting that the mineralized volcanic pile may be of Carboniferous age. Indeed, these biostratigraphic constraints are sparse and rest mainly on correlation higher in the sequence rather than direct radiometric dates on the volcanic pile itself, and Holcombe et al. (1997) note that the lower Gympie Block volcanics "may contain older volcanic units." The data here support the latter interpretation.

The oldest Gympie ages are interpreted as a record of hydrothermal alteration of the Gympie Block volcanics contemporaneous with ∼300-310 Ma regional granitoid magmatism (§**??**, Little et al. (1995) and Holcombe et al. (1997)). Because the rutile inclusions identified as the U-Th-Sm source in the Gympie arsenopyrite (§**??**) are small (≤20 µm, Fig. **??**), they would self-implant little of their own produced helium, and thus the measured dates cannot be explained by rutile inheritance before a hypothetical sulfide crystallization event at ∼235 Ma (Cuneen, 1994; Holcombe et al., 1997). Thus, the arsenopyrites likely crystallized at or before ∼306 Ma, well before the Au-quartz mineralization event at ∼235 Ma. It is possible that the rutile population predates ∼306 Ma, and only started retaining helium after being incorporated into the sulfide hosts, permitting the volcanic pile's emplacement age to be older than the oldest sulfide ages. We prefer the interpretation that the sulfide crystallized contemporaneously with metasomatism related to the ∼300-310 Ma regional granitoid magmatism because it is more feasible that such large sulfides would be metasomatic rather than magmatic in origin. Therefore, the volcanic pile was likely emplaced sometime before ∼306 Ma. Aside from a single young outlier, the youngest Gympie sulfide ages reported here are contemporaneous with the syntectonic Au-mineralization event at ∼235 Ma (Cuneen, 1994; Holcombe et al., 1997), which we interpret to represent the timing of a recrystallization event for some of the sulfides. At the very least, it is somewhat remarkable that the sulfide U-Th/He ages demonstrate that most samples retained helium through the ∼235 Ma hydrothermal event.

Under this interpretation, the eleven reliable Gympie ages (§**??**) record variable, partial resetting of the ∼300-310 Ma population during the ∼235 Ma hydrothermal mineralizing event, rather than multiple discrete sulfide generations.

The one clear exception is 062123GyPyHClb, at 191 Ma, the youngest age

in the suite, and the only one below the ∼235 Ma mineralization age itself. A partial-resetting model bounded between a ∼306 Ma inclusion age and a ∼235 Ma resetting event cannot, on its own, produce an age younger than 235 Ma, so this aliquot requires additional explanation. One speculative possibility is that this particular aliquot's U-Th-Sm-rich inclusions sat near or on the surface of the sulfide grains, and thus some of the radiogenic helium was implanted elsewhere and not measured in the aliquot. Some Gympie samples contain coarser alkali feldspar inclusions identified alongside the rutile (Fig. **??**). If there were rutile crystals at the interface of the sulfide and the feldspar, then some of the rutiles' radiogenic helium may have been implanted into the feldspar and lost over geologic time, since feldspar is not normally considered a particularly helium-retentive phase (Hurley and Goodman, 1941). In any case, we point out that this single age is only one of eleven, and therefore seems to be the exception rather than the rule.

## 3.5 Conclusions

Sulfide geochronology has so far relied almost entirely on the Re-Os system, which is compositionally restricted to a handful of phases and analytically restricted to a few specialized laboratories (§**??**). This chapter tested whether U-Th/He dating of pyrite and arsenopyrite can serve as an accessible complement to Re-Os geochronology through two lenses: direct application to two independently age-constrained deposits at Kidd Creek and Gympie (§**??**), and a set of sulfur-buffered helium step heat experiments designed to characterize the underlying diffusion and migration behavior of helium in pyrite, arsenopyrite, galena, and chalcopyrite.

The step heat experiments show that pyrite and arsenopyrite are remarkably helium-retentive against thermal loss: cumulative fractional yields never exceeded 5% for any pyrite or arsenopyrite experiment, and never exceeded 2% for the undeformed Leadville pyrite specifically, even after repeated heating cycles up to 600°C (§**??**). Placed on a common diffusive-dose axis against independently characterized phases, pyrite and arsenopyrite sit at or beyond the retentive extreme of the compilation, on par with or exceeding zircon and monazite and substantially exceeding hematite and goethite (Fig. **??**). Arsenopyrite is less retentive than pyrite, consistent with its lower-symmetry, arsenic-bearing structure (§**??**), but is similarly retentive to zircon and markedly more retentive than galena or the copper sulfides, which are not considered

promising U-Th/He targets (§**??**).

The step heat data also point to two distinct helium-loss pathways within pyrite itself. Deformed, fractured Rustenburg pyrite shows steep, retrograde-dependent Arrhenius behavior best explained by a short-circuit or pipe-diffusion pathway along pre-existing fractures (Lee and Aldama, 1992), whereas the visually homogeneous, irradiated Leadville pyrite follows a simpler, shallower-sloped trend consistent with multiple-domain volume diffusion (§**??**). Varying grain size and sulfur-liquid contact within the Leadville suite did not resolve a clear control on this behavior beyond a surface-area-driven nugget effect, in which smaller aliquots simply carry a larger proportion of fine pyrite dust (§**??**).

Applied to natural samples, the U-Th/He ages obtained here are not simple crystallization or cooling ages. Eleven of twelve Kidd Creek pyrite/arsenopyrite aliquots give ages of 465-860 Ma (mean 639 ± 36 Ma, 1$\sigma$, n=11), decisively younger than the ∼2716 Ma host rhyolite (Hannington et al., 1999) but older than the regional 392 ± 32 Ma apatite cooling age (Sturrock et al., 2024); the twelfth instead gives a much older, 1596 ± 46 Ma age. Gympie arsenopyrite ages 191-306 Ma (mean 258 ± 35 Ma, 1$\sigma$, n=11; §**??**). Except for a single young outlier, these ages are bracketed the regional ∼300-310 Ma magmatic episode and the ∼235 Ma gold-vein mineralizing event (§**??**), and thus the sulfides are interpreted to have crystallized during metasomatism related to regional plutonism at ∼306 Ma, then variably reset by the final mineralizing event at ∼235 Ma.

Neither pyrite nor arsenopyrite itself hosts appreciable U or Th, instead relying on U-Th-Sm-bearing accessory inclusions to supply the sulfide hosts' alpha-emitters and radiogenic helium: apatite at Kidd Creek, rutile at Gympie. The helium from small, dispersed inclusions is implanted entirely within the sulfide host (and is thus subject to the sulfide's own helium retentivity), but larger inclusions will partially self-implant, complicating the interpretation of the sulfide U-Th-Sm/He ages (§**??**). At Kidd Creek, a simple nugget-effect model explains the anti-correlation between age and Th/He content among the eleven-aliquot array, but the observed sizes of the apatite inclusions are too small to explain ages this young if this population behaved as a closed system: most of it must have experienced helium loss during its long history. The twelfth, oldest aliquot is instead consistent with the closed-system prediction

at the observed inclusion size, though this rests on a single measurement that could equally reflect incomplete sample digestion rather than a genuinely more retentive phase (§**??**).

Together, these results support pyrite and arsenopyrite U-Th/He dating as a viable complement to Re-Os geochronology in multistage sulfide systems, but only once the identity and grain size of the actual radiogenic host phase are established for a given locality (§**??**): no single digestion protocol can be assumed to transfer between deposits. Extending this framework to the other sulfide-hosted geochronometers proposed in §**??**, and to a wider range of deposits than the two tested here, remains the natural next step.

# Supplementary Information

for Chapter 3: *(U-Th-Sm)/He Sulfide Geochronology*

## 3.1s Chalcopyrite, Chalcocite, Galena, and Sphalerite Step Heat Results and Discussion

This section reports the step heat results and discussion for the two non-pyrite/arsenopyrite sulfides of this study – the copper sulfides chalcopyrite (CCpTS230630) and chalcocite (CCT230707), and galena (GalTS230630) – moved here from the main text because neither mineral is a promising U-Th/He geochronometer or helium isotope target, and neither is otherwise part of this chapter's main narrative (Table 1 in the main text still lists all nine step heat experiments, including these three, for completeness).

### Results

### Chalcocite and Chalcopyrite

Step heat data step heat experiments for chalcopyrite (CCpTS230630) and chalcocite (CCT230707) produced macroscopic evidence of phase transformation, including the development of an iridescent blue sulfide or oxide layer on both specimens and dramatic crystal growth on the ampoule walls for the chalcocite experiment. Although permeation lag was not sufficiently constrained to calculate apparent diffusivities for the chalcocite experiment, the data for CCT230707 are consistent with a primary phase-breakdown control of helium migration at temperatures $\leq$300°C. These step heat data therefore do not bear on the helium retentivity of copper sulfides.

A linear regression is fit to 9 measurements defining a linear region of the Arrhenius plot of chalcopyrite sample CCpTS230630 for use as a reference for the delta plot (Fig. **??**, row 3). This regression has an $R^2$ value of 0.9811, an implied activation energy of 41.8 ± 2.2 kcal/mol (174.8 ± 9.2 kJ/mol), and an implied closure temperature of 128 ± 13°C assuming a cooling rate of 10 °C/Ma. The delta plot generated using this reference line for chalcopyrite clearly shows a dramatic mid-experiment increase in diffusivity following steps above 400°C, followed by a continuous decrease in delta values (Fig. **??**, row 3), similarly to that observed for the dehydrating goethite sample Win-06-01b (Farley, H. B. Monteiro, et al., 2024).

### Galena

The majority of the total helium yield was evolved during the step heat experiment of the encapsulated galena, in stark contrast to the comparatively

retentive pyrites and arsenopyrite. The first 70% of helium released in the galena experiment could not be reduced into diffusivities, because $\lambda t \leq 4$ and so steady state permeation out of the ampoule could not be assumed. There were no permeation steps for this experiment. These data are still included in Fig. **??**, because the cumulative yields are less affected by the permeation lag, which mostly affects the short-term knowledge of helium degassing: earlier degassed helium will have long since permeated out, allowing for generally accurate accounting of evolved helium throughout the experiment. The reference line from the chalcopyrite experiment showed a similar activation energy to the activation energy implied by curved retrogrades of the galena experiment (Fig. **??**, row 2), so it was used as the reference for the delta plot of galena. This delta plot shows a monotonic decrease in delta values as the experiment proceeds (Fig. **??**, row 2).

The full $^3$He step-heat datasets for both experiments, in the same format as the main-text pyrite/arsenopyrite tables (§**??**), are given in Tables **??** and **??**.

### Sphalerite

Although we conducted a step heat experiment on translucent sphalerite (SphTS230630), none of the sample's steps reached $\lambda t \geq 4$ and there were insufficient permeation steps to constrain the permeation lag, so no diffusivities could be calculated. Qualitatively, the sphalerite experiment showed that it is somewhat less helium retentive than apatite, and it was consistent with a single diffusion domain, although our data do not permit any confident interpretation. Future work on sphalerite should conduct disciplined permeation steps to track the helium inventory of the ampoule following the procedure outlined in §**??**.

Table 3.7: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Galena, Tri-State District, Missouri (sample GalTS230630), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (row 2). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 15 | 385.0 | 100.0 | 0.2968 | 11.3209 | 0.0835 | -14.758 | -13.974 | -13.716 |
| 16 | 375.0 | 120.0 | 0.2004 | 11.5213 | 0.0491 | -15.018 | -14.489 | -14.264 |
| 17 | 380.0 | 110.0 | 0.2022 | 11.7235 | 0.0528 | -14.616 | -14.344 | -14.105 |
| 18 | 390.0 | 90.0 | 0.1906 | 11.9141 | 0.0586 | -14.471 | -14.153 | -13.877 |
| 19 | 400.0 | 70.0 | 0.3558 | 12.2699 | 0.1413 | -13.379 | -13.207 | -12.853 |
| 20 | 410.0 | 60.0 | 0.0947 | 12.3646 | 0.0473 | – | -14.316 | -13.904 |
| 21 | 300.0 | 60.0 | 0.0374 | 12.4020 | 0.1171 | – | -15.228 | -13.793 |
| 22 | 350.0 | 60.0 | 0.0241 | 12.4262 | 0.0366 | – | -15.656 | -14.729 |
| 23 | 375.0 | 60.0 | 0.0459 | 12.4720 | 0.0327 | -16.600 | -15.005 | -14.462 |
| 24 | 400.0 | 60.0 | 0.1039 | 12.5760 | 0.0525 | -14.539 | -14.166 | -13.750 |
| 25 | 415.0 | 60.0 | 0.1722 | 12.7481 | 0.0744 | -13.977 | -13.621 | -13.251 |
| 26 | 460.0 | 60.0 | 0.6155 | 13.3637 | 0.1765 | -12.343 | -12.226 | -11.943 |
| 27 | 470.0 | 60.0 | 0.6037 | 13.9673 | 0.1605 | -12.349 | -12.034 | -11.765 |
| 28 | 480.0 | 60.0 | 0.4856 | 14.4529 | 0.1200 | -12.389 | -12.024 | -11.771 |
| 29 | 489.9 | 60.0 | 0.3938 | 14.8467 | 0.0908 | -12.325 | -11.997 | -11.787 |
| 30 | 499.7 | 60.0 | 0.3285 | 15.1752 | 0.0709 | -12.280 | -11.985 | -11.764 |
| 31 | 504.6 | 60.0 | 0.2357 | 15.4109 | 0.0493 | -12.437 | -12.108 | -11.896 |
| 32 | 495.0 | 60.0 | 0.1264 | 15.5374 | 0.0282 | -13.040 | -12.570 | -12.355 |
| 33 | 485.0 | 80.0 | 0.0935 | 15.6309 | 0.0158 | -13.390 | -13.047 | -12.882 |
| 34 | 475.0 | 100.0 | 0.0667 | 15.6976 | 0.0093 | -13.777 | -13.516 | -13.380 |
| 35 | 465.0 | 120.0 | 0.0489 | 15.7465 | 0.0059 | -14.144 | -13.938 | -13.820 |
| 36 | 455.0 | 140.0 | 0.0351 | 15.7816 | 0.0038 | -14.549 | -14.368 | -14.262 |
| 37 | 510.0 | 60.0 | 0.0648 | 15.8464 | 0.0131 | -12.894 | -12.836 | -12.643 |
| 38 | 519.9 | 60.0 | 0.0765 | 15.9229 | 0.0145 | -12.740 | -12.562 | -12.376 |
| 39 | 529.9 | 60.0 | 0.0758 | 15.9987 | 0.0135 | -12.638 | -12.438 | -12.261 |
| 40 | 539.1 | 60.0 | 0.0709 | 16.0696 | 0.0120 | -12.557 | -12.359 | -12.190 |
| 41 | 535.8 | 60.0 | 0.0570 | 16.1266 | 0.0098 | -12.650 | -12.429 | -12.258 |
| 42 | 538.6 | 60.0 | 0.0385 | 16.1651 | 0.0065 | -12.977 | -12.697 | -12.531 |
| 43 | 532.9 | 80.0 | 0.0330 | 16.1980 | 0.0041 | -13.243 | -13.033 | -12.908 |
| 44 | 525.0 | 100.0 | 0.0265 | 16.2245 | 0.0027 | -13.542 | -13.378 | -13.276 |
| 45 | 515.0 | 120.0 | 0.0207 | 16.2452 | 0.0018 | -13.857 | -13.722 | -13.633 |
| 46 | 503.7 | 140.0 | 0.0139 | 16.2590 | 0.0011 | -14.348 | -14.209 | -14.129 |
| 49 | 480.0 | 60.0 | 0.0028 | 16.2618 | 0.0007 | -14.929 | -14.929 | -14.706 |
| 50 | 489.9 | 60.0 | 0.0032 | 16.2651 | 0.0007 | -15.010 | -14.771 | -14.562 |
| 51 | 500.0 | 60.0 | 0.0050 | 16.2701 | 0.0011 | -14.468 | -14.310 | -14.113 |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 52 | 505.0 | 60.0 | 0.0052 | 16.2753 | 0.0011 | -14.495 | -14.262 | -14.070 |

Table 3.8: $^3$He step-heat dataset for Chalcopyrite, Baxter Springs, Kansas (sample CCpTS230630), under the uncertainty bounding method (§**??**)(§**??**): measured and cumulative $^3$He, the upper-bound residual ampoule content ($n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$), and the corresponding lower-bound, central, and upper-bound apparent diffusivities plotted in Fig. **??** (row 3). Only steps meeting the $\lambda t \geq 4$ plotability threshold are listed (§**??**); earlier equilibration/permeation steps and any steps manually excluded as unreliable are omitted rather than shown with undetermined bounds. $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ is left blank where the lower bound is unconstrained (§**??**).

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 16 | 374.9 | 120.0 | 0.0782 | 13.1758 | 0.0247 | -18.321 | -17.572 | -17.296 |
| 17 | 380.0 | 110.0 | 0.0639 | 13.2396 | 0.0220 | -18.167 | -17.680 | -17.383 |
| 18 | 390.0 | 90.0 | 0.0721 | 13.3118 | 0.0296 | -17.713 | -17.350 | -17.005 |
| 19 | 400.1 | 70.0 | 0.0943 | 13.4061 | 0.0509 | -17.198 | -16.822 | -16.388 |
| 20 | 410.0 | 60.0 | 0.0963 | 13.5024 | 0.0610 | -17.385 | -16.637 | -16.143 |
| 22 | 291.8 | 60.0 | 0.0928 | 13.5961 | 3.0586 | -17.704 | -16.664 | -12.980 |
| 23 | 345.2 | 60.0 | 0.2696 | 13.8657 | 1.0009 | – | -15.578 | -13.976 |
| 24 | 375.0 | 60.0 | 0.9931 | 14.8588 | 1.0408 | – | -14.209 | -13.439 |
| 25 | 400.0 | 60.0 | 2.0663 | 16.9251 | 1.4653 | -13.975 | -13.324 | -12.714 |
| 26 | 415.0 | 60.0 | 2.2228 | 19.1480 | 1.3491 | -14.056 | -13.046 | -12.507 |
| 27 | 429.9 | 60.0 | 2.8501 | 21.9981 | 1.4512 | -13.143 | -12.562 | -12.080 |
| 28 | 420.0 | 60.0 | 2.4223 | 24.4204 | 1.3837 | -13.328 | -12.480 | -11.959 |
| 29 | 410.0 | 60.0 | 1.4757 | 25.8962 | 0.9756 | -15.497 | -12.790 | -12.232 |
| 30 | 400.1 | 60.0 | 0.7845 | 26.6806 | 0.6038 | – | -13.309 | -12.706 |
| 31 | 390.0 | 80.0 | 0.5091 | 27.1898 | 0.2693 | – | -13.962 | -13.523 |
| 32 | 380.0 | 100.0 | 0.3706 | 27.5604 | 0.1495 | -15.738 | -14.456 | -14.108 |
| 33 | 370.0 | 120.0 | 0.2689 | 27.8293 | 0.0892 | -15.728 | -14.924 | -14.632 |
| 34 | 360.0 | 140.0 | 0.1510 | 27.9803 | 0.0452 | -16.521 | -15.632 | -15.367 |
| 35 | 355.0 | 150.0 | 0.1416 | 28.1219 | 0.0408 | -16.131 | -15.749 | -15.493 |
| 36 | 365.0 | 130.0 | 0.1775 | 28.2994 | 0.0557 | -15.621 | -15.362 | -15.085 |
| 37 | 375.0 | 110.0 | 0.2245 | 28.5239 | 0.0808 | -15.219 | -14.937 | -14.625 |
| 38 | 385.0 | 90.0 | 0.3152 | 28.8391 | 0.1360 | -14.657 | -14.365 | -13.999 |
| 39 | 395.0 | 80.0 | 0.4454 | 29.2845 | 0.2065 | -14.213 | -13.857 | -13.463 |
| 40 | 405.0 | 70.0 | 0.4926 | 29.7771 | 0.2543 | -14.095 | -13.565 | -13.132 |
| 41 | 415.0 | 60.0 | 0.4935 | 30.2707 | 0.2950 | -14.053 | -13.346 | -12.857 |
| 42 | 460.0 | 60.0 | 0.4521 | 30.7228 | 0.1759 | -14.407 | -13.370 | -13.029 |
| 43 | 469.7 | 60.0 | 0.1397 | 30.8624 | 0.0517 | – | -14.504 | -14.186 |
| 44 | 465.4 | 60.0 | 0.1654 | 31.0278 | 0.0601 | -14.684 | -14.313 | -13.999 |

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*(continued)*

| Step | Temp (°C) | Time (min) | $^3$He meas. (pccSTP) | Cum. $^3$He (pccSTP) | $n_{t,\mathrm{UB}}$ (pccSTP) | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{LB}}$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_m$ | $\ln(D/a^2)_{\mathrm{UB}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 45 | 473.5 | 60.0 | 0.1554 | 31.1832 | 0.0531 | -14.837 | -14.352 | -14.054 |
| 46 | 480.0 | 60.0 | 0.1691 | 31.3523 | 0.0538 | -14.617 | -14.244 | -13.963 |
| 47 | 491.9 | 60.0 | 0.1549 | 31.5072 | 0.0452 | -14.729 | -14.307 | -14.047 |
| 48 | 491.0 | 60.0 | 0.1219 | 31.6291 | 0.0357 | -14.985 | -14.525 | -14.265 |

**Discussion: Thermal Helium Migration Systematics**

*Chalcopyrite and Chalcocite*

Neither copper-bearing sulfide mineral studied here was successfully stabilized by encapsulation with sulfur, so these results provide little insight into helium migration within copper sulfides in nature, though they suggest high potential for helium retention at surface temperatures, similar to apatite. Still, they are unlikely to be promising targets for U-Th/He geochronology or helium isotope studies as there exist many copper-bearing sulfide phases stable at temperatures between 200-500°C, for which phase stability and Cu/Fe ratios are sensitive functions of temperature, composition, and sulfur fugacity (Zhao et al., 2014; J. H. Chen and Harvey, 1975; Yund and Kullerud, 1966). These reactions are likely to result in helium loss during reheating, burial, diagenesis, or metasomatism after crystallization. Copper sulfides are unlikely to be promising targets for U-Th/He geochronology, but may be suitable for helium isotope studies in young or unaltered samples.

*Galena*

Because the majority of the cumulative yield was degassed in steps for which $\lambda t > 4$, the bulk helium behavior for galena is somewhat unclear. The data of the remaining 30% of the cumulative yield were consistent with a multiple diffusion domain helium loss mechanism. As expected for an MDD system, the delta plot for galena monotonically decreases as the fractional yield increases (Fig. **??**, row 2; Farley (2018)). The majority of the 3He cumulative fractional yield was evolved at low temperatures where the uncertainties due to permeation lag could not be constrained, yet these early degassing domains were certainly less retentive than 150 µm half-prism width Durango apatite (Farley, 2000). Additionally, the total 3He concentration for the irradiated galena was less than half that of co-irradiated pyrite, implying poor helium retention even at

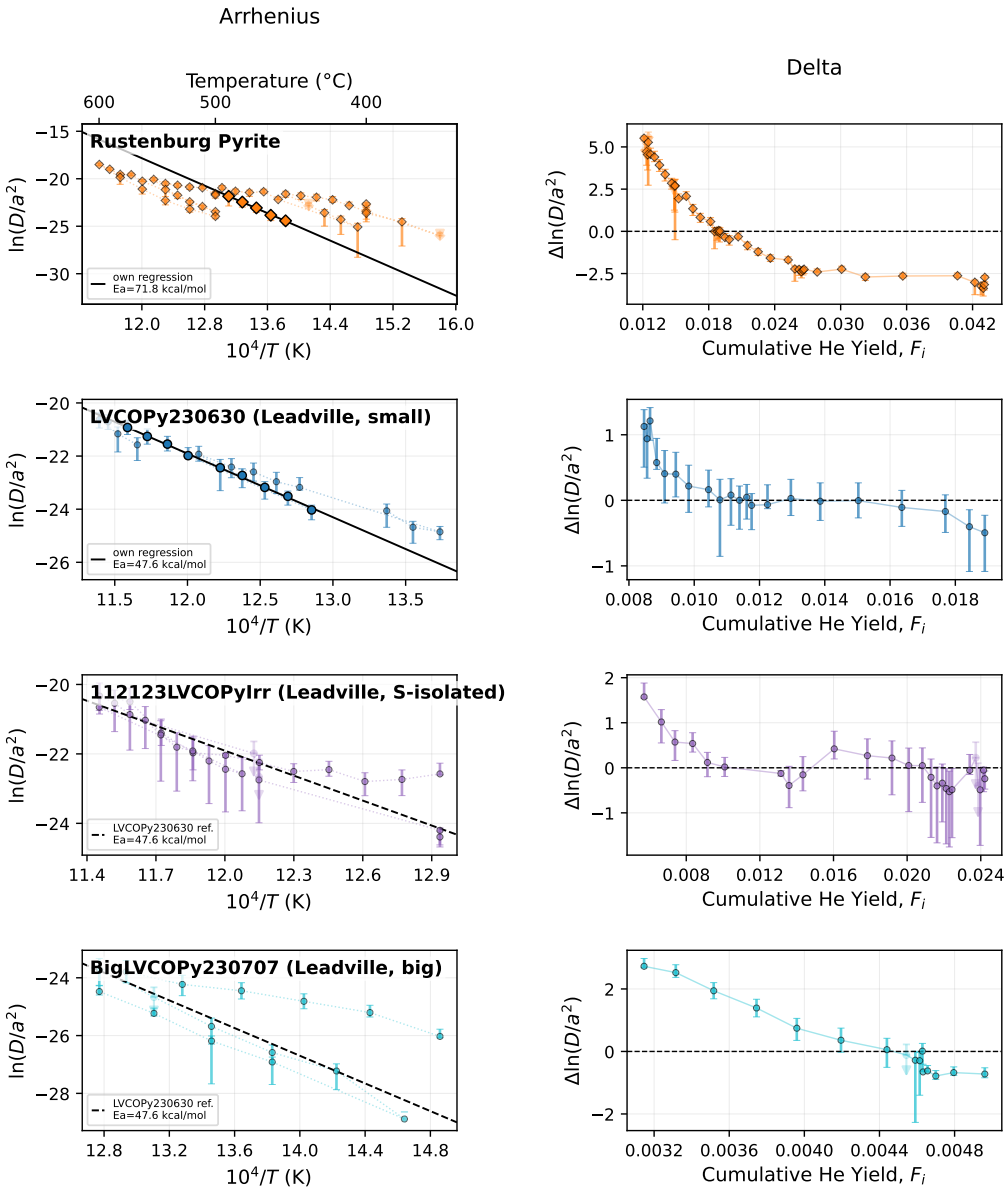



Figure 3.20: Compiled Arrhenius (left) and delta (right) plots for the four plotable Chapter 3 pyrite step-heat experiments: (1) Rustenburg pyrite, (2) LVCOPy230630 (Leadville, small), (3) 112123LVCOPyIrr (Leadville, sulfur-isolated), (4) BigLVCOPy230707 (Leadville, big). Each row's Arrhenius panel plots the reference regression used for that row's delta panel (solid where owned, dashed where borrowed; see §**??**). Each row has its own x-axis scale, labeled on every panel. The three non-pyrite sulfides are compiled separately in Fig. **??**.

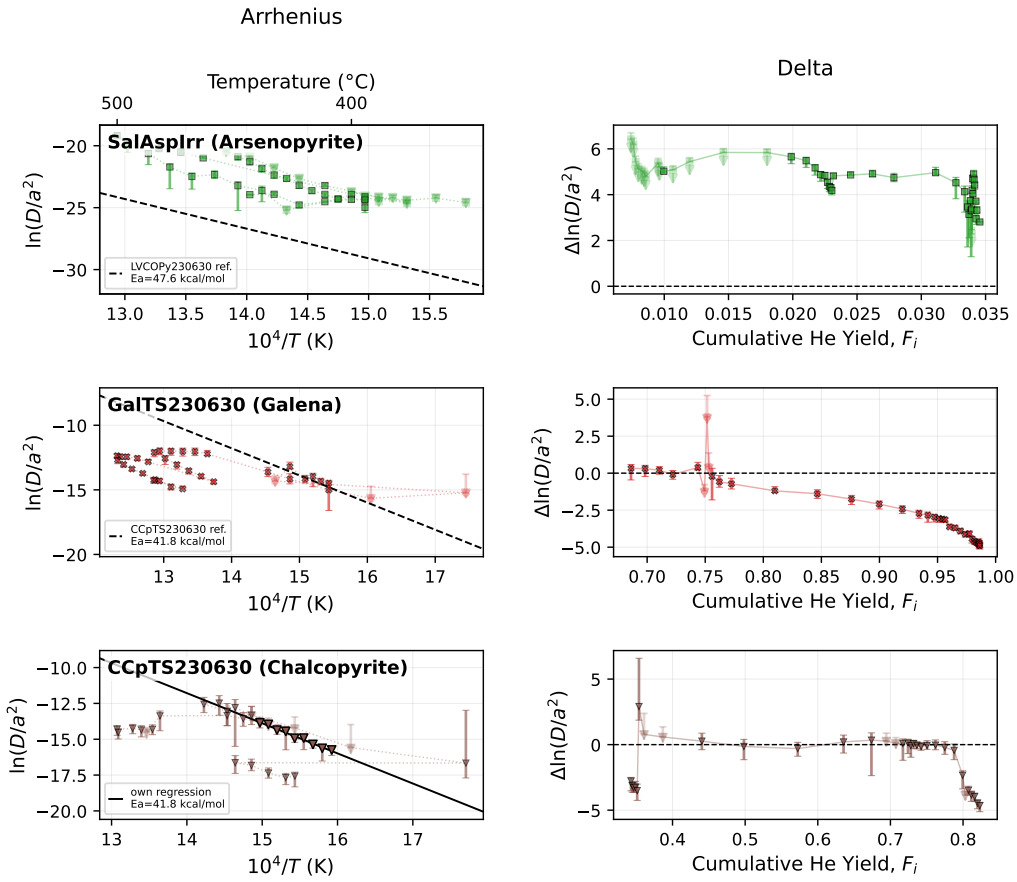



Figure 3.21: Compiled Arrhenius (left) and delta (right) plots for the three plotable Chapter 3 non-pyrite sulfide step-heat experiments: (1) SalAspIrr (arsenopyrite), (2) GalTS230630 (galena), (3) CCpTS230630 (chalcopyrite). Each row's Arrhenius panel plots the reference regression used for that row's delta panel (solid where owned, dashed where borrowed; see §**??**). Each row has its own x-axis scale, labeled on every panel. The four pyrite samples are compiled separately in Fig. **??**.

ambient temperatures. Galena is unlikely to be a promising target for U-Th/He geochronology or helium isotope studies.

## 3.2s Complete U-Th/He Geochronology Compilation

### Trace Elements for the Main-Text Sample Suites

The main-text geochronology table (Table **??**) reports U, Th, Sm, and Zr for the Kidd Creek, Gympie, Durango, and Gogebic aliquots. The remaining ICPMS trace elements measured the same way – Cu, As, Ag, and Sb – are reported here instead (Table **??**), in the same row order, to keep the main-text table within the page width.

Table 3.9: Cu, As, Ag, and Sb (measured as ratios to spike vanadium by the same ICPMS run as U, Th, Sm, and Zr, §**??**) for the same Kidd Creek, Gympie, Durango, and Gogebic aliquots reported in Table **??**, in the same row order; '–' denotes below detection or not measured for that aliquot. Sample notes are repeated from Table **??** for reference.

| Sample | Cu (ppm) | As (ppm) | Ag (ppm) | Sb (ppm) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Kidd Creek Pyrite (Archean VMS, ∼2716 Ma host)** | | | | | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_C | – | – | – | – | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_A | – | – | – | – | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_B | – | – | – | – | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_D | – | – | – | – | |
| 011123KCPyST05C | 248.36±27.86 | 49.38±12.69 | 3.88±0.98 | 15.91±0.94 | |
| 011423KCPyST05A | 555.10±38.86 | 5922.20±397.89 | 7.82±1.12 | 35.69±0.95 | |
| 011423KCPyST05B | 1365.56±58.41 | 1604.14±109.70 | 12.62±1.04 | 22.44±0.41 | |
| 011423KCPyST05C | 780.58±52.49 | 8026.88±487.81 | 11.17±1.64 | 21.97±0.46 | |
| 011423KCPyST05D | 146.71±19.63 | 11440.33±796.21 | 2.13±1.35 | 24.09±0.73 | |
| 013023KCPyST05As1 | 17.41±7.76 | 47121.03±2800.88 | – | 38.45±0.81 | |
| 013023KCPyST05Cu1 | 314.00±30.30 | 11923.72±782.77 | 3.52±2.05 | 23.93±1.33 | |
| 013023KCPyST05Cu2 | 102.88±20.20 | 410116.35±23437.59 | – | 1235.42±29.55 | |
| **Gympie Pyrite (Permo-Triassic orogenic Au)** | | | | | |
| 013023PVGyPy-1 | 42.50±7.50 | 202426.65±12489.88 | 0.73±0.41 | 138.00±3.18 | excl.: early protocol |
| 013023PVGyPy-2 | 196.52±14.56 | 1045127.96±63721.03 | 3.15±1.26 | 733.74±21.57 | excl.: early protocol |
| 013023PVGyPy-3 | 15.93±8.91 | 433911.06±27230.00 | 2.81±0.86 | 345.22±9.92 | excl.: early protocol |
| 013023PVGyPy-4 | 38.76±16.89 | 616561.59±36135.06 | 1.67±0.79 | 333.74±7.83 | excl.: early protocol |
| 0413PyGy-1 | 43.08±8.28 | 552.38±44.66 | 9.26±1.92 | 70.17±4.40 | |
| 0413PyGy-2 | 33.14±8.87 | 164.64±37.86 | 8.78±2.05 | 12.54±3.70 | |
| 0413PyGy-3 | 95.81±27.83 | 3445.18±214.54 | 7.91±4.05 | 61.53±5.65 | |
| 0413PyGy-4 | 30.30±10.79 | 3814.85±170.90 | 7.41±2.90 | 82.93±4.53 | excl.: outlier |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Sample | Cu (ppm) | As (ppm) | Ag (ppm) | Sb (ppm) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 062123GyPyHClb | 29.50±5.71 | 3594.31±91.81 | 4.76±1.64 | 186.80±5.22 | |
| 062123GyPyHClc | 21.71±3.17 | 499.31±18.48 | 2.30±1.11 | 6.36±0.19 | |
| 230625GyPyHCl | 30.60±5.78 | 13394.39±344.59 | 4.16±1.53 | 144.68±5.06 | |
| 230625GyPyUnAbr | 11.48±2.49 | 101443.33±2285.09 | 2.85±1.18 | 166.23±5.89 | |
| 230628GyPyHClab | 60.99±6.34 | 297125.64±8329.25 | 72.30±26.22 | 222.09±12.53 | |
| 230628GyPyHClc | 23.00±4.19 | 33613.36±1092.63 | 7.65±3.09 | 183.41±11.95 | |
| 230628GyPyUnAbrA | 30.71±4.04 | 1615.76±61.65 | 4.60±1.97 | 96.60±6.99 | |
| 230628GyPyUnAbrB | 12.00±5.29 | 1498.79±70.73 | 7.27±3.08 | 45.68±3.40 | |
| **Durango Apatite Standard (accepted age 32.1 Ma; Farley 2000)** | | | | | |
| 2211DApA | – | – | – | – | old method: pre-degassing |
| 2211DApC | – | – | – | – | old method: pre-degassing |
| 2211DApD | – | – | – | – | old method: pre-degassing |
| 2022StDApA | – | – | – | – | old method: pre-degassing |
| 011123DAp1 | – | 924.97±72.80 | 118.08±10.69 | 89.07±4.68 | |
| 011123DAp2 | – | 910.07±100.20 | – | 26.32±2.87 | |
| 011123DAp3 | – | 803.92±55.21 | – | 49.44±1.01 | |
| 011423DAp1 | – | 787.88±50.76 | 1.79±1.42 | 28.71±0.83 | |
| 011423DAp2 | – | 846.83±57.62 | – | 17.66±0.58 | |
| 011423DAp3 | – | 820.23±71.82 | – | 23.65±0.54 | |
| 011423DAp4 | – | 810.88±61.16 | – | 42.87±2.29 | |
| 062123DAp | – | 665.14±204.98 | – | – | |
| 062523DAp | 24.94±8.99 | 799.92±156.54 | – | – | |
| 062823DAp | – | – | – | – | |
| Average for > 0.5 mg | – | – | – | – | |
| **Gogebic Iron Range BIF Hematite Standard (MI-43; 571 Ma)** | | | | | |
| 2211HemMSA | – | – | – | – | |

*continued on next page*

*(continued)*

| Sample | Cu (ppm) | As (ppm) | Ag (ppm) | Sb (ppm) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2211HemMSB | – | – | – | – | – |
| 041323MG16a | – | 338.77±109.12 | – | – | – |
| 041323MG16b | 77.04±34.63 | 1310.34±209.47 | 10.81±9.03 | – | – |
| 041323MG16d | – | 3960.06±226.90 | 20.03±15.53 | – | – |
| 041323MG16e | – | 8490.93±1373.53 | – | – | – |
| 062123MS | – | 2717.17±112.31 | 3.63±1.42 | 18.83±0.96 | – |
| 230625MSHm | – | 1849.86±128.15 | 78.00±29.79 | 89.12±4.54 | – |
| 230628MSHm | – | 443.71±19.65 | 3.06±1.63 | 93.15±7.07 | – |

**Additional Sample Suites**

This subsection is a data appendix, not a narrative: it reports the complete U-Th/He geochronology compilation (Chapter3/Tables/geochronology_ compilation_BJT.xlsx) for the sample suites and replicate aliquots not discussed in the main text – Kidd Creek replicate/mass-only aliquots, Franklin (NJ) pyrite and fluorite, Rustenburg/Pilanesberg pyrite, Magnet Cove carbonatite pyrite, French Creek magnetite/pyrite, and Salzburg arsenopyrite – so that the full underlying dataset is available even where it is not part of this chapter's argument. Later work extending this chapter's geochronology (e.g. to these additional localities) can build directly on this section.

Table 3.10: U-Th/He geochronology results for all remaining sample suites in the compilation, not discussed in the main text: Kidd Creek replicate/mass-only aliquots, Franklin (NJ) pyrite and fluorite, Rustenberg/Pilanesberg pyrite, Magnet Cove carbonatite pyrite, French Creek magnetite/pyrite, and Salzburg arsenopyrite. Reported here for completeness, with the full trace-element suite (Cu, As, Zr, Ag, Sb) retained since these aliquots are not duplicated in the main text; columns and conventions as in Table **??**.

| Sample | Mass (mg) | U (ppm) | Th (ppm) | Sm (ppm) | Cu (ppm) | As (ppm) | Zr (ppm) | Ag (ppm) | Sb (ppm) | eU (ppm) | $^4$He (ncc) | Age (Ma) | Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Kidd Creek Pyrite (replicate / mass-only aliquots)** | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_DU1 | 2.09 | 0.78±0.03 | 1.76±0.04 | 0.08±0.01 | – | – | – | – | – | 1.20 | – | – | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_DU2 | 2.98 | 0.80±0.01 | 2.19±0.06 | 0.02±0.00 | – | – | – | – | – | 1.33 | – | – | |
| 2211KC_Py_ST05_DU3 | 1.77 | 0.77±0.03 | 1.93±0.06 | 0.10±0.01 | – | – | – | – | – | 1.23 | – | – | |
| 12122022KCPyST05A | 14.35 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | 1422.90 | – | |
| 12122022KCPyST05B | 10.52 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | 960.74 | – | |
| 12122022KCPyST05C | 12.19 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | 1203.97 | – | |
| 12122022KCPyST05D | 9.60 | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | – | 865.75 | – | |
| **Franklin, NJ Pyrite (marble/volcanics, ∼1.3–1.0 Ga)** | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 2211GFr_PyA | 2.49 | 0.29±0.01 | 0.05±0.01 | 0.02±0.00 | – | – | – | – | – | 0.31 | 51.29 | 529.1±22.1 | |
| 2211GFr_PyB | 3.00 | 1.78±0.02 | 0.01±0.01 | 0.01±0.00 | – | – | – | – | – | 1.78 | 66.87 | 106.9±1.3 | |
| 2211StFr_PyA | 1.45 | 0.64±0.03 | 0.02±0.01 | 0.02±0.00 | – | – | – | – | – | 0.65 | 42.84 | 322.2±14.8 | |
| 2211StFr_PyB | 2.53 | 0.12±0.01 | 0.00±0.00 | 0.91±0.04 | – | – | – | – | – | 0.12 | 57.76 | 1256.6±124.3 | |
| 2211AtmFr_PyC | 1.93 | 1.00±0.02 | 0.01±0.01 | 0.02±0.00 | – | – | – | – | – | 1.00 | 55.14 | 223.2±4.6 | |
| **Franklin, NJ Fluorite** | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 011423FrFl2 | 1.40 | 3.19±0.03 | 0.24±0.07 | 0.21±0.04 | 32.17±10.03 | | – | 1.82±1.13 | 10.23±1.72 | 35.81±0.74 | 3.25 | 76.81 | 168.7±1.9 |
| 011423FrFl3 | 1.03 | 5.35±0.08 | 0.20±0.06 | 0.34±0.09 | – | | – | 5.80±1.56 | – | 30.63±0.71 | 5.40 | 99.90 | 179.3±2.8 |
| **Rustenberg/Pilanesberg(?) Pyrite** | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 013023BVPy H-3026-1 | 1.03 | 2.50±0.31 | 1.04±0.09 | 0.29±0.07 | 173.63±26.23 | 3328.64±233.02 | | 10.86±5.67 | – | 152.60±3.84 | 2.75 | 226.12 | 747.3±79.0 |
| 041323BVPy1 | 0.95 | 0.56±0.02 | 0.17±0.05 | 0.05±0.05 | 105.69±27.36 | 391.95±59.38 | | – | – | – | 0.60 | 45.43 | 724.9±19.9 |

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*(continued)*

| Sample | Mass (mg) | U (ppm) | Th (ppm) | Sm (ppm) | Cu (ppm) | As (ppm) | Zr (ppm) | Ag (ppm) | Sb (ppm) | eU (ppm) | $^4$He (ncc) | Age (Ma) | Note | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 041323BVPy2 | 0.53 | 2.07±0.28 | 2.34±0.41 | 0.77±0.45 | 484.42±455.64 | 22900.08±4862.73 | | 130.29±59.21 | | – | 680.02±100.62 | 2.63 | 70.82 | 490.3±52.8 | | |
| 062123BVPyHCla | 1.22 | 3.13±0.12 | 0.81±0.07 | 0.25±0.01 | 95.87±10.25 | 582.38±13.15 | | 12.17±2.15 | 2.43±0.97 | | 10.07±0.42 | 3.33 | 241.19 | 571.5±19.2 | | |
| 062123BVPyHClb | 0.53 | 1.46±0.05 | 0.25±0.18 | 0.16±0.01 | 102.76±11.05 | 1499.31±44.51 | | 7.89±4.05 | 3.30±1.37 | | 10.48±0.72 | 1.52 | 1046.06 | 5109.8±58.3 | | |
| 230628BVPyUnAbrB | 0.75 | 2.15±0.07 | 0.42±0.13 | 0.14±0.02 | 64.34±12.08 | 996.13±55.99 | | – | 3.09±1.39 | | 3.54±0.32 | 2.25 | 233.66 | 1244.1±39.2 | | |
| 230628BVPyUnAbrC | 1.11 | 0.50±0.13 | 0.12±0.09 | 0.09±0.02 | 979.31±62.60 | 1028.86±34.43 | | – | 7.63±3.34 | | 4.60±0.29 | 0.53 | 723.21 | 5050.8±429.6 | | |
| 230628BVPyUnAbrC | 0.60 | 29.01±0.40 | 5.44±0.33 | 2.01±0.17 | 138.48±15.53 | 728.93±53.84 | | 202.97±10.19 | 11.80±4.77 | | 10.59±0.76 | 30.32 | 881.54 | 474.1±6.0 | | |
| **Magnet Cove Carbonatite Pyrite, Arkansas (∼100 Ma)** | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 011123MCARPy1 | 3.38 | 0.06±0.00 | 0.41±0.03 | 0.31±0.03 | 15.72±4.66 | 3.86±1.22 | | 1.63±0.65 | 1.10±0.48 | | 18.58±0.78 | 0.16 | 9.67 | 177.1±7.5 | | |
| 011123MCARPy2 | 3.90 | 0.01±0.00 | 0.20±0.01 | 0.02±0.01 | 56.98±6.51 | 62.10±8.60 | | 1.58±0.65 | – | | 11.49±0.88 | 0.06 | 3.25 | 52.2±4.7 | | |
| **French Creek, PA Magnetite and Pyrite (∼130 Ma)** | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 062123FCHCl | 4.36 | 0.01±0.00 | 0.00±0.02 | 0.01±0.00 | 8.97±2.49 | 29.58±2.10 | | – | 21.25±6.89 | | 7.65±1.10 | 0.01 | 1.55 | 218.0±52.4 | | |
| 062123FCMagHCl | 3.84 | 0.06±0.00 | 0.00±0.02 | 0.05±0.00 | – | 81.88±3.18 | | – | 0.71±0.29 | | 15.55±0.44 | 0.06 | 2.67 | 97.7±5.5 | | |
| 230625FCHFa | 3.41 | 0.63±0.05 | 0.71±0.03 | 0.34±0.02 | 209.62±15.43 | 1118.04±38.65 | | 7.76±0.88 | 5.71±2.12 | | 19.75±0.77 | 0.80 | 276.46 | 953.2±53.0 | | |
| 230625FCMagHCl | 4.07 | 0.05±0.00 | 0.00±0.02 | 0.02±0.00 | – | 85.58±8.67 | | – | 0.74±0.33 | | 4.22±0.19 | 0.05 | 3.60 | 137.1±7.7 | | |
| **Salzburg, Austria Arsenopyrite** | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
| 230625SBAsPy | 2.52 | 0.96±0.01 | 1.29±0.05 | 0.11±0.01 | 78.87±11.98 | 187365.67±4344.31 | | 24.74±1.67 | 3.67±1.41 | | 94.85±3.82 | 1.27 | 33.95 | 106.2±1.3 | | |

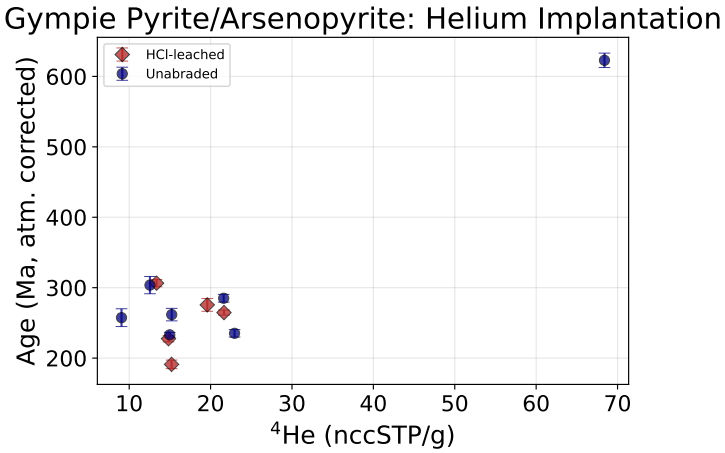



Figure 3.22: Companion to the main-text Gympie age-vs-eU figure (Fig. **??**), plotting atmospherically corrected age against measured 4He content (nccSTP/mg) for the newer-protocol Gympie arsenopyrite suite with the 0413PyGy-4 outlier put back in (§**??**, main text). Its 4He content stands well off the trend defined by the other eleven aliquots, consistent with the helium-implantation interpretation offered there.

*Chapter 4*

# NGIBBS: FAST, DIFFERENTIABLE PHASE EQUILIBRIA FOR MULTICOMPONENT SILICATE SYSTEMS VIA DEEP LEARNING

***[TODO: One-paragraph chapter summary.]***

## 4.1 Introduction

**[TODO: Motivate the need for fast thermodynamic forward models in geodynamics. Review current tools (Perple_X, THERMOCALC, MAGEMin) and their computational bottlenecks. State the deep learning acceleration approach.]**

## 4.2 Background

### Gibbs Free Energy Minimization in Petrology

**[TODO: ]**

### Machine Learning Surrogates for Physical Models

**[TODO: ]**

Chapter 4 main body

## 4.3 Introduction

### Motivation

-Motivate the need for fast thermodynamic forward models in geodynamics. Composition space is highly unexplored -Review current tools (Perple_X, THERMOCALC, MAGEMin) and their computational bottlenecks. (research and citations)

### Previous Work

-Review the state of surrogate modeling in geodynamics (research and citations) (qian and ETH group)

**Properties and Innovations of nGibbs**

-High level introduction to nGibbs and what its innovation is (full thermodynamic emulator, obeys mass balance, differentiable, flexible, central tool for many geology-relevant tools, which are all written in their own languages and have independent learning curves)

## 4.4 Methods

**Network architecture**

**Motivation: the discontinuity problem**

Before the introduction of the continuous-saturation framework described below, the early *nGibbs* architecture predicted phase presence with a binary classifier and phase abundance with a distinct regressor, multiplying the two so that the predicted abundance is the regressed magnitude gated by a thresholded presence probability. This gated model was simple and easy to train, but it has a structural defect. Because the gate and the magnitude were distinct functions, nothing tied the magnitude to zero as the gate closes. Therefore, when the presence probability of a phase crosses its threshold, the predicted abundance jumps discontinuously from a finite value to exactly zero, which is (for most phases) an unnexpected behavior for a mixed system.

Natural systems of interest to geologists and planetary scientists are typically complex, chemically-mixed systems. These systems, and the thermodyanamic models that describe them, behave continuously. In addition to the continuous quality of phase abundance, thermodynamic models like MELTS and HeFESTo also track each phases' chemical affinity, which is a continuous quality that measures the free energy cost of a metastable phase's formation introduction to the system. Even when the phase is absent, the chemical affinity is a meaningful, continuous quantity that smoothly goes to zero as the phase approaches saturation. Likewise, at a phase-out boundary, the abundance of the departing phase goes to zero smoothly, linearly in reaction progress. A gated model is therefore structurally wrong precisely at the phase boundaries that constitute the most interesting content of a phase diagram.

The architecture used for all released models removes this defect by making the gate and the magnitude the same variable, analogously to a prediction of chemical affinity. Some emulators predict a scaled chemical affinity, while others simply activate their continuous molar output with a ReLU function. The

models trained with a scaled affinity perform slightly better, but require a more complex data processing pipeline that cannot be applied to datasets where the data are not structured in paths that hold a state variable constant. Because the HeFESTo data were generated along mock-isentropic pressure-temperature paths (and not true isentropes), the HeFESTo emulators were trained with the simpler, ReLU activated architecture, hereafter referred to as the affinity-naive architecture. The MELTS emulators, which were trained on data generated by isobaric cooling, were trained with scaled affinities with an architecture hereafter referred to as affinity-aware.

### Variables

Here a table is provided to name the key variables used in the equations below that describe the training and function of nGibbs. These equations rely additionally on general letter codes to describe the dimensionality of the datathat are used internally within the nGibbs codebase and are borrowed here for clairity: P phases, VP compositionally variable phases, C components (endmembers of all phases), VC components of the compositionally variable phases, E elements and O oxides. Two further sizes are used here: F, the number of physical non-compositional input features (e.g. pressure and temperature, with or without $_2$), and B, the number of rows in a mini-batch (the amount of assemblages processed in a single pass during training). Every quantity in Table **??** is per row; a batch stacks B rows. For emulator outputs, the hatted symbol is the prediction and the plain symbol is the ground truth taken directly from the thermodynamic model (e.g. MELTS or HeFESTo).

### Inputs

Each emulator takes pressure and one further intensive variable (temperature for the isothermal models, specific entropy for the isentropic models) and a bulk composition as inputs. The emulators are trained on and expect the same units for pressure, temperature, and entropy that the real thermodynamic MELTS and HeFESTo use: Kelvin and GPa for HeFESTo, and Celcius and bars for MELTS. Both expect specific entropy in units of J/g/K. nGibbs recieves as input normalized cation atomic abundances, following $\mathbf{b} \in \mathbb{R}^E$ with $\sum_e b_e = 1$. Compositions are supplied by the user either as oxide weight percents or as element molar abundances for any model; oxide inputs are automatically

| Prediction | Truth | Dim. | Meaning |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Inputs* | | | |
| | $u$ | F | Physical state (pressure, temperature, ...), min–max normalised to $[0, 1]$ |
| $\hat{b}$ | $b$ | E | Bulk composition in element moles, normalised to sum to 1. $\hat{b}$ is the bulk reconstruction $\hat{b} = \hat{m}A$ |
| *Emulator outputs* | | | |
| $\hat{n}$ | $n$ | P | Phase abundance (moles); 0 for an absent phase |
| $\hat{x}$ | $x$ | VC | Endmember mole fractions of each variable phase (sum to 1 within a phase: $\sum x_i = s_i\|1 - b\|$) |
| $\hat{m}$ | $m$ | C | Extensive endmember components/species in moles; $\hat{m} = (\hat{x}V + b) \circ (\hat{n}M)$ |
| $\hat{s}$ | $s$ | P | Phase presence, 1 if present and 0 if absent; $s = [n > 0]$ |
| *Quantities used only in training* | | | |
| $g$ | – | P | Phase affinity/abundance: the raw output of each phase's mole head; $\hat{n} = \max(g, 0)$ |
| $\tilde{n}$ | – | P | Smoothed, positive, non-zero abundance used to evaluate mole loss; $\tilde{n}(g, T)$: Eq. (**??**) |
| – | $\bar{s}$ | VC | Phase Presence $s$ projected to phases' endmembers (chemistry mask) $\bar{s} = s\,M\,V^\top \in \{0, 1\}$ |
| *Training constants* | | | |
| $T_0$ | | P | Reference abundance scale per phase (5th percentile of present abundances) |
| $T$ | | P | Annealed smoothing temperature; $T = a\,T_0$ |
| $a$ | | 1 | Annealing factor, decreased linearly over an episode |
| $w$ | | P | Phase weights |
| $\omega$ | | VC | Endmember weights; $\omega = w\,M\,V^\top$ |
| $\lambda_s, \lambda_x, \lambda_n, \lambda_b$ | | 1 | Weights for the binary phase presence, chemistry, molar, and bulk loss terms |
| *Fixed stoichiometric/projection matrices* | | | |
| $A$ | | C×E | Element moles per component mole |
| $M$ | | P×C | Which components belong to which phase; $M \in \{0, 1\}$ |
| $V$ | | VC×C | Indexing matrix that places the VC components into the full component list; $M \in \{0, 1\}$ |
| $b$ | | C | Which components belong to fixed-composition (pure) phases; $b \in \{0, 1\}$ |

Table 4.1: Key to the symbols. "–" marks a quantity with no prediction or no ground-truth counterpart.

converted internally to the normalized cation abundances expected by nGibbs.

Entropy is offered as a useful alternative to temperature because isentropic paths are the natural coordinate for the convecting mantle (**Davies1977**; **Brown1981**; **Asimow1997**; **Asimow2001**; **Ganguly2005**; **Tirone2016**). Supplying $S$ directly removes an inner iteration for $T$ at every pressure step, which is the dominant cost of constructing an adiabat by conventional means.

The full non-compositional feature vector (i.e. pressure, temperature, entropy, $f\mathrm{O}_2$) is min–max normalized to $[0, 1]$. The minima and maxima used for these normalizations are fit on the training data, and are carried by the emulator and automatically applied during inference. This avoids presenting the network with inputs on a different scale than the one it was trained on, leading to errors that would be difficult to diagnose.

The neural networks driving *nGibbs* expect that the input composition vector sum to a total of one. During inference, this is explicitly enforced by a renormalization so that, similarly to MELTS and HeFESTo, the user can supply a composition that sums to values other than one for convenience. The outputs of *nGIbbs*, however, are not rescaled and will always map to a cation sum of one regardless of user input.

### Compositional basis

Three compositional bases are used. *Components* ($m$) are the endmembers of the reference code's solution models ($C$ in total across all phases); *oxides* ($O$) are accepted as an input because it is conventional to measure and report rock compositions as oxides; and *elements* ($E$) are the conserved quantities that *nGibbs* conserves. Ferric and ferrous iron are distinguished as oxides but not as elements for models with oxygen buffering, for which $O = E + 1$, but closed system models distinguish ferric and ferrous iron in the element basis as well so that they are conserved: $O = E$. Conversion between bases is exact stoichiometry, expressed as fixed matrices that relate components to oxides and oxides to elements. The product of the two, $A$, is the most commonly used stoichiometry matrix because it relates model outputs to the bulk elemental composition it conserves. These matrices are model constants, not fitted parameters.

*nGibbs* models closed systems that conserve oxygen content, as well as open

systems where oxygen fugacity is imposed. Iron is the major redox-active element in *nGibbs*. Every element besides iron is tracked at a single, fixed oxidation state (with a limited exception for carbon) and therefore the oxygen content of the system is fully specified by the ferric-to-total iron ratio. The only other redox-active element is carbon in MELTS 1.2 emulators, wherein carbon exists as an oxide in melt, fluid, and calcite, and as reduced carbon in graphite. Graphite is represented as $C(FeO)_4(Fe_2O_3)_{-2}$ in oxide space in order to conserve oxygen, which introduces strong coupling between $Fe^{2+}/Fe^{3+}$ and graphite for closed system MELTS 120 models. This coupling vanishes for open system models where oxygen is not conserved. Similarly, native iron phases are represented as $(FeO)_3(Fe_2O_3)_{-1}$ in oxide space in *nGibbs*.

*nGibbs* accepts one of two inputs that define the redox state: an explicit, distinct definition of both FeO and $Fe_2O_3$, which the closed-system models conserve; or an oxygen fugacity ($fO_2$) in log unit offset from the fayalite-magnetite-quartz buffer ($\Delta$FMQ), which the open-system models impose. Oxygen buffering is neither available in HEFESTO or its *nGibbs* emulator. In these open models, only cation mass is conserved and the oxygen contents of the system is a consequence of the predicted phase assemblage, except for the liquid, for which total iron is speciated following the procedure of **kress1991**.

### Forward pass

The network sees the input vector state variables $u$ and bulk composition $b$, represented as the vector $[u, b]$ and:

1. a shared encoder produces a central working representation of the system's state;
2. one small network per phase gives the signed abundance/affinity $g$;
3. one softmax-activated network per chemically-variable phase gives that phase's endmember fractions $\hat{x}$.

During inference, the predicted abundance is the rectified affinity,

$$\hat{n} = \max(g, 0). \tag{4.1}$$

Because $\max(g, 0)$ is continuous at $g = 0$, a phase leaving the assemblage is a kink in $\hat{n}$ rather than a jump. Additionally, phases and chemical endmembers that contain an element that is absent from $b$ are forced to be zero.

Component moles and the reconstructed bulk composition follow from stoichiometry:

$$\hat{m} = (\hat{x}V + b) \circ (\hat{n}M), \tag{4.2}$$

$$\hat{b} = \hat{m}A. \tag{4.3}$$

Here $\circ$ is the element-wise product, so $\hat{m}$ is each component's phase abundance multiplied by its fraction in that phase. Mass balance (adjusting $\hat{m}$ until $\hat{b} = b$) is enforced only at inference (§**??**).

### Thermodynamic justification for softmax activated phase composition prediction

The softmax activation function produces a positive, nonzero output that sums to 1, and is most often applied in machine learning for classification problems in tandem with cross-entropy loss, as its outputs are often interpreted as a probability or liklihood distribution over categorical classes (Holm et al., 2023; Pearce et al., 2021; X. Li et al., 2019; Yang et al., 2018). For class $i$ of $\phi$ categorical classes, the softmax function is $\frac{e^{z_i}}{\sum_{j\in\phi} e^{z_j}}$ where $z_i$ is the logit (linear dense layer output) for class $i$.

The softmax function is used here for a bounded regression problem, to predict the mole fractions of chemical endmembers in a phase, which are also positive, nonzero, and sum to 1. Originally, we chose the softmax function because of this quality, and early tests showed it outperformed alternative activations (such as a renormalization of ReLU outputs) for predicting chemical endmember fraction. Although this application of the softmax is unusual, it is justified in that its functional form mirrors that of the thermodynamic problem of predicting chemical endmember fractions in a phase at equilibrium.

For a general solution, the chemical potential of endmember $i$ in phase $\phi$ is $\mu_i = \mu_i^\circ(P,T) + RT\ln a_i$, with activity $a_i = \gamma_i x_i$ (e.g. Anderson, 2005; Ganguly, 2008). The activity coefficient $\gamma_i \equiv a_i/x_i$ collects the departure from ideal molecular mixing, including excess (interaction) terms and multi-site configurational effects. At equilibrium, $\mu_i$ equals the apparent chemical potential $\mu_i^*$ that the coexisting assemblage imposes on that endmember, so

$$\ln x_i \;=\; z_i \;\equiv\; \frac{\mu_i^* - \mu_i^\circ(P,T) - RT\ln\gamma_i}{RT}. \tag{4.4}$$

The standard state chemical potential $\mu_i^\circ(P,T)$ and the unideal contribution ($RT\ln\gamma_i$) may be gathered together in an effective reference chemical potential $\tilde{\mu}_i^\circ(P,T) \equiv \mu_i^\circ(P,T) + RT\ln\gamma_i$.

$$\ln x_i \;=\; z_i \;\equiv\; \frac{\mu_i^* - \tilde{\mu}_i^\circ(P,T)}{RT}. \tag{4.5}$$

Imposing the constraint that the sum of the chemical end members is 1 ($\sum_{i\in\phi} x_i = 1$), it follows that

$$x_i \;=\; \frac{x_i}{\sum_{j\in\phi} x_j} \;=\; \frac{e^{z_i}}{\sum_{j\in\phi} e^{z_j}} \;=\; \mathrm{softmax}(\boldsymbol{z})_i. \tag{4.6}$$

so the softmax is the exact functional form describing the equilibrium composition as a function of the chemical potential with respect to a reference state, normalized by $RT$. The network does not need to track the non-ideal terms because it predicts the logits $\hat{z}_i$ that satisfy it directly, which absorbs the activity model into the learned mapping from $(P, T,$ bulk composition$)$ to $\boldsymbol{z}$. In the ideal limit ($\gamma_i = 1$), the logit output z represents a unitless chemical potential of each endmember relative to the reference state.

**A non-negative, closure-preserving reparameterization of the pyroxene and spinel components of the MELTS models**

The softmax function always produces outputs that are strictly positive and sum to one, so the network cannot emit a non-physical composition (e.g. negative atoms) for phases composed of components that are themselves legal compositions, regardless of its unconstrained raw output. For spinels and pyroxenes, however, MELTS predicts legal compositions that are outside the simplex defined by the end members (i.e., some components can be negative). A softmax activation therefore cannot be applied to these components directly, but these compositions can be remapped to another basis that iscompatible with a softmax activation: components that are non-negative and sum to one.

Even for spinels and pyroxenes, which can contain negative components, there exists a limit lying outside the simplex that expresses legal compositions, implying that there exist some compositional basis that can remap legal compositions to lie within the simplex. We were able to analytically derive a solution for pyroxene, but spinel was instead solved numerically. All other

Table 4.2: Site occupancies of the seven MELTS pyroxene components (**SackGhiorso1994**).

| Component | M2 | M1 | T, T |
|---|---|---|---|
| diopside ($x_0$) | Ca | Mg | Si, Si |
| clinoenstatite ($x_1$) | Mg | Mg | Si, Si |
| hedenbergite ($x_2$) | Ca | $Fe^{2+}$ | Si, Si |
| alumino-buffonite ($x_3$) | Ca | $\frac{1}{2}$Mg + $\frac{1}{2}$Ti | Al, Si |
| buffonite ($x_4$) | Ca | $\frac{1}{2}$Mg + $\frac{1}{2}$Ti | $Fe^{3+}$, Si |
| essenite ($x_5$) | Ca | $Fe^{3+}$ | Al, Si |
| jadeite ($x_6$) | Na | Al | Si, Si |

phases' compositional bases in MELTS and HeFESTo are already strictly non-negative.

### Pyroxene

We write the mole fractions of the seven MELTS pyroxene components (diopside, clinoenstatite, hedenbergite, alumino-buffonite, buffonite, essenite, jadeite) as $x_0, \ldots, x_6$. Pyroxene has the general formula $\mathrm{M2\,M1\,T_2O_6}$, with one large octahedral site (M2), one small octahedral site (M1), and two tetrahedral sites (T); the site occupancies of the seven components follow **SackGhiorso1994** and are given in Table **??**. The atoms-per-formula-unit totals implied by that table are

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Ca} &= x_0 + x_2 + x_3 + x_4 + x_5, & \mathrm{Na} &= x_6, \\ \mathrm{Mg} &= x_0 + 2x_1 + \tfrac{1}{2}(x_3 + x_4), & \mathrm{Al} &= x_3 + x_5 + x_6, \\ \mathrm{Fe^{3+}} &= x_4 + x_5, & \mathrm{Ti} &= \tfrac{1}{2}(x_3 + x_4). \end{aligned} \tag{4.7}$$

Seven components subject to closure leave six independent directions. These separate naturally into three groups. Three elements are carried by exactly one component each and can be read off directly: $Fe^{2+}$ (hedenbergite), Na (jadeite), and Mg on the M2 site specifically (clinoenstatite, the Mg–Ca exchange vector distinct from the M1 magnesium already carried by diopside). Three further elements—$Fe^{3+}$, Al and Ti—are each split across two or three components, so no single component fraction stands in for them; the corresponding coordinates are obtained by requiring their pairwise sums to equal the element totals of Eq. (**??**),

$$r_1 + r_3 = \mathrm{Al}, \qquad r_2 + r_3 = \mathrm{Fe^{3+}}, \qquad r_1 + r_2 = 2\,\mathrm{Ti}, \tag{4.8}$$

Table 4.3: The pyroxene reparameterization matrix $\mathsf{T}_{\text{px}}$. Rows are the seven MELTS pyroxene components; columns are the transformed coordinates. Every row is non-negative and sums to unity. The same matrix is applied to both the orthopyroxene and clinopyroxene solutions.

| Component | $u_C$ | $u_0$ | $u_1$ | $u_2$ | $u_3$ | $u_4$ | $u_5$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| diopside | 1 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 |
| clinoenstatite | 1/2 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 1/2 |
| hedenbergite | 2/3 | 1/3 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 | 0 |
| alumino-buffonite | 1/2 | 0 | 1/4 | 1/4 | 0 | 0 | 0 |
| buffonite | 1/2 | 0 | 1/4 | 0 | 1/4 | 0 | 0 |
| essenite | 1/2 | 0 | 0 | 1/4 | 1/4 | 0 | 0 |
| jadeite | 2/5 | 0 | 0 | 1/5 | 0 | 1/5 | 1/5 |

which is a $3\times3$ system with the unique solution given below. The remaining two quantities, Ca and Si, are never tracked directly; they are pinned by requiring each crystallographic site to be exactly full—a second, local layer of closure nested inside the overall constraint $\sum_i x_i = 1$. Collecting these,

$$r_0 = x_2, \quad r_1 = x_3+\tfrac{1}{2}x_6, \quad r_2 = x_4-\tfrac{1}{2}x_6, \quad r_3 = x_5+\tfrac{1}{2}x_6, \quad r_4 = x_6, \quad r_5 = x_1. \tag{4.9}$$

Each $r_i$ is bounded for any physically legal pyroxene, but not on $[0, 1]$. Rescaling and recombining gives six quantities that are individually bounded on $[0, 1]$:

$$u_0 = \tfrac{1}{2}r_0, \quad u_1 = \tfrac{1}{2}(r_1+r_2), \quad u_2 = \tfrac{1}{2}(r_1+r_3), u_3 = \tfrac{1}{2}(r_2+r_3), \quad u_4 = \tfrac{1}{2}r_4, \quad u_5 = \tfrac{1}{2}r_4+r_5. \tag{4.10}$$

Unit-sum closure of the full transformed vector is a separate matter and does *not* follow from site positivity. Because $\sum_i x_i = 1$, the constant $u_C \equiv 1 = \sum_i x_i$ is itself a linear function of the mole fractions and can be appended as a seventh coordinate. This makes the map square (and hence invertible), and gives the diopside reference endmember, for which $u_0, \ldots, u_5$ all vanish, a non-zero value in the transformed space. The resulting vector $(u_C, u_0, \ldots, u_5)$ is non-negative for any legal pyroxene but does not sum to one. Closure was imposed by evaluating the linear map of Eqs. (**??**)–(**??**) at each of the seven pure endmembers and dividing each resulting row by its own row sum, yielding the fixed matrix $\mathsf{T}_{\text{px}}$ of Table **??**, in which every row is individually non-negative and sums to unity.

Because closure was imposed by endmember normalization rather than derived from the site-occupancy argument, its validity for a general (non-endmember)

Table 4.4: The spinel reparameterization matrix $\mathsf{T}_{\mathrm{sp}}$. Rows are the four (non-chromite) MELTS spinel components; columns are the transformed coordinates. Every row is non-negative and sums to unity.

| Component | $u_C$ | $u_0$ | $u_1$ | $u_2$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Hercynite | 1 | 0 | 0 | 0 |
| Magnetite | 2/5 | 3/5 | 0 | 0 |
| Spinel | 19/20 | 0 | 1/20 | 0 |
| Ulvöspinel | 1/5 | 0 | 0 | 4/5 |

composition is not guaranteed *a priori*, and was instead established empirically: applying $\mathsf{T}_{\mathrm{px}}$ to the full set of MELTS-computed pyroxene compositions in the training data yields vectors that are non-negative and sum to unity, and $\mathsf{T}_{\mathrm{px}}^{-1}$ recovers the original mole fractions within numeric precision.

### Spinel

We were unable to reduce the spinel components (chromite, hercynite, magnetite, spinel *sensu stricto*, ulvöspinel) to a comparably clean set of site-occupancy inequalities. No analogous analytic transform was therefore pursued. Instead a masked, invertible linear transform $\mathsf{T}_{\mathrm{sp}}$ was fit numerically.

The matrix was parameterized as lower triangular, which guarantees invertibility for any non-zero diagonal. Chromite uniquely expresses Cr contents and is therefore always non-negative. It was mapped onto its own dedicated output coordinate and excluded from the fit so that chromium-free models would be able to use the same transform. The remaining entries were optimized by gradient descent (Adam; PyTorch) against approximately $3 \times 10^6$ MELTS spinel compositions drawn from the training data, minimizing a two-term objective: a mean-squared term driving each transformed composition's row sum toward unity, and a leaky-ReLU penalty on negative transformed entries driving them toward zero. The learning rate was annealed by a factor of ten every 2,500 of 10,000 steps; the diagonal was reset to unity whenever it decayed toward zero, preserving invertibility; and coefficients falling below 0.05 in magnitude were periodically hard-thresholded to zero to keep the fitted matrix sparse. The solution satisfyingly converged to one that can be expressed in terms of relatively simple fractions.

The resulting matrix and its analytic inverse were empirically validated in

the same way as the pyroxene transform: by histogramming the transformed compositions and their row sums, checking their extrema, and comparing round-tripped compositions against the originals across the full training set. Original compositions are recovered within numeric precision and the transformed components of all MELTS spinels are confined almost entirely to $[0, 1]$.

==========

**Legality polish for pyroxene and spinel compositions**

The transforms derived above in §?? guarantees that every legal composition lands in the simplex ($\hat{x} \geq 0$, $\sum \hat{x} = 1$), but not the reverse: the legal compositions fill only part of the simplex, and other regions of the simplex are forbidden for legal compositions. Because the softmax can return any point in the simplex, it is possible for a softmax output to be illegal without further constraints. To address this, we apply a post-processing step to the softmax outputs of pyroxene and spinel to force them to be legal compositions. This correction is commonly applied to orthopyroxene (6-7% of predicted OPX), for which CaO is low generally and can easily be pushed negative. For spinel and clinopyroxene, these corrections are more rare, affecting less than 2% of predicted spinel and 0.1% of predicted clinopyroxene.

**Correcting a single negative oxide**

A single negative oxide can be safely corrected with trivial arithmetic.

The first step in correcting a single negative oxide is to separate the positive and negative oxide contributions from each component ($S_+$ and $S_-$ respectively). For oxide $i$, let $q_i$ be the column of oxide stoichiometry for the transformed components as given in Table **??**.

$$S_+ = \sum_{q_i>0} q_i \, \hat{x}_i, \qquad S_- = \sum_{q_i<0} |q_i| \, \hat{x}_i, \qquad \text{oxide moles} = S_+ - S_- \tag{4.11}$$

The oxide is negative if $S_- > S_+$. We employ a simple fix that aims to preserve as much of the original prediction as possible. We find two scaling factors to scale the positive and negative contributing components to balance the oxide. We multiply every component fraction on the positive side by one factor $a$ and every fraction on the negative side by one factor $b$. If we set the oxide to zero and enforce the closure constraint, we formulate a system of two equations that

| Component | Definition ($T^{-1}$) | $Al_2O_3$ | CaO | FeO | $Fe_2O_3$ | MgO | $Na_2O$ | $SiO_2$ | $TiO_2$ | $Cr_2O_3$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *Pyroxene* | | | | | | | | | | |
| $u_C$ | Di | 0 | 1 | 0 | 0 | 1 | 0 | 2 | 0 | - |
| $u_0$ | 3Hd − 2Di | 0 | 1 | 3 | 0 | −2 | 0 | 2 | 0 | - |
| $u_1$ | 2Abf + 2Bf − 2Ess − Di | 0 | 1 | 0 | 0 | 1 | 0 | 0 | 2 | - |
| $u_2$ | 2Abf − 2Bf + 2Ess − Di | 2 | 1 | 0 | 0 | −1 | 0 | 0 | 0 | - |
| $u_3$ | 2Bf + 2Ess − 2Abf − Di | 0 | 1 | 0 | 2 | −1 | 0 | 0 | 0 | - |
| $u_4$ | 5Jd + 2Bf − 2En − 2Abf − 2Ess | 0.5 | −2 | 0 | 0 | −4 | 2.5 | 4 | 0 | - |
| $u_5$ | 2En − Di | 0 | −1 | 0 | 0 | 3 | 0 | 2 | 0 | - |
| *Spinel* | | | | | | | | | | |
| Chr | Chr | 0 | - | 1 | 0 | 0 | - | - | 0 | 1 |
| $u_0$ | Hc | 1 | - | 1 | 0 | 0 | - | - | 0 | 0 |
| $u_1$ | $\frac{5}{3}$Mt − $\frac{2}{3}$Hc | $-\frac{2}{3}$ | - | 1 | $\frac{5}{3}$ | 0 | - | - | 0 | 0 |
| $u_2$ | 20Sp − 19Hc | 1 | - | −19 | 0 | 20 | - | - | 0 | 0 |
| $u_3$ | $\frac{5}{4}$Usp − $\frac{1}{4}$Hc | $-\frac{1}{4}$ | - | $\frac{9}{4}$ | 0 | 0 | - | - | $\frac{5}{4}$ | 0 |

Table 4.5: Transformed components and their chemical definitions. These are the rows of the inverted transform matrices $\mathsf{T}_{\mathsf{px}}^{-1}$ and $\mathsf{T}_{\mathsf{sp}}^{-1}$. Mapped into an oxide space, these transformed component contain negative atoms and therefore a softmax output in this space is capable of producing illegal negative atoms. Endmember abbreviations: Di diopside, En clinoenstatite, Hd hedenbergite, Abf alumino-buffonite, Bf buffonite, Ess essenite, Jd jadeite; Chr chromite, Hc hercynite, Mt magnetite, Sp spinel ($MgAl_2O_4$), Usp ulvöspinel.

fix the two unknowns $a$ and $b$:

$$\text{oxide becomes exactly zero:} \quad aS_+ = bS_-, \tag{4.12}$$

$$\text{fractions still sum to one:} \quad aP + bN = 1, \tag{4.13}$$

where $P$ and $N$ are the plain sums of the component fractions on each side.

$$P = \sum_{\hat{x}_i>0} \hat{x}_i, \qquad N = \sum_{\hat{x}_i<0} \hat{x}_i, \qquad P + N = 1 \tag{4.14}$$

From Eq. (**??**), $b = aS_+/S_-$; substituting into Eq. (**??**) gives

$$a = \frac{S_-}{S_-P + S_+N}, \qquad b = \frac{S_+}{S_-P + S_+N}. \tag{4.15}$$

**Pyroxene: CaO** $< 0$

From Table **??**,

$$S_+ = \hat{x}_C + \hat{x}_0 + \hat{x}_1 + \hat{x}_2 + \hat{x}_3, \qquad S_- = 2\hat{x}_4 + \hat{x}_5. \tag{4.16}$$

All positive coefficients are 1, so $P = S_+$ and $N = \hat{x}_4 + \hat{x}_5$, and Eq. (**??**) simplifies to:

$$b = \frac{1}{3\hat{x}_4 + 2\hat{x}_5}, \qquad a = \frac{S_-}{S_+\,(3\hat{x}_4 + 2\hat{x}_5)}. \tag{4.17}$$

The CaO correction is applied to clinopyroxene only.

**Pyroxene: MgO $< 0$**

$$S_+ = \hat{x}_C{+}\hat{x}_1{+}3\hat{x}_5, \quad P = \hat{x}_C{+}\hat{x}_1{+}\hat{x}_5; \qquad S_- = 2\hat{x}_0{+}\hat{x}_2{+}\hat{x}_3{+}4\hat{x}_4, \quad N = \hat{x}_0{+}\hat{x}_2{+}\hat{x}_3{+}\hat{x}_4, \tag{4.18}$$

$a$, $b$ then can be calculated using Eq. (**??**). The MgO correction is applied to clinopyroxene only.

**Spinel: FeO $< 0$ and $Al_2O_3 < 0$**

Spinel has two oxides that can go negative, sometimes simultaneously, substantially complicating the problem. From Table **??**,

$$\mathrm{FeO} = \hat{x}_{\mathsf{Chr}} + \hat{x}_0 + \hat{x}_1 + \tfrac{9}{4}\hat{x}_3 - 19\,\hat{x}_2, \tag{4.19}$$

$$\mathrm{Al_2O_3} = \hat{x}_0 + \hat{x}_2 - \tfrac{2}{3}\hat{x}_1 - \tfrac{1}{4}\hat{x}_3. \tag{4.20}$$

In models without Cr, $\hat{x}_{\mathsf{Chr}} = 0$.

**Three pools.** Because the two constraints share components, the components are grouped by the signs they carry in the two equations, and each group gets its own factor:

| Pool | Components | FeO | $Al_2O_3$ | Factor |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $A = \hat{x}_{\mathsf{Chr}} + \hat{x}_0$ | Chr, $u_0$ | + | + | $a$ |
| $B = \hat{x}_1 + \hat{x}_3$ | $u_1$, $u_3$ | + | − | $b$ |
| $C = \hat{x}_2$ | $u_2$ | − | + | $c$ |

In all cases, the closure constraint is enforced:

$$aA + bB + cC = 1, \tag{4.21}$$

If only one oxide is negative, then only the violated oxide is set to zero, and the pool it does not involve held fixed. Then, the second equation for each scenario is:

- *FeO only* ($b = 1$): Eq. (**??**) and $aA + \hat{x}_1 + \frac{9}{4}\hat{x}_3 = 19\,cC$;
- *$Al_2O_3$ only* ($c = 1$): Eq. (**??**) and $a\hat{x}_0 + C = b\left(\frac{2}{3}\hat{x}_1 + \frac{1}{4}\hat{x}_3\right)$.

**Both violated.** If both oxides are negative, or if fixing one would push the other below zero, all three factors are solved together with three constraints: closure, $\mathrm{FeO} = 0$, and $\mathrm{Al_2O_3} = 0$,

$$\begin{pmatrix} A & B & C \\ A & \hat{x}_1 + \frac{9}{4}\hat{x}_3 & -19C \\ \hat{x}_0 & -\left(\frac{2}{3}\hat{x}_1 + \frac{1}{4}\hat{x}_3\right) & C \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} a \\ b \\ c \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{4.22}$$

**[TODO: Add Spinel 1:1 figure]**

### Mass balance

The assemblage predicted by the emulator is not strictly constrained to reproduce the bulk composition; it is only encouraged to with a loss term during training (§**??**). Therefore, a post-processing step is necessary to ensure that the final assemblage is consistent with the requested bulk composition. *nGibbs* uses a mass balance correction adapted from **asimow1998**, who find the smallest relative change to $\hat{m}$ that makes $\hat{b} = b$. The implementation in *nGibbs* differs from their procedure most strongly in two ways: (1) the minimisation is solved in parallel for thousands of assemblages at once on a GPU, and (2) the correction is done iteratively, with constraints enforced at each step so that no elemental abundance becomes negative.

The section makes use of variables defined in Table **??** as well as those unique to this section in Table **??**. Index forms are given alongside the matrix forms throughout, with $c$ running over components and $e, e'$ over elements.

The neural network returns the component moles $\hat{m}$ (the endmembers of every phase, in the transformed basis of Section **??**). The element moles they imply are $\hat{m}A$ ($[1 \times \mathrm{C}][\mathrm{C} \times \mathrm{E}] \to [1 \times \mathrm{E}]$). The reconstructed bulk is normalized to sum to one, then it's residual is given by

$$\delta b = b - \hat{m}A \qquad . \tag{4.23}$$

Mass balance seeks a correction $\delta\hat{m}$ to the component moles such that

$$\delta\hat{m}\,A = \delta b, \qquad \text{i.e.} \qquad \sum_c \delta\hat{m}_c\,A_{ce} = \delta b_e \quad \text{for each element } e. \tag{4.24}$$

| Symbol | Dim. | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| $\delta b$ | E | Bulk residual in element moles, $\delta b = \Gamma\, b - \hat{m} A$ |
| $\delta\hat{m}$ | C | Correction to the component moles |
| $\zeta$ | C | Relative correction, $\zeta_c = \delta\hat{m}_c / \hat{m}_c$ |
| $D$ | C×E | Abundance-weighted stoichiometry, $D = \mathrm{diag}(\hat{m})\, A$, i.e. $D_{ce} = \hat{m}_c A_{ce}$ |
| $\nu$ | E | Lagrange multipliers, one per element |
| $G$ | E×E | $G = D^\top D$, the matrix of the system solved for $\nu$ |
| $\kappa$ | 1 | Regularisation added to the diagonal of $G$ ($10^{-12}$) |
| $\sigma_i$, $\Phi$, $\Psi$ | E, C×E, E×E | Singular values and singular vectors of $D$: $D = \Phi\ \mathrm{diag}(\sigma)\ \Psi^\top$ |
| $N_{it}$ | 1 | Number of correction iterations (3) |

Table 4.6: Symbols added for the mass balance. Dimensions as in Table **??**.

This is E equations (about ten) in C unknowns (several tens), so the system is underconstrained and has infinitely many solutions. Because the network's prediction is the best available estimate of the assemblage, it is most reasonable to choose the solution that changes it least. We define this as the solution that minimizes the sum of squared relative changes to the component moles. For convenience, we define the relative change $\zeta_c$ for each component $c$ as

$$\zeta_c = \frac{\delta\hat{m}_c}{\hat{m}_c}, \tag{4.25}$$

We minimize the sum of squared relative changes,

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\,\zeta\,\zeta^\top = \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_c \left(\frac{\delta\hat{m}_c}{\hat{m}_c}\right)^2. \tag{4.26}$$

The factor $\frac{1}{2}$ is arbitrarily added to elegantly cancel the 2 produced by the differentiation below. We introduce a new variable: $D$, the component abundance-weighted stoichiometry matrix, to relate $\zeta$ to the bulk residual $\delta b$.

$$\zeta\, D = \delta b, \qquad D = \mathrm{diag}(\hat{m})\, A \quad (\mathrm{C} \times \mathrm{E}), \tag{4.27}$$

A component absent from the assemblage ($\hat{m}_c = 0$) has a zero row at $D_c$ and, by Eq. (**??**), $\delta\hat{m}_c = 0$ so absent components are never changed.

We therefore formulate the problem as a minimization of Eq. (**??**) subject to the constraints of Eq. (**??**). In other words: our solution is the smallest relative change to the component moles necessary to satisfy conservation of mass.

**Solving with Lagrange multipliers**

Lagrange multipliers reformulate this problem into a set of ordinary equations. One new unknown, the multiplier $\nu_e$, is introduced for each element. Each constraint is written as an expression that must equal zero. The multipliers $\nu_e$ relate the derivatives of the objective function to the constraints. Requiring every derivative of the result to vanish then expresses two conditions at once: the constraints hold, and no change that respects them can lower the objective $\frac{1}{2}\,\zeta\,\zeta^\top$. This is the Lagrangian,

$$\mathcal{L}(\zeta,\nu) = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\zeta\,\zeta^\top - \Big(\zeta D - \delta b\Big)\,\nu^\top, \tag{4.28}$$

with $\nu$ the row of E multipliers. Now, differentiating with respect to the relative correction $\zeta$ gives

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial \zeta} = \zeta - \nu\,D^\top = 0 \qquad \Longrightarrow \qquad \zeta = \nu\,D^\top \quad [1\times \mathrm{E}][\mathrm{E}\times \mathrm{C}] \to [1\times \mathrm{C}]. \tag{4.29}$$

This reveals that the C relative corrections are not independent: they are all determined by just E numbers, the Lagrange multipliers. The problem has been reduced from C unknowns to E, and now the system is well-constrained.

Substituting Eq. (**??**) into the $\zeta\,D = \delta b$ constraint gives

$$\nu\,D^\top D = \delta b, \tag{4.30}$$

and now the only unknowns are the E multipliers $\nu$, which can solved with an LU (lower-upper) decomposition as

$$\nu^\top = SOLVE(D^\top D, \delta b^\top). \tag{4.31}$$

With $\nu$ known, Eq. (**??**) relates the relative correction $\zeta$ to the multipliers.

$$\zeta = \nu A^\top \,\mathrm{diag}(\hat{m}) \tag{4.32}$$

The absolute correction $\delta\hat{m}$ is then obtained by multiplying the relative correction by the component moles (Eq. (**??**)).

$$\delta\hat{m} = \zeta\,\mathrm{diag}(\hat{m}) = \nu A^\top\,\mathrm{diag}(\hat{m})^2 \quad [1\times \mathrm{E}][\mathrm{E}\times \mathrm{C}][\mathrm{C}\times \mathrm{C}] \to [1\times \mathrm{C}], \tag{4.33}$$

**Why the Lagrange form is used.** **asimow1998** obtain the same solution by SVD, however their problem is distinct from this one in that they correct one assemblage at a time, whereas *nGibbs* applies this operation to tens of thousands of assemblages in parallel. The Lagrange form is used here because batched SVD handles these matrices poorly on a GPU. An informal test on a dataset of 15,000 assemblages from the HeFESTo Earth model validation dataset (E = 8, C = 68) shows HeFESTo test bundle (B = 15,000, E = 8, C = 68), torch.linalg.pinv took 10.1 s on the GPU against 0.29 s on the CPU (single precision), whereas the Lagrange solve took 25 ms on the GPU (double precision; 48 ms on the CPU). The Lagrange form, however, requires double precision floating point arithmetic to recover an accurate solution, whereas the SVD is robust to single precision arithmetic because the $\nu\left(D^\top D\right)$ solve of the Lagrange formulation squares the condition number. This cost is marginal, however, beside the speedup of the Lagrange form on both CPU and GPU, and it elegantly avoids the need to bus data between CPU and GPU when *nGibbs* is run on a GPU.

### Regularisation

**The regularized solve.** In practice, a small number $\kappa$ is added to every diagonal entry of $\left(D^\top D\right)$,

$$\nu\left(D^\top D + \kappa I\right) = \delta b, \qquad \kappa = 10^{-12}, \tag{4.34}$$

where $I$ is the E×E identity matrix. This is because $D^\top D$ has all-zero columns and rows for any bulk composition lacking any particular element and is therefore singular. For a row lacking an element, its equation becomes $\kappa\,\nu_e = 0$ for the regularized case and $\nu$ is zero because $\delta b_e = 0$ for an absent element. Without regularization, the equation for this row would be $0\nu_e = 0$, for which $\nu_e$ is undefined.

On the HeFESTo Earth Model validation dataset, the smallest non-zero diagonal entries of $D^\top D$ are $\sim 3 \times 10^{-7}$ (median over rows), so $\kappa$ must be far smaller than that. A $\kappa$ as small as $10^{-12}$ requires double precision floating point values, but this is also required by the solve of the Lagrange multipliers and therefore poses no additional complication.

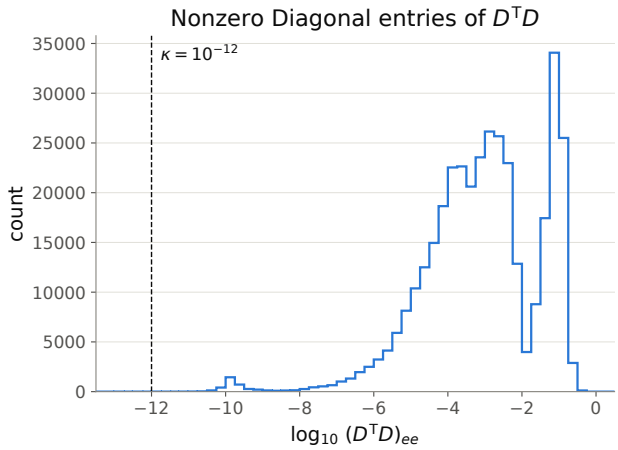



Figure 4.1: Histogram of the non-zero diagonal entries of $D^\top D$ formed by the conservation of mass correction (all three iterations) on the 15,000 assemblages of the HeFESTo Earth adiabat isentropic (NPS) test set. The dashed line marks $\kappa = 10^{-12}$.

### Seeding phases for unexplained elements

**Why it is needed.** The conservation of mass correction can only move an element through components that contain it and are present ($\hat{m}_c > 0$). If the predicted assemblage contains no carrier of an element that is in the bulk (for example K, P or H when the network places the K-, P- or H-bearing phase just below saturation), that element's residual cannot be removed: the regularised solve leaves it in place (Section **??**). In the 102 Closed Cr test set this happens in 13 of 15,000 rows.

**Procedure.** Before the correction, for the continuous models ($\mathrm{NN}_M ELTS.seed_u nexplained_p hases$)

**Unexplained elements.** Element $e$ is unexplained if $b_e > 0$ and no component with $\hat{m}_c > 0$ contains it ($A_{ce} = 0$ for every present $c$). Call the set of unexplained elements $\mathcal{U}$.

**Candidates.** Absent phases ($\hat{n}_p = 0$) whose *predicted* composition contains at least one element of $\mathcal{U}$. The chemistry heads predict a composition $\hat{x}$ for every phase, present or not, so one is always available.

**Choice.** The candidate closest to saturation: the largest (least negative) affinity $g_p$ ($\hat{g}_p$ for AffinityModel).

**Abundance.** Let

$$a_e = \sum_c M_{pc} \, (\hat{x}V + f)_c \, A_{ce} \tag{4.35}$$

be the moles of element $e$ in one mole of the chosen phase $p$: its predicted component fractions (Eq. **??**, restricted to phase $p$ by $M_{pc}$) times their stoichiometry. The phase is added with the abundance $\hat{n}_p$ that best supplies the elements of $\mathcal{U}$ it carries,

$$\hat{n}_p = \frac{\sum_{e\in\mathcal{U}} a_e \,\Gamma\, b_e}{\sum_{e\in\mathcal{U}} a_e^2}, \tag{4.36}$$

the least-squares fit of $\hat{n}_p\, a_e = \Gamma\, b_e$ over those elements. When the phase covers a single unexplained element, $\hat{n}_p$ supplies exactly the bulk's amount of it, $\hat{n}_p = \Gamma\, b_e / a_e$.

**Insert.** The phase's components get $\hat{m}_c = \hat{n}_p\,(\hat{x}V + f)_c$ for every $c$ with $M_{pc} = 1$, as in Eq. (**??**).

The loop stops when $\mathcal{U}$ is empty or no candidate is left; each round adds a new phase, so it ends after at most P rounds. $\hat{m}$ is then renormalised so that $\Gamma = 1$. Rows that need no seeding are not touched.

**Effect.** Seeding gives every element of the bulk a non-zero column in $D$. Because the seeded phase already carries about the right amount of the missing element, it also gets a sensible weight: the correction moves each component in proportion to $\hat{m}_c^2$ (Eq. **??**), so a phase added at a negligible abundance would barely be used. On the 102 test set, 14 phases were seeded in the 13 rows, and 11 of them are present in the ground truth (apatite, leucite, fluid, hornblende). A single unclamped correction step on those rows reduces their residuals from order $10^{-3}$ to about $10^{-8}$.

### The iterative correction

**Why one step is not enough.** The step of Sections **??**–**??** places no bound on $\delta\hat{m}_c$. Nothing prevents $\delta\hat{m}_c < -\hat{m}_c$, which would leave a component with negative moles; this is the "overstepping" failure Asimow and Ghiorso note. Setting such a component to zero restores a physical assemblage but breaks the mass balance again, because the moles it would have supplied are now missing. The step is therefore repeated: each repetition spreads the remaining residual over the components that are still present.

**Procedure.** Starting from the seeded $\hat{m}$, each of $N_{it}$ iterations ($N_{it} = 3$ by default) does:

1. **Residual on the current scale.** Recompute $\Gamma = \sum_e (\hat{m}A)_e$ and $\delta b = \Gamma\, b - \hat{m}A$ (Eq. **??**). Only the proportions of the bulk are enforced, and each clamp (step 4) changes the total, so the target $\Gamma\, b$ is rebuilt every iteration. A target held at a fixed scale would make the residual grow between iterations.
2. **Weights.** Build $D = \mathrm{diag}(\hat{m})\, A$, with each present $\hat{m}_c$ raised to at least $10^{-9}$ in the diagonal. The floor keeps a very small but present component solvable; absent components keep a zero row.
3. **Solve.** Form $G = D^\top D$, solve the regularised system Eq. (**??**) for $\nu$, then $\zeta = \nu D^\top$ (Eq. **??**), all in double precision. This is the operation that runs batched on the GPU.
4. **Update and clamp.** $\hat{m} \leftarrow \max\left(\hat{m} + \zeta\, \mathrm{diag}(\hat{m}),\ 0\right)$, element by element: Eq. (**??**), followed by setting any negative component moles to zero.
5. **Polish.** For MELTS models containing orthopyroxene, clinopyroxene or spinel, re-impose the legality corrections of Section **??**. The update moves component moles within a phase and can create a negative oxide in a phase whose predicted composition was legal.

After the last iteration the remaining residual, $\|\hat{b} - b\|$ with $\hat{b}$ from Eq. (**??**), is reported for each row.

**Properties.**

- *Termination.* A component set to zero has a zero row in $D$ from then on and cannot return. The set of present components can only shrink, so the iteration cannot cycle, and a phase removed by the correction stays removed.
- *Exactness.* Each unclamped step removes the residual up to the regularisation. After the final clamp and polish a small residual can remain: the median on the 102 test set is $3.0 \times 10^{-8}$.
- *Non-negativity and legality.* Returned component moles are never negative, and the polish runs after every step rather than only at the end.
- *Special cases.* With one iteration, no clamp, no polish and $\kappa \to 0$, the procedure reduces to the single weighted step of Asimow and Ghiorso, Eq. (**??**). That single step remains available for comparison as $\mathrm{mass}_b alance =' pinv', evaluatedbySVDontheCPU.Settingrelative = Falsereplaces\mathrm{diag}(\hat{m})$ by the identity on present components, giving the unweighted smallest

change.

### Data generation

### Bulk composition sampling

Bulk compositions are sampled from whole-rock analyses in the GEOROC and PetDB databases (**GEOROC**; **PetDB**), preferentially weighting the compositional range the emulator is intended to serve. Whole rock analyses from GEOROC in particular are weighted towards more evolved compositions, so mafic and ultramafic compostions were more heavily weighted in the *nGibbs* training datasets than in the original source datasets. For the HeFESTo models, one fifth of the training data are drawn from the population of compositions between 5 and 20 wt% MgO, three tenths of the data are drawn from the population of compositions with greater than 20 wt% MgO, and the remaining half is a mixture of these two mafic and ultramafic populations in random proportions. These base compositions were substantially randomly altered so that *nGibbs* would perform well in a wider variety of parameter spaces, including rock compositions that are uncommon or unknown on Earth's surface. For the Earth model, one quarter of the compositions are not perturbed. For the MELTS emulators, half of the training data is generated from any composition in the compiled database, one fifth of the data are pulled from ultramafic compositions with greater than 25 wt% MgO, and three tenths of the data are pulled from compositions with greater than 5 wt% MgO. These bulk compositions are perturbed by guassian noise with a standard deviation of 5%, a substantially more modest perturbation that that applied to the HeFESTo emulator training data.

For volatile-focused MELTS 1.2.0 emulators in particular, 35% of the training and validation datasets are drawn from sedimentary compositions within the Gard database (**Gard2019**). Of these sedimentary bulk compositions, about one quarter are drawn from carbonate rich compositions, with $CO_2$ contents greater than 10 wt%, whereas the remaining sedimentary compositions contain less than 10 wt% $CO_2$. The remaining 65% of the training data were drawn from igneous whole rock data from GEOROC and PetDB, similarly to the other models (**GEOROC**; **PetDB**).

In order to train emulators that perform well in a variety of redox conditions, each sampled composition is randomly assigned an oxygen fugacity from -5

to +5 $\log_{10}\Delta$FMQ for MELTS training data, or -7 to +3 $\log_{10}\Delta$FMQ for HeFESTo training data. Open system models simply carry this oxygen fugacity as a feature, whereas closed models translate this oxygen fugacity into a molar $^{+3}$Fe/$^{+2}$Fe ratio using an empirical parameterization. This is not meant to be explicitly correct; it is meant to generate training data with an appropriate distribution of molar $^{+3}$Fe/$^{+2}$Fe ratios.

$$^{+3}Fe/^{+2}Fe \approx 10^{(0.2\times\log_{10}\Delta\text{FMQ})-1} \tag{4.37}$$

Manganese and nickel are excluded from the compositional basis of all released models. Manganese and nickel are not handled by HeFESTo, and we have observed that MELTS solutions that carry MnO and NiO frequently stabilize phases with compositions rarely observed in nature, and there is little value in emulating the regions of a model that are not themselves trusted. Excluding these oxides also removes two dimensions from the component basis at small cost to the applications the emulators target.

### State-variable sampling

For the MELTS 1.0.2 and 1.2.0 emulator families, each sampled composition is isobarically cooled from 1800°C in 1°C increments at a random pressure between 1 and 12000 bars. These computed assemblages have well-defined entropies and therefore are acceptable for use in training isentropic models.

HeFESTo Earth and Mars models are each trained around a core of (approximately) adiabatic simulations at reasonable potential temperatures (1200–1650°C for Earth; 500–1750°C for Mars). These adiabats are supplemented with cooler conditions due to a conductive lid at the surface, which is assumed to be between 0-250 km thick for Earth and 100-700 km thick for Mars. **[TODO: Potential temperature citations?]**. Similarly, warmer conditions are modeled at the approach to the core-mantle boundary (CMB) for the Earth model, which assume a mantle temperature between 3200–4700°C at the CMB and a 100-300km width conductive layer

Although HeFESTo natively calculates isentropes, such a calculation requires an iteration of T at every step to retrieve the imposed entropy, which roughly doubles the computation time. Therefore, adiabatic PT paths were instead approximated to reduce computational expense in the generation of the training

dataset. To accomplish this, a second-order linear regression of temperature as a function of specific entropy and pressure was fit to a dataset of dozens of HeFESTo isentropes at representative compositions and potential temperatures. A similar linear regression was fit for specific entropy as a function of temperature at P = 0 GPa on the same dataset to translate potential temperatures to specific entropy. Similarly to the iron speciation parameterization described in §**??**, this approach is not intended to be explicitly correct; it is intended to control the distribution of the training dataset in pressure-temperature-entropy space without unnecessary computational expense. These regressions are used to impose a roughly adiabatic pressure-temperature path for training data. These paths are pertubed with small random noise to prevent the emulators from learning relationships between composition and entropy.

### Execution

MELTS simulations are driven through alphaMELTS on a window (**Smith2005**) run with GNU parallel. HeFESTo simulations are run on the Caltech High Performance Computing cluster as SLURM array jobs. **[TODO: describe hefesto resampling procedure]**

### Import and attrition

Reference-code output is parsed into a single wide table in which each row is one equilibrium state and columns follow a `quantity(phase)` convention. Retained per row are the state variables, the bulk composition, the phase assemblage, the per-phase component molar abundances, the per-phase masses, and the bulk physical properties reported by the reference code. The last of these are retained for validation only; consistent with Section **??**, they are never training targets.

A fraction of simulations fail to converge or terminate without usable output. These are detected and discarded at import. Attrition differs sharply between codes and compositional domains, and is reported here because it determines the difference between the sampled and the achieved distribution: approximately 0.1% for HeFESTo, approximately 15% for MELTS on igneous bulk compositions, and approximately 40% for MELTS 1.2 on sedimentary bulk compositions. The last figure reflects that MELTS 1.2 was applied near the edge of its calibration.

### Coverage

The achieved envelope of each released model in pressure, temperature or entropy, and composition defines its domain of applicability.

The emulators are fits, not theories. No accuracy claim can be made for states outside the sampled envelope. Examples of the behaviour of each model on extrapolation are reported in Section **??**.

### Data preparation

Three operations are applied to prepare MELTS and HeFESTo outputs for training.

### Consistency filtering

Rows are removed where the reference code's output is internally inconsistent, e.g. where the composition reconstructed from the reported assemblage disagrees with the stated bulk composition beyond tolerance. The fractions actually removed are reported in Table **??**.

### Rare-phase removal

Phases occurring too infrequently in the training set to be effectively learned are removed from the component basis entirely to simplify the model. This operates on entire rows; assemblages with rare phases are discarded for containing a rare phase at any low modal proportion. It is presumed that this operation is minimally damaging, because very few assemblages are affected by design.

### Rare-phase augmentation

The MELTS 1.2.0 emulator's training dataset upsampled phases containing rare phases like calcite that were especially desired so that they would surpass the removal threshold and be tracked by the emulator. To upsample, rows containing the rare phase would be duplicated, but with perturbed abundances of its phases, which shift the bulk composition for the same assemblage. This operation was only applied to the isothermal models to avoid invalidating the extensive entropy value natively reported by MELTS. For all models, modal imbalance is addressed through per-phase loss weighting (Section **??**) during

training, which incentivizes the emulator to learn rare phases that otherwise would have little affect on the loss function.

### Partitioning

To monitor model overfitting during training, a validation dataset distinct from the training set is used. Training and validation datasets are generated with the same pipelines, but are separated *by unique bulk composition*. Bulk compositions were partitioned between training and validation datasets and are treated independently as separate datasets throughout the processing pipeline. This ensures that the validation dataset tracks the same fundamental structure as the training dataset while avoiding data leakage. Successive states along one path are strongly autocorrelated, and a row-wise random split would place near-duplicates on both sides of the partition. The resulting held-out error would measure interpolation between adjacent states of a rock the model had already seen, rather than generalization to a rock it had not, and would be optimistic by a wide and unquantifiable margin. Splitting by composition, before the reference thermodynamic models were applied, makes the validation dataset's error track overfitting to the training dataset more faithfully. This overfitting metric is instrumental to develop an emulator that can be effectively applied to new data.

Compositions were assigned in the ratio 80:20 between training and validation. The validation partition is used every epoch for model selection, to tune adaptive regularization, and for early stopping. Unless otherwise stated, all performance metric presented here in Section **??** are for the validation datasets; the emulator's performance on the training datasets is not reported.

### Training

-continuous model types: Affinity aware and affinity naive -figure: affinity projection method dndp dndT (plot of real, rescaled affinity vs projection) -figure: softplus thermal annealing activation for different a, saturation activation (weighted sigmoid, on the same scale?)

-figure: learning rate schedule + losses, shared epoch x axis

**Material Properties from Phase Equilibria**

-vectorized EOS. Refer to sources -figure: 1:1 plots of material properties (density, bulk modulus, thermal expansivity, heat capacity) for MELTS and HeFESTo

## 4.5 Results

-Quality Tables for MELTS and HeFESTo (chemical errors, mole fractions, material properties, deployment tests) -Figures - Phase sections P|S for HeFESTo, T|P for MELTS - Phase diagrams for HeFESTo, MELTS in these same spaces - Isentrope properties for HeFESTo - Density curves by phase for MELTS? - LLD's for MELTS, - computational speed comparisons

## 4.6 Discussion

- Compare to other surrogate models in geodynamics (research and citations) - Discuss model limitations and future work - Discuss affinity aware vs naive performance - use cases: compositionally aware seismic inversion (Mars profiles) - transition zone search: depth, strength, width of transition zone as a function of composition, plot colored ternaries for depth, strength, width of transition zone

## 4.7 Uncertainty Quantification

**[TODO: ]**

## 4.8 Validation

**[TODO: Benchmark speed and accuracy against classical minimizers on held-out $P$–$T$–$X$ points and on known phase diagrams.]**

## 4.9 Application to Geodynamic Modeling

**[TODO: Demonstrate integration into a geodynamic simulation. Show a representative case study.]**

## 4.10 Discussion

**[TODO: Discuss accuracy/speed tradeoffs, generalizability to other bulk compositions, and extension to systems relevant to the Bushveld Complex (foreshadow Appendix ?? and the Conclusion).]**

## 4.11 Conclusions

**[TODO: Summarize the ML minimizer performance and implications for future thermodynamically coupled geodynamic models.]**

# CONCLUSION

**[TODO: Write short dissertation conclusion. No data, few or no figures. Synthesize contributions. Allude to the Bushveld Complex fieldwork (Appendix ??) as motivating nGibbs work and sulfide/goethite geochronology. Mention the laterite geomorphology at Draaikraal as an unexpected and compelling target for goethite geochronology.]**

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